Is It Gay To Kiss Your Homie Goodnight?
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Is It Gay To Kiss Your Homie Goodnight?

by SoundlessWhisper

Summary

Phainon's life isnt an easy one: rent is going up, dating had been nothing but a disaster, and now the entire internet thinks he’s gay because he kept looking— absolutely not staring— at the male barista during his date.

He swears he’s straight. Totally. Completely.
It’s just that... Well... The barista has a lethal face card, okay?
And maybe a really nice body too... He's saying it in a bro way, of course!

Or; Phainon is pretty sure he's not into guys. At least until the universe —or Cipher, he isnt sure about it yet— decides to test it, by making him share an apartment with the most attractive man he had ever seen.

Notes

Make sure you check this beautiful art by @maskyll - portraying the events of chapter 6 ❤

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: It’s Not Gay if You’re Just Appreciating a Fellow Bro

Phainon shifts in his chair, the worn leather creaking like a mocking whisper. Regret is already surging through him, reminding him of every foolish choice that dragged him to yet another date, on the other side of the city nonetheless...

He's twenty-seven. Looks good, or so he's told; sharp features, charming, has an outgoing personality that draws people in and a decent office job that keeps his bills paid. All the things point to someone who should have life figured out.

Which means he gets to date around a lot, right? Or so he thought.

“*Hey, remember? You never went beyond second base with anyone.”* His brain adds unhelpfully, jabbing at his evident lack of experience in the lower department.

It’s not like it’s that weird to be a virgin at the prime age of twenty-seven, right?

Wrong. Apparently, very wrong.

Because almost every girl he tried dating so far backed off the moment they learned he was inexperienced. The ones he doesn't tell upfront? Sadly, they still notice when makeout sessions heat up, when he gets too eager, yet also too inexperienced to know what to do beyond kissing and groping.

And the few who find his lack of experience charming? Cute, even? Those only stick around long enough to peek behind the *"charming boy next door"* façade.

Be it the overthinking, the awkward humor that fails to make anyone but himself laugh, hobbies like spending an entire weekend playing video games over going outside, or those rare cracks in his confidence… Every

single time he lets a glimpse of his true self show, he gets a polite smile, maybe a break-up text if he's lucky enough not to be completely ghosted.

So naturally, over time, Phainon started avoiding dates. Until recently.

Inflation has been skyrocketing recently, and his rent is about to jump by nearly twenty percent upon renewal— his landlady delivered him the news in the most chipper tone possible on a Monday morning, as if it were something good and not a horrible way to start his week. Without a significant other to share the financial burden, it means downgrading to something even tinier than his shoebox-sized apartment, or living in his car.

Phainon is doomed. Utterly.

He has two months left before the lease ends. Two months to figure things out. Suddenly, a stable relationship feels less like a luxury and more like a necessity.

Which brings him to this moment. Phainon does his best to look relaxed on the outside, while inwardly praying to every god he can think of.

Because he really needs this to work…

Iris, the girl who approached him at his co-worker's birthday party and flirted through most of the night before asking him out, waves at him from the entrance, quickly approaching his table. Phainon waves back, forcing his trademark smile— the same smile that got him free drinks in bars, closed deals at work, and even landed a second date once or maybe twice.

“Iris!” He leans forward and waves at her, head tilting playfully. “Are you a parking ticket?”

She pauses, hand gripping the chair she's about to sit on, confusion written all over her face. “What?”

Phainon winks, leaning in further— like he's about to share a big secret with her. “Because you’ve got ‘fine’ written all over you.”

Iris lets out a laugh. It's awkward, high-pitched, and her eyes don't meet his as she sinks into the chair.

“Oh, um… that’s… cute, I guess?” Her tone wavers, like a wilting flower. She sounds unsure at best, weirded out at worst.

“Too much? Thought so. It was worth a shot.” Phainon laughs, ready to brush it off, maybe toss in a smoother line to recover, when the sound of shattering glass cuts his train of thought.

His head turns toward the source of the noise, eyes meeting the barista who is responsible for it. A tall, muscular, and *very good-looking* barista. Who is staring right in their direction with wide eyes, his shoulders shaking in what looks like a desperate attempt to suppress a laughter.

Phainon stares back. Shamelessly. The barista's hair, or mane to be exact, is blonde for the most part, dyed red as the ends, and tied in a messy half-ponytail that does nothing to tame it. He lets his eyes trail lower. Red tattoos snake up the man’s arms, vanishing into the sleeves of his crisp white polo— a polo that can barely contain the absurdly large arm muscles that flex with every movement as he sweeps shards of broken glass into a dustpan.

If Phainon thinks of himself as handsome —objectively, of course— this man is… is… He can’t even find a word to capture his beauty.

Lethal, maybe.

In a bro way.

“*Nothing wrong with appreciating someone’s appearance,”* he tells himself. It’s Aesthetic. Purely.

Phainon isn’t into guys to begin with.

His gaze is still locked at the barista, who looks at him again with his beautifully golden eyes, lifting a hand to cover his mouth simultaneously,

but a half-muffled snort still escapes him, loud enough to reach Phainon's and his date's table.

Chuckling, Phainon seizes the moment to lighten the mood. He nudges his elbow toward the counter where the barista is standing, grinning at the woman in front of him. "See? Someone appreciates my flirting attempts!"

Iris's smile falters, her gaze turning to the barista and back, landing on Phainon with an unimpressed look. "Yeah… or maybe he just dropped a glass at a bad timing. No way you ever got a positive response over that line."

Phainon's laugh dies in his throat, her words are harsh, but he tries not to let it upset him. It's only the start of the date. Yet, even as they order their drinks and start asking each other questions— the usual interview-like part of a first date and he keeps losing interest in her predictably boring answers and keeps drifting subconsciously back to the barista.

He notices the name tag reading "Mydeimos" when the blonde man turns to place a mug of steaming coffee on the bar. It allows Phainon a better look at his sharp features; there's a streak of red eyeliner under his left eye, followed by a small matching tattoo underneath, a little braid on the same side, and a long earring on the opposite. The tattoos are symmetrical, running up both his arms and peeking out of the neckline… And don't even get him started on the man's obviously built chest.

Phainon finds himself staring a beat too long to be appropriate for a fellow dude. Yet, there's something calming in watching Mydeimos that he cannot help it. Be it the way he moves, like each step is calculated or the concentrated expression as he pours milk into the mug.

"*Just appreciation,*" Phainon convinces himself. It's curiosity, the same impulse that makes people linger in museums over a marble sculpture. Curiosity doesn't mean anything.

Absolutely nothing more than that.

Sighing under his breath, Phainon returns his attention to Iris, or at the very least, he tries to. It's proven quite difficult when Mydeimos is moving around with so much grace. Phainon finds himself in a trance when the barista makes the process of pouring a cup of coffee too enticing to look away. He wonders if Mydeimos' voice is as smooth as his movements, if he's the type to hum while he works—

"…to watch… next weekend… want to join?"

He shakes his head, mentally, and forces himself to focus on his date. Phainon smiles at her. "Oh, yeah, that sounds—wait, sorry, what?" His mind is still stuck on the barista. Not catching the entire sentence.

"You're not paying attention..." Iris taps against her mug, the look on her face is one of obvious irritation.

"I am, I swear!" Phainon rubs the back of his neck apologetically, sitting up straighter in his chair.

She is saying something about wanting to watch a movie? What kind of movies would Mydeimos like? Action, maybe? Or something artistic, like historical dramas, to match that absolute calmness he carried?

"Why the fuck does it even matter?" Phainon shakes his head again, visibly this time. Blinking at her.

"Sorry, I'm a bit busy next weekend."

The woman sighs loudly. "You've been zoning out since we got here. I'm not imagining it." Her eyes narrow, and she lets her eyes trail in the same direction Phainon was staring moments ago, where Mydeimos is now adding whipping cream on top of what is probably hot chocolate. "Or is there someone more interesting than me here?"

Phainon's stomach twists, heat creeping up his neck. "No, I- I'm just nervous." He forces a laugh, "haven't been on a date for a while." He confesses. In his defense, it is true.

“So, what do you usually do on your weekends?” Brilliant, Phainon. Smooth as ever.

Iris studies him for a minute, her expression softening. “Fine. Nothing much really, I either go out with friends or thrift clothes…” She starts talking and Phainon’s gaze drifts back to Mydeimos again: he is wiping down the counter now, and such mundane motion shouldn’t look so hypnotic and graceful.

She catches it this time. “Seriously, Phainon!?”

“What? I’m listening!” Phainon protests, but it’s futile, he’s been caught.

It’s not that he isn’t trying, he really does, but Mydeimos’ presence pulls at him like a magnet in ways he cannot explain. Like seeing a beautiful piece of art that one cannot take their eyes off.

Iris checks her phone before standing abruptly, grabbing her bag with a huff. “I'm sorry. I just remembered I have a deadline to finish tonight. I need to go.” Her smile is forced. “Thanks for the coffee.”

Phainon rises, fumbling for words. “Wait,” She turns to him, *“Rose? Lily?”* The only name in Phainon’s head is *“Mydeimos.”*

“Daisy, I—”

“I can’t believe it! You can't even remember my name!” She hisses, walking out before he can say another word. Phainon stands there for a moment longer, shame coloring his face scarlet. He fucked up. Royally. Her name is Iris…

No wonder he never liked flowers.

He pays the bill with defeat, too embarrassed to even look in the direction of Mydeimos— in case the man saw the end of his embarrassing date, and drags himself back home. His phone vibrates several times not even five minutes later, and he grabs it, not sure what to expect.

Iris (date) [16:43]: Ur such an asshole for staring at some dude the whole time.

Iris (date) [16:44]: Don’t message me ever again. Loser.

Phainon stares at the screen in a mix of frustration and disbelief.

Her accusation is an overreaction for sure.

Staring? He wasn’t— well, he did look… But stare!? He’s straight for fucks sake, always has been.

For all his twenty-seven years of life, he liked women, big tits, long hair, pretty eyes... All the stuff men did not have. It was purely to calm himself, he reasons. He was looking at the graceful movements, not even at the guy!

“Mydeimos, not just a guy,” his mind reminds him, traitorous as ever.

Phainon shoves the phone into his back pocket.

Whatever. He’ll figure it out later.

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He does not figure anything out.

If anything, the failed date keeps bothering him more with every hour that passes. During dinner, while he goes for a jog outside to clear his head, even when he tries to speed run the event on his favorite gacha game. It’s not even the girl, he already forgot her name, but the accusation that he was staring inappropriately at a guy.

Because he wasn’t.

Phainon flops onto his old trusted couch, hearing the springs creak weakly under his weight, and grabs his laptop, opening Reddit.

Surely, the masses would be on his side. He quickly makes a new account, just in case, and starts typing:

AITA for looking at the male barista during my first date?

u/33550336

Throwaway acc…

I know how the title sounds but hear me out!

I (27m) was on a date (23f) recently, for context it’s been my first date in ages, so I was really nervous…

We sat at this little cafe, and I was looking around to calm myself down, when I saw the barista, and he was impossibly good looking.

Like LETHAL face card.

Somehow looking at him calmed my nerves, so I did it purely to calm down. I'm not into guys or anything, I swear!

But my date got really upset that I wasn’t looking at her or paying enough attention, again according to her, I did pay attention, most of the time, but the barista moved with so much grace my eyes kept trailing to him...

She ended up sending me a message saying that im an asshole and blocked me.

So, am I really? All I did was appreciate a nice-looking bro.

He clicks on the ‘post’ button and closes the laptop, opting to stare at the ceiling instead. Mydeimos’ face pops into his mind again, but Phainon is too tired to shake it off.

“It’s like admiring a statue, a picture. Nothing more,” he tells the empty room, more to convince himself than anything.

He’s not sure how long he keeps daydreaming about gold eyes and red tattoos, or when he falls asleep on the couch instead of his bed. The only thing he does know is that when he wakes up; it's bright outside and his neck is killing him.

Oh, and there are a few hundred notifications on his phone.

Wait. A few hundred?

He opens the phone, too tired to grab the laptop. His post, the r/AmItheAsshole about the date, has blown up overnight. Phainon feels nauseous as he opens the app, scrolling through the thread with anticipation.

“Surely, the internet would be on his side…” he repeats, full of hope.

u/SleepDeprivedSince95

> YTA. Dude, you spent your date ogling a guy? That's not 'appreciating a nice-looking guy,' that's being rude AF to your date. And let's be real, straight guys don't call another man 'good looking' and stare like that. Sounds like you're in denial about being gay.

Phainon’s thumb hovers over the reply button, his cheeks reddening at the accusation. Denial? He’s not. Absolutely not in denial! He is very much straight!

He scrolls through the other comments before responding, although he really wants to reply to that top comment.

u/SlightlyUsedHuman

Own it, man. Definitely asshole move. If I was on a date and my guy was staring at the barista, I'd block him too. And yeah, gay vibes. NTA if you're figuring out your sexuality, but YTA for wasting her time.

u/HungryKirby

Bro, you date the lady not that man. The amount of gay denial in this post needs to be studied.

u/ChimeraPancakes

YTA "nice-looking guy with a lethal face card"

beeeep! That's my gaydar going off!!

u/ GachaVictim

Bro you said "I'm not into guys or anything" after describing this barista like a Greek god descending from Olympus. Just admit he unlocked something in you. Better than denying your feelings…

u/HandsomeButLagging

NAH**.** Honestly, dude, sounds like you were nervous and trying to get your shit together. You didn't flirt or made comments about the barista, you just spaced out. Yeah, your date probably felt ignored, but it doesn't sound malicious really. Next time, maybe focus a bit more on whoever you're with, but this feels more awkward than asshole-y.

Bless 'Handsome but lagging'. The only one on his side in the myriad of YTA's.

Phainon spends most of his Saturday morning replying to every comment that got enough upvotes:

“Not gay, just honest. Some people are objectively attractive, doesn’t mean I want to date them.”

“Y’all are reading too much into it.”

“Straight as a ruler, thanks.”

“Not into guys, just calming my nerves.”

“Appreciating aesthetics isn’t the same as attraction.”

“Bless you. At least someone understands! ⊂(´ ▽ `)⊃”

He keeps replying to the users, but the more he comments, the more it sounds like he’s fighting a losing battle. Phainon really just thinks Mydeimos has a nice face, nothing more.

Yeah, the guy has a sharp jaw, mesmerizing amber-gold eyes... And yeah, he obviously works out. Phainon remembers the way the white shirt stretched around his muscles yesterday, fabric struggling to contain his broad shoulders and biceps as he moved around. It was impressive, that’s all. Enviable, even.

Why can’t the people on Reddit see it?

Phainon is someone who knows how hard it is to maintain such a physique. He runs in the evenings, keeps his own body toned and fit, but Mydeimos looks like he lives in the gym, like he eats dumbbells for breakfast. Nothing more to it.

Maybe he could use a friend like that. A workout buddy. Someone to motivate him to actually use his gym membership more than twice a year. That makes sense. He wants to be his friend. It’ll be a practical friendship that would benefit them both.

He closes the app after a good hour of reading and replying to comments, tossing his phone to his feet.

It’s not attraction, he tells himself firmly. Just curiosity.

Yeah.

“Just… Curiosity.” He keeps insisting as he’s getting dressed.

“Nothing than admiring a fellow bro.” He reasons as he gets inside his car.

“These comments are stupid.” He convinces himself as he enters the same café he visited yesterday.

The guy at the barista counter is not Mydeimos, but another tall man with long red hair, who looks very busy flirting with a young woman.

Phainon exits the café before anyone notices him.

He visits the next morning, too, only to be met with a female barista this time. Still no Mydeimos. Phainon grabs a coffee to go before leaving, defeated. Perhaps Mydeimos only works part-time, or he keeps missing his shifts.

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Cipher slides in across from him inside the bar booth, dark circles under her eyes, her usually messy grey hair tied in a loose braid. They’ve both survived another brutal week. Phainon, dealing with corporate impossible demands, and Cipher, with her all-over-the-clock police job.

Their little hangout feels like a prize after a week of suffering and grinding *“adult life.”*

“God, I needed this,” Cipher stretches across the table like a cat, sipping on a pint of beer. She raises her hand to get the attention of a passing waitress, ordering the biggest portion of fries the bar offers before looking at Phainon.

“You look like hell. Worse than me, even.” She comments, taking another big gulp of her beer.

Phainon manages a half-hearted laugh, leaning back once the waitress comes with his drink; an overly sweet cocktail to mask the taste of alcohol, and the fries. “It’s been a long week.” He admits.

“Tell me about it,” Cipher groans, stuffing more fries than should be humanely possible into her mouth, and starts a long monologue about all the *“shit I had to deal with.”*

Her words, not his.

He listens to his friend’s ramble, sneaking a few fries and sipping on his cocktail in between, amused by the animated storytelling, until Cipher sighs. “And that’s how my hell of a week went. Now, how about you? How’s your ‘get a relationship before my lease ends’ mission been going?”

Phainon should’ve expected the question, but his grin still falters. He laughs nervously and pulls out his phone, scrolling to the Reddit post that is still getting upvotes despite it being a week since he posted anything. “Oh, it went as bad as you can imagine.” He slides the device across the table, groaning. “Read this. It should answer your question.”

Cipher takes the phone, eyes skimming the screen before she snorts. Loudly. Phainon thanks the heavens that she isn’t mid-drinking or else there would be beer everywhere.

AITA for staring at the male barista during my first date?

“You what—?” She tries to hold back her laughing, failing miserably, pausing on every other word to *wheeze* as she keeps reading.

I know how it sounds but hear me out. I (27m) was on a date (23f) recently, for the record it's been my first date in ages, so I was really nervous… We sat at this little cafe, and I was looking around to calm myself down, when I saw the barista, and he was impossibly good looking. Like LETHAL face card.

"Oh. My. God. Phainon." Cipher can no longer hold back her laugh.

Somehow looking at him calmed my nerves, so I did it purely to calm down. I'm not into guys or anything, I swear! But my date got really upset that I wasn't looking at her or paying enough attention, again according to her, I did pay attention, most of the time, but the barista moved with so much grace my eyes kept trailing to him... She ended up sending me a message saying that im an asshole and blocked me.

So, am I really? All I did was appreciate a nice-looking bro.

"I—Can't—" she gasps, breathless between fits, her voice loud enough to get a few stares from people around them, and Phainon wants nothing more than to sink lower in his seat and disappear from shame. "Your post is hilarious! You totally dug your own grave there!" She wipes her eyes, still chuckling as she hands the phone back. "Oh my God, *'lethal face card'*? You're a disaster!"

"I walked right into that, didn't I?" Phainon snatches the phone, pouting at the chaotic woman. "Look, I tried to focus on her, but…" He trails off, and the memory of Mydeimos comes uninvited. "The barista just… distracted me. I wasn't doing it on purpose."

Cipher leans forward, smirking. "Distracted you? Huh... Sounds like you were staring like a lovestruck maiden if your date called you an asshole." She grabs another fry, pointing it at him in mock accusation. "What's this guy look like, anyway? Spill the details."

Phainon chugs his cocktail, quickly ordering another one and a beer for Cipher. He's too sober for this. And maybe he gets Cipher drunk enough, she won't remember this conversation. Because if she does? She would roast him about it for the next month, possibly longer.

It’s Cipher he is talking about, the same woman who still reminds him of the one time he drunk-flirted with a store mannequin. Four years ago.

Even with the rush of alcohol in his system, heat still creeps up his neck as he tries to put the man’s appearance into words. “He’s tall, built, like *really built*, you know? His shirt barely contained his arms.” He explains, unable to look into his friend’s eyes. “Didn’t help that he laughed at my pickup line to the point of dropping the glass he was holding.”

“Pickup line?” Cipher’s eyes widen, and she cackles again. “Oh, I need to hear this one. Might use it on Cas if it’s any good.”

He whines, “You never approve my lines!” Although he still shares it with her. “All I said was ‘Are you a parking ticket? Because you’ve got ‘fine’ written all over you.”

Cipher howls again, nearly spilling her —already half empty— second beer. “That’s the most embarrassing thing I’ve ever heard! No wonder she bailed. And the barista laughed at this? My gaydar says you two are meant for each other.”

She calms down eventually, her grin still wicked as she starts talking again. “You know I love you, Phainon, but ‘Impossibly good looking’ and ‘lethal’ are strong words for a straight guy. You sure it’s not a crush by accident?”

“I’m sure,” he snaps, a bit too quickly. “Can’t appreciate a fellow bro anymore?” He crosses his arms defensively. “I think he’d be a good workout buddy, that’s all.”

Cipher snorts, unconvinced. “Uh-huh. Sure, ‘workout buddy.’ Whatever makes you sleep better at night.” She leans back, studying him. “Takes one to know one. Castorice would agree too if she was here.”

“Girl… I’m not into guys.” Phainon sighs, knowing there’s no convincing her. Cipher is pure chaos like this… She will keep teasing him mercilessly until he either agrees with her claim or diverts her attention to something more interesting. “Anyway. I’m out of options again. Might as well start looking for a new place,” He groans loudly, sipping on his second drink.

Tapping her chin, looking like she is contemplating something for a good minute, Cipher's eyes widen with what looks like an idea.

It's never a good sign.

"You know, I think I have the perfect solution!" Her tone becomes more serious, and Phainon, who has nothing to lose at this point, gestures her to keep talking as he shoves the last of the fries in his mouth.

"So, you know how Cas asked me to move in with her, and how I chickened out and renewed my lease last month, right?"

Phainon nods. "Right."

"And how breaking it would be too expensive and rude to my roommate, right?" She adds.

"Yeah."

"How about..." Cipher pauses, looking at him with a sly smile. "You take over my lease. Sublet it from me or whatever. The rent is lower than yours, the place is big, and I have the best roommate ever!" She counts the pros on her fingers "He's clean, quiet, respectful, and mostly sticks to his room so it's almost like living alone!"

He blinks at her. The offer is too good to be true. "And the cons?"

Cipher gives him an offended look "You hurt me, boy. I'd never make such an offer if there were cons." She brings a hand to her heart, feigning betrayal. Maybe it is genuine this time.

"Are you sure Castorice would be ok with you changing your mind?" He asks, not wanting to get his hopes up. Not yet.

"Please! Princess homebody been moping about it hinting how I should find someone to take over my half. It's a win-win for us both!"

A room in a bigger apartment, half of the bills, lower rent, perfect-sounding roommate… "That's, damn. That's tempting. Are you sure it's something

you can do, though?”

“I’ll talk to the landlord on Monday, and then with Cas and my roommate, so, hmm.” She pauses for a moment. “I can give you a more certain answer by next weekend,” Cipher offers.

Phainon nods happily, mood instantly lifting. He won’t need to pressure himself to find a girlfriend— he does want a serious relationship but not to force himself into one for the sake of his living comfort, and he gets an upgrade while saving money. It’s the best outcome ever. “Deal. This could save my ass. Thanks, Cipher.”

“You’re acting like a dog who got a treat now” she teases, finishing her beer. “Don’t wag your tail yet. I still need to do some talking.” She says, and Phainon rolls his eyes. He’s not a dog.

They stay for another round of drinks and snacks, Phainon’s treat. A small thanks for the offer, even if it doesn’t fall through at the end. Cipher fills him in on Castorice’s latest art project, and her success at the latest con, and Phainon cries how he had to miss two cons in a row because of work, or in his words: *“Ugh. Adult life.”*

He enjoys the chat, the laughs, the pleasant buzz from the alcohol, that he almost forgets about the whole Reddit disaster. But as they part ways a little past midnight, Phainon checks his notifications again on his walk home. The comments are still about the same a week later; most of them deeming him the asshole, and claiming he’s having a crush.

He isn’t. Mydeimos’ face flashes again in the back of his mind, and he shoves the thought down, it’s not like he would ever see the guy again after two failed attempts to revisit the café and befriend him.

The rest of his week passes in the same way, he refuses to keep thinking about the guy, busies himself with his deadlines, and by Thursday afternoon, Cipher calls him with an update, exclaiming happily that even her roommate is surprisingly cool with the idea. Castorice messages him a “thank you” later that night as well.

It is a two-birds-with-one-stone situation; he gets his housing problem solved, and his two dear friends get to finally live together. Perfect.

— ◇ —

The first person he tells the good news about fixing his living arrangements is Cyrene, his older sister. He travels to her over a free weekend, taking her out for dinner.

Cyrene always picks restaurants with overpriced desserts and fancy drinks, and tonight is no different. Phainon watches her take a bite of a patisserie with a satisfied hum, then another one, and another.

“So?” she prompts after half the thing is gone. “You look suspiciously pleased with yourself. Did you finally get promoted, or, wait, don’t tell me —” she pauses to add a dramatic effect. “My little brother finally passed the third date without being dumped?”

Phainon pouts at her, exaggerated and dramatic. “You’re evil. It’s not about work or dating.” Before adding quietly, “Let’s not talk about the dating part.” He leans back with a sigh, remembering his disastrous date and Mydeimos. He really needs to stop thinking about that barista.

“I fixed my housing problem.”

“Fixed?” Cyrene arches a brow, taking another bite of her dessert. “Last time we spoke, your rent was about to increase and bleed you dry.”

“Not anymore.” He grins, raising his hand in a V sign. “Cipher offered me her lease. She’s moving in with her girlfriend, and her place is bigger and cheaper. I even get a roommate who Cipher can vouch for being a quiet and responsible one.”

“I don’t know Phai,” Cyrene hums. “Sounds too good to be true.”

“I know, I thought so too at first.” Phainon shrugs. “But at this point, I’ll take anything that isn’t smaller than my already tiny apartment or cost a fortune.”

Her expression softens and she reaches for her glass of white wine, swirling it. “That’s good, Phai! I was starting to worry you’ll move to live in your car, or crash on my couch for eternity and work from home,” she laughs, adding, “You sure about the roommate though? Cipher’s definition of quiet might be different from yours…”

He groans. “I’ll take it even if he’s a little weird or loud. The bottom line is simple. I get cheaper rent, Cipher gets to move in with Castorice, a true win-win.”

“That actually sounds… responsible,” she admits. “Look at you, being a functioning adult.” And before he can say anything, she adds with a wink, “Just don’t fall for that roommate.”

“Why would I—” He kicks her under the table. “Don’t jinx it. I’ll be fine though. New place, new start. What could go wrong?”

Cyrene raises her glass, smirking at him. “Famous last words.”



The next month and a half stretch out. Between working and packing his belongings he forgets about the handsome barista almost completely, and by the time he’s ready to move, he only remembers that the guy's name starts with M. Or was it N?

“Better this way” Phainon tells himself. Once he moves out, he can go back to dating, and maybe… Maybe the new place would bring him better luck too, and he could get laid for once… He hopes his roommate wouldn’t mind if he brings women over.

And on a Saturday morning, a day before his lease ends, Phainon packs all his small belongings into his car and makes his way to Cipher’s place, with the movers in tow.

“Ready to meet your new home?” Both Cipher and Castorice greet him at the building entrance, and he doesn’t miss the lavender-haired girl's possessive grip on her partner. *Cute.*

“Thank you again, Phainon. I'm sure you and Mydei would get along!” Castorice chirps and grabs the suitcase from his hands.

“Mydei?” Phainon asks, the name scratches a familiar memory he can’t quite remember. It almost feels like he heard the name before.

“Your new roommate. He’s out at the moment but he should be home soon.” Cipher says, guiding the movers who are holding his mattress to the correct room.

Phainon steps into the living room, dropping a box on the coffee table. The place is cozy, much bigger than his apartment, like Cipher said. There’s a fancy looking couch right in front of him, a big kitchen to the right, and even a small balcony.

He suddenly feels like his landlady was ripping him off all these years.

The girls stay around to help him unpack, and they are almost done with the boxes in the living room when he hears the front door open. Eager to leave a good first impression, Phainon turns around to greet his new roommate.

And freezes in place, air leaving his lungs.

Semi-long blonde hair, dyed red at the tips. Sharp golden eyes. Chiseled jaw. A tank top that barely hides the man’s *very* muscular body… Recognition hits him like lightning.

Phainon is looking at the most handsome man he’d ever seen in his life.

Again.

Phainon’s stomach drops “Cipher!” He whisper-shouts, reaching her for attention. “It’s him. The guy— from the date.”

He’s too shocked to hear Cipher hollering in laughter, and from the way Mydeimos, or Mydei as Castorice called him, stares back at him, he’s probably just as shocked.

YTA and probably gay.

“So, I assume no introductions are necessary?” Castorice laughs alongside her girlfriend.

Fuck.

Chapter 2: It’s Not Gay, It's Just Exhaustion

Chapter Summary

> Phainon drags himself out of bed, putting on his glasses and tries half-heartedly to tame his bed hair— a mission impossible after he fell asleep last night without drying it first. He’s halfway through a yawn when he freezes at the kitchen’s entrance.
>
> Because Mydei is standing by the stove, a spatula in one hand, cooking what smells like Eggs and something meat. And he is very much shirtless, unless the towel around his neck can be called a shirt.
>
> Phainon’s brain short-circuits for a second.
>
> *“Wow.”* His mind supplies, unhelpfully.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon stands in the living room, frozen like a statue, and refuses to believe the whole situation is real. He’s glad he didn’t start unpacking his console yet, or else he would probably drop it on his foot out of sheer shock.

No-*fucking*-way.

Out of all people…

Mydeimos’ expression mirrors his at first, golden eyes widening in recognition, staring back at Phainon, before he averts his gaze to the laughing girls. The barista— no, his new roommate— crosses his arms over his chest in what seems like displeasure, and the tank top he’s wearing stretches with the motion, struggling to contain all the muscle, revealing more ink across his chest.

Phainon swallows hard, feeling the choker around his neck tighten as his throat bobs. He lets his gaze travel from the man’s broad chest to his surprisingly snatched waist, to wider hips covered by shorts that stretch nicely around his muscular legs and Phainon’s heart skips a beat when Mydeimos coughs awkwardly, catching him mid-staring, and is that a flush on the man’s cheeks?

“My eyes are up here.”

Nope. His heart absolutely did not skip a beat. He wasn’t checking him out just now. It’s not like that. He’s not into him, absurd body or not.

He doesn’t even know the guy for fuck’s sake!

"Sorry. Your physique is just… Impressive." Phainon manages, voice coming out higher-pitched than normal. "What are the chances… right? My name is Phainon by the way." He tries again.

Mydeimos looks at him with a reserved caution in his gaze, like he's assessing if Phainon can be trusted, before he lets his shoulders relax and nods at him, the single braid on the side of his face swaying with the motion in a way that should not look as cute as it does on a grown, muscular man.

“Mydeimos. Or Mydei for short.” He says, short and clipped. His voice is deep and smooth, as hypnotic as he remembers his movements at the café. Phainon briefly wonders what it would sound like in a quieter, more intimate setting.

“Like an ASMR” he tells himself. Not in person, of course.

"…date."

“Sorry, can you repeat that?” Phainon snaps into reality at the mention of dating, rubbing the back of his neck while scolding his brain for feeding him unnecessary thoughts.

They are about to be bros, homies, roommates. He really should stop acting weird around the guy.

“I said, What a small world, I didn’t expect my roommate to be the failed date guy.” The blonde repeats, adding, “Your attention span is just as bad outside of dates it seems,” with an unimpressed scowl.

Cipher wipes tears from her eyes, still doubled over against her girlfriend. "Oh man, this is gold. Absolute gold!"

Castorice elbows her, though her own smile is still there too, which is equivalent to a hysterical laughter from a regular person. "Be nice, Cipher. Don’t bully the poor guy too much. He’s already looking on the verge of combusting." She turns to Phainon then, her smile softening as she looks both at him and at Mydei, "I hope you two would get along."

Phainon nods, forcing a grin and falling back on his trademark charm like a lifeline. "Yeah, I hope so too!” he exclaims, a little too happy, “And, Mydei? Nice to officially meet you.” He extends a hand, proud of himself for not visibly shaking as he does so.

Mydei regards him for a moment, then uncrosses his arms and clasps Phainon's hand. His grip is firm, but his palms are surprisingly soft against Phainon's suddenly clammy ones. Up close, Phainon can see a small matching tattoo under the blonde’s left eye.

"Likewise," Mydei replies, tone gentle now that he doesn’t deem Phainon as an enemy. There's no accusation in his voice about the staring in the café, or minutes ago, just a quiet acceptance that eases some of the knot in Phainon's chest.

It takes Phainon two more trips to the car to finish getting all his belongings, while the movers carry the last of his furniture inside, and once everything is unloaded, Cipher claps her hands together, gathering Mydei’s attention who is chatting with Castorice about something Phainon can’t hear. "Alright, lovebirds” she says teasingly, “we'll leave you to it. Cas and I have some unpacking to do at her place as well. Don't get too handsy with each other." She winks at Phainon, then grabs Castorice by her waist and pulls her toward the door, the two women exchanging a quick giggle between them as they look at Phainon, making his face heat up.

“Why would I—we!?” Phainon shouts back at the now closed door.

He’s not into him. Although Mydei’s hands did feel really soft earlier…

— ◇ —

It takes Phainon nearly the entire day to unpack, the only thing forcing him to take a break is the consistent rumbling of his stomach— reminding him that he only ate a quick breakfast that day, and the dryness in his eyes from wearing contact lenses for so long.

“Mydei, I'm ordering takeout, you want anything?” he calls while making his way to the bathroom to take out the lenses and swap to his thick-framed glasses, but gets no answer. Weird, maybe he left at some point while Phainon was unpacking things in his room.

Why was he getting upset over it? It made no sense.

Ordering pizza, or two, in case his new roommate would want some, Phainon finishes unpacking the two remaining boxes.

An hour later, he is halfway through eating his pizza, lounging on the couch like he’s been living there forever with a random game walkthrough on TV — one about gathering data from a dinosaur overrun facility—mostly to watch something while he’s eating, when the apartment door opens.

Phainon glances over to see Mydei step inside, hair tied in a messy bun, wearing the same white polo he remembers under a leather jacket and carrying a few grocery bags in his hands.

“Hey,” Phainon says with his mouth still full, adjusting the glasses frame to sit better on his nose. “You’re alive.”

Mydei sets the bag on the kitchen counter and gives him a look that’s both offended and confused at once. “This is one way to greet your roommate...”

he trails off, eyeing what Phainon is wearing. "…and what is that hideous color combo?" In Phainon's defense, there is nothing wrong with an orange t-shirt, purple sweats, and green socks. It's not like he's planning to go out like that.

"What's wrong with it? I like the colors," He pouts defensively, taking another bite from the slice in his hand, "Anyway, you left so quietly I didn't even notice, thought you died or something."

"Left for work," Mydei replies, pulling off his jacket. He moves toward the kitchen with the kind of controlled ease that makes even unpacking groceries look way more interesting than the video on TV. "Got called in to cover a colleague."

"That sucks."

"It's not too bad." Mydei shrugs. He finishes emptying the bags before finally looking over. "You ordered food?"

"Yeah. Pizza. Want some?" Phainon gestures to the box beside him.

Mydei eyes the box for a moment, as if debating internally if he feels like cooking. With a sigh, he circles around the kitchen and sits on the other side of the couch, grabbing his phone from the back pocket. Phainon can see him open the pizza place's site, *"Is he about to count calories?"* Gym rats, he swears…

After another moment of searching whatever on his phone, Mydei leans forward and grabs a slice; at the same time he leans for another slice too, and their shoulders bump in the process. Phainon has to force his heart to *stop* doing this weird thing it did earlier too.

Why is he acting like a high schooler with a crush. Next to a dude.

He must be tired from all the unpacking.

"Didn't know you wear glasses," Mydei mentions between bites and looking at the TV screen.

“Why? Like me better with glasses on?” Phainon winks, to which his roommate rolls his eyes. “Although I wear them mostly at home, I prefer contact lenses.” He explains.

Mydei hums, returning his attention to the screen. The silence should feel awkward, perhaps even nerve-wracking, but it feels… comfortable in ways he cannot explain. The usual nervousness he feels around new people is not there, nor does he feel the need to wear his mask around the blonde, almost like he can be himself without worrying.

It’s pleasant.

“So,” Phainon changes the topic, because silence makes his brain think, no matter how comfortable it is, and he doesn’t want to keep thinking right now. “Did you really drop the mug because of my pickup line that day?”

Mydei huffs a quiet laugh, the corner of his mouth twitching upward. “I was caught by surprise.” He says, “It was quite funny too.”

“Just funny?”

“No, you’re right. It was terrible.”

Phainon gasps in mock offense. “Excuse you! That line was one of my best!”

Mydei smirks at him, challenging. “I'm sure you can do better than that, Deliverer of bad pickup lines.”

Phainon grins. Challenge accepted. “Oh?” He’s going to make Mydei take back his word. The blonde turns slightly toward him with a teasing glint in his gold eyes. “Alright, go on” he says, voice smooth and calm.

“Are you a time traveler?” Phainon asks, unable to suppress his smile from spreading wider.

Mydei raises a brow, tilting his head in question. “?”

“Because I can see you in my future.”

There’s a pause. A second where Mydei’s brain seems to malfunction. Then he bites back a snort, shoulders shaking like the day in the café, where he tried to contain his laughter. It takes him a solid minute or two to regain his earlier composure. “That was even worse.”

“You asked for it!” Phainon retorts, smiling wider now, almost proud of himself. He studies the man next to him for a moment. Looks aside, Mydei is quite stoic, if he lets the laughter at his own expense slide. It feels strange how easy it is to talk to him, he feels like they have known each other for years and not barely a few hours. Like they skipped the awkward getting-to-know-you stage without meaning to.

“I did. Unfortunately.” Mydei nods.

“I work in marketing, so I'm pretty good with words. Most don’t find it charming sadly.” He ends up explaining in a desperate attempt to defend his pride.

Mydei chuckles, grabbing a second slice. “So that’s your secret.”

“But don’t tell anyone,” Phainon brings a finger to the man’s mouth. “Gotta keep looking mysterious and charming to the ladies.”

He realizes what he is doing when it's too late, his finger is touching Mydei’s —very soft— lips, and Mydei is looking cross-eyed at the finger first, then at him, which makes the whole scene more intimate than anything he has ever experienced…

“Ah, sorry for that,” Phainon withdraws his hand too fast, like the contact burned him. Something is wrong with him today for sure. “What— what about you?” He fixes his glasses again so he can keep his free hand busy. “I know you’re working in that café, but is that all?”

Mydei nods, averting his eyes, and Phainon swears he can see that the blonde’s ears are as red as the tips of his hair. *Cute.*

No. He did not think that was cute. He didn’t.

“Working as a barista passes the time and gives me extra income.” Mydei says quietly, and Phainon focuses on his words the hardest he can, refusing to let his stupid brain sneak any more weird thoughts in his head. “I’m studying physical therapy, focusing on sports injuries.”

“That’s really cool!” He quips. The conversation drifts off after that as Mydei explains his field of studies in more depth, and Phainon can only blame himself and his —too tired— brain for not following much of it. So, he opts to talk about something lighter once his roommate grows quiet, making comments about the walkthrough on the TV instead. It distracts him enough not to think, but also keeps the silence away.

To his surprise, Mydei listens, offers little remarks, and engages in the conversation in a way that encourages Phainon to keep rambling, despite admitting that he does not know about gaming at all.

So he keeps rambling. From the game commentary he talks about his work again — about his coworkers, how he swears that his boss, Aglaea, has eyes everywhere, about how his office coffee tastes like wet cardboard and he has to make Starbucks runs every morning just to survive the day. Normally, he would feel embarrassed about oversharing so much on day one, but Mydei doesn’t look bored. He looks… relaxed. Like he’s actually enjoying himself.

“You’re staring, again,” Mydei points out, amused. “Is that a habit of yours? To stare at random guys?”

Phainon groans, burying his head in his —still greasy with pizza— hands. He didn’t even notice that he was looking at Mydei and not the TV. “You’re never gonna let me live that down, are you?” He groans again, this time from realizing that he smudges his glasses, and it’s going to be hell to clean pizza grease off the lenses.

“Not a chance.”

They both laugh. Phainon leaves for a moment to grab a lens wipe and wash his hands before returning to his place on the couch and letting the convo flow again. He learns that Mydei likes to read; mostly history books out of

all things, loves cooking, goes to the gym almost daily. He also owns a bike, which should be illegal for someone as attractive to be a biker too, but that is a thought for another day. Oh, and he is into guys. Which Phainon is totally cool with. He even offers to be his wingman if Mydei ever needs one.

And before long, lulled by the man's deep and calming voice, he finds himself yawning, barely able to keep his eyes open.

"Falling asleep already?" Mydei chuckles once he yawns for the who knows what time in the past minutes.

"Yeah." Phainon rubs his eyes, smiling sleepily. "Think the couch hypnotized me."

"Mhm, the couch, sure," Mydei teases, standing up to collect the empty cartons. "I'll clean this up. Go rest."

"Thanks, man. And, uh, thanks for the company. I'm glad we're getting along already."

Mydei looks at him for a second before smiling back. "Same. Good night, Phainon."

Phainon retreats to his new room after wishing Mydei good night as well. He emerges only once to quickly shower and brush his teeth, then flops onto the bed, staring at the ceiling, the night's banter replaying in his mind.

"*I knew it. We'd be great friends."* He thinks, and if his head repeats the way Mydei said his name, and his heart beats a little too fast, he chooses to ignore it. Mydei is just a bro, his new roommate and maybe a gym buddy, if Phainon starts working out more often. Nothing more.



Phainon wakes up to the smell of something delicious being cooked. Panic settles in him first, alarmed at the thought there was someone in his house, until his brain wakes up too, reminding him he doesn't live alone anymore. He moved out yesterday, and is sharing the place with Mydei, who he can safely assume is the one cooking.

One blurry glance at his phone tells him it's almost 10 A.M. Seems like he was beyond tired last night if he slept for almost twelve hours.

He drags himself out of bed, putting on his glasses and tries half-heartedly to tame his bed hair— a mission impossible after he fell asleep last night without drying it first. He's halfway through a yawn when he freezes at the kitchen's entrance.

Because Mydei is standing by the stove, a spatula in one hand, cooking what smells like Eggs and something meat. And he is very much shirtless, unless the towel around his neck can be called a shirt.

Phainon's brain short-circuits for a second.

"Wow." His mind supplies, unhelpfully.

The tattoos he saw in glimpses until now stretch all across Mydei's chest and back, trailing down his ribs before disappearing into the waistband of his sweatpants. Every muscle looks sculpted, and *God*, his waist looks even smaller without a shirt.

"Thinner than a woman's." His mind comments. Phainon peels his eyes away from the sight. He blinks, once. Twice. His mouth opens, but nothing comes out except, "Oh."

Mydei turns to look at the source of the noise, surprised. Then, as if realizing the situation or noticing the redness on Phainon's face, he apologizes. "Sorry. I forgot you're here." He scowls after saying it, much to Phainon's confusion, and opens his mouth again. "No, that's not right. I apologize. I didn't forget you, it's more of a habit."

"Huh? Habit?"

Now it was Mydei's turn to look away awkwardly. "Cipher didn't care, calling it an eye candy as a joke." He gestures vaguely to himself, like that explains everything. "I'll go put something on."

Phainon blinks again, managing something that resembles a smile. "You're fine, I don't mind it either," he says, voice steadier than he feels.

"Ok." Mydei, mercifully, nods and goes back to cooking, as if this isn't the most dangerous visual assault Phainon's eyes have ever experienced. He crosses the room, forcing his gaze anywhere but the broad expanse of tattooed skin. The counter. The half-full trash can. The microwave. Literally anything.

"Want me to make you a portion too? Unless you had time to grab groceries yesterday." And he's forced to look at Mydei again… Lord help him.

For a second, language abandons him.

He clears his throat.

"Please," Phainon responds, quieter than intended, and drops onto one of the dining table chairs, mind full of static at the sight of the man in front of him. He stares again, without meaning to, as Mydei moves around the kitchen. It's the same graceful motions as before; he cracks another two eggs one-handed, chops what looks like sausage into perfect cubes, grabs two mugs from the shelf above the counter, muscles flexing with every motion.

He tells himself it's pure admiration. That anyone with functioning eyes would stare at someone like Mydeimos, really. The guy's built like a Greek statue. It's the same as appreciating art in a museum. Nothing more.

"You're staring."

Phainon jolts so hard his knee hits the table. "I wasn't!"

Mydei's smirk is barely there, but it is there, and that's the problem. "Mhm." He slides a mug toward him. "Do you want sugar or sweetener?"

“Yes.”

“...That’s not an answer.”

“Right. Uh. Sugar.” He clears his throat, grateful to have something to look at that is *not Mydei*. He forces himself to focus on the mug, letting the steam fog up his glasses, and not even a minute later, a plate is placed in front of him, with Mydei sitting across with his own breakfast.

Phainon eyes the breakfast in awe: eggs, sausage, chopped cucumbers and bell peppers. He never had something this fancy in the morning, usually shoving a protein bar in his mouth or skipping breakfast completely whenever he woke up late.

“So, are you one of those people who eats healthy all the time?” He ends up blurting out his first thought.

“Pretty much,” Mydei says, matter-of-fact. “Keeping your physique is seventy percent diet. I can safely assume you don’t?”

“I usually don’t have the time in the morning, so whatever I can grab on the go,” Phainon admits, fingers idly messing with his choker. That earns him a quiet laugh from Mydei, low and warm. It shouldn’t sound as good as it does.

“Noted.” The blonde answers, and Phainon isn’t even sure what he means by that.

They eat in relative peace, relative because the food is so delicious that Phainon has to hold back from crying and making an even bigger fool of himself. He opts for commenting on how Mydei’s talent is wasted and how he should become a chef instead, and once they are done eating, Mydei stands up with a stretch of his arms before grabbing the plates.

It’s such an ordinary motion, but Phainon’s eyes catch the flex of his shoulders, the way his abs stretch, the trail of blonde hair disappearing into his waistband—

He nearly chokes on his coffee.

“You good there?” Mydei looks at him, concerned and confused at once.

“Fine! Totally fine.” Phainon waves him off, coughing into his elbow. “Coffee went down the wrong pipe.”

“Be careful.”

“I will. Thank you for the breakfast!” He says once he stops coughing, and heads back to his room, shutting the door behind him. Phainon leans against it, exhaling slowly, carding a hand through his hair.

“What is wrong with me?” He mutters to the empty room like it has the answer to that. There's no way he's into guys, even if Mydei is one hell of an eye-candy…

Cipher’s words.

Not his.



The following weeks settle into a rhythm that feels surprisingly domestic.

Phainon is genuinely surprised by how easily he adjusts to living with Mydei. He expected awkward silences, maybe fighting over chores or dirty dishes or fridge space— all the things he read or the r/badroommates subreddit about sharing an apartment.

Instead, it’s... comfortable, he’s usually one to hate silence, but even that feels welcoming with the blond around.

In the mornings, he starts seeing a lunchbox with his name on the counter, which becomes both a blessing and a curse: The food inside is always

amazing, and now anything he grabs from his workplace's cafeteria feels bland or subpar.

And then there is the other problem. Those lunchboxes are always arranged in the cutest ways.

"First word problems" Tribios, his senior at work, laughs when he complains half-heartedly that he doesn't have a heart to bite into the cat-shaped rice-ball. Her long red hair fills his field of vision as she leans over to grab a piece of fried chicken from his lunch. Another coworker leans from the other side of him, stealing a flower-shaped slice of carrot from the container, saying "Wife up the girl already."

Phainon laughs. He doesn't know where, or how, to explain that there is no girl, and those cutesy lunches are prepared by his roommate— a tall man who works out more than his whole department combined.

Although the idea of 'wifing up' Mydeimos makes him blush.

He changes the topic quickly before anyone notices.

During evenings, they settle into a routine that includes taking turns cooking, a competition that started somewhere in their first week of living together.

"Don't get used to it," Mydei said one night, while sliding a steaming bowl of pasta across the table.

"I already am," Phainon replied, grinning as he dug into the delicious looking dish. "You should try my salad too." He added around a mouthful.

"I'm not eating that rabbit food." Mydei huffed back, and Phainon took it personally, clutching his heart dramatically as if he was hurt by the blonde's words.

"Careful. Tomorrow I'm cooking dinner and I'll prove you that salads can be amazing." He declared.

The rest… well, the rest is history. It's been weeks, and there is still no clear winner. Mydei still slanders his salads.

After dinner, they usually spend their time together in the living room, chatting about their day, bickering over something meaningless, or just chilling. On some nights, Mydei sits at the opposite side of the couch and watches Phainon play through his games. On others, they are huddled closer as they watch Mydei's cooking show or catch up on Phainon's latest anime obsession.

Phainon never thinks too much about those nights. Never allows himself to.

He doesn't let his mind focus on their proximity, on their shoulders touching, or the way he can sometimes feel Mydei's eyes on him rather than on the screen. And definitely not about that one time where Mydei missed the bowl of popcorn and grabbed his thigh.

Nope. He was not thinking about that incident for two days straight.

Mydei is just a tactile guy, Phainon decides. Some people are like that, confident and comfortable about casual touches between bro's —at least, that's what he tells himself.

Because the more time passes, the more he becomes aware of it.

Mydei leaning in when he talks, Mydei brushing his fingers against Phainon's when he hands him a mug, Mydei laughing at every single one of his jokes…

His thoughts are weirdly full of Mydei as of late.

"We share a place, it's nothing unusual," he repeats for the umpteenth time that week. He just likes Mydei's presence in a friendly way. Mydei is steady and calm in contrast to Phainon's more outgoing personality. And he doesn't seem to mind Phainon's less cheerful moments, where his mood gets the better of him…

“You’re a good listener,” Phainon mumbles one night after venting to Mydei about how bad his day was; he was late to work, there was no nearby parking so he had to walk in the rain, Aglaea scolded him, and when he was about to grab lunch, he realized he had left his wallet at home. He rests his forehead against Mydei’s shoulder and groans loudly before he can think about how close they are.

Mydei chuckles, low and amused. “You’re loud enough for two people; someone has to balance it out.”

“Don’t insult me while I’m emotionally vulnerable.” Phainon pouts, his palm shoving at Mydei’s unoccupied shoulder light-heartedly.

“That was a compliment. I don’t mind your loudness.”

“You’re terrible.”

“Says the guy who admitted I'm a good listener seconds ago, looks like I'm not as terrible as you claim.” Mydei returns the gesture, smacking his head playfully.

Phainon laughs, feeling the tension from the day finally ease. He doesn’t move away. Doesn’t really want to. Mydei’s warmth is nice, his scent is calming.

He tells himself it’s normal friend stuff.

━ ◇ ━

Weeks turn into a month, then another, and Phainon feels less like they are roommates but partners, platonic, of course. Mydei borrows his sweaters once the temperatures start dropping, claiming he only owns turtle-necks— which sounds believable enough considering the guy's fashion style— and Phainon starts joining Mydei in the gym.

Occasionally.

He isn’t one to spend too much time in the gym to begin with, preferring running or doing manual labor over lifting weights in a crowded space, unless the weather is really bad and he can’t go out; an excuse he tells himself to justify the gym membership he keeps paying for without using. Yet, when Mydei texts him one afternoon, asking if he wants to join him in the gym, he agrees instantly.

Phainon regrets it after the first set. His physique is impressive, yes, but Mydei lifts way more than should be humanly possible, and being the sore loser he is, Phainon makes the mistake of challenging the blonde into a lifting competition, using the same weights Mydei does.

Needless to say, he loses, spectacularly, to the point of being so sore the next day he needs to call off work.

And a few days later, on a sunny Saturday, when Phainon’s date cancels on him at the last minute— he’s not sure why Mydei sounds almost relieved about it when he tells him, but he chooses to ignore it— he decides to pay his roommate back for the gym torture by dragging him into a gaming session. It’s more fun than sitting at a bar with a stranger anyway.

“It’s easy. You literally can’t mess it up, all you have to do is avoid falling off the platform, literally.” Phainon explains the rules of the game, tossing Mydei a controller.

“I’ll take that as a challenge,” the blonde deadpans.

An hour later, Phainon is crying from how hard he’s laughing. Mydei manages to get knocked off the platform in every round and every map they tried: by a spinning bar, by falling fruit, by other players when he tries matching up with others, and even by standing completely still.

“Man, you’re hopeless!” Phainon wheezes, doubled over, wiping his glasses from all the tears.

Mydei scowls at him, adding a sharp glare for emphasis, his controller resting in his lap. “You said this was easy.”

“I’ve never seen someone die so many times in a game that’s literally about *not falling*!” Phainon shoots back between fits of laughter.

It’s just them playing a stupid game, but it’s the most fun he had in weeks. And two more rounds later, two rounds where Mydei still falls off of every single platform in the funniest ways possible, the man puts the controller on the table, and leans against him, resting his head on Phainon’s shoulder with a scowl.

“I’m done with this. We will rematch tomorrow over something less difficult” Mydei huffs. And Phainon only nods weakly, suddenly hyperaware of their proximity, heart beating so loud he’s pretty sure Mydei can hear it.

“This is normal between two bros.” He screams inside his head.

But is it really?

Later that night, Phainon finds himself unable to sleep, mind reeling. He has male friends, plenty of them… Piso, for example, is his childhood friend. They were always close, but he can’t think of a single encounter where Piso’s touch made his heart beat loudly in his chest, and they shared a lot of hugs between them in the past.

He thinks of Caelus next, although they don’t speak too much nowadays with Caelus traveling around the galaxy, they have a mutual love for games and have flown to cons together several times, sharing hotel rooms to save costs. Phainon never found it embarrassing or weird to sleep in the same bed as his friend, yet the idea of sharing a bed with Mydei makes heat crawl to his face at an alarming speed.

“Maybe it’s admiration then?” Phainon whispers into the quiet room, pouting. That would make sense. He admired his professor back in university, too. But at the same time, he never felt at ease around Prof. Anaxagoras as he does around Mydei.

The only person who comes to mind when he’s thinking about his current relationship with Mydeimos is Livia, another childhood friend of his. But back then, when they were close friends, he had a crush on the girl…

“Enough of this nonsense,” Phainon rolls over to face the wall, burying his face into the pillow with a loud groan.

“We are just friends.”



His reasoning of being “just friends” goes down the drain merely a few days later.

Phainon’s day had been long, dragging with too many client meetings and co-worker drama. He returns home exhausted and all he wants is to sink into the couch and zone out for a solid hour, maybe have a nice dinner if Mydei is home early, as it is his roommate's turn to cook.

Yet, the gods seemed to have a different plan for him, because Mydeimos is indeed home when Phainon enters the apartment, but he’s also bent down in front of the couch, rummaging for something with one arm extended, the other braced against the floor for balance, ass up in the air.

And just like that, Phainon forgets how breathing works.

“You okay there?” he manages to ask, weakly, not that he’s paying attention to anything other than the illegally short gym shorts Mydei is wearing, ones that leave absolutely nothing to the imagination. The thin fabric stretches across his muscular thighs, clinging like a second skin, showing a glimpse of round flesh and the outline of his balls when he stretches further, trying to reach whatever is under the couch.

Phainon’s mind goes utterly blank at first, then floods with too many thoughts at once, the majority of them scale between *“fuck,”* and *“his ass looks really nice...”*

He tries to look away, to act normal, but his eyes disagree and remain glued on Mydei— watching his back arch, zeroing in on the glimpse of ink where his shirt is riding up, then trailing down to watch his shorts ride up even more when he shifts.

Phainon's stomach flips. His pulse stutters. His cock twitches.

What?

“Oh, fuck,” he breathes, too quietly for Mydei to hear. The urge to knead the soft looking flesh, to grab Mydeimos’ hips and *thrust*, leaves his knees weak.

“…fell under the couch.”

Phainon doesn’t notice when Mydei sat back on his knees, or when he turned over… But it’s somehow worse that he did, because his roommates’ eyes are on the growing bulge between his legs, and he swears he can see Mydei lick his lower lip momentarily.

Phainon feels lightheaded, caught like a deer in headlights, eyes wide and face *burning*. His throat is dry, voice stammering out of him before his brain can say something much dumber. “Oh. Did you say something?”

Mydei raises a brow, clearly amused, and looks up at him. “My phone. Fell under the couch.” He can see the sharp golden eyes of his roommate studying his face for a second.

“You seem flustered.”

“I’m not flustered.” Phainon manages a polite smile, clearing his throat. “Just tired, it’s been a long day, that's a—”

“Mhm.” Mydei doesn’t let him finish the sentence. He holds Phainon’s eye contact for a long moment, gold staring at blue, and then he lowers his gaze

back to the now *very visible* tent in his pants with a knowing smirk. “Tired. Right.”

Phainon nearly chokes on his spit.

Mydei gets up and takes a small step toward him. There’s a glint of something in his eyes; playfulness, curiosity, maybe both.

“You sure it’s exhaustion?” he asks, voice dropping lower, sounding more intimate.

“Yes,” Phainon forces a laugh that sounds painfully fake. “In fact. I’m so tired I'm going to take a nap right now… Nice ass—uh, evening! Have a nice evening!” He disappears into his room before Mydei gets a chance to say anything else.

Slamming the door behind him, Phainon buries his head in his arms, leaning against the door. His mind is a mess— running the image of Mydei's ass like a broken video. His cock throbs pathetically, begging for attention. His heart beats too loudly in his ears. Phainon squeezes his eyes shut, trying to take a deep breath.

“What is wrong with me?” he mutters, frustrated.

Getting hard over his friend’s— stupidly round and soft-looking— ass was not something he ever thought he’d be doing. But here he is, still hard, painfully so, wishing for the ground to open up and swallow him.

And the fact that Mydei didn’t seem to mind, in fact, the blonde didn’t seem to mind at all.

Gods, something was really wrong with him.

Phainon sits on his bedroom floor for a long time, trying to calm down. Yet, the image of Mydeimos refuses to leave his head. With a defeated sigh, he stands up and walks to the bathroom, hoping that a cold shower will help him clear his mind.

Unfortunately for him, the cold water, although refreshing, doesn't offer the desired help. Each droplet only reminds him of the line of water that had trickled down Mydei's chest that one morning when he came out of the shower, the way sweat beaded at his collarbones after an intense workout—

He grits his teeth and stands there until he's shivering.

"Okay," he mutters under his breath once he can feel his erection going down, finally. "Okay. That didn't happen. That didn't mean anything. I'm just tired."

The excuse sounds weak, even to him, but it's better than thinking about it more than he already does.

He turns the water into a hotter setting, finishes showering, and escapes back to his room with the same cautious steps, in case Mydei is around.

Dressed up, Phainon falls face-first into bed, praying that a nap will fix whatever is happening to him.

It doesn't.

He ends up dreaming of gold eyes, teasing smiles, and a *very nice-looking* ass.

Chapter End Notes

I was planning to post this one last night, I blame currency wars for not locking in the same way Phainon blames his tiredness ↕

Come and yap with me on twt

Chapter 3: It’s Not Gay, It’s a “Glitch”

Chapter Summary

> What the fuck has he done? Did he really just…?
> Yes. He absolutely did.
> This isn't like him. Phainon isn't... into guys. He likes women. He’s supposed to like women. That’s what society expects from him...
> Today was— today is another glitch.
> He is pent-up, that's all.
>
> Or; the lies Phainon tells himself to justify his attraction.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon’s nap lasts longer than planned, and by the time he wakes up, it’s already morning and he’s somehow both emotionally tired and starving.

Mydei moves around the kitchen when he emerges from his room, humming under his breath as he preps breakfast for them like nothing happened. It should be another morning, something completely harmless, but Phainon sees a familiar pair of shorts on his roommates’ legs.

He blinks once. Twice. Suddenly *very* awake.

Those are the same shorts he wore yesterday. The. Same. Shorts.

Phainon tells himself to stop thinking, and immediately starts thinking harder.

The sound of the coffee pot boiling distracts his indecent thoughts away, followed by Mydei’s soothing voice, “same as usual, right?” and Phainon croaks a “Yeah, thanks,” in response, surprised by how composed he sounds on the outside.

Mydei glances over at him once he sits down at his usual spot by the table, and places breakfast in front of him like nothing's weird. Maybe nothing is weird. Phainon wishes he believed that.

"It's better to forget it," he convinces himself. No, that would be incorrect. He forces himself to forget that and act like he didn't get turned on by his roommate's perfectly round ass—

"Stop it!"

Thankfully, Mydei doesn't mention yesterday's incident, doesn't tease him, or joke about his reaction. Not during that morning, nor in the days that follow.

If anything, Phainon notices, Mydei warms up to him even more: offering to cook for him more frequently, listens intently to Phainon's complaints about work and his emotional distress over an anime episode ending in a cliffhanger, and even picks his favorite chocolate one day, after Phainon sulked the day prior about it being out of stock in the grocery store next to his workplace.

And Phainon? He does the same, tries to, even if he withdraws his hand away too fast when Mydei's fingers brush his by accident, or moves to the edge of the couch so they don't sit too close to each other while gaming, convincing himself he's just being respectful by keeping their physical touches to a minimum.

He also encourages Mydei to go on a date when the blonde tells him about a match he got, asking to show him pics and approves the guy with a thumbs up. Even going as far as offering to stay at his sister's place for the night and free up the apartment like a good bro would. He's due to visit Cyrene anyway.

"That's how it should be," he tells his own mind. Mydei should let loose, have his fun, and Phainon, as his friend and roommate, will be supportive of it. That's what friends do after all.

Mydei only looks at him with a raised eyebrow, denies the offer to free the apartment, and… does he seem upset about this? Phainon tries to believe he imagined it, ignoring the unsettling feeling in his stomach when Mydei does, in fact, tell him that he's right and he'll be going out with that guy in a few days.

He ends up sulking the whole day at work, to the point where even Aglaea herself got concerned, approaching him with a hot coffee and telling him to have a longer break, and Phainon thanks her, but instead of taking that break he texts Cyrene and asks her to meet up on the same day, not even sure why he did that.

Cyrene's reply comes later that day, informing him she's too busy to travel all the way to Okhema to see her little brother. What kind of sisterly love is that? Busy when he needs her most…

"Back to square one," he sighs, trying to focus on his mountain of emails.

— ◇ —

Phainon's day had been a disaster since the second he opened his eyes. He couldn't find his glasses at first, dropped one of the contact lenses as he tried to put them in instead, only to realize it was his last pair, and if that wasn't enough— he got distracted while cooking and burned his breakfast…

And it's only been an hour since he woke up.

At least he found his glasses sometimes during his cooking process.

He tells himself it isn't because Mydei has a date after work today. Definitely not. He is a supportive roommate. A good friend… And yet here he is, sulking into his phone like a kicked dog while sipping on his lukewarm and too-bitter coffee.

At least the gods are kinder to him as the day progresses, and his salvation comes in the form of a message from Castorice, about an hour later. He's never been so thankful for his friend's timing.

Castorice [11:02 AM]: Are you free?

Phainon [11:03 AM]: Let me check my calendar…

Castorice [11:04 AM]: That means you're free. I'll drop by in 30 minutes, get dressed nicely please. No weird color combinations.

Phainon [11:05 AM]: What? Why?

Castorice [11:06 AM]: Cipher's birthday is coming soon, I need help with a gift.

He should tell her no, stay there and wait for Mydei to return, congratulate him if the date went well... But "no" isn't really an option when Cas decides she needs something from him, nor does he really want to hear about the date. If it's a success, he'll be happy for Mydei. If not, well, somehow Phainon thinks he'll feel better if it doesn't work out.

Shaking the thought away he gets dressed, muttering "I really need to get my shit together" under his breath. Mydei was nothing but kind to him, and here he is, being a weirdo over him dating people. And while at it, he should stop looking at Mydei's body at every chance he gets. Although that is easier said than done when you live with a man as attractive as Mydeimos.

True to her word, Castorice picks him up not even thirty minutes later, nursing an overpriced iced coffee while parking the car outside the building with a surgical focus. The first thing she does when he opens the car door is eye him from head to toe, sighing in relief as she sees him dressed decently per her request, like he's incapable of dressing nicely— he does, occasionally.

"Remind me," he says once he's inside the car, "why are we buying a gift now when her birthday's next month?"

“So I won’t have to worry about it later,” Castorice answers without looking at him, cursing something under her breath when another car merges into her lane without turning their blinkers. “Also, you owe me for letting you take over my girlfriend’s lease.”

“I’m pretty sure I owe Cipher for that.”

“And she’s my partner, so technically speaking, you also owe me.” She hums, clearly playing with him.

“That’s… not how math works.”

“It’s how *relationships* work,” she counters, sounding too proud of herself.

“Right, of course. The sacred math of partnership, I wouldn’t know it since I got none.” He tries to pout and act offended, but ends up laughing.

“Exactly.” She gives him a small smile, which, for Castorice, is the same as a regular person’s loud laughter.

They end up driving to Okhema’s biggest mall, checking all the relevant stores. It takes Castorice seven stores to admit defeat, ready to drive to a different mall, when she stops in front of a small jewelry shop. Cas’s gaze locks on a leather choker, one that has a pendant of a cat’s head attached to it. “How about this? You think she would like it?”

“She’d like anything you give her,” Phainon says casually, but still leans closer, studying the craftsmanship of the accessory as if it was one of his favorite antiques. “Even more than like, since it has a cat pendant.”

“Really?” She sounds casual, deadpan, but he can see how happy she looks underneath the calm facade. Call it years of friendship, but he’s quite confident in his ability to read Castorice, her chaotic partner though? Not so much. At least he knows what she likes.

“I’m pretty sure that Cipher was a cat in her past life. She’d absolutely love it.”

Castorice nods, pleased, and drags him inside the store. “You’re surprisingly useful sometimes.”

“High praise coming from you, ‘princess homebody’”

Castorice smacks him lightly on the shoulder, but hums happily under her breath nonetheless while the clerk packs the gift.

They end up refilling Phainon's lenses prescription and wander around the mall afterward, Castorice still beaming in her every stoic way, and him tagging along, carrying the ever-growing amount of shopping bags as they enter yet another store, where she leaves him momentarily to try on a dress. Phainon doesn’t mind the aimlessness, or the new bag that pops in his hands minutes later; anything to keep him from thinking too hard. It’s easier to comment on Castorice’s outfits and laugh about overpriced accessories than to sit at home, waiting for a door to open and hear Mydei laugh on the phone with someone else…

“Nope. Not thinking about that.” Phainon shakes his head.

He should focus on Castorice, be a good friend, definitely not wonder if Mydei’s date liked blondes, or men who basically live in the gym, or look unfairly good in shorts—

“Stop thinking.”

Eventually, his stomach reminds him that he hadn’t eaten anything since his failed breakfast attempt in the morning, and he drags Castorice to the food court. They end up sitting at a small corner table with trays of noodles and a giant iced tea for Cas. She eats in her usual quiet way: taking small bites, like a hamster, while Phainon pokes at his stir fry, chewing only because she gives him a flat look every minute or so.

Despite the hunger, the earlier thought of Mydei is still gnawing at him, and he’s losing his appetite again.

“Phainon,” she says finally, after looking at him for the umpteenth time, “what’s wrong?”

“Nothing, I'm fine,” he tries laughing it off.

“You’re moping,” she points, reading right through him. “You’ve been sighing every five minutes since I picked you up.”

Phainon lets out another sigh, this time on purpose, and leans back in his chair. “I’m fine. Tired after a long week that’s all.”

Castorice raises an eyebrow at him. “A long week, or perhaps it has something to do with Mydei?”

The question catches him off guard. He chokes on his noodles. “What? No! Why would— what kind of— who told you that?!”

“No one,” she responds, watching him calmly, “Just a wild guess.” Cas points at him with her fork, worry written all over her face. “Are you two not getting along? Or did something *different* happen between you two?”

Phainon blushes, coughs, blushes deeper. The memory of the accident from last week pops into his head, completely uninvited. “It’s not— I mean, he’s great! Really great! And nothing happened, not that anything should happen! We’re getting along really well. It’s just…” He trails off, searching for words he doesn’t know how to put together. “I don’t know. He has this date today, and it’s… weird. That’s all.”

“Weird?” she echoes.

“Like,” he gestures vaguely, like the random wave of his hand is a perfectly understandable explanation, “I shouldn’t care, right? He can date whoever he wants, sleep around, whatever floats his boat... I do want him to be happy and all that. I just,” His voice drifts again, heart beating too loudly with confusion, and another emotion he is too scared to name. “It feels strange, like I have a hard time being genuinely happy for him. And I don’t even know why.” He confesses, rubbing the back of his neck - a nervous gesture he never seems to get rid of. “Maybe I’m being stupid.”

Castorice studies him quietly for a long moment. Then her expression softens, a small knowing smile curves on her lips. “I don’t think you’re

stupid, Phainon. Love is a complicated emotion after all."

Phainon's mind short circuits, time stopping around him. Love? No way. Return it. Send it back. He didn't order this.

If silence had a sound, it would be the ringing in his ears.

It takes him a moment, but Phainon blinks at her once, then once more, his face lighting on fire. "Love? No. Cas, no. What— I don't— It's not like that!"

"Mm," she hums, clearly not buying it.

"It's not!" He tries to laugh it off, but it comes out high pitched, nervous. "We're just friends! Roommates. That's it." *"Bros. Dudes. The platonic stuff."* He doesn't add that part loudly.

"Sure, if you say so." She takes a slow sip from her iced tea with the same innocent-looking smile.

He slumps forward on the table, mindful of the trays and runs a hand through his hair, groaning in defeat. "You're enjoying this too much."

"I do" she admits, deadpan, but her eyes are kind when she looks at him. "But don't be too hard on yourself... Feelings don't always make sense."

"I'm telling you there are no feelings!" He whines again, defeated. Castorice gives him the mercy of not pushing further, but the thought has already taken root in his head.

There's no way he likes Mydei more than a friend, it's absurd.

Yet, his heart skips a beat at the thought. Again.

Phainon changes the topic after that: Inquires about Cipher's latest job shenanigans, Castorice's new novel, his own usual work drama, and once they leave the mall, the sun is slowly setting in the sky despite it being barely five p.m.

He leans against the car’s window as Castorice drives them back to his place, and thinks about what she said.

Ridiculous. He doesn't love Mydei. Not like that. They are roommates and nothing beyond that. Whatever weird flutters his heart has been doing are... anomalies. Glitches in his straight-as-a-ruler system. They just get along well. That’s all. Mydei is easy to talk to, easy to be his true self with, easy to… like, *as a friend*.

It’s normal to be upset when your new best friend might be taken away by a stranger. Isn’t it?

“…non?” Phainon feels a cold hand on his shoulder. He turns around slowly, returning to reality. Castorice is looking at him with concern and a knowing smile. “Earth to Phainon, we're at your place” she says.

“Sorry, I got caught up in thoughts” he smiles sheepishly at her, thanking the girl for today, and exits the car, her words *“Feelings don’t always make sense”* still linger in his head as he looks up, toward his apartment.

The light in Mydei’s room is on.

He feels a ridiculous little jolt of hope: maybe the date went badly.

Then dread: maybe the date went really well.

“Why am I like this...” Phainon bites the inside of his cheek until he tastes metal.

Aside from the light coming from Mydei’s slightly open bedroom door, the rest of the house is dark, silent, and smells like a freshly baked pastry.

“Was Mydei stress baking again?” Phainon wonders, followed by *“Why is he so adorable.”* And “*Stop that thought right there.”* He takes off his shoes and coat as quietly as possible. already tiptoeing into his own room, in case Mydei does have someone over. He doesn’t want to make it awkward or interrupt anything.

He'll take a quick shower first, calm down his nerves, and if Mydei is alone he would ask him how the date went.

Phainon emerges from his room moments later in nothing but a towel, fantasizing about relaxing under the hot stream, when a muffled sound coming from Mydeimos' room, stops him dead in his tracks.

His eyes open comically wide, head turning so fast he feels dizzy. No, the reason for the sudden dizziness was the sound. Phainon stares at the slightly open door like a startled animal.

Did he just hear a *moan*?

It happens again seconds later. Low, muffled, deep, and unmistakably Mydei's. Followed by a slick sound that sends his mind into overdrive, and all his blood to his gut.

Phainon's heart stutters. Is Mydei... alone? Or does he have someone over?

Despite his better judgment, Phainon doesn't move, he strains his ears, tries to listen harder, tries to pick up on a different voice under the wet noises of skin-on-skin, when another moan follows, louder this time, drawn out and desperate.

"Wait a minute" his brain catches up, finally. There are no extra shoes by the entrance, or a coat, or anything indicating there's another person in the house. Which means… his thoughts take a different direction: Since Mydei is alone, what is he thinking about? Does he have a random porn video open on his phone? Maybe an erotica book, like the ones Castorice writes? Or— Brain, stop, please— someone specific? Like him…

His little fantasy is cut off with a louder grunt, followed by a string of muffled curses and rustling of fabric.

Phainon bolts into the bathroom faster than a cat who encountered a cucumber.

“Calm down. Calm down. Calm down!” He repeats like a broken record, closing the door as quietly as he can despite the panic. He did not just listen to Mydei pleasuring himself. He did not.

The attempt his futile though, his body has already reacted to the erotic sounds. Heat pools low in his stomach, the towel around his hips tenting. He is hard. Embarrassingly hard. From the sound of his roommates' moaning, *Mydei's moaning*. Phainon swallows, cheeks burning with shame.

This isn't happening. Not again. Not like the gym shorts incident he has buried deep in denial.

"Fuck," he groans, pressing a palm to his face. He wants to scream. Of course Mydei's moans would be as beautiful as the rest of him; deep and rough, almost pornographic. His traitorous cock throbs again, begging for attention as the blonde’s deep voice keeps playing over and over in his head.

"What the hell is wrong with you?" Phainon mutters to his reflection in the mirror, stripping the towel off with shaky hands. The cool air in the room does nothing to help; it makes him twitch harder instead, like his cock is searching for warmth, wanting to bury itself inside Mydei—

Hell no. He isn’t continuing that thought.

Turning the water and stepping into the shower, Phainon tilts his head back, letting the coolness of it wash over his face, and hopefully wash his dirty, dirty mind too. It doesn’t. If anything, the quiet of the shower amplifies his thoughts. Mydei's moans replaying on loop, each one sending a fresh jolt through him.

His hand moves south before he can stop it, wrapping around his hard length with a hiss. It should not feel *this* good.

“Just to take the edge off,” It's not desire, Phainon convinces himself. It's not. He’s pent up, he didn’t get the chance to get off in a while. That's all this is. It’s not about it being Mydei, it’s about *him*. Hearing anyone’s moans would’ve caused the same effect.

Phainon starts slowly. He closes his eyes and thrusts experimentally into his fist.

“Fuck…” he grunts, trying to think of some of the prettier girls he got to date to make it more pleasurable, like the one with the really big chest, how soft it felt against his palm when she allowed him to touch it. But his fantasy doesn’t hold, it changes to Mydei within seconds; the way his muscles flex when he cooks shirtless, the tattoos that disappear below his waistline, those amber-gold eyes, sharp and blown wide with pleasure…

“I wonder if his chest would be as soft, big enough to wrap around his length if he pressed his pecs together—” Biting his lip, Phainon picks up the pace, fucking harder into his fist. His traitorous brain keeps thinking of Mydei, imagines a soft palm wrapped around his begging cock instead of his own callused one. What would it feel like? Would he be slow and gentle? Or maybe Mydei would stroke him hard and fast, too impatient to tease? Maybe he’d even suck him off if Phainon asked him to? He whimpers at the thought of the blonde’s soft lips on his cock.

God, Mydei sounded so good, so hot, so… Needy.

He shouldn’t be thinking of that, shouldn’t be thinking about what fantasy was his roommate moaning to, yet his mind kept betraying him, conjuring the idea of Mydeimos, moaning *his* name, pleading for Phainon to take him, fuck him, *claim him*.

If he wasn’t this hard and pent up, he would’ve been angry at himself for even entertaining the thought, but he’s too far gone to care.

Phainon leans against the shower wall, tipping his head back with another moan he manages to suppress this time— by biting on his knuckle. His pace picks up once he feels the familiar coil in his stomach tightening, and he chases the pleasure; thumb circling the head on each upstroke, then teasing the sensitive underside when his hand glides lower.

He’s so close he can’t filter his thoughts any longer, and it’s a dangerous thing, because his mind wanders freely, back to Mydei, bent in front of the couch. What if Phainon had given in to his intrusive thought, walked up

behind him and grabbed his hips? Tore those shorts and thrust into that round ass?

Would Mydei love it? Would he moan his name this time?

"Fuck, Mydei," he gasps, squeezing the base just right, thrusting once, twice more, and his hips still. Phainon comes so hard he can swear he’s seeing stars. His back arches off the wall, toes curling, cock pulsing in his hand, spilling hot ropes of cum over it, body shuddering as he cries out, "Mydeimos!"

The aftershocks leave him trembling, spent. He stands there long after his body calms down, the back of his head pressed to the tiles, the high of his pleasure fading into a cold wave of mortification.

What the fuck has he done? Did he really just…?

Yes. He absolutely did.

He jerked off to his roommate's moans. And to make things worse, called his name while coming. This isn't him. He isn't... into guys. He likes women. He’s supposed to like women. That’s what society expects from him...

Today was— today is another glitch. He is pent-up, that's all.

Yeah. That makes sense.

He needs to get laid.

“It’s time I get back to dating” Phainon decides, stepping under the still running water. That’ll fix it. Right? Cipher's teasing, Castorice’s claims, the Reddit comments, they are all wrong. He isn't in denial. He is stressed, horny, and sharing space with someone objectively hot. Anyone would react like this if they lived with a man who looked like a Greek statue and a supermodel at the same time.

Taking a deep sigh, he washes quickly, scrubbing his skin harder than necessary as if it will wash the shame away, and by the time he gets out,

he’s clean, sure— but mostly of his dignity.

Dressed up and dry, Phainon walks to the kitchen, noticing briefly how Mydei’s door is now fully closed. He needs a beer, or three, to forget this emotional mess he’s been experiencing.

That sounded like a really good, and unhealthy, plan.

Sinking onto the couch with a bottle in hand, he reaches for his pocket to grab the phone and starts scrolling through dating apps with renewed determination.

Left. Left. Left again. He slaps himself internally for being so picky all of a sudden. Right. Nothing in common but he still swipes right. The next girl’s bio says she’s not looking for anything serious. He swipes right anyway.

It doesn’t matter if the women are his type or not, he’s doing it for the sake of his sanity.

He lands on a profile of a young woman with blonde hair and bright hazel eyes. He never swiped right this fast.

Phainon: *Are you a religion?*

Phainon: *Because you’re everything I’ve been praying for.*

Mydei enters the living room as he’s typing the pick-up line with one hand, and sips on his beer with the other. The first thing he notices is that Mydei is wearing a loose sweater, *his* sweater, and shorts that thankfully cover more than the gym ones. He looks relaxed, a post whatever-he-was-doing glow on his handsome face. Phainon forces his eyes away, scolding his brain for not cooperating, as usual.

"Hey," Mydei says, his voice sounding slightly higher, like he’s surprised to see Phainon home. "When did you get back?"

“When you were… a little busy in there,” Phainon almost blurts out, stopping right as he opens his mouth. “About half an hour ago?” He sounds steadier than he feels. Good.

Mydei nods, his posture tenses, face flushing, then relaxes seconds later when Phainon doesn’t add anything else. "I see. How was your day?"

"Castorice dragged me to do some shopping." Phainon shrugs, “How about your date?” He doesn’t address the discomfort in his chest as he asks the question, nor the hope to hear that it wasn’t good.

Mydei opens the fridge and pours himself a glass of a dark red liquid, and if Phainon didn’t know the man well enough by now— he could’ve been fooled that it’s actually wine and not his beloved pomegranate juice. He sits on the couch beside Phainon, close enough for their shoulders to touch.

“It wasn’t worth it,” he ends up saying. “The guy didn’t want anything serious and I don’t do casual hookups.”

Phainon hums in response, pretending its sympathy he's feeling and not relief. Why would he even feel relieved about it? “His loss, more Mydei for me” he adds lightly, teasing, reaching over to give Mydei a light pat on the shoulder. He means it as casual comfort, a friendly gesture, but Mydei doesn’t pull away. Instead, he leans in closer, resting his head on Phainon’s side with a quiet “yeah. Maybe it’s not such a bad thing.”

Phainon tells himself not to think about it. Not to think too much about the implications or the physical proximity. Definitely not about the physical proximity.

Their conversation dies after that, settling into a comfortable silence as Phainon plays the latest cooking show episode— Mydei’s favorite— and they settle more comfortably as they watch a guy who worked in Michelin star restaurants fail to impress the judges with his seared cod dish. At some point, when another contestant panics on screen for not finishing her dish on time, he gets up to grab another beer; to make sure he doesn’t sober up and start thinking.

When he sits back down, Mydei leans in again, forcing Phainon into a half-lying position as he cuddles to him, relaxed and content. Phainon starts praying for his heart to stop beating so loudly.

By the time the episode ends, Mydei is dozing on top of him, and Phainon is glad he's tipsy or else he would've panicked for sure. He wakes up his roommate gently by caressing his hair, whispering, "You shouldn't sleep on the couch or you'll catch a cold."

To which, Mydei grumbles something that sounds close to "you're warm enough", but still gets up when Phainon pokes at his cheek, dragging himself to his bedroom with a sleepy pout.

It's only when Phainon grabs a third beer that he allows his thoughts to reflect on this evening, determined more than ever to prove —mostly to himself— that the accident from earlier and the cuddling session they had minutes ago are nothing more than a slip-up. He's just comfortable around Mydei. They are really close friends. That's all.

And once he hears Mydei's bedroom door close, Phainon does what any emotionally stable adult would do:

He opens Reddit. Goddamn Reddit. Again.

The first thing he does is scroll aimlessly through the relationships sub, looking for any situations similar to his. When he finds none, he types in the subreddit he was initially supposed to look at: *r/askgaybros*.

His first? Second? Tenth? Mistake for the night is to press the "new post" button. He blames it on Mydei. On the stupidly handsome Mydei who shows his naked torso too much and moans like a porn-star.

> **Is it gay to get hard from hearing your roommate moan?**
>
> **u/33550336**
>
> Idk where to ask and I need someone to tell me im not losing it.
>
> so I (27M, straight) live with my best friend/roommate (25M, gay). He's a cool guy, nothing weird between us, total bro situation.

Anyway, earlier today I *accidentally* overheard him… you know, doing stuff. Alone.

I wasn't trying to eavesdrop or anything, it just… happened when I passed by his room on my way to the shower. The thing is…he … *sounded really good*. Like, ridiculously good. And I got so hard I had to take care of it. I might've ended up thinking about him while doing that too…

I've only ever liked women, or at least I think so? The idea of liking men never crossed my mind. But for some reason, hearing him did something to me. idk. I feel weird even typing this, honestly.

It's not like I *want* him or anything. He's objectively attractive, and maybe I was pent-up, and the sound caught me off guard. Right?

Anyway, it's been a few hours and we cuddled on the couch for a good hour just now (I was comforting him after a bad date, nothing more!) but I can't stop thinking about earlier and it's driving me insane. Like, am I a creep or it means im into him now?

TL;DR Heard my male roommate jerking off, got hard, don't know what the hell that says about me. Please tell me this isn't gay.

He reads it quickly, cringing internally. Maybe externally as well.

"Don't do it," he mumbles, "you're gonna regret it in the morning." He commits another mistake and clicks the 'Post' button.

Phainon groans, flopping onto his back, phone slipping from his hand onto the couch, already regretting posting it. He'll delete the post tomorrow. Or blame it on the alcohol. Or both. But for now, he gets up from the couch and brushes his teeth quickly, hoping he's drunk enough to fall asleep before his brain betrays him and starts replaying Mydei's moans.

— ◇ —

He wakes up the next morning with his head pounding and his mouth still tasting like beer, even though he brushed his teeth, or at least he thinks he did. His senses catch up slowly, and everything feels bothersome: The room feels too bright, the blanket makes him sweaty, and the central heating's whirl doesn't help his headache.

Phainon groans loudly and grabs his phone from the nightstand, blinking at the time: six a.m., he still has thirty minutes before he has to officially get up. He also has over ten Reddit notifications waiting for him— what was he doing last night again? After Mydei cuddled him as they watched his cooking show?

It takes him a second to remember why he was on Reddit last night.

Ah. Sunlight, headache, mortification. What a way to start his day.

Phainon opens the app reluctantly, staring at the post with a sick twist in his stomach. The title alone makes his soul leave his body.

Is it gay to get hard from hearing your roommate moan?

"Fuck me." He can barely remember posting it, let alone what he actually wrote in there. But there it is, sitting at nearly three hundred upvotes and about ten comments.

His curiosity, stupid and masochistic, wins out.

u/HungryKirby

Please that gay denial and dense need to be studied

u/BelobogTrashCan

Just kiss him already, dude. You’re gay af.

u/ProudFujoshi

rainbow_flag.gif

u/SleepDeprivedSince95

Wait—aren’t you that AITA guy from a few weeks back? Who stared at a dude during his date? Not beating those allegations, my man.

u/coffeeandcats

You’re not crazy. You might be bi. Attraction doesn’t have to fit into neat boxes. Sometimes it surprises you, especially with people you’re emotionally close to. Don’t beat yourself up for it.

u/ForkThis

“27, straight” ??? the muddlefudger is in denial.

u/FollowerOfBeauty

This entire post screams bi panic. We've all been there, take your time to figure out your feelings.

u/GachaVictim

I’ve been in your shoes. Spoiler: you don’t write Reddit essays about your “totally platonic” roommate unless you’ve already fallen for him.

u/ScottNo1Fan:

It’s 2025. Go touch grass—and maybe his ass.

“I hate the internet.” Phainon face-plants into the pillow.

Yet, something about ‘coffeeandcats’ person’s comment sounds oddly reassuring in the sea of “*bro you’re gay”* and *“we’ve all been there.”*

“Bi…” he whispers, tasting the word on his tongue. Maybe he’s bi, or insane. It’s hard to tell after publicly questioning his sexuality online for the second time.

He can think about that once he cries, internally, into his emails at work. For now, he has a different matter to deal with, he has to act normally around Mydei, without the help of alcohol.

Disabling his alarms, Phainon rolls out of bed, gets dressed quickly, leaving the top button of his dress shirt open for now, and makes his way into the kitchen. Mydei is already there, like every morning, flipping protein pancakes with the same effortless grace that normally makes Phainon stare.

Not today. Today, he keeps his gaze on anything that isn’t Mydeimos, on anything that isn’t the bare skin of his roommate or the droplets of water trailing from his hair and down his muscular back.

“Morning,” Mydei greets him, voice low and warm, and Phainon makes the obvious mistake of looking at him— because God help him, he can’t keep his eyes away— right at his stupidly handsome face.

“Just kiss him already.”

That comment was absurd. He doesn’t want to kiss the man, doesn’t want to kiss those soft-looking lips—

“All you have to do is lean in a little…”

“Morning!” Phainon chirps, too fast, too cheerful. He pours coffee with shaky hands, spilling some on the counter, to which he laughs awkwardly. Thankfully, his phone pings in his pocket as he wipes the mess he made, providing the much-needed distraction. The match from last night, Aphrea, replied to him, asking if he wants to meet this upcoming Saturday.

Phainon doesn’t bother drinking his coffee, he replies a quick “sure :)” to his new date, empties the mug into the sink, and leaves earlier than necessary to work, mumbling something about “not needing breakfast today,” to Mydei’s confused gaze.

It’s easier to text his potential date than stick around in the kitchen and think about his mess of emotions.

Chapter End Notes

And the fumbling continues...

Chapter 4: It’s Not Gay, I Just Need Some Space

Chapter Summary

> Wrapped in the darkness of his room, Phainon rehearses what “normal” looks like instead of counting sheep or whatever people do to fall asleep— he imagines greeting Mydei without his eyes traveling to any bit of exposed skin like a starving hyena or sitting with him on the couch without sweating buckets or being extremely self-aware of every miniscule motion.
>
> He tells himself that this is achievable. He is a grown adult, for fucks sake, not some hormonal teenager experiencing a crush. He can move on and be a normal roommate, a normal friend, a normal—well, normal something...

Chapter Notes

> Buckle up, this one is going to be a fun one

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Surprisingly, Phainon doesn’t end up crying about his emotions like he planned, although he has different reasons to cry: two meetings back-to-back, a rapidly approaching deadline, and a request from Aglaea to come to her office and review a marketing proposal the client completely rejected. After approving everything during the process. What an asshole.

Between all the tasks, he slowly manages to convince himself that everything is normal, that yesterday's actions were simply an unfortunate lapse in self-control and meant absolutely nothing. That it was nothing but a *“weird moment,”* that he is *“totally fine,”* and that *“It’s just a physical reaction,”* even though deep down he knows it’s more than a physical reaction, and the Reddit post his drunk self had written is a painful reminder of that.

Still, he manages to convince himself it’s fixable.

All he needs is the rest of the day to himself, and he'll be as good as new by tomorrow, after tucking the incident away to the furthest folder of his brain, the same one containing all his other embarrassing memories since childhood, and for once, the universe gives him a break from the internal torment that is called his life.

Mydei is not home when he makes it back, or so says the note on the kitchen counter: Working closing shift today, your portion of dinner is in the fridge.

The first thing Phainon does is take a long shower; without any accidents this time, then heats up the food his roommate left him, and being the considered *friend* he is, he bakes a small batch of granola cookies, the ones Mydei likes, in case he's hungry when he gets home.

Waiting for the oven's time to go off, Phainon busies himself with his games daily missions and scrolls through social media without opening Reddit once. A great victory if you ask him. The rest of his evening is spent in a similar manner, and by the time he retires to bed, earlier than usual, Phainon has the confidence of a man who has somehow convinced himself he can reprogram his entire sexuality overnight. Not that there is anything wrong with his sexuality. He's just your average straight guy like the world expects him to be.

He thinks lightly, but the words feel strange in his chest, too hollow, too polished to feel real.

Wrapped in the darkness of his room, Phainon rehearses what "normal" looks like instead of counting sheep or whatever people do to fall asleep; he imagines greeting Mydei without his eyes traveling to any bit of exposed skin like a starving hyena. Imagines sitting with him on the couch without sweating buckets or being extremely self-aware of every miniscule motion. He also allows himself to imagine them sharing dinner and small talk and perfectly platonic laughter without his heart fluttering every time those golden eyes look at him with fondness. He even imagines— because he's feeling bold in the safety of his blanket cocoon—walking into the kitchen tomorrow morning and saying something casual like, "Hey, man," or "Sup, bro?" without flinching.

He tells himself that this is achievable. A simple task. He is a grown adult, for fucks sake, not some hormonal teenager experiencing a crush. He can move on and be a normal roommate, a normal friend, a normal… Well, normal *something*, he doesn't want to think about labels.



When his alarm rings the next morning, he feels surprisingly energized—and not because he slept for more than six hours for once.

Phainon works quickly through his morning routine: brushes his teeth, fixes his bed-hair, and steps into the hallway with confidence fifteen minutes later. He walks into the kitchen like a normal person would, ready to greet his roommate like nothing has ever happened, and absolutely determined to focus on literally anything other than Mydei's body or the way his voice tends to sound deeper in the mornings or—

"Morning," Mydei turns to him with a smile "Staying for breakfast today?"

And Phainon manages to act casual, to answer like the *normal* person he is.

"Good morning," he smiles back, smooth, casual, sounding like himself. His voice is steady, his hands don't shake this time as he pours himself a cup of coffee. "Yeah, I'm in no rush today."

They talk while eating; comments about the weather at first, then about Mydei's closing shift and how a middle-aged lady complained that the coffee she ordered extra hot was, in fact, extra hot. Phainon finds himself laughing at the story with ease, instead of letting his mind run circles in his head, hyper focusing on his roommate's tone or whatever it loves doing to torment him.

It feels shockingly easy once he stops actively thinking about the man in front of him in inappropriate ways. Which is no easy task, but Phainon is a

determined man. Today, he doesn't stare at Mydei's hands or forearms or his chiseled abs. He doesn't think about any incidents. He doesn't panic when Mydei reaches over him to grab a paper towel, and his muscles flex beautifully.

Phainon is normal. He is composed. He can do it. He can steer their friendship back into safe, bro-friendly territory and pretend that nothing catastrophic happened in his brain over the past week. If he doesn't think too hard, he can almost believe himself.

"Shouldn't you be leaving for work?" Mydei's concerned tone brings him back from celebrating a little too early, and he glances at the clock, 7:45. Shit. He is late. Phainon stands up fast enough to feel dizzy, tosses the plate in the sink with a "I'll wash it when I get home!" and practically runs to grab his things before rushing to his car.

He might be late for work, Aglaea might want to kill him, but at least he didn't make a fool out of himself in other ways. Small victories.

His very successful morning continues into a very productive noon, where he manages to go over most of his emails and send three revisions with the self-satisfaction of a man who has conquered his inner demons. He's even humming under his breath while drafting a marketing plan for the latest client: A small bakery, tapping his fingers on the keyboard with efficiency, as if nothing in the universe could possibly go wrong.

"You're not going to eat?" Tribios' red hair pops into his field of vision as she walks toward him with a curious gaze. "It's unusual to see you so focused, Snowy," she smiles, giggling at the nickname she gave him when he started working at the company, claiming he reminded her of the neighbor's dog.

Shit. Right. Lunch.

"Small victories" Phainon reminds himself. Forgetting his lunch at home is a small price to pay compared to behaving normally again. He can stomach cardboard if it means keeping up the façade of emotional stability.

“Right! I’ll head to the cafeteria in a few, forgot mine at home.” Phainon picks on his choker with a quiet laugh, and the redhead pats his head with another giggle, as if he was really a dog. “There, there, I'm sure your wife would forgive you.” She teases, remembering the cutesy looking lunches he’s been packing for the past couple of months.

“It’s not—” He sighs, knowing there’s no way reasoning with Tribios, not when she’s determined to tease him. He swears that she and Cipher would get along, making a mental note to never let the two women meet.

It’s ten minutes later that he makes his way down to the office building’s cafeteria, standing in line to get yet another bland tasting sandwich, when his phone buzzes in his pocket, by none other than Tribios, again.

Did he forget something at his desk? A message pops on his screen before he has the chance to call her back.

Phainon stares at the message like it’s a bomb ticking down to detonation. His feet carry him upstairs before his mind processes the words, dry-as-the-desert sandwich long forgotten.

Tribios-work [13:20]: There’s a pretty blonde guy here looking for you.

She wasn’t kidding.

Mydei stands by his cubicle, right next to the red-head— who is busy asking him millions of questions— looking like the physical embodiment of every romantic cliché known to humankind: hair loose around his shoulders, soft smile on his lips, broad chest framed perfectly by a fitted black sweater, a black leather jacket that makes him look like a model, and a pastel-blue lunchbox in his hands. The one he forgot to take.

“Sup!” Phainon tries to greet him casually, ignoring the way his heart skips a beat at the sight. “What are you doing here?”

“You forgot this,” Mydei lifts the lunchbox like it’s obvious, his deep voice carrying through the office in a way that makes everyone around stop what

they’re doing and turn to look at the source. “Thought I’d drop by on my way to campus.”

On his way to campus. To see him. In the middle of the day. With his lunch. *Holy shit.*

Phainon’s brain malfunctions.

Tribios doesn’t even try to hide her grin. She leaves Mydei’s side and pops right behind his, leaning her chin on his shoulder as she looks between Mydei and the lunchbox, saying loudly, “Wow. So that’s your wife? He’s so handsome!”

“He’s not my—!” Phainon jumps back, hissing in denial, heat rushing so violently to his face he feels lightheaded. Totally not from the thought of Mydei being his wife, of course.

“So that’s who’s making Phainon’s lunches? Oh.” Another coworker says from behind them. “Sorry mate. I was sure it was your girl or something.” The guy laughs.

Phainon wants to strangle his coworkers one by one, Mydeimos included.

Meanwhile, Mydei— sweet, oblivious, devastatingly sincere Mydei— simply tilts his head in confusion, and hands him the lunchbox like this is the most normal thing in the world.

“I added a blueberry muffin in there,” he turns his attention back to Phainon, smiling. “You mentioned they were your favorites.” It’s such a small act of kindness; effortless, thoughtless, and it hits him with more force than it should

Him, and his coworkers. The gasp that echoes through the area is collective and immediate. One of the girls groans, “I want a man like this, please tell me he’s single,” while another one adds, “Packed lunch? That’s wife-material!”

Phainon starts praying for the earth to crack open and swallow him.

“Thanks,” he replies, voice surprisingly steady. “You didn’t have to come all the way or make something only because I like it…”

“It was no trouble” Mydei says, with that warm, gentle tone that should be illegal in public spaces. “And your coworkers seem nice, the redhead one let me into the building as soon as she heard I was looking for you.”

There is nothing nice about the way his coworkers are staring at them, ready to jump Phainon with millions of questions the moment Mydei leaves.

He ushers them outside to escape the growing crowd, saving his last remaining dignity— the one he didn’t scrub off his skin two days ago, and once they’re in the parking lot, he tries again, feeling slightly more composed now that they are alone. “You really didn’t have to”

“I wanted to,” Mydei interrupts, looking anywhere but at him, a faint dusting of pink on his cheeks.

“Thank you,” Phainon mumbles, feeling a bit dumbfounded. All he does is stand there, still holding the lunchbox like it’s some precious gem, heart pounding with so much force it might actually crack his ribs, wishing desperately that he could… be normal about his roommate bringing him lunch. Or disappear. Either works.

Mydei studies him for a moment, golden gaze unreadable, before asking “I should be going, but I’ll see you at home?”

Phainon nods too fast. “YES! I mean, yeah. I’ll be home, where else would I be!”

“Is everything ok?”

“Great job, self.” Shit. Now he made Mydei worry.

“I'm great! Excellent!” Phainon answers, smiling at him as normally as he can.

He is not excellent. He is nine seconds away from spontaneous combustion, but Mydei nods, unconvinced, and walks to his bike, throwing him a “don’t forget to actually eat the food.”

Only when Mydei disappears behind the corner of the parking lot, Phainon allows himself to breathe again and return to the elevator, mentally preparing himself for his coworkers' relentless teasing.

His predictions are correct.

Tribios calls him name dramatically the second he makes it to his line of cubicles, despite not even being a part of his department. “Snowy! Where did you hide this man all this time? I thought you were single!”

One of the guys nods in agreement. “I didn’t know your nerdy ass pulled someone as hot as that guy, Phainon. Impressive.”

Phainon slams the lunchbox down and groans, “We are not dating!” With the conviction of someone who absolutely sounds like they’re lying.

His coworkers exchange looks full of pity, affection, and maybe a bit of joy at his suffering.

“Are you sure?” The same guy asks.

“That doesn’t sound very believable…” another adds.

“Introduce me to him then? Mr. ‘im single’?” Tribios finishes, winking.

He ignored them all, sits back down, lunchbox unopened, cheeks still flaming, and pulse refusing to return back to normal.

So much for normalcy, and it's barely past lunch time.

Today is going to be a long one for sure.



Phainon’s productivity drops significantly after Mydei’s visit. Thankfully, the teasing dies down pretty fast once Aglaea emerges from her office, drawn in by the noise. He does get teased a little by her as well once she sees the cutesy lunch, but it’s not as bad as his coworkers.

When the clock finally shows it’s time to leave work, he is quite exhausted and wants nothing but to fulfil his promise to Mydei and get home, maybe watch something together over dinner, or simply talk about anything really, like normal guys do with their roommates.

The drive home is a blur of him smacking his forehead against the steering wheel at a red light, whispering, “Why did you look at him like a dog who got a treat when he said he wanted to bring you your lunch? Get a grip.” And “Act normal. Move on. Stop being weird about it.”

He walks into the apartment still muttering encouragements to himself when he stops at the sight of Mydei in the living room.

The blonde is sprawled on the couch, hidden under in a pink fluffy blanket, wearing another one of Phainon’s sweaters, a soft blue one this time. His hair is loose, still looking wet— possibly from showering, and he’s holding a bowl of popcorn with the ease of someone who makes people question their sexuality on a daily basis.

Not that Phainon is questioning anything.

But the point is, that he still looks like a god-damn model, and if someone told him it’s a shot taken from a magazine, or an Ikea catalogue, he wouldn’t doubt it for a second. Phainon immediately considers turning around and walking back out, maybe taking a sudden, urgent trip to another country.

Nothing too dramatic of course.

“Hey,” Mydei notices him, looking over with a soft smile that hits Phainon like a truck, and much to his disappointment, the truck is metaphorical and

he doesn’t get to reincarnate as a hero in a magical world, or escape reality in general.

“How was work?” he adds.

It takes Phainon a moment to find his voice, because heavens above, why does he sound like that? Why does Mydeimos always sound so happy to see him, like Phainon’s very presence is something he’s excited for? “It, uh- it was fine, you’re officially referred to my wife now though” he jokes, attempting to compose himself.

“Your wife huh, sure.” Mydei ponders for a long second with the same gentle smile, then snaps out of the train of thought he seemed to have, and pats the empty space beside him. “Want me to wait for you before I start the next episode?”

Wanna join. As if they are just bro’s chilling. To which, they should be, this is exactly what they are.

“What are you watching?” he asks.

“A TV show one of my coworkers recommended, something about people pretending to be someone else in online relationships.”

“Yeah, sure” Phainon nods, taking off his coat. “Let me shower first.”

Mydei nods back, already turning his attention back to the screen where the two hosts are interrogating someone. “Take your time.”

Phainon definitely takes his time. He stands under the water for a long while, willing himself back into calmness. Sure, the surprise appearance of Mydei at his work had rattled his resolve a little, but so far today was normal, good even, if he ignores the teasing of his coworkers.

When he finally gets back to the living room, wearing a bright yellow sweater and a pair of red-and-green plaid pants— Mydei looks at him and snorts, choking on a piece of popcorn.

“You look like a festive rubber duck,” Mydei says, mid-cough. “Or a toddler’s art project.”

“I, this is comfortable,” Phainon hisses, cheeks warming. “Fashion is subjective.”

“Your fashion sense is objectively bad,” Mydei counters, scooting away to make space for him. “Take a picture of the fit and ask anyone. They would be on my side.”

“They wouldn’t understand the aesthetics,” Phainon mutters. “And I don’t go out in these anyway.”

“Great, so I’m the only one who is cursed with the sight.”

“Rich coming from a guy wearing one of my sweaters.” That makes Mydei huff an excuse under his breath, so quietly he cannot hear it, and flick a piece of popcorn at him.

He laughs, sitting down on the opposite side of the couch, careful to not let his legs touch Mydei’s as the man presses on the ‘next episode’ button. It’s easy, they make commentaries, Mydei tosses a few more pieces of popcorn at him, which Phainon tries, or fails, to catch with his mouth.

Everything feels peaceful.

And relaxing. For the first time today, he doesn’t immediately think about accidents or messy feelings. He doesn’t think about the shower incident. He doesn’t think about calling Mydei’s name when he came. He doesn’t think about himself blushing brighter than the sun over a muffin at work. He sits down on the couch, maintaining an acceptable distance, and lets the plot of the TV show wash over him.

It’s shockingly domestic. Normal. Like they are back to a week ago, before things got weird, on his side at least.

He even ignores the notification on his phone, Aphrea can wait till later, or tomorrow.

Maybe, maybe he really *can* do this. Maybe today wasn't a fluke. Maybe he really can just… ignore it and move on. Mydei is acting normal, so why can't he? Surely he overreacted and made a big deal out of hearing his roommate get off, it's not like he doesn't do the same. They are both healthy guys with physical needs.

"See?" he thinks smugly, leaning back, crossing his arms in triumph. *"You're fine. You're normal. You're not insane."*

He feels proud.

It lasts a whole lot of five minutes.

Until Mydei shifts.

It's a small movement at first, a little adjustment of his legs under the blanket. Nothing to panic about. Phainon barely glances over, too busy mocking the catfish's horrible attempts to hide their true identity— c'mon, liking the fake picture with their real account, *amateurs*.

Then Mydei stretches, properly this time, and drapes his legs across Phainon's thighs.

Phainon freezes.

Of course he jinxed himself… Of course.

"Is this ok?" Mydei asks, moving his legs a little higher to lie more comfortably, and Phainon malfunctions. His blood cells physically halt. Because Mydei's legs aren't just on his thighs anymore, they are barely a few centimeters from his groin.

His cock twitches.

Oh. *Oh no.*

His pulse jumps straight into outer space. Heat rushes through his body so fast he feels the sweat building on his back already. His mouth goes dry, fingers curling into the blanket like he's holding onto life support.

“Y-yeah” he breathes out, wincing at how wrecked he sounds from a mere touch, one that shouldn’t be anything but casual.

Phainon takes another deep breath, tries to ignore the heat between them. Tries to focus on the TV where the host is yelling something while chasing the catfish. Tries to pay attention, but to no avail. His pulse beats louder in his ears than the TV. His palms are clammy. His thighs are clenched so hard he might actually pull something.

He shifts a little, although it’s a little hard with Mydei’s leg on his lap, and tries to relieve the pressure in his sweats without making it obvious, but his action brings a different outcome.

Mydei casually moves his legs, and the ball of his foot brushes against the tent forming in his sweats—the one he’s trying so hard to adjust away discreetly— before he moves his feet lower with a quiet “Sorry, I think I hit your hip.”

Phainon’s cock pulses again. Harder. Begging for the pressure to return.

Oh god. Oh no. Fuck. Heavens above. No. No no no—

His mind short-circuits so violently he hears static instead of people talking on screen.

He isn’t sure what’s happening on the TV show anymore, all he can think of are variations of *“Mydei’s legs are on me,” “Mydei’s legs are near my dick,” “Mydei is too close,”* Until he can barely breathe.

And that is when panic takes the reins.

Phainon stands up abruptly, startling Mydei, who almost drops the bowl of popcorn from his lap.

“My—Cramp!” he blurts, clutching his thigh dramatically, acting better than he ever did during his drama club days in high school.

Mydei pauses the show, staring at him with slow, suspicious confusion. “A…cramp? From sitting still?”

“Yes,” Phainon barks, sweating profusely. “I think you just put too much weight on my thigh or something.” He’s trying to stay normal, but he can feel his resolve, and sanity, hanging by one last thread. His breathing is too fast. His heart is too loud. His thighs are still tingling where Mydei’s legs rested.

“Are you sure you’re alright?” Mydei asks, voice dipping lower, full of genuine concern. “You’re acting a little weird, even for you—”

“Normal.” Phainon interrupts. “Completely normal.”

Mydei watches him, brows furrowed. “Phainon…if something is wrong you know you can tell me.”

“Nothing wrong.” He lies, hating himself for being dishonest with Mydei. “I guess I’m tired after today. I’m going to call it a night.”

He disappears down the hallway so fast it counts as teleportation, leaving a very confused and concerned Mydei in the living room.

Only when his bedroom door closes behind him, Phainon allows himself to grab at his hair, pulling on it hard enough to hurt. This isn’t like him. He’s a confident man who likes women, he isn’t some touch starved virgin —ok, maybe minus the virgin part— to be getting hard from a mere foot on his thighs. He talked himself, convinced himself, that he was normal, and he truly believed it too. For most of the day, he thought he could handle one peaceful evening with his roommate. He dared to hope.

But no.

Mydei’s stupid perfect legs had other plans. His stupid perfect everything had other plans.

Phainon presses both hands to his face and groans into his palms.

He is a disaster. A pathetic, hopeless disaster.

Slowly, Phainon moves from the door to the bed, dropping on it face first, too angry at himself to even consider paying attention to his erection.

His body is a traitor.

His mind is worse.

And he cannot survive another evening like this.

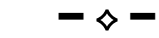
He needs distance. Space. Room to breathe. A few days away from Mydei, before he officially loses it. The thought pains him, because he likes the man; he’s a good friend, fun to hang out with, and he knows he’ll miss him, but he really needs the distance.

Just until the date with Aphrea, where he will reboot his entire system, and move on to focus on his relationship with her instead of questioning his attraction to Mydeimos, and never let his brain wander off again.

“Tomorrow,” he whispers into the pillow. “Tomorrow, I'll be busy myself all day. And the day after, and maybe the one after as well.”

Because if he doesn’t…

He is absolutely, irreversibly, catastrophically doomed.



For the rest of the week, Phainon sticks to the plan and masters the art of avoidance like it is an Olympic sport.

He times his mornings with surgical precision: leaves for work at six in the morning, while Mydei is still in the Gym, buys his lunch in the office’s cafeteria, crying quietly at how bland it tastes, and finds reasons to “grab a drink with his coworkers” most evenings. Even if “the coworkers” are him and his phone, nor it involves any drinking.

When he does end up at the apartment at a normal hour, he slips straight to his room, pretending to be busy, only interacting with Mydei briefly during

dinner, doing his best to act as normal as possible, which he manages thankfully.

He tells himself it’s not avoidance. He needs some space to think. He’s doing both of them a favor by keeping things casual. Mydei definitely doesn’t need to know what kind of a mess his mind becomes every time their hands are touching, or worse, when he’s smiling at him.

But he isn’t stupid. He notices how Mydei looks at him now: confused, upset, a little hurt… Like he can’t figure out if he did something to offend Phainon. And it fills him with guilt, because he still cares about Mydei. Still thinks about him as his friend, his bro. His new best friend, whom he can’t look in the eyes without popping a boner. You know, the normal stuff.

Like any of that is normal.

Phainon manages to avoid his roommate successfully for a whole three days.

By Friday, he’s out of excuses. It’s rainy outside, meaning he can’t escape anywhere after work. He finds himself in the living room, going through his usual gacha-games dailies, the same ones he has been doing on his phone in the past week to avoid the living room when he hears Mydei’s door open.

It’s too late for him to escape to his room. He should’ve checked better if Mydei is home before assuming he’s at work or has a class when he returned to a quiet apartment.

The blonde appears in the living room seconds later. Phainon looks at him, tries to act nonchalant, but all he sees is how loose the collar of his shirt is, how Mydei's inked collarbones are peeking out of the hem. He instantly looks away, gripping the controller harder.

He thinks of taxes, marketing quotes, the elderly neighbor from down the street… Anything to keep his lower half under control…

It seems to do the trick.

“Hey,” Mydei says, surprised, like he didn’t expect to see Phainon there. “Didn’t think you would be home this early.”

“Home early thanks to the weather.” He replies, forcing a smile. “Looks like you’re stuck with me tonight.”

Mydei hums in acknowledgment, moving to the kitchen. “You sure you’re not too busy tonight too?”

The remark is bitter, sarcastic, aimed straight at Phainon’s already frayed mind. It takes everything not to get up, hug Mydei, and tell him that he’s sorry for acting like an ass and avoiding him.

“Work has been kicking my ass,” he lies, accidentally activating a story quest on his game. Great, now he’s really stuck here for the next hour or so.

“Mm.” Mydei grabs a bottle of pomegranate tea and comes to sit beside him, further than usual, further than he ever had. “You sure that’s all?”

“Yeah,” Phainon responds, a little too fast. He diverts his attention from the quest playing on screen. Fuck it, he’ll just watch a playthrough later. “What else would it be?”

“You tell me,” Mydei answers, the hurt in his voice evident.

“You’re reading into things.” He laughs it off, his thumb hovers over the controller, where a text appears, big and bold on the screen. The line reads “You chose the wrong dialogue option.”

The irony. The gods are surely mocking him and his life choices.

“Maybe.” Mydei leans back, studying him with his usually calm look. “It feels like you’ve been avoiding me.”

“I’m not.”

“If you say so.”

Phainon looks away, shame written all over his face. Cipher would call him a kicked puppy if she ever saw him like this.

“I’m sorry, I just,” Just what? Can’t stop thinking about you in ways I don’t understand? Can’t face you without getting hard? “Needed some space.”

Mydei’s brows knit. “Space from what?”

You. Me. Emotions. Phainon is already spiraling.

He blames Reddit. Blames every Redditor who planted the idea of him liking Mydei romantically in his head.

“Everything. Just… everything.”

Mydei doesn’t say anything for a long, nerve wracking moment. He then nods slowly, “Okay. I wanted to make sure it wasn’t something I did.”

“It’s not,” Phainon lies quickly. “It’s really not.” It’s not like he can blame Mydei for something he wasn’t aware of doing.

That ends the conversation, but the silence that follows isn’t comfortable anymore. It’s strained, heavy, full of things he should say but doesn’t know how to— too scared to give them a name and make things more complicated.

“So,” Mydei says eventually, when the silence gets too awkward, “what are you doing this weekend? Or should I assume I’ll be living alone again?”

Phainon laughs, genuinely this time. “You make it sound like I’ve abandoned you!”

“Maybe I'm asking so I can bring someone over.” Mydei’s answer catches him off guard, sending a feeling he doesn’t want to name down his spine. There's no way. He’d know if Mydei is seeing someone, he must be messing with him.

“I’ll actually be home tomorrow.” He retorts before he can think of the consequences.

“Miracle of the century,” Mydei replies dryly, it’s clear now that the man is doing this on purpose, tries to get under his skin, get him to admit what’s been on his mind.

When he doesn’t rise to the bait, the quietness grows between them again, suffocating and unbearable. Phainon tries to think of a different topic, of something lighter, something they can chat casually about… Right. He never told Mydei about his date! They could bond over that, give each other dating tips or something. That’s what bro’s do.

He musters his most casual tone, sounding light and friendly. “Oh. Right, I didn’t tell you, I have a date this Sunday!”

Mydei blinks, his expression looks like a mix of surprise and something unreadable. Ok, maybe this wasn’t the best idea based on the reaction. “A date?”

“Yup!” Phainon smiles, keeping his casual façade going. “Matched with her last week, one of the few to actually appreciate my pick-up lines!”

“Right.” Mydei nods slowly, though he doesn’t look at him when he adds, “Good for you.”

The blonde’s cold reaction makes Phainon’s stomach twist. Unpleasantly. He clears his throat, tries to ease the mood. “Mind if I try a line or two on you? See if it sounds good?”

That gets Mydei’s attention. He lifts an eyebrow, confused, or caught off guard, all Phainon knows is that he looks stunning even when he’s confused. “You want to test your pick-up lines. On me.” Mydei clarifies.

“Is that a no? C’mon Mydeimos, help a bro out!” He jokes again.

“You’re unbelievable.” There’s no humor in Mydei’s voice this time.

Phainon blinks, caught off guard by the shift in his tone. “What?”

Mydei doesn’t answer immediately. He looks at him for a solid minute, expression morphing from confused to offended. “You think this is funny?”

he says finally.

Frowning, Phainon looks at him with confusion. “What are you talking about? No need to take it so seriously... It’s a joke.”

“Of course,” Mydei hisses. “A joke” the word sounds flat, hollow. Sharp golden eyes meet light blue ones. “You’re really good at those, aren’t you?”

“Okay, what the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“It means,” Mydei starts saying, his voice rising, “you can’t just—” He stops, fists clenching tight like he’s trying to restrain himself from shouting. “Forget it.”

“No,” Phainon insists, confusion bleeding into frustration. “Are you really that pissed about me getting a date? Your mood changed the moment I mentioned it…”

Something changes in Mydei’s expression, and Phainon feels it even if he doesn’t understand it. His roommate’s laugh is bitter, pained. “You really don’t get it...”

Phainon blinks, taken aback by the accusation. “Get what?”

“You think I'm stupid, Phainon? You spend the whole week avoiding me like you can’t stand being around me all of a sudden.” It feels like he’s being slapped, again and again. “And now you sit here, pretend everything’s fine, and tell me about your dates? Throw pickup lines in my face like none of it mattered?”

Mydei isn’t looking at him anymore.

It hurts.

Phainon wants to reach out, beg him to look at his face, beg him to tell him how to fix this.

“None of what?” He ends up asking, still confused about his roommate’s sudden anger.

“Hell, Phainon.” Mydei’s voice cracks with fury. “Do you think before you open your mouth!?”

Phainon gives in to his earlier thought and reaches a hand out in an attempt to make Mydeimos look at him. “I’m seriously trying to understand here!”

“No, you’re not!” The man in front of him snaps, recoiling away from the touch, “not when you can’t see what is right in front of you!”

Phainon feels tears of frustration prickle in his eyes, startled by the volume, by Mydei’s uncharacteristic anger. “Mydeimos!” he snaps back, a self-defense mechanism he knows he’s going to regret in a moment. "What the hell did I do? We were joking two seconds ago!

“Because that’s the easy thing to do, right?” Mydei grits between his teeth, full of venom. “You make it a joke. You act like it’s nothing.”

He already regrets snapping back.

The words feel like another well-aimed slap to his face. No, scratch that. It feels like a punch in the gut, one that leaves him breathless. Phainon can’t even process his roommates’ words properly. They don’t make sense. Nothing makes sense anymore. “What are you talking about? I never—”

“Don’t.” Mydei cuts in, his body trembles visibly with restrained fury. “Don’t play dumb. You think I don’t notice how you—” He stops himself again, takes a shaky breath, and stands up, facing away. “You shouldn’t say things you don’t mean, Phainon. Not to me.”

“I don’t even know what I said!” Phainon shoots back, hurt. He mimics Mydei and stands up too, one hand mid-air, wanting to reach but afraid of Mydei flinching away again, “You’re mad about me having a date, aren’t you? How is that my fault? Are you jealous or something?”

There's a long pause where Mydei looks at him, baffled.

“So that’s it, then,” the blonde says quietly, sounding defeated. “You really don’t get it...” He turns to look at Phainon, his earlier anger is replaced with

hurt, lashes wet with tears he's trying to hold back.

Mydei’s expression catches him off guard.

“You caused it, you fool!” Phainon’s brain screams at him. He wants to hold the man close. Apologize for hurting him, for the avoidance, for not understanding, for… He doesn’t know anymore but he’d apologize for it. He’d even get on his knees and beg if it would make the blonde smile again. Anything to make those tears go away.

Phainon takes a step closer, hesitant. “Then explain it to me. Please. I can’t fix it if you don’t tell me what I did.” His voice softens, fragile, hopeful.

Mydei laughs again, short and sharp, more a bark than a laugh really. “There is nothing to fix. There’s nothing."

Before Phainon can reply or ask anything else, Mydei steps closer, but his relief is short lived when he feels one hand grabbing the collar of his shirt, pulling him closer, until there is barely any distance between them.

“Mydei—”

“Stop pretending,” Mydei growls.

Then his fist meets Phainon’s face.

The punch is hard enough to make him stumble back to the floor from the impact. Phainon thinks his lip is bleeding as he tastes blood in his mouth all of a sudden.

For what feels like an eternity, neither of them say anything. All they do is stare at each other in shock. Phainon, wide-eyed and speechless, one hand clutching his throbbing cheek. And Mydei, standing above him, breathing hard, tears trailing down his cheeks, and regret written all over his face.

“What the hell!?” Phainon mumbles, finally exiting the state of shock.

Mydei lowers his head in shame. “I’m sorry.” He sounds so quiet all of a sudden, so vulnerable. “Forget it.” He turns away from Phainon's pained

face, disappearing down the hallway.

Just like that, Phainon is left alone in the living room, with a bleeding lip, a cheek that would most certainly bruise in an hour or so, and a just-as-bruised ego.

What just happened?

What did he do wrong?

He doesn’t know. He genuinely doesn’t know why Mydei acted so upset, and as the silence stretches, a different kind of pain overtakes the physical one, one that hurts ten times more than the punch— Mydei’s hurt expression refuses to leave his mind, the man’s beautiful amber eyes, usually so sharp with determination, looked dull and lifeless.

Phainon presses a hand over his face. His throat burns. He wants to scream. Cry. Beg.

His head is such a mess, he doesn’t even know what he wants anymore. All he knows is that he hates himself for hurting Mydei. For possibly ruining their friendship.

“It's guilt,” he tries to reassure himself. *“You’ll figure things out tomorrow.”*

It feels more like heartbreak than guilt.

Chapter End Notes

Remember that "miscommunication" tag...

Chapter 5: It’s Pretty Gay, But My Roommate Is in Denial

Chapter Summary

> “Look. I'm no relationship expert, but it sounds like he’s just scared.” The pink-haired girl lifts her face from the screen.
>
> “Of what?”
>
> “Of you, *genius.*” She shrugs. “You know— the good old emotional constipation."
>
> “…Emotional what?”
>
> “You heard me.”
>
> Mydei had never heard the term before, nor did he ever want to associate emotions with bowel movements, or lack of them. But Hyacine surely knows better than him about emotions apparently, so he chooses to trust her words, whatever they mean.
>
> Or; Mydei's POV

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei always wanted to enjoy a quiet, peaceful life.

He never expected a fairytale-like dream life, like the one in the novels he sometimes read— he wasn’t naïve— all he wanted was something quiet, simple, predictable. Mornings where he had time to hit the gym, nights that he could spend trying out new recipes or catch up on his favorite cooking reality shows. Perhaps with someone by his side, if luck would allow it.

What some people would call boring… He cherished.

And then he met Cipher. It was quite simple being her roommate despite being complete opposites, they bonded over bad dating experiences, their love for seafood and mutual hatred for early morning classes, and even though there was nothing similar between them on paper, they found peace and comfort in each other. Almost like long-lost siblings.

Then, she dropped the bomb on him, one peaceful morning, three years into them living together, barely a month into renewing their lease for the fourth year.

“Guess what,” Cipher turned to face him from her spot on the couch the moment he entered the apartment on a peaceful-seeming Tuesday evening. “I’m moving out.”

Mydei stopped in his tracks, blinking. “What?”

“You know how Castorice really wanted me to move in with her...” She starts, and he already doesn’t like where this is going, but he nods anyway.

“So I have a friend who wants to take over the lease. He’s really nice, a bit of a nerd, but I can vouch for him,” she gives him the best puppy eyes she can muster, which fails spectacularly. Cipher is more of a cat than a dog.

“I don’t need to move out or search for a new roommate? Sounds suspicious.”

Cipher ignores the jab and smiles at him like a cat that got its paws on the freshest fish in the market. “Little princess” she jabs back, “you wound me. I’d never leave you on your own like that! Nor offer the place if it’s not someone I absolutely trust.”

Mydei still gives her a look, a scowl, a glare. “And…?” he asks, having learned to never take her on her word.

“He’s not into men, so you can waltz around half naked like you love doing.”

He sighs. “Cipher—”

“Relax. It’ll be the same as living with me, or a male, less impressive version of me.”

Mydei frowns. “Move out already.”

She acts hurt, pressing a palm on her chest. “Getting rid of me so fast? Did our friendship mean nothing to you!?”

His frown turns into a smile, then a laugh, and Cipher joins him. Everything was simple… Just like he wanted. Until said roommate moved in.

— ◇ —

It happens on a Saturday three weeks later, and he really should’ve stayed home instead of going to the gym, but Mydei is all about routine, so he can’t help it.

It’s when he comes home, sweaty and disgusting, that the first thing he sees is white hair. *Familiar white hair*. Followed by the same voice that made him drop a mug at work; because no one in their right mind can forget how bad that pickup line was, or how handsome is the guy who said it.

“Phainon,” he introduces himself. And even his name is one Mydei knows he’ll have a hard time forgetting.

For better or worse, the guy is as attractive as Mydei remembers; slightly taller than him, looks well built under the tight t-shirt he’s wearing, charming in his awkwardness… Even if he has a habit of staring, especially at his chest, Mydei notices.

“My eyes are up here.” He coughs, amused, and Phainon’s reaction is quite priceless and flattering. Perhaps too flattering for a guy who Cipher claimed is *not* into men.

He learns quickly that Phainon, much to his surprise, is quite easy to talk to when he isn't staring or busy being flustered whenever Mydei calls him on it. He talks a lot, laughs, and without Mydei noticing —slips past the distance he usually keeps with new people.

In fact, he's so relaxed around Phainon that he momentarily forgets they barely know each other. Until Phainon's gasp catches his attention mid-cooking, and Mydei remembers a certain gray-haired roommate teasing him about his habit of not wearing shirts around the house. He apologizes quickly, offering to go get dressed more… appropriately, when his new roommate stammers there's no need, trying his best not to stare at his naked chest. Again.

"Shame he's not into guys" passes through Mydei's mind, and he frowns, shaking his head. For all he knows, Cipher might've been wrong.

No completely straight guy ever stared at him like this before.

His interest in Phainon only grows from there, and since he firmly believes in 'actions speak louder than words', Mydei starts showing his interest through his actions.

He starts prepping breakfasts for Phainon whenever he cooks early enough, remembering the man saying he hardly has time to prepare anything, and starts packing him lunch boxes too, something he's done for Cipher for years, to the point of it becoming another habit.

It costs him nothing to make an extra portion and shape the vegetables into something cute. Mydei is confident enough in himself to admit he likes cutesy things, ignoring the way guys look at him like he has grown a second head when he mentions liking pink and owning a stuffed animal.

Mydei doesn't expect anything in return either, he likes cooking. Yet the way Phainon thanks him so genuinely and blushes while telling him how his coworkers were jealous of his lunches sends warmth to his heart. He pretends not to be pleased, but he is.

Evenings quickly become his favorite time of the day.

When he isn’t at his job or stuck in his room working on university assignments, he spends time with Phainon in the living room, willingly, Cipher was beyond shocked when he told her, claiming the white-haired is cheating, since it took her a good three months to achieve the same when they first started living together.

They compete over who cooks better, bicker like they’ve known each other for years and watch shows side by side, shoulders brushing as they share snacks or lean closer mid-laughing. And to his surprise, Phainon doesn’t flinch when touched. Doesn’t move away when Mydei sits closer. Phainon knows he likes men and still allows all this.

It must be some sign he’s interested too, right?

Or so Mydei thought. Because the next day Phainon acts fidgety around him, more self-aware, like letting Mydei close was an accident.

“It’s fine,” Mydei tells himself, “Don’t get your expectation up, he’s straight, it doesn't matter if he acts like he isn't.”

Yet, his desire to stay close to Phainon only grew stronger with each passing day.

So, he starts inviting his new roommate to the gym with him, to spend more time together, and maybe show off a little in hopes of attracting the man. Mydei is proud of his body after all. But Phainon’s stubborn competitiveness carries to the gym too, and instead of showing off, they end up competing; Phainon tries to keep up with his routine, fails spectacularly, and insists he’s fine— only to sulk on the couch the next day with sore muscles and a glare that isn’t actually angry.

It makes Mydei stupidly fond. More than he should be toward his *straight* friend. But Phainon doesn’t seem to notice his attraction, and invites him to spend more time with him as well; by playing games together.

“Nerd,” He finds himself thinking, affectionately, as he sits down next to the white-haired man who looks stupidly handsome with his glasses on,

willing to ignore his horrible sense of fashion. He's sure Phainon would look much better without clothes anyway—

"Focus, Mydeimos. You're getting distracted."

Perhaps it's purely Mydei's fault that he dies in every imaginable way, because he is, in fact, too distracted by how *attractive* his roommate looks in that hideous orange sweater and green pants he's wearing, fixing his glasses between rounds, tongue peeking out in concentration…

Phainon laughs when he falls off the platform again, shoulders shaking in a failed attempt to control himself, and although the constant losses poke at his competitive streak, it's the sweetest sound Mydei has heard from anyone in a long time.

Without thinking, he leans against him with a defeated huff and Phainon doesn't move. Doesn't shy away, but instead leans in, just a little.

That is when hope starts blooming in his chest.

Maybe it isn't as one-sided as Mydei thought.

✧

The next afternoon, Mydei's suspicion gets confirmed, in a way.

His phone falls under the couch, and he bends down, trying to reach for it, not thinking about how he looks or what he's wearing. He's home alone anyway, who cares about some shorts riding too high up his ass? Him. He should care about it, because not even a minute later he hears the entrance door, and a sharp intake of breath behind him.

"My phone fell under the couch." Finally reaching the device, he turns his head to look back.

Phainon is staring. Not at his face. Lower. Much lower. Eyes wide, flushed, unblinking, and Mydei cannot help but notice the very obvious, very undeniable bulge straining against the front of his pants.

Mydei freezes.

Oh.

He can feel his body reacting in a similar manner, cock slowly filling under the attention.

Fuck.

Pleased by Phainon’s obvious attraction, Mydei sits back on his heels and turns around, eyes fixated on his roommates’ thick thighs, gaze growing hungry by the second. Phainon’s reaction is immediate, he turns red from his neck to his ears, unable to form a full sentence as he tries to smile, tries to act casual, and fails miserably.

“You seem flustered,” Mydei looks up at his face, and points out calmly despite the pulse ringing in his ears, and lower. Disbelief and delight mixing into a dangerous feeling in him.

“I’m not flustered,” Phainon lies, badly, it’s obviously a lie when the man’s face is as red as a tomato.

“Mhm.” Mydei lets his gaze trail back down deliberately, to the impressive looking hard-on, then back to his eyes— intent clear.

“You sure it’s exhaustion?” He makes sure to emphasize the last word, already imagining how good Phainon's cock would feel on his tongue…

The snow-haired man makes a noise that barely qualifies as human and bolts to his room with the lamest of excuses, slamming the door behind him, leaving Mydei in the living room, still on his knees, head tilting in confusion.

“Baby steps.” He whispers to the empty room. Now he knows the attraction is mutual. He got hard evidence —*literally*— that Phainon is into him, at

least physically.

Mydei lets himself smile, small and helpless and real.

“There is a chance,” he thinks, firmer this time, as he bee-lines to his room to take care of his own erection, mind already drifting to the fantasy of Phainon doing the same behind his door, thinking about him.

And just to mess with Phainon a little? He puts a mental note to wear the same shorts the next morning. A little payback for running away.



The outcome of the incident is not exactly what Mydei hoped for. If anything, it leaves him more confused than ever. On some days, Phainon avoids sitting too close and keeps a clear distance between them. On others, he leans in and acts like a partner rather than a friend.

The confusion is irritating to say the least.

Yet, Mydei is not one to be easily provoked, not after learning how to restrain his emotions during his teenage years; where his short temper got the better of him and got him into more trouble than his parents could hope to clean.

To keep his sanity intact, Mydei pretends not to notice how Phainon’s hand always hovers for a little too long before pulling away, or the way he stares at him when he thinks Mydei isn’t looking.

Those little inconsistencies refuse to let him move on and accept that his feelings are unrequited— because romance aside, they act completely domestic: they cook together, they bicker, they get each other little things.

It feels more like whatever Cipher and Castorice have going on than being roommates.

Then one evening, his dating app notifies him of a new match.

He stares at the notification, contemplating if he wants to open it. He's been so focused on Phainon in those past months, that he barely feels like dating around. Mydei's thumb hovers the phone, hesitant, reluctant, before he finally opens it. It’s better for him to move on, to stop hoping for Phainon to like him back, and start something new with someone who can say proudly they like him instead of sending mixed signals.

Plus, once he replies to the message— the guy is nice, enthusiastic, eager to get to know him, and the attention feels welcomed.

Mydei mentions it to Phainon casually one evening while they exchange commentaries over a random TV series, expecting, maybe stupidly, some reaction. A spark of jealousy. A look of disappointment. Something…

Instead, Phainon smiles, bright and encouraging, and offers to leave the apartment if Mydei wants to bring the guy over. Like it’s nothing. Like *they* are nothing.

His confusion feels sharp and deep.

Maybe he really misread everything.

◇

The date sucks.

Mydei realizes fifteen minutes in that the guy isn’t listening to a single word he says, unlike the way he acted while they texted. All he does is stare, anywhere but his face. He’s pretty sure that if he asked the guys what his eye color is, he wouldn’t know. Not with how his eyes are glued to Mydei’s chest. The questions he asks aren’t better either, focusing on Mydei’s look rather than interests, like all the guy has in mind is getting

inside Mydei’s pants, or vice versa, he’s not even sure what his date’s preferences are.

It’s flattering in theory. In execution, it feels hollow.

Somewhere between the first round of drinks and the guy’s third comment about “how good his body must look in bed,” Mydei realizes it's futile. This guy would never see him beyond a hook-up, a fuck buddy at best.

And while Mydei isn’t entirely sure what he wants for his future, being someone’s trophy wife is sure not on the list of his life goals.

He cuts the date short with a quick lie and fake apology, ignoring the man’s protests and pleas to stay and come over to his place. The afternoon air outside is cool on his skin, grounding him, but the walk home only pulls his disappointment deeper. He wasn’t hoping for fireworks, he knows better than that. But he at least hoped for a connection, a spark…

Something like what he has with Phainon.

Phainon. The name comes uninvited, but clear all the same. The white-haired man has set a pretty high standard for his potential dates, and Mydei lets out a hollow laugh, because of course. The universe has quite the fucked-up humor.

By the time he reaches their apartment, he’s tired, stressed, and quite irritated too— his date keeps texting him with various pleas and unsolicited pics; as if that would make Mydei change his mind, and he wants nothing but to de-stress by playing something with Phainon, or rope him into watching a funny video together for a good laugh.

Surprisingly, the apartment is silent when he steps inside. Completely silent.

That never happens on a weekend. Phainon is usually in the living room, shouting at his games, cursing his bad luck at pulling characters, or trying to convince Mydei to watch “just one more episode” of the anime that is so bad it's surprisingly good.

The quiet catches him by surprise.

Sulking, he takes off his shoes, hangs his coat, and enters the living room only to see Phainon's clothes messily thrown on the couch, almost like he barely had the time to change before whatever got him out of the house on a weekend.

Mydei stops in his tracks. Stares at a gray sweater hanging off the armrest like it had personally offended him. Then, before he can catch up with the action and stop himself, he steps closer and picks up the cloth.

The fabric is as soft as it looks, a little worn at the neckline from frequent wear, and Mydei traces it with his hand, fighting the sudden urge to bury his face into it.

"You don't want to cross that line."

He drops the sweater like it burns him, feels the heat on his neck, face, ears, everywhere really. He's not doing this. He refuses to act like a lovesick teenager and sniff Phainon's clothes. Absolutely not.

He needs to distract himself somehow.

"Baking." His mind supplies. Baking often calms him down. Castorice always says he bakes when he doesn't want to think and she might be quite on the mark with that statement.

Mydei grabs a few ingredients from the cabinets: flour, sugar, vanilla extract, the butter and salt are on the counter already. He should make something simple, like cookies. Something he can do on autopilot, without thinking.

He mixes, measures, and focuses on the motion of whisking the ingredients. It's therapeutic in a way, allowing him to focus on the task at hand and not on a stranger who sees him as a body to fuck, or the stupidly tempting sweater on the couch.

Yet, the second the cookies are in the oven, and he has nothing to focus on but waiting, his mind betrays him again.

Phainon's sweater. Still on the couch. Possible smelling like…

He grits his teeth, waits harder for the oven's timer.

It doesn't help.

His head is too full of Phainon. Stupid Phainon and his stupid smile, his stupid mixed signals— flirting one second, avoiding him the next. His stupidly bright laugh, or his stupidly beautiful blue eyes that look at him like Mydei is the brightest star in the sky without ever realizing it.

It's infuriating. It should be infuriating. But more than anything, *it's arousing*.

Mydei gives in to temptation the second the oven dings, only bothering to open it slightly to allow the cookies to cool off.

He turns to the living room, grabs the sweater and inhales Phainon's scent with a contented sigh. The fabric smells heady: a mix of citrus from Phainon's body wash, musk from sweat, and something *very Phainon*. Addicting in ways Mydei cannot explain. He buries his face deeper into the fabric, inhaling one more time, before letting out a shaky groan.

This is pathetic. He's crossing every possible line. He knows it.

He doesn't stop.

The smell is comforting and dizzying at once— an illusion of closeness if he closes his eyes and imagines he's holding Phainon, inhaling the crook of his neck rather than a piece of cloth, finally getting to tug on his choker, to kiss the sun-shaped tattoo beneath it, and suddenly all his meticulously built self-restraint shatters like the mug he dropped on the fateful day of their meeting.

His mind drifts instantly, replaying the memory of Phainon standing in front of him, flushed, the outline of his cock thick and unmistakable through his

pants, eyes fixated on Mydei’s ass like it’s the most delicious dish he has ever seen.

Mydei bites back a moan.

He’s home alone, there’s no reason to hold back, no reason to feel ashamed about getting hard to the scent of Phainon and the thought of how big his dick must be…

“You’re going to regret it,” Mydei screams inside his head. Right before walking to his room, sweater in hand. The consequences can wait till he’s more clear-headed.

He closes the door behind him, or at least he’s pretty sure he does— mind too occupied with *Phainon* to focus on anything else, already as hard as the white-haired man was that day.

Lying on his bed, Mydei reaches blindly into the drawer of his nightstand, palm closing around his trusted toy; the same one he uses on lonely nights, when he’s too pent up to think straight. He feels the smooth silicone and its familiar weight in his hand, but tonight, it feels different — tonight he allows himself a moment of weakness, to imagine it’s Phainon’s cock and not a mere toy.

Just the thought is enough to make him shudder with excitement.

He unzips his jeans with hands that aren't as steady as he wishes, kicks them to the floor together with his underwear, hissing as his flushed cock meets the cool air of the bedroom.

Pumping his length a few times, Mydei presses his face into the sweater once more and taking a deep inhale. The scent feels even stronger like this and it makes him believe for a second that Phainon is there, looming above him, ready to fuck him into the mattress. Nice and hard like Mydei had been craving for the longest. His cock twitches in his palm, drooling precum already, desperate for relief, *for Phainon*.

“Fuck.” he breathes into the fabric.

Shifting on the bed until his face is buried in the sweater and ass high up in the air, Mydei realizes how his current position is embarrassingly open. His first thought is to change positions or hide under the blanket- in case Phainon comes home and knocks on his door. The following thought is a much more dangerous one, sending a sharp wave of arousal through his body, because deep inside he wants Phainon to walk on him like this, to grab his hips, replace the toy with his cock, make him feel drunk on pleasure—

The idea alone is enough to make him skip the usual teasing, pour lube on his fingers messily, and circle one digit around his rim. His body relaxes quickly, too quickly, from how worked up he already is and the first press of his fingertip inside draws a shaky groan from his throat.

“Phainon—” A quiet plea is all it takes for him to press a second finger in almost immediately, impatient and so unlike himself. Mydei tries to stay composed, to take it slowly like he always does, to savor the burn of the stretch…

He fails.

Because it’s Phainon’s hands he imagines and not his own. Phainon kneeling behind him, curling his fingers just right, breathless at the sight of Mydei opening for him.

“Mydei, Can I add another? Please,” he imagines him whimpering, needy, begging.

Mydei groans into the sweater, possibly drools, not that he cares.

He adds a third finger, pumping them a few times for good measure before replacing them with the tip of the dildo, knowing he’s not entirely ready yet but too pent up to prep himself any longer.

The first press of the toy inside makes his breath hitch, the stretch pushing the air out of his lungs. It hurts in the best way possible. The same way he imagines taking Phainon would feel like. His thighs tremble as he presses the toy all the way in, until the silicone balls press flush against his own.

“Oh—fuck.”

It’s too easy to picture Phainon holding his hips still, murmuring something filthy and sweet like, “Relax for me… that’s it… You’re taking it so well, like you were made for My cock Mydei.”

He starts thrusting the toy. Slow at first, the way he thinks Phainon would tease him, but his hole is already clenching around it with every pull, greedy, demanding more.

Mydei lets his free hand slide to his chest, squeezing the inked flesh first and teases his nipples; pulling on the hardening nubs until they are red and swollen. Knowing how obsessed Phainon is with staring at his chest, he believes the man would pay extra attention to it: tease and suck on his nipples until Mydei begs for him to focus his attention elsewhere. Then, once the pressure in his stomach coils tighter, he slides his palm down to wrap around his neglected cock.

“Phainon…” he whispers again without meaning to.

Pressing his nose into the sweater, Mydei times each stroke with the thrust of the toy inside him, ignoring the discomfort in his wrist at the angle. His hips start meeting the rhythm, desperate in ways he normally isn’t, chasing the pleasure spreading low in his stomach.

He imagines Phainon above him, snowy hair sticking to his face from excretion, cheeks flushed beautiful red, lips parted with his name spilling repeatedly from between them. Taking another deep breath of Phainon’s heady scent, he lets himself imagine Phainon’s big palm around close Mydei’s throat, limiting his breath intake, only to press flush against his back and pick up the pace, grinding mercilessly against his prostate.

“Fuck, please—”

The fantasy is so vivid he can barely breathe, thighs trembling with the effort to keep up, until his legs give out and Mydei allows himself to fall sideways. With the new position it’s much easier to fuck himself stupid, and Mydei thrusts the toy faster, deeper, desperate to come. The sweater is no

longer pressed to his nose like this, but it doesn’t stop him from grabbing the fabric and leaning to inhale Phainon’s addicting scent again.

“Please” he repeats, voice hitching as the pleasure coils impossibly tight, ready to snap any second. “Please—Pha—fuck!”

He's not even sure what he’s begging for. More? Too much? For the fantasy to be real?

The toy grinds his prostate again, and Mydei’s toes curl, balls drawing tight, breath catching in his throat.

“Phainon!”

He comes with one final slam of the dildo against his sweet spot, the sound escaping his throat is something akin to a muffled scream. High-pitched and broken and way too loud. Hot ropes of cum spill over his wrist and the bedsheets, rim clenching so hard around the toy his vision blacks out.

Mydei keeps pumping himself through the aftershocks, toy forgotten as his entire focus shifts to his throbbing length, grinding into his fist in shallow thrusts, riding the pleasure out until the tremors stop and it becomes too much.

It is only when he feels himself start to soften that he pulls the toy out with another weak twitch from his spent cock, and slumps on his back, wrecked and somewhat satisfied.

If only it was really Phainon fucking him…

Mydei presses his face into the man’s sweater one last time, eyes closing, not wanting to let the fantasy go just yet.

“…fuck,” he whispers into the quiet room.

Then, with his mind clear enough, he notices it. The background noise. Running water, followed by a soft thump against glass, and his eyes snap open.

Phainon is home.

Home. And he might’ve been home for long enough to hear him.

Mydei bolts up so fast the room spins, panic evident in his eyes as he realizes his door isn’t fully closed, thoughts immediately racing to his roommate. Did Phainon hear him? What would he think if he did? Would he find it flattering, or perhaps refuse to talk to Mydei afterwards? His heart clenches painfully at the idea of Phainon finding it disgusting, but he wills himself to calm down with a few deep breaths. It's not like him to jump to conclusions.

The first thing he does is close his room properly.

With the door closed and locked for good measure, he waits— with his heart beating in his throat— until he can hear the sound of water stopping, and footsteps pass by his door. Only then does he allow himself to let out a breath he didn’t know he was holding and look at the sweater still in his hands like it's some kind of incriminating evidence.

He should get rid of it. Hide it. Dispose of it entirely. And put on some pants, preferably.

Instead, he takes off his own sweater and wears Phainon’s, together with a random pair of shorts he grabs blindly from his closet— it's not the first time he wears Phainon's clothes, and it feels less incriminating like this, as long as he ignores the drool stain.

It takes him another twenty minutes to leave his room, stomach twisting at the thought of being caught. Yet, thank whatever gods above, Phainon acts blissfully unaware— sitting on his side of the couch, scrolling through his phone.

"Hey," Mydei says, trying to sound as normal as possible. "When did you get back?"

“About half an hour ago?” Phainon answers without looking up at first, sipping on a bottle of beer, and Mydei can feel relief crashing over him

when he doesn’t say anything beyond that. He looks down at Phainon once again, and the man flashes him a bright smile that doesn’t reach his blue eyes. “How was your date?”

“It wasn’t worth it,” Mydei answers honestly. “The guy didn’t want anything serious, and I don’t do hookups.”

To his surprise, Phainon laughs, soft and full of warmth, almost like he’s relieved. “His loss. More Mydei for me.”

The world around Mydei stops. Warmth spreading in his chest so quickly he feels his face burning. Phainon says it so casually, and he probably doesn’t mean anything romantic by it, but the words carve deeply into Mydei, sparking the hope he had been trying to suppress.

“More Mydei for me.”

It feels like a promise. A claim. A quiet confession. And Mydei wants to believe those words mean something so badly that he can't help himself but press closer, lean in against Phainon’s shoulder in what he hopes gets the message across; that he too, wants more.

Wants *him*.

Phainon doesn’t move away. Doesn’t tense. Instead, he gets up and grabs another beer, only to sit more comfortably when he returns, allowing Mydei to press even closer, until he is lying against Phainon’s chest.

And God, it feels so good. So easy. Like this is where he belongs, like it's mutual and finally Mydei can allow himself to relax and be happy. He dozes off with a smile, content in a way he hasn’t felt in months, years even.

Yet, when morning comes, he feels like cold water is poured straight over his fragile hope.

Because Phainon is acting weird, and by weird, he means weird even for Phainon— the man is fidgety, avoiding eye contact, wearing mismatched

socks, and his shirt isn’t buttoned the right way. He doesn’t even bother to drink the coffee he made, dumping the whole thing back into the sink as he stammers, “not needing breakfast today,” and practically runs out of the door, a whole hour before he usually leaves the house.

The silence he leaves behind is a painful one.

It takes Mydei a long moment to understand the hollow ache forming in his chest.

Last night, Phainon acted like he felt something for him, enjoyed the proximity, smiled and said “more Mydei for me,” like it meant something. Then this morning, he couldn’t even look him in the eye.

And Mydei, standing alone in the kitchen, heart sinking, can’t tell which version of Phainon is real.

The confusion only grows from there, leaving him unsure and quite hurt if he has to be honest. Phainon is avoidant one day, then closer the next— like nothing happened, thanking him for bringing his lunch to work, only to get up abruptly while they are watching a TV show later that evening, disappear down the hallway, and act like he can’t be in the same room with Mydei the following morning.

He tells himself he’s imagining it at first. Perhaps Phainon is as busy as he claims to be. It’s normal. The white-haired man has a demanding job, unlike his. That’s what he repeats on the fourth day too, when Phainon texts him to eat without him, since he’ll be home really late.

Staring at his phone like the device itself has done him wrong, Mydei sulks into his plate of lasagna, no longer hungry.

It doesn’t get better the next day either. Phainon leaves too early again, returns home late, and when Mydei asks him about his day- just a casual friendly question- the man jokes about his busy schedule like he’s reading from a script of “how to act normal” instead of speaking freely, flinching away when Mydei reaches to give him an encouraging pat on his shoulder.

Mydei gets the hint that his touch is no longer welcome, tries not to let the hurt show. He gives him space, like Phainon seems to want. He cooks as usual. Leaves meals in the fridge when he knows Phainon will be late. Knocks on his door once in hopes to ask what he did wrong, but backs off the second he hears the faint “sorry, I'm busy” from inside.

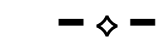
With each day like that, the distance between them stretches. And stretches.

“Did I read everything wrong?”

The question sits heavy in his chest, like a heavy stone. They went from cuddling together in what seemed like an intimate moment, to Phainon barely sitting near him at all. From “more Mydei for me,” to not meeting his gaze in the mornings.

If it was withdrawal he could live with it. He’s used to people pulling away. But it’s the whiplash that hurts. The hot and cold, the warmth and then sudden distance, like Phainon is playing games with heart.

By the weekend, his composure—the careful calm he prides himself on, feels like something thin and brittle.



Mydei sits through his Friday morning lecture despite wanting to be anywhere but studying. The professor explains something about protocols, or rehab, maybe even something completely unrelated. He would have known if he had paid any attention. But he can’t. All Mydei can think of is Phainon, the obviously fake smile he gave him this morning as he skipped breakfast again, bolting out like the house is on fire.

Did he really mistake everything and made his roommate so uncomfortable around him to the point of avoidance?

He is staring at his empty Word document like the blank file has all the answers to his troubles when Hyacine silently elbows him, brows raised. She doesn't say anything at first, just flips her phone around for him to see.

On her screen is a picture of Ica: her fat and round pet, perched on an edge of a chair, looking like he's violating a few rules of physics altogether, and on a normal day Mydei would laugh quietly, at least smile at the round creature that weighs more than it should be…

Today, though, he only manages a faint twitch at the corner of his mouth.

Hyacine stares at him. Then at the picture. Then at him again. She locks her phone and puts it back.

"…Okay," she leans closer. "Start talking. It's the first time you didn't smile or try fat-shaming little Ica."

"Little is a bit of a stretch don't you think?" He tries to joke, but even that comes out meaner than he intended, and Mydei apologizes quietly, trying to avert his gaze back to the professor.

Hyacine is having none of that though. "First of all, he is little. A small round baby, if you insist!" She huffs, "and second, don't you dare escape once the lecture is over. I'll make you tell me what happened one way or another." Her pink ponytails sway as she leans into his field of vision, determined.

Mydei knows a losing battle when he sees one, but that doesn't stop him from trying to slip outside nonetheless. He barely manages a few steps out of the lecture hall when Hyacine hooks her fingers into the back of his turtleneck and drags him to the library, where Mydei surely wouldn't be able to escape without causing a scene.

Smart. He hates her wits sometimes. Affectionately.

The second they sit down in a quiet corner, she crosses her arms.

"Talk."

Mydei rubs a hand over his face “It’s nothing. Really.”

“And that’s a lie,” she smiles at him cheerfully, clapping her hands together. “Try again.”

She’s a scary one, Mydei decides as she keeps smiling sweetly, expecting him to start talking like she’ll commit a felony if he doesn’t. He’s too young to die.

So, he opens his mouth, for the sake of staying alive mostly. He hesitates at first, unsure where to begin, but with Hyacine’s guiding questions everything starts spilling out faster than he means to. He tells her about his life with Phainon, the looks, the shorts incident, the more than a friendly intimacy between them. The way he let Mydei feel like there’s something more than friendship there.

He isn’t sure how the pink-haired girl does it, but she even gets a confession from him about his physical attraction, something he never thought he’d be sharing with anyone. That night with Phainon’s sweater was supposed to be his personal secret.

“Keep going” Hyacine says, more like a threat.

Mydei does, telling her about the sudden change, the mixed signals, the distance, the weirdness, the dodging… The way Phainon physically recoiled from his touch as if it burned all of a sudden.

About how he thinks he probably misunderstood it all and made things weird.

Hyacine listens through all of it, doesn’t hesitate to ask questions when he omits something from the story, preceptive as always, and when he finally grows quiet, she exhales, deep and exhausted like a tired mother who has to deal with her kids fighting for the umpteenth time.

“…Okay. First of all,” her smile is gone. “Phainon sounds like he’s having a gay awakening, or crisis. I don’t know him enough to point out which one.”

Mydei blinks. “That’s—”

“I’m not done,” she cuts in, giving him another fake smile, one that says *‘shut up and listen.’*

“Second, you did not imagine it. From what you told me so far, he’s clearly attracted to some degree but is holding back.”

He tilts his head in question.

“Let me explain in terms you’d understand, Mydei,” Hyacine sighs, “It’s like someone staring at a freshly baked pastry, but they are afraid to take a bite, because they know they’ll devour the whole thing if they do. You are the pastry, by the way.”

“Hyacine,” he mutters, face flushing at the thought of Phainon wanting to devour him. In bed, preferably.

“Hush. I'm not done here.”

Mydei coughs to get his composure under control and lets her continue. She grabs her phone, taps something furiously, then again. And again.

“Look. I'm no relationship expert, but it sounds like he’s just scared.” The pink-haired girl lifts her face from the screen.

“Of what?”

“Of *you*, genius.” She shrugs. “Of liking you. Of messing it up. Of wanting something different from what he’s used to. You know—emotional constipation.”

“…Emotional what?”

“You heard me.”

Mydei had never heard the term before, nor did he ever want to associate emotions with bowel movements, or lack of them. But Hyacine surely

knows better than him about emotions apparently, so he chooses to trust her words, whatever they mean.

The pink-haired girl bumps his shoulder with hers. “Listen, you’re hurt. And you’re allowed to be. Giving you mixed signals is a crappy thing to do. But I don’t think he’s playing with you,” She pauses, looking at the notes she made on her phone again. “I think he’s mostly scared, and that's what drives him away every time.”

Scowling, Mydei whispers between them, quiet and vulnerable, “I don’t want him to be scared of me.”

“I know,” her smile returns, a genuine one this time. “Talk to him. Not as in a confrontation.” She warns. “Just ask him how he feels, or do the first step and tell him yourself that you wish for more between you two.”

He swallows. “And if I’m wrong? If he really doesn’t want…”

“I don’t believe for a second that’s the case here,” she says simply. “What happened to the ‘*there’s no word for fear in my dictionary’* guy that I know?” Hyacine teases, mimicking his words.

Mydei laughs, actually laughs at her bad impersonation. Bless her soul, she cannot copy his deep voice in the slightest.

“And Mydei?” she pokes his face, the smile on her lips is one of both affection and irritation.

“…Yeah?”

“Please fix your life, or I’ll start charging you for therapy sessions.”

He huffs, folding his hands on his chest.

“I'm serious,” she declares, standing up. “Go home, communicate or something. Act like the grown adults you are. Before both of you implode from sheer stupidity, okay?”

“Yeah. Ok.” Mydei breathes out. Maybe she’s right. Maybe he didn’t imagine everything. Maybe it’s not too late to fix things.

— ◇ —

It starts raining barely five minutes after he leaves campus, making his drive pure hell. Mydei is drenched by the time he makes it home and the first thing he does is take a long hot shower, followed by a much-needed nap.

To his surprise, when he enters the living room post napping, somewhere around late afternoon, Phainon is there and not hiding in his room as usual.

“Didn’t think you’d be home this early,” he admits, not fully ready to have that talk Hyacine urged him to do.

“Stuck home thanks to the weather,” Phainon replies, too quick, too bright. “Looks like you’re stuck with me tonight...”

Something in Mydei loosens at that, a hope? He’s too hesitant to let himself hope again.

He tries teasing instead, the same light banter they ease into all the time, “You sure you’re not too busy tonight too?” but it comes out accusing, mean, and Phainon’s answer matches the energy—nonchalant, professional, *distant*.

“Work has been kicking my ass, needed a break from spreadsheets.”

Hesitant, Mydei sits in his corner of the couch, further than normal, because he doesn’t know where he stands anymore, and the distance between them physically hurts. He watches Phainon’s eyebrows furrow at the game, watches the way his shoulders tense, the way his jaw tightens. None of it matches his words.

“You sure that’s all?” he asks quietly.

“What else would it be?”

“Me,” Mydei thinks. “You tell me,” he says instead.

“You’re reading into things.”

“Maybe I am, but your avoidance is hard to miss.” Mydei doesn’t say any of it, knowing Hyacine would chew him alive if he does, but being vulnerable with the person you like, the person you don’t want to drive further away, is harder than he thought.

“I just needed some space,” Phainon adds eventually, cutting his line of thought.

“Space from what?” He asks, unable to mask the hurt in his voice. He deserves to know that much at least, deserves to know if Hyacine was correct or missed the mark entirely.

“Everything. Just… everything.”

It stings more than he expects. Everything includes him. Everything means it might be too late.

Mydei nods anyway, because what else is he supposed to do? “Okay. I wanted to make sure it wasn’t something I did.”

“It’s not.”

The lie is so obvious it hurts.

An unpleasant silence follows, the complete opposite of the comfortable quiet they used to enjoy, almost to the point where Mydei feels like he’s sitting next to a stranger who happens to wear Phainon’s face.

Remembering Hyacine’s words of *“fixing his life,”* he asks, carefully, if he’ll be here this weekend, in hopes of maybe spending some time together, having a heart-to-heart, and clearing things. Like the adults they are. And

hopefully return to at least being friends, because truth to be told, Mydei likes having Phainon around, even without the romantic feelings. He'd be willing to bury them away if it meant he gets to have the white-haired man close to him again.

It works for about ten minutes. They ease into their usual banter, poking at each other with their words like everything is normal again, until Phainon drops a bomb he did not expect to hear.

"Oh. Right. I didn't tell you, I have a date this Sunday!" The words slide out of his mouth bright and casual, and for a moment, all the air leaves Mydei's lungs.

A date.

The hope that had been clinging to since the talk with Hyacine earlier shatters into millions of shards. Her words echo in his head *"he's scared,"* so that's what he chose, that's where the avoidance led. Phainon chose to ignore his feelings—if there were any to begin with— move on, get back to dating, sleep around like Mydei isn't right in front of him and dying to be in the place of these women...

"Good for you," he mutters, both angry and hurt, mustering all his will to stay calm. If that's what Phainon chose, he'd handle it. He will wish him good luck and accept the awkwardness for the rest of their lease, or look for a different place, depending on how frequently Phainon would be bringing women around.

To pour more salt on his wounds, the white-haired man keeps talking, unaware of Mydei's inner turmoil. "Mind if I try a line or two on you? See if it sounds good?"

For his date.

On him.

"You want to test your pickup lines. On me," Mydei repeats, to make sure he's hearing it right and this isn't some trick from the gods above to test his

sanity and self-restraint. A self-restraint that's too close to snapping the more Phainon keeps running his mouth.

"Is that a no? C'mon, Mydeimos, help a bro out!"

Bro.

The word feels like a slap to his face.

"You're unbelievable," he hisses, the lack of humor in his own voice surprises even him.

Phainon gives him a baffled "What?", looking genuinely confused as if Mydei's flat reaction doesn't add up in his head. And maybe that's what finally breaks his remaining composure, allowing anger to boil inside him.

The way Phainon can walk around, wreak havoc on his composure, on his life, pull him in then push him away like it's some kind of game, and still have the audacity to act like he doesn't understand how much he hurt him.

"You think this is funny?" The words leave Mydei's lips harsh and accusing. The exact opposite of what Hyacine told him to say.

"No need to take it so seriously…" Phainon gets defensive, frowning. "It's just a joke."

A joke. Now it's a joke. Mydei's feelings are nothing but a joke to him…

Mydei laughs, bitter and humorless. "A joke. You're really good at those, aren't you?"

He shouldn't say it. He knows he shouldn't, but the anger is boiling too hot to ignore, mixed with days of confusion and hurt, made worse by Phainon's obliviousness.

"Forget it." Mydei clenches his fists hard enough to hurt, one last attempt to remain in control of himself.

Phainon’s voice rises back, confused and hurt. Not that he had any right to act hurt now, not when he’s the one hurting Mydei. Their tone rises with each accusation and he isn’t sure what he’s saying anymore, none of the words come right, none of the things he’s saying convey his emotions.

“You’re mad about me having a date, aren’t you? How is that my fault? Are you jealous or something?”

Mydei’s brain halts like someone pressed the brake pedal all of a sudden.

Jealous!?

Is that what it looks like from the outside? Jealousy— petty, irrational, childish? Phainon really doesn’t see it.

He feels like a fool. An idiot for believing there was something between them.

“So that’s it, then,” Mydei says quietly, defeated. “You really don’t get it…”

He’s so tired. Tired of swallowing it down, of hoping quietly, of yearning for something real in the way Phainon looked at him, touched him, leaned into him.

It was all in his head, never mutual.

Turning away, he tries to bite down the tears threatening to fall, no longer angry but impossibly hurt.

“Then explain it to me!” Phainon demands, taking a step closer. “Please. I can’t fix it if you don’t tell me what I did.”

“There is nothing to fix,” His laugh is hollow and full of disbelief. There is nothing to fix if there wasn’t anything there to begin with. Every lingering look, every flushed face, every word that sounded like a confession— none of it meant anything.

His composure snaps at last, the hurt becomes too much to contain, talking over him.

“Stop pretending,” Mydei hears himself growl as his hand grabs Phainon by the collar of his shirt, dragging him forward. There’s a split second where he could still let go, walk away, swallow his emotions like he taught himself to.

He doesn’t. He acts like his teenage self again. Reckless and impulsive.

His fist makes contact with Phainon’s cheek.

Regret fills him instantly. The pain in his knuckles forgotten the second he sees the blood trickling down Phainon’s lip, and the shock on the man’s face. Phainon stares at him with wide eyes, hand on his slowly bruising jaw, and the sight is enough to break Mydei; the tears he managed to hold back finally falling down his cheeks.

How long has it been since he allowed himself to cry? He cannot remember.

“I’m sorry” he manages weakly, barely above a whisper. “Forget it.”

Mydei flees to his room before he can make things worse, slamming the door behind him.

“What have I done...?”

He hit him. He actually hit him. The one person he didn’t want to hurt.

Reaching for the phone in his pocket with shaking fingers, Mydei scrolls blindly until he finds his mother’s contact.

No, he shouldn’t bother her, he shouldn’t make her drive all the way from Kremnos to Okhema, because she absolutely would the second she hears he’s distressed. Instead, Mydei scrolls back up to the second best alternative: Castorice.

“Can I come over?” He doesn’t bother with a greeting when she picks up, her voice confused as he prefers texting over calling.

“What happened?” Castorice asks back, worry laced in her tone.

“I—” His throat tightens, a quiet sob escapes him, one that he knows Castorice heard. “I messed up.”

“I’ll come get you,” she says. “You don’t sound like you’re in a state to drive over.”

Mydei nods even though she can’t see it, murmurs a quiet “thank you,” and hangs up.

Left alone in the silence of his rooms, Mydei stares at his— still red— knuckles and hates himself for not being strong enough to control his emotions. With this punch, he crashed not only his hope, but possibly every chance of reconciliation too.

Castorice, true to her word, comes to pick him up not even fifteen minutes later, and Mydei sneaks out, thankful that Phainon isn’t in the living room. She takes a look at him the moment he sits inside the car, taking his state in, and pulls him into a tight hug, not saying anything.

He’s thankful for silence.

She still doesn’t say anything when she prepares him pomegranate tea or throws five different fluffy blankets at him. It is only when Cipher arrives about half an hour later, still in uniform and with an expression that says she’s ready to commit crimes on his behalf despite being a cop, that Castorice asks, “Do you want to talk about it?”

He doesn’t. Not really. But he knows better than to keep secrets from his closest friends— and he ends up explaining everything he told Hyacine the same morning: the closeness, the mixed signals, the hope he shouldn’t have allowed himself; knowing damn well Phainons wasn’t into men, then the sudden distance, and the ugly fight.

When he finishes, neither of the girls speaks right away.

Castorice breaks the quiet first. “You know he’s not malicious, right? He’s an idiot. I’ve known him since our university days and he really is. But I’m sure he’s not being cruel on purpose.”

Cipher nods. “Grade-A idiot. Certified. And knowing him, he’s probably not even aware of his own emotions...”

Mydei lets out a slow breath, staring into the empty cup in his hands. “I know. That’s the worst part.”

“Then maybe you two should talk,” Cas suggests. “You’ve read enough of my novels, you should know proper communication is the key. It might not fix everything, but it might land you back into a friendship at least. If you want one.”

Cipher leans forward, eyes narrowed. “Or, hear me out, you could let him apologize first, chase you a little, maybe he’d realize his feelings in the process. And if he doesn’t, you move on. That boy is cute, but no man is worth you looking like a soggy cat.”

Castorice shoots her a look. Cipher shrugs.

“It’s your call,” the lavender-haired girl adds. “But you don’t have to punish yourself for caring. Or for being hurt. Your emotions are valid.”

Mydei closes his eyes. He can still see the hurt on Phainon’s face when he punched him. Still hear the confusion, the pleading. Still feel the pain of that week’s worth of distance tightening slowly around his heart.

“I don’t think I can hope for anything anymore,” he finally admits. “Not after this.”

Cipher reaches over and squeezes his shoulder. “I'm sorry, little prince.” She never calls him prince unless it’s bad, opting to tease him with *princess* instead. “If I’d known it would end like this…” she trails off.

“It’s not your fault.” Both he and Castorice say at the same time, laughing softly in reaction.

Cas pats his other shoulder. “It’s not your fault Mydei, feelings are complicated. I told Phainon the same a while ago.” Her smile softens, “Take

your time to think, I’m sure you two could still be great friends once the emotions die down.”

The words sink in slowly, easing something inside him.

Friendship. Maybe he can do that. It might hurt now, but it wouldn’t be his first breakup. He’ll move on eventually like he did all the times before.

“You’re right,” he says quietly. “I’ll apologize to him, then move on. And if he wants to stay friends, I’ll accept that.”

Cipher smacks his back hard enough to hurt. “That’s my little princess! Erase those emotions from your dictionary, as you love saying.”

Mydei laughs, mentally erasing the word “hope” from his inner dictionary.

He wouldn’t make the same mistake twice, wouldn’t let himself be swayed by Phainon’s charm. Or so he *hopes*.

Shit. Now he has to erase the word again.

Chapter End Notes

This one got a little long

Chapter 6: It’s Not Gay, It’s… Complicated

Chapter Summary

> A week ago, Phainon was so mortified by thinking about his roommate that he scrubbed his skin raw in the shower, drowned himself in beer and poured his confusion on Reddit like an idiot. Oh, and almost ruined his friendship with Mydei... Can't forget that one.
>
> Now? He just feels tired. Tired of pretending it’s something he can keep avoiding.
>
> He runs a hand through his hair and takes a deep breath. “Okay,” Phinon mutters to the empty room, like the walls hold the answers to his emotional mess. “So, you’re possibly attracted to him. Great. Now what?”
>
> Or; baby steps...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon spends most of the next day in his room, nursing a swollen jaw and a busted lip that luckily doesn’t need stitches.

Fuck, the man’s fists are no joke, now that he got to test them himself. Even something as simple as frowning sends jolts of pain through his face.

He’s *not hiding.* Totally not hiding. Nor avoids Mydei in any way.

Or that’s what Phainon tells himself at least. He just… needs space and time to think. Time to figure out what the hell went wrong, and what he said or didn’t say in this case, to make Mydei snap like that. And Mydei probably needs space too anyway, judging by how quiet the apartment is, assuming

the blonde is either brooding in his room or out in the gym, punching something while imagining Phainon's face.

He hates it. The quiet. The sudden rift between them. The emotional mess he is.

It drags into the evening, when the apartment is still too quiet, when he knocks on Mydei's door to try and apologize, and hears no response.

By night, he's worried. Phainon opens the door to Mydei's room, *"to make sure Mydei isn't dead,"* because that's a normal roommate thing to do, right? Check up that everyone in the house are alive and all that.

He only finds an empty space, realizing Mydei hadn't been home since morning, or possibly since last night.

Phainon [23:19]: Mydei?

Phainon [23:25]: Are you ok? Im worried.

Mydei leaves him on read. Fantastic. At least he knows his roommate is alive somewhere, even if he's currently avoiding him like the plague. Phainon grabs a protein bar for dinner— same as breakfast and lunch, despite not feeling hungry at all and winces with every bite as his bruised jaw protests the movement.

Oh, and he skips showering. It's not like he left the house anyway.

Sleep is when his mind starts spiraling all over again. How does Mydei feel? Is he spending the night outside? Maybe crashes at a friend's place? He should be mad at him, upset, but Phainon can't help but worry. Mydei is his friend.

He likes him.

In a *friendly* way, of course. Platonic concern, that's all.

He doesn't know when exhaustion finally wins and sends him into a pitiful sleep, but when it does, he dreams of Mydei knocking on his room's door,

only to tell him he’s moving out and never wants to see him again. Phainon wakes up with hot tears soaking into his pillow. He was never this upset about losing a friend. Until now.

“Maybe friendship hurts sometimes,” he mutters, turning the pillow to its dry side.

His brain mocks him like it knows something he doesn’t. “*Or maybe it’s more than friendship.*”

Curling under the blanket, Phainon chased the thought away. He’s too tired to deal with his brain, he has a date to think about.

He suddenly wants to call the whole thing off and go back to sleep.



Phainon shows up twenty minutes early. Not because he’s eager or anything, but because it’s better than sulking at home, waiting for Mydei to return, or reply, or… anything other than radio silence.

Convincing himself for almost a whole hour in the shower helped set his mind into normalcy again, somewhat. And although he can’t say he’s fully excited about it; this date is supposed to set him back on track. Away from the confusion and the hundreds of anonymous people calling on his sexuality.

He’s going to enjoy it. Prove the universe he’s straight, maybe get laid too — as long as he can keep the cool guy façade long enough.

Choosing to wait inside rather than stay out in the cold, Phainon sits at the bar and orders a gin and tonic instead of his usual sweet cocktails, trying to look impressive, manly, like all the dating tips he’s been reading on his phone in the past few hours. And when his drink is served, Phainon takes a small sip, only to realize that alcohol and wounds are not friends.

He winces, regretting all his life choices immediately. Hopefully the other tips would be better.

His phone vibrates in his pants pocket, and he grabs it immediately, heart racing at the thought of Mydei finally replying to him, only to be met with a message from Aphrea, the girl he's supposed to meet.

Aphrea- date [13:55]: Running a bit late! Promise I'm worth the wait <3.

She probably is. But Phainon only feels disappointed that it isn't a text from Mydei.

By the time Aphrea arrives, he's halfway through his drink and about thirty-three million cycles into overthinking, only drawn back to reality when he hears a soft, feminine voice calling his name, "Phainon?"

He stands up, smiles at the woman in front of him and leans in for a quick hug— this one proves to be successful. "Hey! You must be the speed of light, because time stops when I look at you." He winks.

Aphrea laughs at his joke, much to his surprise, and Phainon allows himself a moment to look at her properly. She is exactly like her pictures, maybe prettier; long blonde hair, hazel eyes, big chest, red lipstick, and Phainon suddenly feels guilty for not feeling more enthusiastic about this date.

"Hey! Sorry I'm late" she says, tucking a strand of blonde hair behind her ear. "Traffic was a nightmare."

"No worries!" Phainon replies, pulling out the chair next to his in a gentleman-like gesture.

She orders her own drink, eyes his bruised lip, and asks if he's ok. Phainon makes up a story about bumping his head into a kitchen cabinet and she laughs. Thankfully, the conversation between them flows easily after. She talks about her work as a fitness instructor and her love for hiking, and he tries to match her energy, smiles, throws in an occasional "I know, right?" or "I totally get that."

He doesn’t totally get that.

“Mydei would’ve hated this place.” His mind drifts mid convo. He’d probably mock the lack of healthier food options on the menu. Or order a glass of juice, to prove a point, then tease Phainon for picking a cocktail that is more sugar than alcohol.

Phainon huffs out a laugh without realizing it, stopping Aphrea mid-sentence, and she looks at him, confused.

“Sorry,” he says quickly, rubbing the back of his neck, already missing the lack of his signature choker- the one he took off after reading it’s not manly to wear anything but a watch to a date. “Just remembered something stupid.”

“Oh,” she smiles politely. “Good stupid or bad stupid?”

“Definitely good.” Phainon can’t help but smile fondly at the thought.

Aphrea is good company, he decides halfway through their date. She’s funny, bright, confident. He *likes* her. But… not the way he should. He tries to like her the right way. God, he really tries.

Phainon attempts to pay more attention, to engage further, to comment about her cat, who acts like he’s the owner of the house and not the other way around, but everything feels too neat. Too rehearsed.

Like he is acting out a role he has done countless times before and has grown bored with.

With Mydei, it never felt like that. It’s stupid jokes and endless teasing. It’s evenings where they end up laughing until his stomach hurts and both men lose track of time. It’s the quiet comfort of being next to the man. Hell, they didn’t need to talk at all, chilling around the house with Mydei’s company felt more exciting than sitting at the bar right now.

He misses him.

“Phainon?” Aphrea reaches across the table, her soft palm touching his hand lightly to catch his attention, and his mind flashes with something it shouldn’t. A different hand. Larger. Warmer. Just as soft. Tattoos as red as her lipstick trailing up a muscular forearm.

Mydei’s hand.

He blinks the thought away, heart beating too loud to be comfortable in his chest. “Sorry,” he laughs weakly, withdrawing his hand from hers. “Didn’t sleep enough, was nervous for the date.” He lies, partially. He did have a hard time sleeping, although she didn’t need to know it had nothing to do with her.

The woman grins, buying the excuse, and turns to face him, leaning closer. At the new angle her cleavage is quite generous, and Phainon has a hard time looking anywhere else, gulping audibly. “Maybe I could help with the nervousness, want to go back to your place and I’ll show you how?”

The invitation is direct, hard to interpret as anything else. Phainon should say yes. Wants to say yes. That’s what he’s been waiting for twenty-seven years of his life, or at least for the past decade. Semantics.

Aphrea is beautiful, and most importantly, interested. It would be so easy to accept her offer, to let the warmth of someone new consume him and make him forget about all the accidents involving Mydei. But when she looks at him expectantly with her red lips curved in a smile, waiting for him to nod, say ‘yes’ or grab her hand and lead them out of the bar— the image that comes to his mind is of Mydei, laughing while teasing him about his bad pick-up lines, humming while cooking, wishing him *good night* in his deep voice…

Phainon feels sick.

“Aphrea,” he starts, expecting to feel regret for declining her offer, but there’s none. There's only relief. “You’re lovely and I appreciate the offer,” he pauses. “But, I— there is something I can’t seem to get out of my head.” Admitting it should not feel like a stone has been lifted off his chest.

“Oh,” she sits back and gives him an understanding smile. “Something, or someone?” her eyebrows wiggle suggestively.

“It’s…” he trails off, chugging the rest of his drink in one go. It’s awful and his lip burns. “…Someone.”

“At least you’re honest” Aphrea says with a shrug. “And it wasn’t a total loss,” she adds “You’re pretty fun when you’re paying attention.”

Phainon opens his mouth, then closes it. She is right about him not paying enough attention. “You got me there.”

They leave soon after she finishes her own drink, and end up sharing another hug before parting, dating tips long forgotten. “Good luck with your crush, I’m sure the guy would like you back!” she says with a grin.

“It’s not a—” he protests. It’s not a guy, or a crush, or… He’s not sure anymore. But Aphrea is already gone before he can finish the sentence. Phainon stands there for a long minute, staring at the spot where she was moments ago, then laughs under his breath, shaking his head.

Somehow this was one of his best dates, despite the outcome.

━ ◇ ━

The apartment is still silent when he returns home, and the uneasiness that was pushed to the back of his mind crawls back to nag at him. Mydei isn’t there, and he didn’t respond to his message either.

Checking his Phone’s notifications, he sees a new message from Cipher, sent around the time he left the bar.

Cipher [15:30]: So, what did you do?

Phainon [15:52]: Wdym?

Cipher [15:53]: Mydei stayed the night at our place and told us the tea… here's your chance to defend yourself.

"That's not helpful at all," he mutters, pouting, the motion makes his lip throb. Although somewhere deep inside, relief washes over him now that he knows his roommate stayed somewhere safe.

Phainon [15:56]: I…

He starts typing, deletes it, starts again.

Phainon [15:57]: We fought, he punched me, im not sure what was the reason for it.

Cipher [15:58]: Im surrounded by idiots. Great.

Closing his eyes, he can see the gray-haired girl groan, possibly roll her eyes too. Always the dramatic one.

Cipher [15:59]: Anyway. hes on his way home after a nice and long pep-talk from Cas and yours truly. be nice to my little brother or hed call his mother... shes a scary one.

Phainon groans loudly, tossing the phone to the couch. He *was* nice! He was waiting all day to talk things out! His reflection in the balcony window looks back at him, tired. Dressed nicely, sure. But still an exhausted mess.

He doesn't have much to ponder his appearance, because true to Cipher's words, he can hear their apartment door open not long after her last message.

Phainon's pulse stutters. He stares at the door like it's a ticking bomb he doesn't know how to detonate. "Mydei?" His voice comes out shaky, hesitant.

"Hey," Mydei says quietly, entering the apartment with an unreadable expression and a takeout bag- the salad place he was telling him about ever since they started living together. Mydei must feel really bad if he brought him 'rabbit food' as he called it before.

For an unknown reason, his heart beats louder in his chest at the gesture.

“Hey.”

Silence stretches between them. Seconds— or maybe hours, who knows— with each heartbeat drawn out too long. Then Mydei sighs, his free hand reaches to fiddle with the braid he always has no matter the hairstyle, eyes widening at the sight of Phainon’s visibly injured lip.

“I’m sorry.” The blonde murmurs, full of regret. “I shouldn’t have lost my temper. Or hit you.”

The man looks like a kicked cat. A six-foot-two cat.

Phainon wants to say it’s fine, but it’s not. His face still aches with every movement, and yet, seeing Mydei standing there, shoulders drawn tight with shame, makes it impossible to stay angry even if he should be. “You were pissed. I get it.”

“That’s not an excuse,” Mydei insists. He looks away, anywhere but at Phainon, as if he's thinking what to say next. “You didn’t deserve that. Allow me to apologize again.”

The plea hangs heavy in the air.

Phainon steps closer to him, grabbing the takeout bag from Mydei’s hand. The touch of his palm against Mydei’s feels electric, overwhelming almost. “Apology accepted.” He smiles, barely, not wanting to move his sore lip too much. “Can I ask what upset you?”

Mydei looks away immediately, hand retreating from Phainon’s grasp. “It doesn’t matter anymore.”

“Figures.” He lets out a quiet laugh, already on his way to the kitchen to grab forks and open the salad containers, “Are you going to eat too, or you planning to sulk in the living room like a wet cat?”

Mydeimos follows him into the kitchen, less tense than moments ago. “A wet cat? Ha! At least I don’t look like a kicked dog.”

It’s the softest laugh, barely there unless you know the small nuances of Mydei— the ones he learned over the months they spent under the same roof, and the sound makes the knot in his stomach loosen a little.

“I’m not a dog!” he exclaims with a matching laugh of his own.

“Cipher could claim otherwise.”

The silence between them while they eat isn’t entirely comfortable, but it’s not unbearable either. Surely an improvement from twenty-four hours ago. If improvement meant not being murdered by your roommate…

“I really am sorry,” Mydei says again, stabbing at a piece of cucumber with unnecessary force.

“I know.” Phainon glances sideways at him. “I forgive you. My lip though, you might have to apologize harder to the poor thing.”

An amused smirk curls on Mydei’s lips, one that feels like normalcy again, like the strain between them is gone. “Should I kiss it better?”

"I—" Phainon’s mind crashed like an overheated computer. He knows it’s a joke, he knows Mydei is teasing. The man’s infuriating smirk says it all. But holy fuck, his mind is not helping with the mental Image of Mydei leaning in, of a soft palm cupping his cheek, of Mydei’s lip touching his—

Abort mission. Abort mission.

“…I’m joking.”

He groans, praying for his cheeks to stop *burning*. Of course Mydei would be joking. *That brat*. “God, you can’t stay serious for five minutes, can you?” He flicks a cherry tomato at him, which is a terrible choice, considering his cheeks are matching in color.

“No. You’re fun to tease, at the very least that didn’t change.” Mydei catches the small fruit easily, his grin widening as he pops it in his mouth, bringing Phainon’s attention to his lips again. Fucking hell, he’s losing it.

“Still friends?” the blonde asks as he finishes chewing, quietly, like a resignation, the smirk from barely a moment ago gone completely.

“Yeah,” Phainon coughs, deciding that his lettuce is far more interesting than Mydeimos’ face all of a sudden. “Still friends.”

The rest of their early dinner passes without further incidents and so does the rest of the evening. They settle in the living room and Phainon loads one of his games, neither of them talks much aside from a few chuckles and teasing remarks.

Like the “Skill issue,” that Mydei comments as he watches him die, for the third time, over trying to fight a weekly boss with no healer in the team.

A skill issue indeed.

Between respawns, Phainon averts his eyes from the screen to look at Mydei, taking in the bags under his eyes and the way his hands fidget with the hem of his sweater in a nervous habit. The blonde looks almost… What is the word he’s looking for? Oh yeah. Vulnerable. He doesn’t like it. All Phainon wants is to see the man smile again.

“I don’t want to lose this,” he admits, more to himself but loud enough for Mydei to hear him.

“What do you mean?”

“This,” Phainon gestures vaguely between them. His team dies again on the screen but he couldn’t care less at the moment. “What we have between us. I don’t want to screw it up.”

The look on Mydei’s face is an unreadable one, his eyes are locked at the TV screen, where the bold red letters are saying ‘*would you like to try again?’*.

“You mean our friendship…” The blonde trails off, just as quietly, sounding defeated. “Yeah, I won’t screw it up again, don’t worry.”

Phainon forces a smile, but something in his chest twists painfully. It shouldn’t sting, yet it does.

“Won't screw it up again.” He isn’t sure why the words feel so bitter on his tongue.

— ◇ —

Later that night, Phainon lies awake in bed long after he should be up, going over the day in his head. He knows he will regret it in the morning, but that’s a problem for future him.

Friends... That’s how they should be, they can be friends again, ease into a comfortable routine and spend their evenings laughing as Phainon teaches his— horrible at gaming— roommate how not to die every other second during PvP matches, or banter over TV shows.

He turns on his side, smiling at the memory of them arguing, playfully of course, over preferred cooking techniques and how they thought they could be better than the contestants. The memory is a pleasant one, and Phainon pulls the blanket over his head, hiding the wide grin spreading on his lips. The scent of the detergent he associates with Mydei after months of living together floods his nose; something clean and fresh and floral.

The scent shouldn’t be so comforting, but it is. It is comforting.

Everything about Mydeimos is comforting to him, and maybe that’s exactly the problem, the reason behind his confusion, because the first thought that comes to his mind when he thinks about the man is not panic or denial. Not anymore. Instead, it’s warmth.

He’s still not sure what to do with this weird feeling. He doesn’t want to name it, doesn’t want to think too hard about that word Castorice mentioned: *love*. Phainon doesn't think he loves Mydei, not that he even

knows what romantic love feels like. His love for his sister and his other friends is a lot different than what he's feeling toward Mydeimos, so surely that's not the case here.

Yet, the thought of loving Mydei doesn't make him recoil anymore. Doesn't make him feel *wrong*.

Just… scared of the meaning behind it, scared of how it defies everything he thought he should be.

"It's all Mydei's fault" Phainon huffs. His missing sweater? Mydei. The dinner he burnt by accident last week? Mydei. Traffic at six a.m.? Also Mydei's fault – just because he feels petty.

It's easier than thinking about emotions.



Phainon ends up waking before his alarm rings.

His body feels heavy with sleep, but his mind is still buzzing with the *very pleasant* dream he woke up from— heat, skin against skin, someone moaning his name, arousal...

God, the arousal.

He exhales slowly as his senses wake up one by one and he becomes aware of how painfully hard he is, how much his body is thrumming with the need for release from an erotic dream alone.

"You've got to be kidding me…" Groaning into the pillow, Phainon rolls over to lie on his stomach. He tries to ignore the throb at first, the same way he had been doing in the past days, but his dick apparently didn't get the memo about emotional restraint, because any attempts to ignore his lower half are only making things much worse.

He shouldn’t be surprised, not really. It’s been more than a week since *that accident* in the shower, since he swore to never touch himself again, like willpower could rewrite desire. No wonder his body demands the attention, he thinks, mind clouded with sleep and need.

Huffing stubbornly, he rolls on his side and hugs his extra pillow, willing himself to think of anything that would make his erection go away— like the traffic he hates in the mornings. Yet, his hips move on their own, rutting into the pillow shallowly, chasing the delicious friction on his, painfully hard, cock.

Maybe number would do the job; taxes, bills, budgeting… A muffled moan he cannot hold back rips from his throat as he picks up the pace, feeling *so good* already.

Phainon tries his last resort: Lygus. The creep from sales who flirts with every woman in the office and speaks like he’s a second away from orgasm or something. His hips don’t stop rutting into the pillow even as the memory of his coworker makes him shiver in disgust.

He gives up. If Lygus can’t make his erection go away, he is afraid that nothing will.

Lowering his boxers enough to free his cock, Phainon gives himself a few pumps— pressing at the underside the way he likes it the most, then thumbing at the slit, gathering the precum beading there. Sliding his hand lower, he cups his balls, feeling how heavy and full they are in his palm, cock twitching desperately in reaction. Fuck, that dream riled him up so badly he’s already close, shame he cannot remember what he dreamt about. Another moan rips from his chest as he adjusts the pillow lower between his legs and resumes his earlier action.

It’s almost pathetic, he thinks distantly through the haze of desire. How pent up he is after barely a week, rutting into a pillow like the desperate virgin he is, when barely a day ago he had a chance to finally have sex with someone.

Phainon shakes his head. Too late for that. Forcing his mind to conjure a fantasy instead of overthinking— he squeezes his eyes tighter and focuses,

imagining that instead of a pillow, there's a woman in his arms: narrow waist, wide hips, she has a really nice ass he is thrusting against, round and firm, pushing back against his hard length. Her flat stomach tenses under his palms when he presses her closer and buries his face in her blonde hair. Blonde and dyed red at the tips—

Wait. Red tips?

It doesn't matter. The fantasy pleases him, if the way his cock pulses is any indication. He ruts faster into the softness of the pillow, the familiar coil in his lower belly drawing tighter with each thrust. Almost there, just a bit more… He bites on his lower lip to muffle a whimper when the head presses just right into the fabric, wincing instead when he accidentally applies pressure on the healing cut.

The woman in his fantasy arches into him, crimson tattoos flexing under his grip, broad shoulders pressing against his chest.

"Phai—" A deep, manly voice moans, rough and needy.

Wait.

No.

That's not—

Phainon's eyes fly open, but it's too late. Pleasure crashes through him in intense waves as he cums with a choked cry, cock twitching desperately, spilling milky release into the pillow. He would need to wash the entire thing for sure after this.

His hips don't stop though, grinding through the aftershocks until he is spent, panting, and suddenly very aware of the thought that tipped him over the edge: Blonde with red tips, broad shoulders, tattooed back, deep voice. That's not a woman. That's…

"Mydeimos," he whispers, mortified. He came to the thought of Mydei. Again. Not some vague fantasy but Mydei's body. Mydei's voice. Mydei

pressing against him, enjoying it.

He rolls onto his back and stares at the ceiling like it’s personally responsible for this crisis, mind replaying the last few seconds of the fantasy; the sound of Mydei moaning his name and how it made him come almost instantly.

He wants the ground to open, right below him, and swallow him alive.

“You’ve got to be kidding me” Phainon repeats again, more tired this time. Of himself. Of his traitorous brain. Of everything.

Once could’ve been an accident. But twice?

Dragging a hand down his face, he groans, loud.

Fine. Okay. He’s attracted to Mydei. Physically, at least. Can anyone blame him for that? The man is objectively hot— built like a Greek god, blushes like a maiden… But it’s more than his body. He likes being around Mydei. Likes the way he listens with interest, teases him about his, subjectively, bad fashion sense, grounds him when he spirals, accepts his challenges with a matching fire in his eyes…

“You’re in deep shit, man,” Phainon sighs, defeated.

He doesn’t know what to call it. Doesn’t know if it’s love, lust, or some confused middle ground. Maybe it’s only curiosity. Maybe he is just lonely. Maybe the bond he has with the blonde fills his heart in a way no one else ever bothered.

Maybe it’s all the above.

It’s almost funny, he thinks, how he doesn’t feel weird about it anymore.

A week ago, he was so mortified by thinking sexually about his roommate that he scrubbed his skin raw in the shower, drowned himself in beer and poured his confusion on Reddit like an idiot. Oh, and almost ruined his friendship with Mydei… Can't forget that one.

Now? He feels tired.

Tired of pretending it’s something he can keep avoiding.

Phainon runs a hand through his hair and takes a deep breath. “Okay,” he mutters to the empty room, like the walls hold the answers to his emotional mess. “So, you’re possibly into him. Great. Now what?”

— ◇ —

His answer, funnily enough, comes later that same day.

The rest of his morning is hell. He takes too long to get dressed, Mydei questions him— shirtless, because of course— why he’s tossing a whole pillow into the washer. His excuse of “I spilled water on it” is as lame as his attempt not to stare at Mydei’s shirtless torso, or not blush when he catches himself staring, without a teasing remark from the blonde this time.

Phainon makes himself coffee on autopilot and pretends to study the salt shaker’s ingredients like it’s the most fascinating thing he’d ever read for the rest of the morning. Who knew that the ingredients of salt were in fact… Salt.

At least until Mydei gets up to wash his place, done with his meal, and realizes the blonde never offered to make him a portion like usual, nor packed him a lunchbox.

He basically sat in the kitchen for thirty minutes over a cup of coffee. He feels stupid.

Traffic doesn’t help his sanity either, the slow movement of his car allows too much room for thinking, or overthinking: they might've made up, but it's still strained, something is still off and he wishes he could fix it, win

Mydei's affection again and go back to the platonic intimacy they had before the fight.

By the time he reaches the office, he already knows he's not going to be productive. At all.

True to his word, Phainon spends the first hour staring at his monitor, re-reading the same email for the fifth time, every line turns into white noise, barely registering in his head. He should focus, should write that marketing proposal, should make the edits he was requested by the client…

Yet, he can't bring himself to care about any of these. Not when his brain is stuck in a loop: last night where they made up, sort of, followed by this morning's accident. Oh, and the way his heart still does that stupid loud *'thump'* when he thinks about Mydei in a more romantic sense, or involuntary lower-half reactions whenever he thinks about Mydei's shoulders…

Phainon shakes his head, chasing the indecent thoughts away. At least he's coherent enough to filter those out. The last thing he needs mid-work is a boner.

He tries to drown his emotional mess with caffeine, hoping to increase his efficiency but it doesn't work as planned. Three coffees in and he's still useless, but now with the added jitteriness and the ability to hear colors, which does not help. At all.

When he gets up to the kitchenette to make a fourth cup, wondering what side effect he'll gain this time, Tribios pokes his shoulder, startling him. "Snowy, are you ok? You look like you've seen a ghost."

"Worse," he groans. "I'm feeling emotions."

"Finally fallen for your "not boyfriend"? Should I throw a party?" The redhead teases him with a knowing grin.

He throws a sugar packet at her, and she runs away laughing, telling him she sent something to his email as her voice fades down the hall. The little

distraction doesn’t help, nor does another cup of coffee. Phainon is pretty sure he’s one cup away from caffeine poisoning at this point.

And his newly gained ability to associate everything with Mydei only makes things worse.

His male coworkers laugh? He imagines a deeper voice. Someone mentions adding pomegranates to their yoghurt this morning— that’s Mydei’s favorite fruit. He’s answering a request for a work meeting, and puts the address of the café Mydei’s works at before even realizing it.

“You like him.” The words loop like a broken record, terrifying in their meaning. “*More than a friend*.”

Yeah, there’s no way he’s concentrating on anything like this.

It’s bad enough that Aglaea makes her way to his desk around lunch, telling him to go home early and get his shit together, in a more professional “Go home, rest, and come back tomorrow with a clear head” way.

He sits in his car for a good twenty minutes before driving home, already planning on a much-needed nap— non-erotic, please and thank you— and do some more thinking once he’s more awake and coherent, but the universe decides to twist the knife a little deeper, in case he hadn’t suffered enough just yet.

Because when he steps into the apartment, sighing happily at the warmth indoors, Mydei is standing by the mirror right in front of him; buttoning up a black dress shirt.

Phainon freezes, the tiredness from before completely gone.

At first, all he can do is gawk at his roommate. Heavens help him, Mydei looks stunning. His usual mane is tied in a low ponytail, and the dress shirt fits him perfectly, enhancing his physique in all the right ways. He smells divine too. It's not the usual deodorant he wears but a cologne. Sweet with a musky undertone.

He stares for another second before forcing his eyes away. His first thought is “*God help me, he looks so good.”* The second thought stabs him in the chest. “*He never dresses up this much for work or classes.”*

“Hey,” Mydei glances at him. His voice is casual, but there’s a faint flush on his cheeks, like he knows what kind of thoughts Phainon was having while staring at him. “You’re home early.”

“Was so tired my boss kicked me home for the day,” Phainon admits, playing with the leather of his choker nervously. “You- you look fancy. What’s the occasion?”

Mydei fixes the shirt’s collar, checking his reflection. “Someone asked me out at the gym this morning.”

“Oh.”

Phainon blinks once. Twice. His stomach drops.

Mydei continues, adding more salt to the wound. “Didn’t plan on it at first, but the guy almost begged. It was kind of cute,” He chuckles, “Figured I’d give it a try, not like I had a reason to turn him down.”

Phainon laughs awkwardly, face flushing in a mix of emotions he’s too exhausted to deal with – frustration, hurt, fear... “Wow. Look at you, Mr. Popular.”

Mydei looks at him with an unreadable expression, before easing into a smile that doesn’t reach his eyes. “It was quite flattering. The guy tried hard to impress me.”

“Right,” Phainon says, hoping the pain he’s feeling inside isn’t written all over his face. “Nothing screams romance like the smell of sweat and testosterone. Anyway, show me a pic? As your favorite and only roommate, I got to approve the guy!”

That earns him a chuckle. It shouldn’t make his heart ache like that, but it does. It hurts even more when Mydei shows him the guy’s profile picture:

messy hair, scrawny, not a single attractive feature. Mydei is totally out of this man's league.

"I see… He's ok. I guess? You didn't have to get all dressy though," he adds, gesturing at the outfit Mydei is wearing. "This guy looks like he's going to show up in a t-shirt and jeans."

"I do not care about what others wear to their dates," Mydei replies, his tone is colder this time.

"Oh come on, Mydeimos. Surely you value yourself better than that." *"Shut up."* "I can tell just by the picture that he's not worth it." *"Stop talking."* "Trust your friend on this one." His mouth doesn't listen and keeps running.

"You're sounding quite hostile. Are you jealous or something?" Golden eyes narrow at him.

Well, that successfully shuts Phainon up. He is not jealous, is he? He's upset, yeah, but to call it jealousy?

"You can lie to Mydei, but not to yourself."

The silence that follows is awkward, heavy, full of words Phainon wants to say but doesn't know how to yet. He wants to reach Mydei's arm, beg him to stay, wants to say "*don't go*", wants to shout that this is unfair, that he only barely started realizing his emotions and he already lost his chance.

But instead, he jokes. Because that's what he does instead of being vulnerable. Mydei was right.

"At least tell me you've got a good pickup line ready," he grins, forcing himself to sound like he's a supportive friend. Because that's all he is now, Mydei made it clear last night.

The blonde glances at him, eyebrow raised in confusion. "I don't use pickup lines."

"Time to start! Let me think of a good one," Phainon steps closer, which, in his defense, is totally not to take a closer whiff at his roommate's cologne.

“Should I be concerned?”

“Absolutely.” He taps his chin dramatically. “Nice to meet you, Mydei. I feel like you’re about to make my day.”

That earns him a groan and a roll of eyes. “One- that’s terrible. Two- how am I supposed to use this on my date when it’s about me?”

“Oh, you’re right, want to hear another one then?”

Mydei laughs under his breath, shaking his head. “I don’t want my ears to bleed more than they already do.”

“Too late. Do you have a name?”

“What?”

“Or can I call you ‘mine’?” Phainon finishes with a laugh, ignoring the way his ears burn as he thinks of Mydeimos and *‘his’* in the same sentence.

“This one is worse.” Mydei groans, but he seems to be just as affected, thanks to his tied hair Phainon can see the flush crawling up his neck.

The somewhat intimate moment lasts barely a second before Mydei coughs, composing himself.

“I should go now.” His roommate grabs his keys. “Thanks… for the pick-up line.”

He wants to stop Mydei from leaving, but his hands won't move. He wants to block the door, but his legs do the opposite and step away from the entrance. So, he watches silently as Mydei puts on his shoes and closes the door behind him. “Have fun,” he mumbles to the now-empty apartment.

Phainon stands there for a full minute, staring at the closed door like it might open again and Mydei would return, tell him it’s a joke and he has no date planned, that all of it is nothing but a prank, maybe something Cipher suggested as petty revenge for upsetting Mydei.

The door doesn’t open again. The sudden wave of anxiety makes him nauseous. Phainon barely manages to carry himself to the couch before his legs give out.

“Have fun,” he mutters under his breath, mocking himself. “Yeah. Great job, Phainon. Top-tier acting. Weren’t you good with words?”

“Now what?” He screams in his head.

“Now you accept that you’re too late and be there for him, like the bro you claimed you are all this time,” it feels like a punch to the gut. The word Bro feels like poison.

Staring at the ceiling, Phainon tries to calm down, his anxiety feels more and more like a panic attack with every passing minute: It’s hard to breathe, everything hurts, his vision blurs— he wants to cry, throw up, claw at his own chest for hurting so much. It takes him a few minutes and all of his willpower to count his breaths like Cyrene taught him when he was younger; In. Count to ten. Out. In again. One. Two. Three. Four…

He is in the middle of counting his third breath, or seventh, when realization hits him all at once; sharp and sudden, like a thunderstrike.

The fight.

The look on Mydei’s face when he mentioned going on a date. The sudden change of mood. The anger he couldn’t understand. The way the blonde sounded so hurt when he said, *‘You really don’t get it’*

Oh, God.

He gets it now.

He gets everything.

Phainon clutches a hand over his mouth, no longer able to hold his tears. “…You absolute idiot.”

Mydei liked him. And Phainon, in all his oblivious glory, had spent that night talking about girls and being stupidly in denial, refusing to see how every touch, every small act of kindness, the way Mydei always looked at him… Was not platonic. Mydei was testing the waters to see if the feeling was mutual.

And what had Phainon done? He laughed it off, sent mixed signals, called him *“bro”* and *“friend”* and shattered Mydei’s heart like it was nothing more than the glass the man dropped when they met for the first time.

Phainon sinks deeper into the couch, burying his face in his hands as sob after sob wrack through his body. “You’re a fool. An idiot. The worst man alive. You hurt him...”

He can’t even bring himself to be angry at Mydei for going on that date or acting distant in general. Why should he? Mydei deserves someone who sees him. Someone who doesn’t take three months and a nervous breakdown to realize they like him.

Yet, at the same time, the thought of his crush— as terrifying as it is to admit he has feelings for a guy, sitting across from someone else, letting someone who *is not Phainon* see his shy smiles and quiet charm, makes his stomach twist so violently he’s sure he is about to throw up for real.

Jealousy burns through his body, ugly and unfamiliar and scary.

Phainon stares at the empty wall in front of him, sight blurry from the tears still streaming down his face, trying to count breaths like it’s his last lifeline.

One. Two.

“You don’t get to be jealous,” he scolds himself.

Three. Four. Five.

“You had your chance.”

Six...

It doesn’t help.

He imagines the date going well. Imagines Mydei laughing or blushing, or holding the guy’s hand… He really hates the anonymous guy he decides then. Not that he has the right to.

“I hate my life,” Phainon mutters. The ceiling doesn’t argue, only mocks him with more silence.

He sits like that for a long while, waiting for his tears to dry and his breath to finally calm down. His mind, unhelpful as always, makes sure to replay every moment he ignored until now, every chance he had and screwed up—how Mydei started spending more and more time in the living room with him. How he always made sure to leave him breakfast even if he left early for his classes. How he leaned in that night on the couch, and Phainon was so deep inside his own head, too afraid of not meeting society’s expectations that he didn’t notice the meaning behind it.

It all seems so obvious now.

Like a film he had seen dozens of times; one where every hint was clear from the start, yet somehow he managed to miss all of them until the ending makes it obvious.

He’s so stupid.

The biggest idiot on the planet.

“’lethal face card’ my ass” he mutters through tears, “You were never platonic about him.”

Chapter End Notes

We're slowly getting there!!!

Chapter 7: I Don't Know if It's Gay But...

Chapter Summary

> Almost like on cue, and not because Phainon knows his roommate's routine by heart, Mydei walks into the kitchen as he finishes setting the plates, shirtless as always, and Phainon can not for the love of god stop the flush from spreading high on his cheeks— remembering how the man looked so inviting in his earlier fantasy.
>
> Mydei blinks at the table. Then at Phainon. Then back to the table.
>
> "…You cooked?"
>
> Phainon clears his throat, averting his eyes from Mydei's body. "Yeah."
>
> "You don't cook in the mornings."
>
> "I can if I want."
>
> Or; The roles have been reversed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It takes Phainon nearly thirty minutes to fully calm down. His headache borders on a migraine, and his eyes burn every time he blinks, but what he needs more than rest— is someone to knock sense into him, someone to call him out for the idiot he is and then, maybe, reassure him that not everything is lost.

There's only one person he can think to call, and that person is Cyrene. She'd tease him into the next life and back, sure, but if anyone can deal

with his chronic overthinking, it’s her.

She picks up after two attempts, “Phai? If you’re calling because you got dumped again, I swear to the gods—”

“Wow. Your faith in your little brother’s romantic life is still non-existent,” he laughs, dry and empty, lying down more comfortably on the couch.

“Please. You only call me for emotional support nowadays.”

“Wrong. I also call to hang out, but you’re always busy.”

Cyrene’s laughter bubbles through the speaker, light and warm and *calming*. “Alright, little disaster,” she giggles at the nickname she came up with. “What’s wrong this time? Work drama? Mid-life crisis before your thirties?”

Phainon sighs. “Something worse.”

“Oh?”

“I like someone.” He admits, barely registering that he's about to come out to his own sister, over a phone call.

Cyrene grows quiet on the other side of the line, long enough for him to regret calling. Then, as he predicted, she giggles again. “god help me, I didn’t think I’d live to see the day! You better invite me to the wedding~”

“Cyrene, don’t—”

“So, who is she?” She cuts him.

‘She’ of course. “That’s… the part you’re really going to laugh at.”

“Oh no. You didn’t fall for your boss, did you?”

“What? No!”

“A coworker?”

“No…”

“Neighbor?”

Phainon already knows what comes next. She will laugh first, then tell him he lost his mind and something is wrong with him, maybe both. “It’s…” He hesitates, already imagining Cyrene telling him she wants nothing to do with him anymore. A quiet sob escapes him at the thought.

“Phai, you know I won’t judge you” She reassures him, “Even if it’s ‘that creep from your workplace’ level of bad.” Her voice softens.

“Ew! Cyrene.” He gags a little at the mental Image, but it eases something in him. She won’t judge. Phainon blurts the confession before fear can take over him. “I like my roommate.”

There is silence over the line, followed by a dramatic gasp and laughter, but it’s not as mean as he expected, more surprised, delighted even. “Oh heavens!” she exclaims between chuckles. “You like a *guy*?”

“I knew you'd laugh.” He recoils at the way it sounds, bracing for her to call him disgusting, or hang up and never speak to him again.

“I’m not laughing at you,” Cyrene adds quickly, as if to make sure he doesn’t misunderstand her reaction. “I’m just… surprised. I know I'm a good prophet, but I never thought I would predict *that*.”

Phainon sighs, she was. Cyrene teased him about it when he took over Cipher’s lease. “Yeah, well, guess the universe decided to follow your little prophecy and I'm into men now.”

“I don’t see an issue here.” She comments, and it’s more reassuring than anything; she doesn’t think of him as a freak. A quiet, tired laugh escapes him as Phainon feels like a giant tock has been lifted off his chest.

“Can’t believe I thought you’d hate me for that.” He admits quietly.

“I like girls and it never bothered you, so why would it bother me if you like guys!” she huffs, scolding yet full of fondness. “Anyways, I can hear

from your voice it's not the romantic story it should be... What's wrong?”

Phainon rubs his thumb over the seam of his pants, distracting himself as he organizes his thoughts. “It’s… complicated. I became aware of these feelings barely an hour ago, and I'm still unsure if it's romantic or I don’t know what, everything is confusing tight now, and I’m probably too late anyway.”

“What do you mean by too late Phai?”

“It’s a long story.”

“Good. I like stories.” He can hear Cyrene’s smile through her words.

Phainon takes a deep breath and tells her everything.

He starts with the first time they met, how he found him extremely attractive, but didn’t think much of it, then their moving in together and his awkward, to say the least, reactions to Mydei. Then, to the night he overheard him, the catalyst that made him start questioning everything. He skips the Reddit posts though, those are a black stain on his digital footprint and he doesn’t wish to talk about those.

After a short pause where Cyrene asks a few questions, he keeps going. He tells her about the fight, about the date that made him realize spending time with Mydei was more enjoyable to him, followed by their make-up and today’s events. Minus the sexual fantasy. There’s only so much he’s willing to disclose to his sister.

There’s only so much he’s willing to disclose with his sister.

When he finishes talking, his throat feels as dry as his eyes, and Cyrene is quiet on the other side of the line, apart from a rustle and the sound of scribbling. Is she writing everything down?

“So let me get this straight,” she says finally, chuckling under her breath at the pun, “You just realized you like him, but it seems like he moved on after you two fought?”

“Yeah. Pretty much.”

“I still think you should give it a try, you're not too late.”

He blinks. “You don’t know him.”

“I don’t have to” she says. “I know you. And my oracle powers tell me this story should have a romantic ending.”

Phainon turns his head sideways, staring aimlessly at the turned-off TV. “I don’t know what I’m supposed to do now. It's not like I can walk to him and say ‘Hey, so turns out I have a crush on you, sorry it took me three months and a punch to the face to realize it?”

Cyrene laughs. “Please don’t say it like that! Try something less dramatic, you’re good with words.”

“Not when I’m around him apparently.” He sighs, “Besides, I’m not sure what I'm supposed to do… Even if I like him, being with a guy is not what society expects…”

“Who says you need to meet anyone’s expectations?” Phainon can hear her huff over the line. “Phai, the only one who can write your story - is you. No one else. Do what you want, be what you want, date whoever you want! And I’ll support you no matter what path you take.”

It feels like he’d been slapped. His throat tightens up at her words. Can he really? Is it really as easy as she makes it sound?

“Cyrene…”

“Enough.” She scolds him “You’ve always been selfless. Allow yourself this one selfish wish and take him out.”

He frowns. “On a date?”

“Yes, on a date, what else can it be?” Phainon knows she’s rolling her eyes at him. “Spend time together. Go somewhere, do something you both enjoy.

See how he acts, see how you feel about it.” Cyrene suggests “You don’t have to call it a date, call it, allow me to quote you ‘bros hanging out’”

“Fuck. That sounds so bad. I was a real idiot, wasn’t I?” Phainon hates it when she uses his words against him. Still, he imagines it for a second- the two of them going out, grabbing food or shopping together… The warmth that is spreading in his chest at the thought is all the confirmation he needs to know that his sister is right, perhaps he should listen to her and try acting on those feelings instead of running away.

“What if it feels weird and awkward and I don’t enjoy myself?”

“Then you’ll know it’s not meant to be, and maybe you two can still stay friends after that,” Cyrene says gently. “But if it feels right, you’ll know that for sure.”

“You make it sound easy.” Phainon rolls on his side, too many thoughts race in his head, but despite that, he’s surprisingly calm for once. He’s not sure if he wants to date Mydei, not yet at least, but he does like him, not platonically according to his recent realization, so a date disguised as hangout would be a good way to test things.

“It isn’t,” she clarifies. “But you barely finished telling me how close you two are: You cooked for each other and spent weekends gaming together… that kind of bond doesn’t vanish in a week.”

He smiles. Cyrene knows him too well. “You say that like you’ve been spying on us.”

“Call in a woman’s intuition,” she huffs proudly. “Besides, you sound different when you talk about him.”

Phainon pauses. Does he? “Different? How?” he asks, curious.

“Like you’ve finally found someone you don’t want to keep at an arm’s length.”

He opens his mouth to deflect, but nothing comes out, his heart picking up its rate as the words echo in his head, again and again. Perhaps she's right, *again*.

Cyrene fills the silence with her usual confidence. "Look, if you want my advice, and you called, so you obviously do— stop thinking about expectation or normalcy. Be selfish. Take him somewhere, spend a day with him and see what happens. Hopefully it'll help you see where you two stand and how you feel about each other."

Phainon stares at the faint reflection of the room in the darkened TV screen. He can see the shape of himself; tired, messy, uncertain. "You really think there's still a chance?"

"I think you know better than me about trying again and again until you win a boss fight, nerd."

He lets out a quiet laugh. "You're annoyingly wise sometimes."

"Comes with being the better sibling~"

Of course. He rolls his eyes. "Bold claim. Also very subjective."

"You misspelled accurate claim, little brother."

They fall into a comfortable silence for a moment, and Phainon can picture Cyrene smiling to herself, proud of her wisdom, and genuinely happy for him. He's truly blessed to have her as his sister.

"I'll do that, as long as he doesn't tell me he got a second date," he decides, thinking bitterly about the possibility of the date going well, tossing all the pep talk to the trash.

"Good. And if you end up dating him, you owe me an introduction and a dinner."

"You just want free food."

“Me? Never. I want to hear a successful love story. You know how much I love those!” She giggles.

“And, Phai?”

“Yeah?”

“Stop acting like you’re already too late. You still haven’t written the end of the story.” The call ends a moment later, leaving the apartment quiet again.

Phainon stares at the phone's screen until it turns off. He isn’t sure what he feels. Hope, dread, maybe both, but he feels somewhat lighter.

“Be selfish.”

“Alright, Cyrene,” he murmurs to the silent room. “I’ll try it your way. I’ll put all the stakes on a day spent together.”

He imagines it— Mydei’s laugh, his hand brushing Phainon’s when they reach for the same thing, the easy warmth that used to fill the space between them before everything got complicated. Perhaps a kiss too if things go well...

He shakes his head, blushing furiously.

Maybe it's too early to think about kissing.

Baby steps.

— ◇ —

The sound of the door opening wakes Phainon from his shallow nap on the couch.

He blinks at the darkness of the room and sits up, his neck reminding him that he is too old to be sleeping on the couch like that and his eyes burn— both from crying earlier and falling asleep with his contacts still in. It takes him another minute until his head stops pulsing in pain and he sees Mydei at the entrance: soaked to the bone, looking both tired and irritated at the same time.

“Hey,” Phainon says, sitting up and glancing at the clock. “You’re back early.”

“Yeah.” Mydei kicks off his equally soaked shoes and lets out a low, exhausted sigh. “Date wasn’t worth it.”

Phainon’s heart skips with a sudden surge of hope. “That bad?”

“Another guy who was after my body,” Mydei mutters. “Didn’t even pretend otherwise. Tried too hard to get in my pants.”

He sounds more exhausted than angry— like someone who is one bad date away from giving up. Phainon watches the blonde from the couch, caught between sympathy and a rush of relief.

“His loss,” he ends up saying. And as hypocritical as it may sound, it’s really the guy’s loss for not seeing how great Mydeimos is. The blonde hums something back, heading toward the hallway in what Phainon can assume is to shower, or at least get out of his soaked clothes.

Twenty or so minutes later Mydei re-appears in the living room, dressed in a pair of sweatpants and a towel hanging on his shoulders, hair still wet and messy.

“What about you?” He pads over to the kitchen, pouring himself a glass of juice and looks over at Phainon. “I’m surprised you’re still up. You looked tired earlier.”

“Couldn’t sleep.” Phainon hesitates, choosing his words carefully, praying Mydei won’t notice how red his eyes are from all the crying he did earlier.

“You’re good with words” he reminds himself, “So I figured I’d stay up and wait for you, call it a gut feeling.” Hand reaching to fiddle with his choker, a habit of his when he’s nervous.

That earns him a tired smile. “Didn’t peg you for the overprotective type.”

“Haha, I’m normally not—” he trails off, and Mydei’s goes back to the task of drinking his juice, accidentally letting a few drops trail down his chin, his throat, collarbones, down his chest... Phainon follows it with a predatory gaze, eyes darkening, until he feels a throb in his pants, and looks away shamefully.

Not the time to pop a boner.

Phainon takes a moment to compose himself, then clears his throat. “So…”

Mydei glances over with curiosity. “So?”

“You’re free this weekend?”

“Why?” Mydei narrows his eyes a little, suspicious.

Phainon shrugs, trying to sound nonchalant and casual. “Thought maybe we could hang out. Y’know, do something. Grab lunch, maybe check out the new arcade in the mall, I don’t know.”

One of Mydei’s brows arches higher. “Are you,” he pauses, “asking me out?”

Phainon nearly chokes. “What? No! God, no— I mean, yes! But not *like that.* Just, ugh…” he lets his shoulders sag in defeat. So much for being good with words. “I thought we could hang out, since we made up and all…” He trails off, flustered. The “*I miss your company*” left unsaid.

For a moment, Mydei looks at him, unreadable, as if studying Phainon’s flustered state. Amusement flickers in his eyes seconds later and he smirks at him. “Perhaps we should check a clothing store or two and fix that fashion sense of yours instead.”

Phainon groans. “There's nothing wrong with my fashion sense!”

Mydei sets his glass down, crossing his arms. “You were wearing red pants and a green sweater three days ago. What are you, a Christmas tree?”

“Fine, Mr. always dressing like a model.” He grumbles quietly.

“You think I look like a model?”

Phainon realizes that he, yet again, blurted his inner thoughts out. “I- yeah? You always dress nice.”

“Alright,” Mydei says after a beat of silence, smile warming. Phainon really likes it when he smiles. “Sure. We can hang out this weekend.”

“Really?”

“Yes.” Mydei pushes away from the counter. “But I pick your outfit.”

“Deal!” Phainon grins, the action making his still healing lip hurt a little.

“I work Saturday morning, but I'm free after that.” Mydei nods, disappearing down the hallway and into his room. Phainon leans back against the couch, feeling giddy all of a sudden. Mydei said yes. He said he will hang out with him this weekend.

“It’s a date, Mydeimos,” he smiles, before shaking his head furiously. It’s not a date. Just two friends spending time together, like Cyrene suggested, but the flutter in his chest says otherwise.



The rest of the week drags so slowly, Phainon thinks he’s going to lose it.

Tuesday starts the exact same way Monday did, no. Scratch that. It's different this time, the scenario playing in his dream isn't of a random woman. It's Mydei. He is hovering above Phainon, leaning in to seal their lips together in a heated kiss. One of his hands roams across Phainon's arms, then his chest, before dipping under the waistband of his pants.

Fuck, he can feel his cock throb through the haze of sleep, begging to be touched.

Phainon buries his face in his pillow. "You're so screwed" he whispers to no one.

"So, so screwed." His hand sneaks lower, wrapping around his length.

At least this time, the fantasy doesn't catch him by surprise. This time, he's willingly thinking about Mydei as he fucks into his fist, as he whimpers the man's name, as he imagines it's Mydei's mouth and not his own hand, sucking him as he cums with a guttural moan of "Mydeimos".

The post-orgasmic clarity hits him as hard as the fantasy did. Phainon rolls out of bed, way earlier than he should, muttering curses under his breath, shame boiling hot in his veins. He *absolutely did not* have another erotic dream, and he *definitely did not* rut into his palm while imagining Mydei's mouth on him.

And he is *most certainly not* cooking breakfast because he feels guilty for consciously fantasizing about his roommate-slash-crush like that.

Nope. He's here because… protein is important. Or something.

Phainon cooks two portions of sunny-side ups with the precision of a surgeon, focusing on the task so hard he cannot think of anything else—which is exactly what he's trying to achieve: It's too early for overthinking. He even chops a few cherry tomatoes and cucumbers, seasoning them with extra salt, the way Mydei likes it.

Totally normal roommate behavior.

Mydei did it for him for months.

Almost like on cue, and not because Phainon knows his roommate's routine by heart, Mydei walks into the kitchen as he finishes setting the plates, shirtless as always, and Phainon can not for the love of god stop the flush from spreading high on his cheeks, remembering how the man looked so inviting in his earlier fantasy.

Mydei blinks at the table. Then at Phainon. Then back to the table.

"…You cooked?"

Phainon clears his throat, averting his eyes from Mydei's body. "Yeah."

"You don't cook in the mornings."

"I can if I want."

Mydei keeps staring, clearly trying to solve the riddle of *'Why the hell is Phainon awake at six in the morning?'* for a long minute. Eventually, he gives up and pours himself a cup of coffee, sitting down at the table.

"Thanks," he says with a small smile.

That softness in Mydei's voice launches a meteor-sized ball of warmth into Phainon's chest and he immediately turns away, taking extra time to prep his own coffee to hide the grin spreading on his face.

"You act like a teenager with a crush." His mind chimes in, not helping at all.

Breakfast passes comfortably, feeling like there was never a strain between them. Mydei hums in delight as he slowly chews, while Phainon pretends not to notice and pretends even harder not to enjoy it. And when they're done, Mydei rinses his plate with another quiet 'thank you' and disappears back to his room.

Phainon can't hide the grin this time.

The rest of his day is less exciting. Meetings feel longer than usual: clients keep asking for absurd things, testing his patience one request at a time. He smiles through them because that's what he does best, the same way he smiles at Aglaea when she calls him into her office to remind him of a few approaching deadlines. The only distraction he allows himself is an occasional glance at the calendar— where he marked Saturday with a small heart like the love-sick fool he is.

He really needs the weekend to come already, really needs to see if they are as compatible as a couple as they are as roommates.

At lunch he looks for Tribios, wanting to apologize to her for acting off the day before. The young woman is sitting at one of the kitchenette tables, muttering curses in three languages as she taps something into her phone.

"Tribios!" he waves at her, way more cheerful than he should be on a Tuesday noon.

She looks away from the phone, eyeing him from his shoes to the top of his always-present cowlick, before a knowing smirk curls on her lips. "You look like someone who got laid."

He chokes. "I did not— What!?"

"Then congratulations, you've discovered religion." She takes a bite of her lunch, adding mid-chewing, "And if my guess is correct, that religion is blonde, tall and very attractive."

"You're…"

"Correct. Now, please share the details." He swears the redhead is too smug about it.

Still, Phainon talks. Tells her some details about his and Mydei's current standing, Cyrene's advice, and how he doesn't really know what to do, or how to show his roommate he likes him now without actually saying it, mostly because he's not entirely sure if they can be as good of a couple as

they are friends and he doesn’t want to ruin everything by blurting his feelings out if they aren’t mutual.

Tribios listens to the entire story-turned-ramble with the calm of someone watching a train wreck in slow motion.

When he finishes, she sighs, crumpling her sandwich bag with extra effort. “Who would’ve thought that the smart and charismatic Snowy is such a disaster? Never would’ve guessed you’re capable of struggling with words.”

“I do, when it comes to him.” He admits, surprisingly relaxed instead of the usual nervousness he felt every time someone called him out on his feelings for Mydei until now. Maybe some of Cyrene’s pep talk is finally taking root in him.

“Glad we're on the same page.” She flicks his forehead teasingly. “But let me get one thing straight first: there is nothing wrong with liking a guy.”

He laughs. “My sister said the same.”

“Well,” Tribios says, standing up and filling her tumbler with fresh water. “Now I know where the wits in your family went.”

“Wow,” Phainon gasps playfully. “Rude.”

“I don’t know, sounds like your sister would agree with me” she sing-songs, then takes a deep breath, expression turning serious as she sits back next to him. “Look, Snowy, if you spend the rest of your life performing Straight-and-Responsible acts for an audience that isn’t even watching, you’ll wake up at fifty with nothing but regret. Take the guy on a date. Drag him into a fitting room and make out, or whatever other scandalous thing runs in your head. The world won’t end.”

Phainon is glad he finished eating because he’d choke for real this time. “I never thought of things like this!”

“And I like Lygus.” The redhead makes a disgusted face. “It’s not easy, and it makes sense to be scared. But regret is heavier than awkwardness.” She pinches his cheek like he’s twelve. “Besides, that day he came to drop your lunch was the happiest I’ve seen you in a while. That’s not roommate energy. That’s ‘I want to wake up to your stupid face for the next sixty years’ energy.”

“Shut up.” he grumbles, ready to comment back, only to feel a shiver crawling up his spine; sensing someone standing behind him.

“Ah… the tender aroma of romance,” the person interrupts their conversation, and judging by the tone... “I could hear your whispered confessions from across the corridor, Phainon. Matters of the heart call to me like wounded birds seeking a seasoned hunter.”

Phainon glares at Tribios, mouthing, *‘You jinxed it’* before turning to the man with a forced smile.

Lygus leans closer— far too close— eyes glittering with predatory enthusiasm. “If you ever require guidance… I have tasted many flavors of love. Bittersweet. Forbidden. Physical.” He winks at Tribios.

She recoils visibly.

“That’s… very generous of you, Lygus. But I’m good.” Phainon tries not to gag as he says the man’s name, which is quite a challenge when he opens his mouth again with a sigh that sounds borderline inappropriate. Maybe he should contact HR about it, or get a restraining order.

“Oh… but love is my expertise!” Lygus exclaims dramatically, gazing at the ceiling as though expecting a revelation, or an orgasm, both options sound repulsive when related to the man.

“Right,” Phainon smiles politely, already stepping away from the table with Tribios in tow. “Looks like my break is over, there’s still so much to do...” He gestures vaguely in the direction of his department, retreating not subtly at all.

The last thing Phainon needs is dating advice from *this* guy.

— ◇ —

To his disappointment, Mydei is not there when he returns home from work, and for a second it almost feels like a nasty flashback from the past weekend. Too quiet, too much, too consuming.

“He’s at work or has a class. He didn’t leave.” Phainon reassures himself, shaking his head and turning all the lights on in what feels like an attempt to make the apartment feel less lonely.

It doesn’t help.

He orders take-out because cooking for one feels like too much effort, nor does he know if Mydei would want to eat when he comes home. Using the time until his food arrives, Phainon takes a quick shower and switches his contacts to glasses, completely ignoring the questioning look the delivery guy gives him when he opens the door with his usual *“disastrous color combos”* as Mydei calls it.

“He doesn’t understand the importance of wearing your favorite colors.” Phainon huffs, crossing his arms over his chest.

“—sir?” Only to realize he’s still standing in the doorway, with one confused delivery guy in front of him. “I’m sorry!” Phainon flashes them a smile, giving an extra tip as apology, not letting his embarrassment show until the door is closed.

“I need to stop thinking about Mydei all the time,” he sulks, and keeps sulking as he eats his dinner. An hour later, he is still sulking as he plays through his daily gaming routine, same when he packs the leftovers into his lunchbox for tomorrow…

He really needs to stop thinking about Mydei. Not that it's possible. Not after he realized he likes the blonde in a way that is more than friendly, not when every little interaction between them makes him think 'Do I want this?' and 'Is there still a chance?'

Phainon feels the need to do something to gauge Mydei's feelings better, so by Saturday— when they go on their not-date-date, he could focus on figuring out if things feel right or wrong.

That's why, another hour later, when Mydei is still not home, not that he looks at the entrance door every five minutes, definitely not, Phainon is typing furiously into his phone, because the only idea he can come up with is writing Mydei a letter that can be perceived as a confession, and what is he? A Victorian maiden in the 1940's?

r/relationship_advice

How do you let your roommate know you like him *without* asking him out?

u/33550336

Okay, so… this is either a love story or a full-speed car crash, there is no in between.

I (M27) recently realized I have feelings for my roommate (25M). We've been living together for a little over three months now, and at first I didn't think it was anything, but the more time passed… well… I basically realized a day ago that those feelings are not platonic at all.

For example: Im staring at him, a lot. Daydream, dream, the other kind of dream... You get the point. I really like him.

Here's where I'm stuck though: I'm not asking *how to ask him out*. I know that's the obvious answer and I am aware that "just talk to him" exists but I've never really been into guys before, so I'm still figuring out what this actually *means* for me. I know I care about him. And

> want to be around him. It also bothers me more than it should when he goes on dates. I just don't know if that automatically means "I want to date him" or if I need time to let my brain catch up with my feelings.
>
> Anyway. What I'm asking is... Is there a way to make it known I like him in a subtle way? I thought about writing a letter, but that's not subtle at all.
>
> Please help before I start making flowcharts! I suck at those btw.

He closes the app, opens it, and refreshes it two or three times. One comment.

> **u/MasterDiviner**
>
> You're overthinking this. If you don't know yet whether you want to date him, that's fine. You're allowed to explore "I like you" before committing to "I want a relationship." Attraction isn't a legally binding contract.

Reassuring, but not helpful.

Maybe he should wait a little longer, play something in the meantime.

Phainon wakes up at god-knows-what hour, or around two in the morning if he squints hard enough at the clock. He didn't mean to fall asleep like that, nor does he remember when he fell asleep exactly. One moment he was waiting for one of his games to update and the next ... It's the middle of the night and something soft is tucked around him. He brings it closer to his face, squinting in the darkness— Mydei's favorite blanket. The one he curls into on the couch when they watch TV and gatekeeps in his room.

His glasses are resting on the coffee table. There is a glass of water next to it and a small note saying *"your back will hate you tomorrow, old man."*

It takes him a moment to wake up enough to realize the meaning of it.

Mydei did it for him. Mydei came home from work, saw him passed out on the couch, covered him with his favorite blanket, took his glasses off so he

wouldn’t bend them in his sleep and left a little note behind.

Phainon pulls the blanket closer, burying his face into it. It smells like Mydei’s body wash and a slight trace of musk, which somehow makes it even more soothing. He reaches to adjust his glasses on his face out of instinct, only to remember they are folded on top of the coffee table—

Wait a second.

Mydei touched his face, he had to in order to take off the glasses. His cheeks flush, heart skipping a beat.

He thinks he just fell a little harder for the man.



The next afternoon, he stops by the grocery store on his way home, noticing they were running low on eggs after cooking breakfast for the second day in a row, making Mydei smile more earnestly this time. His plan is simple; grab eggs, pay, go home. Especially since He did a proper grocery run a few days ago.

Yet, his shopping basket stares back at him, suspiciously full of things that are *not* eggs: The protein chips Mydei likes, the spicy sauce the blonde uses on everything and swears it’s not spicy enough, and a bar of his favorite strawberry chocolate.

Phainon blinks at his basket as he waits in line. Oh right. He almost forgot the eggs.

By the time he returns to the register the basket also contains rice crackers, the weirdly expensive pomegranate juice Mydei pretends isn’t his favorite, and a small tub of low-calorie ice cream that he personally thinks tastes like cardboard. Not that he ever tried eating cardboard.

He pays for everything quickly, smiling at the cashier like the purchase is completely intentional and his mind didn’t practically auto-piloted his arm toward the shelves to grab all his roommate’s favorites. The receipt glares at him as he packs everything— he just spent as much as he spends on a week's worth of groceries, impulsively.

Mydei is home when he returns, baking something in the kitchen, humming quietly while kneading dough. He hears the door unlock and glances over his shoulder, golden eyes landing on the large collection of bags in Phainon’s hands.

“Didn’t you say we only needed eggs this morning?” Mydei asks, wiping his hands on the pink apron around his waist, inked arms rippling under his shirt, not that he is staring. Maybe a little.

“How many bags are those?”

“Uh.” Phainon glances down, suddenly aware of the mountain-sized evidence of his subconscious shopping spree. “A few.”

Mydei grabs one of the bags from his hand— carefully, barely letting their fingers touch— and looks inside with surprise at first, then with a small, fond smile. The rest of the bags are pried from his hands a second later with the same fleeting contact that sends pleasant sparks up his arm, before Mydei looks back at him, confusion written over his face instead of the smile from moments ago. “Phainon, why did you get all these?”

“It was on sale,” Phainon says with the grace of a brick thrown through a window, knowing he’s fooling no one.

The blonde gives him an unimpressed look, one that says I-can-see-through-your-bullshit. “Nothing in these bags ever goes on sale, Phainon.”

Smiling in what he hopes can pass as nonchalant, Phainon instinctively reaches for his choker, fiddling with the leather to stop his fingers from buzzing with the remnant of Mydei’s touch. “Fine. You’re right, I was already there. Figured I’d grab some stuff while I was there.”

“You grabbed half the store,” The blonde points out, but not unkindly, more like he’s still trying to figure out what’s the reason behind it. “You didn’t need to get all this. Really.”

“It’s fine, we were running low on some of these anyway,” he waves his hand in dismissal, opting to act more confident than he feels, leaning his hip against the clean part of the counter, standing so close to his roommate he can smell his cologne, the same one he remembers from the day before. He wants to lean in, bury his face in Mydei’s neck, and inhale it directly from his skin.

“We weren’t running low on anything in here. You don’t eat most of these anyway.” Mydei’s claim snaps him back from his little fantasy to the sight of the blonde holding up the chocolate bar, as if presenting Exhibit A.

“Maybe I wanted some?”

“You hate strawberries.”

Touche. He does. He’s pretty sure Mydeimos is the only target audience for this fruit-flavored chocolate. Mydei observes him for another second before placing the chocolate down. “How much do I owe you?”

The question catches Phainon off guard, hurting him. It feels like Mydei is refusing his kindness and he doesn’t like it. He feels rejected. Forcing his signature smile back even though his throat burns and eyes threaten to water, he waves his hand again in dismissal. “You don’t owe me anything.”

“This is a lot.” Mydei insists quietly, avoiding his eyes now, “Just tell me.”

“You don’t need to pay me back,” Phainon repeats, more defensive. “I wanted to get it.”

“Why?”

A simple question. But not simple at all coming from *him*.

Phainon swallows, suddenly unsure why he did that to begin with.

Is it because he likes Mydei?

Is it because he wants to see him smile?

Is it because he can’t stop thinking about him?

Come to think of it, he never went out of his way to get his roommate any of the things he liked, it was always Mydei who got him his snacks whenever he stopped by the store…

“Isn’t that normal? You do the same for me all the time.” He chooses to say, because it’s true, but mostly because he doesn’t really know why he did it to begin with.

Mydei looks at him with an unreadable expression, ears turning red like he’s embarrassed to speak the reason. “That’s different.”

“How?”

“Because I...” The blonde drifts off and turns his attention back to the dough, grumbling, “Just tell me how much it is.” Phainon can see how tense his posture is; how mechanical his movements are.

“Mydei,” He calls the man’s name gently enough that it barely counts as a sound, as if Mydei is some wild animal he doesn’t want to startle. “Take it as a kind gesture.”

He can see hesitation in the blonde’s normally sharp eyes when he turns his head to look at him, like he doesn’t want to accept Phainon’s kindness, like he’s scared of being hurt again— and Phainon can’t even blame him for it. Still, he’s determined. He wants to show him that he *does* care, that he knows how Mydei felt, and he feels the same now.

“Look. I wanted to do something nice for you. That’s all.”

He hopes it’s clear enough.

Mydei’s gaze flickers up, searching his face as if waiting for the catch. Finding none. “…Alright,” he murmurs, returning to the pastry he’s baking.

“Thank you.”

It’s not the reaction he expected, but it’s better than complete rejection.

He probably should check Reddit later, see if there are any helpful comments there by now.

— ◇ —

They end up watching TV later that evening, Phainon is there because well… He’s mostly in the living room in his free time; trying to maintain the unhealthy balance of a full-time job and four different gacha games that demand his attention of the daily, and Mydei joins him at some point, grabbing the remote directly from his lap and warns him, with a smirk that means he’s feeling like a menace, that he has two minutes to wrap up the game or he’s going to close it down by force.

Phainon huffs for a second, but turns off the console, opening the same game on his phone instead. He knows not to interfere with Mydei’s precious routine, and Kitchen Strife isn’t that bad of a reality show either. Plus, he gets to spend some time with Mydei.

Win-Win. If he ignores the ten minutes of dialogue he probably has to go through again, or the way his ears are burning from the brief touch against his thigh when the blonde grabbed the remote.

Mydei drops onto his usual corner of the couch, away from Phainon. His apron is now gone, replaced with the same pink fluffy blanket he wraps himself in like an oversized burrito, not offering to share it this time.

For a while, they watch the new episode in relative quiet, exchanging comments and little laughs here and there. It feels almost like before. Like they used to be, like he wants them to be again.

“There’s no way it’s going to reduce on time,” Mydei groans as the camera zooms on a pan of sauce that looks more like a bad attempt at making soup if anyone asked for Phainon’s opinion. “The judges won’t like it.”

Phainon glances at him, amused. “You really can’t help yourself, can you?”

“It’s hard to watch someone ruin food like this,” Mydei mutters, suddenly sounding self-conscious, then adds grudgingly like he’s trying really hard to find something good to point out in the disastrous-looking dish, “The garnish is nice though.”

“High praise coming from the great Mydeimos.”

Mydei snorts. “Hmph. I give compliments when they’re earned.”

“Are you?” Phainon leans back, smirking. “Then what do I have to do to earn a compliment or two?”

“Start by not over seasoning the eggs,” Mydei side-eyes him, but an equally matching smirk is already curling on his lips. “And add the ham thirty-seconds later than you did today.”

Feigning hurt, Phainon clutches at his chest dramatically. “I’m never cooking breakfast again!”

Mydei laughs, bright and carefree, and Phainon missed the sound of it so dearly. He can already feel his heart beat a little faster, warm and happy.

“You’re in a good mood tonight” the blonde points out, still smiling, still looking at him rather than at his precious cooking show, gaze full of affection.

“Am I?” Phainon asks, unable to suppress the giddiness of his tone. All he wants to do is to lean in, rest his head on Mydei’s shoulder and whisper ‘I like you’, but he stops himself before that happens. He really doesn’t want to ruin everything by blurting his feelings out like that. Not until he knows they’re mutual and Mydei hasn’t moved on.

“Mhm.” The blonde’s eyes sweep over him with a lazy, assessing sort of interest. “You talk a lot more when you’re relaxed.”

“Hard not to be relaxed around your favorite person,” Phainon answers like it’s obvious before his mind catches what he said and his brain screeches to a halt. Wait. Favorite person? He didn’t mean to say it like that. It just… slipped.

Mydei stills, color blooming high on his cheekbones before he turns back toward the TV without saying anything.

He should stop talking. He really should. But his mouth, traitor that it is, keeps going.

“I mean, you’re easy to be around. Easier than you probably realize.” Phainon really can’t stop blurting his inner thoughts, can he?

Mydei's fingers curl tight into the blanket, like he is holding himself back as he repeats quietly, “Easy to be around?” He whispers, too intimate, too vulnerable.

“Yeah.” Phainon hears how soft his own voice has gone; how emotional he sounds. He leans in, just a little, aiming to bury his face in Mydei’s shoulder in that familiar, harmless way they did before and murmur that he should stop teasing him.

But the moment Phainon shifts closer—

Mydei leans backward, like a cat that curls away from a hand to avoid being touched.

Phainon freezes, whatever words he was about to say dying on his tongue, giving place to pain. It hurts so much his throat tightens. Mydei used to lean in. He used to let their shoulders touch, used to rest his head against him, and even put his legs on Phainon’s lap once.

Now all that’s left between them is distance.

Has Mydei moved on?

The silence stretches, thick and awkward. Mydei's gaze stays fixed on the TV, but Phainon can see how stiff he is, how much he's holding back. From what? He's not entirely sure.

"Say something, you fool."

Mydei beats him to it, sounding guarded, careful, full of emotions Phainon can't name as he tries to hold onto nonchalance but fails. "…Are you flirting with me?"

The world blanks. Absolutely blanks.

He was. Fuck. He was flirting, and he didn't realize it. Phainon can't think of anything clever to say back, not when his brain is busy combusting with the force of a dying star.

"I… would it upset you if I say yes?"

Here goes nothing.

The blonde's eyes widen, golden orbs staring deep into his own cerulean ones for a small eternity. "You shouldn't say things you don't mean." he whispers, and faces the TV screen again as if nothing happened. Mydei doesn't say anything after that. But he also doesn't leave the room, nor laughs it off, and unless the lighting is playing tricks on him, he's pretty sure he can see Mydei's ears burning red.

"Is it a good sign? A bad sign?" his heart demands answers his brain cannot provide, because he doesn't know. He doesn't- fucking- know. How is he supposed to know when he's getting mixed signals like this!?

Mixed signals again…

A bitter laugh leaves him, one that Mydei doesn't entertain or comment on.

Right… He's been feeding Mydei these exact crumbs for months. And now Mydei is handing the plate back.

Karma tastes terrible.

If this is what those mixed signals felt like from the other side… he’s amazed he got away with just a punch and wasn’t murdered.

He really can’t wait until Saturday; he needs to confirm his feelings and start acting before he loses it completely.

Chapter End Notes

This guy's heart is yearning so much... You can do it Phainon!

Chapter 8: ...I Want Him.

Chapter Summary

Hyacine looks up at him with an unimpressed look.
“I don’t know what goes inside your head, nor do I want to know. But Mydei told me everything, from his side at least. So please,” she smiles at him in a way that feels more threatening than reassuring, “Get your shit together.”

Phainon’s heart skips a beat, wanting so bad to ask her what exactly Mydei told her, needing to know how his crush feels about him.

“I…” he tries, searching for words, any words. What is he even supposed to say? That he did but he’s still unsure? That he’s still a little scared of actually trying to act on those feelings?

“You don’t need to give me answers. Mydei is the one deserving them.” Hyacine pats his arm once, light and reassuring and slips past him back to the living room.

He almost burns the pasta.

Or; Phainon finally gets his shit together.

Chapter Notes

Enjoy the early update~

Thursday yields the same result.

Phainon is about to insert the keys into the apartment door, tired from a long day of work and over-analyzing Mydei’s mixed signals, when the door swings open, followed by a soft-yet-sturdy chest bumping into his.

His first instinct is to look down, to the conspicuous pectorals pressed against his own, only to catch himself in time, right as his eyes drift lower

and look upwards instead. Which proves to be as dangerous of a sight, because Mydeimos looks devastatingly good with his hair tied in a low ponytail; so good that Phainon has to stop himself from staring at him, ignoring the way his mouth dries up at the sight of his exposed nape.

What is he? Some pervert?

Well. *Not the point*.

“Are you going somewhere?” Phainon asks, more high-pitched than intended, the earlier tiredness gone completely at the mouthwatering sight of the blonde, replaced by a restless energy he knows he’ll need to burn one way or another. If Mydei is about to leave and the house would be empty maybe he could…

Phainon shakes his head. He’s *not* a pervert.

Mydei pulls one earbud out, eyebrow raised. “Yes, gym.”

“I see.” Gym. The gym is a great way to burn through the restless energy.

“Mind waiting for me? Haven’t accompanied you in ages.” He tries to make the excuse sound more like a proper reason and not just him wanting to spend more time together, or avoid being left alone at home with his lizard brain.

Blinking at him in confusion, Mydei nods once, a teasing lilt on his tongue. “Sure. Think you’re in shape to keep up?”

Excuse him? That brat. He can outlift Mydeimos any day. Hell, he’s pretty sure he can even lift the man himself if he tried. Phainon’s arms were always the part of his body he’s most proud of.

“Is that a challenge?” He calls over his back, already rushing inside to grab the first shirt and sweatpants he sees, shoving them into a duffel bag together with a clean towel and his sneakers. Phainon is out of the house in record speed, pleased with the impressed whistle Mydei gives when he appears next to him not even five minutes later.

Much to his surprise, the gym is quite empty except for a few people who look like they live there rather than come to work out. Mydei changes quickly next to him, and Phainon tries not to stare too much, but fails, because the man brought the same cursed shorts he hoped to never see again, outside his more private fantasies at least.

“You’re going to stare or change?” Mydei’s deep voice pulls him out of his trance. Caught red handed, Phainon stammers something that he hopes is coherent enough and turns away to fumble with his button-up shirt, hoping the redness on his ears isn’t as bright as it feels.

They start with basic stretches first, then separating their ways temporarily as Mydei moves through the rest of his warm-up and Phainon opts to burn off some of the energy on a treadmill. Which takes him exactly five minutes to start regretting, because Mydei’s reflection is right there in front of him, doing squats with perfect form, ass looking criminally good in those stupid shorts. Phainon speeds up the treadmill to the point of sprinting and almost flies off of it when he dares to glimpse at his roommate through the glass reflection again.

“Get it together, Phainon.”

They take turns spotting each other once the blonde finishes with warmup, and Phainon can feel his heart back in his chest instead of his throat. He spots Mydei with determined focus as he goes through his first set, stares at the man’s chest rather than spotting him properly during the second, and completely loses count on his reps at the third set because Mydei grunts on an upward pull and— *fuck*— Phainon’s brain dives south immediately.

It should not sound as pornographic as it did.

“Not subtle, man, not subtle at all.” Phainon slaps himself mentally, willing his mind to get out of the gutter. That’s not how one burns energy. It takes him a solid minute to calm down, to act unaffected, and he hopes he counted Mydei’s reps properly when he tugs the bar back in place, signaling it’s time for them to switch.

“Thank you,” Mydei nods, sitting up and wiping the sweat from his forehead and Phainon takes his eyes away from him, ready to go grab lighter weights for himself, when his gaze lands on a guy across from them and it makes something hot and ugly flare in his chest. The guy is scrawny like a stick, absolutely out of Mydei’s league, yet he ogles his roommate like he’s a fine piece of meat, paying zero attention to whatever he’s doing on that treadmill.

Jealousy boils through Phainon’s veins within seconds.

He clears his throat louder than necessary to gather the man’s attention and lies down on the bench without changing the weights, knowing it’s way more than he can normally lift. He smiles at the guy, all teeth and full of venom, as if to show the scrawny man how superior he is, and how Mydei’s attention is on him only.

It takes three reps for Phainon to feel it, grunting loudly as he pushes through the first set, his arms turning into jelly with every rep until Mydei has to grab the bar and place it back right as he’s about to finish the first set.

“What’s gotten into you?”

“Just proving you I can keep up,” Phainon lies through his grin, eyes still locked on the guy as if saying, *“Scram off.”*

The blonde’s eyes follow his line of sight to the stranger, who blushes and looks away, then back to Phainon, an amused smirk on his lips. “Is that how you assert dominance?”

“Maybe.” Phainon blushes too and lets Mydei adjust the weights before he lies back down. He grips the bar again, trying not to think about his crush standing over him— thighs almost bracketing his head, hands hovering close; ready to grab if he fails, chest looking even bigger from this angle…

He does fail. On purpose. Just to feel Mydei’s fingers brush his as he takes the weight from his grip. Mydei lifts it smoothly back onto the rack and steps away like nothing happened. No lingering touch. No smile. Just a teasing remark of, “Rest your arms now, showoff.”

Those damn mixed signals again.

They go through the rest of the workout like that, teasing each other, competing through the exercises, and it's the closest to normal they have been, and the happiest Phainon felt in a while, to the point of barely noticing they spent over an hour at the gym. At least until his arms start protesting even at body-weight exercises.

Mydei seems to notice his struggles, observant as ever, and although Phainon protests that he can keep going, the blonde offers to switch to a quick ab workout and call it a day. He never agreed to anything faster.

Lying down on the mat, Mydei asks him to kneel at his head and hold his shoulders down so he could do leg raises. Phainon follows the order, only to realize how dangerous it is; Mydei's head is nestled between his thick thighs, too close to more… reactive parts of him.

Tearing his eyes away and looking anywhere but his roommate, Phainon notices a group of guys in the corner, clearly staring at Mydei's ass every time the man lifts his hips from the mat, drooling like starved hyenas at what's *his*.

"How dare they!?"

Phainon shakes his head furiously to prevent the flush from returning to his cheeks.

What is he thinking? Mydei isn't his, not yet at least, maybe if Saturday feels… Right. Still, the idea of others staring indecently at the man he likes annoys him in a way he cannot ignore, and he deliberately changes positions, blocking the '*view*' from the group of strangers.

He can hear one of the guys 'tsk' loud enough for him to hear. Success.

"Phainon?"

"This is a better angle." Phainon smiles, reaching for Mydei's hips, as if to prove a point and pins him to the ground with surprising ease, swearing he

can hear the blonde yelp for a second.

“You’re right, for once,” Mydei grunts at him, clearly feeling the added challenge when he tries to lift his legs up. Phainon side eyes the strangers once more for good measure, returning to his task of being the sole person ogling his roommate—

No. He meant holding him down so the exercise is extra effective.

He’s not ogling anyone.

Or so Phainon lies to himself, fully aware of how compromising their position looks.

A few leg raises later, Mydei tells him he’s done and sits up, grumbling something about feeling it in his abs tomorrow.

“Pass me my water?” he asks, and Phainon complies, handing him the metallic bottle, breath hitching when their hands brush by accident; pinky sliding against the blonde’s knuckles. Mydei pulls away immediately, like the contact burns, sending the bottle to land on the floor with a loud thud.

Phainon’s chest aches. It continues aching when Mydeimos apologizes quietly, nor does it stop when he forces a smile that feels carved out of glass and says, “Shall we go home?”

“Are you sure? You haven’t done your part yet.” The blonde looks at him with a confused head tilt.

“Yeah, don’t want to overdo it.”

They change in silence, and Phainon doesn’t dare looking at his crush this time. The walk back to their apartment is even worse, the quiet between them allowing Phainon’s head run faster than his legs did on the treadmill. He wants to say something. Anything. *Sorry, I was an idiot. I miss our casual touches. I think about you all the damn time and I need to know it’s mutual.*

Instead, all that comes out is, “Still good for Saturday, right?”

“Yes.” Mydei glances at him, expression softening, like he can see that Phainon is upset about his earlier withdrawal, always perceptive of him. “And by the way, there is no need for you to show off like that. I know you’re strong.”

Phainon’s ears burn. He wasn’t showing off, was he? He was just… Hating how others were staring at Mydei and lifted more than he should, putting more effort than usual—

Shit. He was totally showing off.

— ◇ —

Friday feels like he’s watching the most boring movie, in slow motion.

He spends the entire day at work literally vibrating in his chair, restarting the same proposal for the thousandth time because numbers stopped making sense three hours ago. Tribios wishes him good luck on his date during lunch, right before they have to make a tactical escape, seeing Lygus walking in the direction of the kitchenette.

The rest of the day is just as ineffective. He only looks like he's working but accomplishes absolutely nothing.

Sighing for the umpteenth time, Phainon opens the apartment door, hoping to spend the evening bickering with Mydei now that their friendship has returned to somewhat normal, minus the mixed signals… But that will be over in a day, or so he hopes.

His plans to relax with the blonde by his side disappear the second he looks into the living room and sees an unfamiliar pink-haired woman. She’s tiny, her pink hair is tied into high ponytails, and she is wearing a cutesy dress that looks too big on her petite form. The girl is sitting on the couch next to Mydei, closer than Phainon had been allowed in the past week, with a bowl

of fruit being the only thing to physically separate them, if he ignores the mountain of papers each of them has on their laps.

What bothers Phainon about the whole situation is not the proximity— well, that too— but the fact that Mydei is laughing. Actually laughing, head tipped back and shoulders shaking at whatever joke the girl just told him. Phainon's stomach drops straight through the floor. He doesn't know this girl. He's never seen her before. And Mydei looks so happy around her.

The idea that someone else is out there making his Mydei laugh…

"He's not yours. Stop it." He scolds himself for thinking that *again*. Mydei isn't his. He can't get jealous over anyone who is remotely close to the man. Yet, he really can't help himself. The idea of Mydei moving on, liking someone else, makes jealousy course through his veins.

Phainon must've taken his shoes off too loudly, because the girl notices him first. Big green eyes look up, curious, then squint at him, to Mydei, then back at him.

"Oh," she says, smiling sweetly at him. "You must be Phainon."

Mydei looks over at her words, his laughter fading into something smaller, almost shy. "Hey."

Phainon's mouth is as dry as the desert. "Hi. Didn't expect to see you here." *"Smooth."* His mind mocks him.

"I live here too, you know."

"Not going to officially introduce me to your infamous cr—" The pink-haired girl interrupts, "I mean, roommate?"

Mydei hits her shoulder gently, whispering something Phainon cannot hear. "This is Hyacine. We're in Advanced Medical Terminology together. She's here for a project we're both doing."

Hyacine waves, a tiny wiggle of fingers. "It's nice to meet the person this guy talks about all the time." She punches Mydei back, with a lot more

force than he would expect from someone as small as her.

Phainon can feel himself relax visibly. She's a friend, not a threat. Then his mind catches up to what she said.

"He talks about me?"

"Can't shut up about his roommate for five minutes." Hyacine deadpans.

Phainon feels his cheeks heat up. Mydei groans and hides his face in one hand.

"Hyacine—"

"What? It's accurate." She pops a grape into her mouth. "Also, he claims you're very bad at picking outfits, but…" Hyacine turns to look at Mydei "…You forgive him because he's good looking, was it?"

Mydei kicks her foot, hissing at her. "Stop embarrassing him."

"I'm not embarrassing him, I'm embarrassing you." She teases, but it's fond. Clearly, Mydei and her are close, and it would've been cute to continue watching the two bicker if his brain wasn't actively screaming *"he thinks you're good looking. He thinks you're good looking. He thinks you're good looking."* Like a broken record.

For the rest of the evening, Phainon sticks to his own bedroom, not wanting to interrupt the two with their studies, and it works for a good hour or so; until his stomach starts demanding attention in the form of food. Perhaps he can redeem himself by cooking a dinner for everyone. He knows it'll make Mydei happy, at the very least.

But first, he changes his favorite orange sweater to a gray one so it doesn't clash with his bright, green pants. He wants to prove to Mydei's friend he's not the fashion disaster the blonde claims.

Popping his head into the living room, Phainon announces happily that he'll be making dinner for everyone, and Hyacine should stay over for longer. He doesn't take two steps toward the kitchen until he can hear Hyacine

whispering something hushes that sounds like “…glasses huh, knew it.” Followed by Mydei’s hushed groan.

Phainon adjusts his glasses instinctively, in case they got crooked on his nose. Maybe he can ask her later what they were talking about.

Focusing on cooking instead of trying to eavesdrop for more details, he barely notices when the short woman appearing right next to him, tapping on his shoulder for attention and glaring at him, hands on her hips; like a mother about to scold a kid for misbehaving. “Phainon, right? Get your shit together, okay?”

Phainon almost drops the entire pot of pasta over himself.

Hyacine looks up at him with an unimpressed look. “I don’t know what goes inside your head, nor do I want to know. But Mydei told me everything, from his side at least. So please,” she smiles at him in a way that feels more threatening than reassuring, “Get your shit together.”

Phainon’s heart skips a beat, wanting so bad to ask her what exactly Mydei told her, needing to know how his crush feels about him.

“That boy,” The pink-haired girl continues before he has the chance to ask, “is the sweetest idiot on this planet, and he’s trying so hard to move on since you’re not interested. So unless you had an epiphany of sorts, stop giving him false hope. And if you’re interested in him all of a sudden? Do something about it.”

The pot boils over, but Phainon barely registers that; he can’t speak.

“I…” he tries, searching for words, any words. What is he even supposed to say? That he did but he’s still unsure? That he’s still a little scared of actually trying to act on those feelings?

“You don’t need to give me answers. Mydei is the one deserving them.” Hyacine pats his arm once, light and reassuring and slips past him back to the living room.

He almost burns the pasta.

◇

It is later that night, when he’s in bed and trying to mentally relax, that Phainon remembers he never checked the Reddit post from days ago. Opening the app reluctantly, he’s surprised to see a few comments there, although nothing as big as his first ‘Am I The Asshole’ post.

u/ZeroPoints

Statistically speaking, the best way to show someone affection is complimenting them, followed by gift giving and physical contact. Watch for his reaction when you do any of these.

u/actualtherapist123

Spend time with him and notice how you feel: relaxed? Anxious? Excited? Your heart usually knows before your brain does.

u/ SleepDeprivedSince95

OMG there’s new development???

Anyway, my man… Compliment him and not about his appearance but about *him*. “I feel really comfortable with you” for example is a good way to hint that you like their company. See how he reacts from there. Oh and honesty goes a long way!!

u/April8th

Pay attention to how *he* acts around you. Does he prioritize time with you? Get a little weird when you mention dates? Sit too close? It might not be as one sided as you think.

u/relationshipgremlin

> Compliments that aren’t “bro-coded,” making effort to spend time together, small gifts. If he’s receptive, he’ll mirror it. If he’s not, you’ll feel the boundary. That’s your gentle test.

Phainon reads the message one by one, reality slowly sinking in. He has already done all of these in the past week.

Small gifts? Mydei rejected the gesture at first.

Compliments? That got him nowhere. Mydei’s response was too mixed to determine anything.

Spending time? He only learned he’s a jealous man out of it.

Looking at the past week in retrospect, it almost feels like his attempts were not clear enough. Mostly because he didn’t realize he was doing any of these things until Mydei called him out.

Hyacine’s words from earlier echoing in his head, “*If you’re interested in him all of a sudden? Do something about it.*”

It dawns on him. What he was really missing is actively doing something.

“I didn’t lack effort. I lacked courage,” he whispers in realization. There was no true intention behind his shows of affection, hence why Mydei gave him all these mixed signals.

Perhaps he can try courage tomorrow. Otherwise, he would never get a clear answer.

— ◇ —

The next morning, Phainon feels as nervous as a chimera before a vet visit. Today is the day he will get his 'shit together' as the pink-haired girl scolded

him yesterday and figure out both how Mydei feels about him, and how he feels about the whole idea of dating a man.

True to his word, the blonde knocks on his room door a little past noon, proceeding to rummage through his closet after giving a disapproving look at his current attire. If you ask Phainon, there is nothing wrong with the bright green pajamas his sister gifted him years ago, nor with the pink cardigan Castorice knitted him for Christmas last year.

Mydei just doesn't understand it's about the meaning behind the clothes and not the color combinations, he huffs to himself while the blonde tosses a "*better*" attire on his bed.

"Get dressed, I'm going to change as well," Mydei calls behind him, and he does, eyeing the clothes skeptically.

Done changing, Phainon looks at himself in the mirror, and Wow. Ok. Perhaps he can forgive Mydeimos this time. He looks amazing.

The sweater is clearly not his, based on how tight it feels around his shoulders and a little too baggy around the chest area, but it looks nice… Really nice. The black turtleneck matches perfectly with the white slacks he didn't know he owned.

"Are you ready?" his roommate's voice startles him, not even ten minutes later, and Phainon turns around to look at the source of the voice, brain halting to a stop. His immediate thought is *"don't stare"*, followed by *"too late for that,"* because God help him, Mydei is beyond stunning.

It's more casual than the clothes he wore to his date on Monday, but somehow seeing the blonde in a matching black sweater, a pair of black jeans, and a deep red cardigan makes him want to snap a picture and send it to the first fashion magazine he could think of. *It's that beautiful.*

"You're stunning." Phainon compliments, his bright blue eyes full of sincerity and intent.

Mydei’s own golden eyes widen, followed by a rich flush on his cheekbones, and Phainon pats himself on the shoulder, enjoying the much more positive reaction he had gotten.

“You don’t look half bad yourself.” The blonde coughs, “Now let’s go, I'm starving.”

Still a bit mixed, but he’s getting there. He thinks.

Phainon follows him, out of the apartment, down to his car, the directions Mydei gives him, until they are standing in front of a small restaurant. The interior looks cozy, a little run down, but the second they enter, it’s clear why Mydei likes it so much: the place is simple, like him. No fancy decoration, no cluttered menu with fifty-or-so items, simple.

They sit across from each other in a small booth, chat about nothing in particular as they browse the menus, and Phainon tries to read what’s on it and focus, but he can’t— not when Mydei is looking so effortlessly beautiful. More so with the late autumn sunlight illuminating his face. He laughs under his breath at the memory of his first thought about the man, thinking Mydei was as beautiful as a sculpture in a museum, one that it’s impossible not to stare at in awe.

He really was an oblivious idiot since day one.

“What’s so funny?” his roommate’s voice brings him back to the present.

“Nothing much, was thinking how much of a fool I am,” Phainon admits, opting for honesty instead of his usual smiles. He had done enough damage by running away from his emotions, nor would he achieve anything if he keeps running away from them.

“Glad we can agree on something.” If Mydei’s smirk wasn’t so pretty, Phainon would’ve felt offended that his crush is thinking he’s a fool. So much for his good image…

“Rude, but I’ll pretend I heard nothing,” he huffs, exaggerated, setting the menu down. “Since you know the place, any recommendations?”

“Everything is delicious,” Mydei answers. “I used to come here a lot with Castorice, back when Cipher worked in this area. She likes their lasagna.” He smiles fondly at the memory.

Phainon nods, pretending he didn’t already know how his two best friends met. However, he would’ve never guessed that the ‘grumpy guy who staged an accident to introduce Castorice to Cipher’ was none other than Mydei.

“Hmm, I’ll trust you; you have never wronged me with food before.”

“Flattery won’t get you far,” Mydei murmurs quietly, scowling and looking away, and Phainon’s heart sinks. It’s subtle, but it’s there, the same restraint he felt this past week, the way Mydei is holding himself back. It shouldn’t mean anything; his crush might not see it as anything more than two guys hanging out, yet Phainon can’t help but think of the worst- that he’s too late.

Convincing himself that it’s too early to determine anything and their totally-not-a-date has just begun, Phainon opts for safer topics first while they wait for their food to arrive: His work, Mydei’s classes and part time job, the message he got from Cipher this morning about how she downed six donuts in one go last night and had been regretting it ever since. The conversation flows easily, Mydei engages and bites back at his teasing, slowly acting less weary and restrained the more they keep talking.

They eat in a comfortable quiet once the food arrives, exchanging only a few comments between bites, and split the bill, since it’s not a date, of course.

Phainon doesn’t dare to push again, not wanting to make his crush take a step, or twenty, back if he tries another move so soon. But the determination is there, and consistency is the key. Flattery may get him nowhere, but surely getting Mydei a gift or two would work.

“So how about we hit the arcade next?” He offers once they are back in the car.

Mydei gives him a look, half suspicious, half curious. “You were serious about that?”

“Absolutely. Unless you’re afraid I’ll destroy you in every game.”

“That’s a bold statement from someone who keeps losing every time he pulls for a new character.”

“Hey!” Phainon protests with a dramatic huff. “RNG has nothing to do with skills! Besides, you’re the one who keeps dying every time you play against me!”

“Consoles and claw machines are nothing alike.” Mydei shoots back, and that makes Phainon laugh out loud. That’s more like it, laughing with Mydei feels good. *Too* good. God, he likes him so much.

Between focusing on the road and bickering about who is going to get higher scores at each game, the ride passes faster than Phainon expects, and sooner than later, he is already parking the car by the mall. They keep bickering as they load the game cards with more credits than necessary, challenging each other in every game the arcade has to offer.

He loses in basketball tossing, wins in a shooting PvP, and loses twice more in a dancing game— surprised at how well Mydei keeps up with the rhythm and totally not staring at the blonde’s ass. He swears he wasn’t!

Wandering deeper into the arcade, they finally reach the main attraction- the claw machines. Mydei stops in front of a small one, holding chimera keychains in various colors and crouches in front of it, studying the available designs with that same quiet focus he uses for everything: patient, calculating, observing.

“Going to win one?” Phainon teases, shoving his hands into his pockets.

“Two.” Mydei swipes the game card, and the machine’s lights pulses awake. “Like I said, I'm confident in my skills with those.”

Phainon grins. “Ha! I bet it’s going to take you all your credits to get the first one.”

“And it would still be less than what you spend on your precious game characters.”

“You don’t understand meta…” The words die in his throat when Mydei grips the little joystick, tilting it carefully to aim the claw. Long slender fingers guide the stick with such sensual grace, thumb pressing the button on top of the joystick to lower the claw. There is nothing suggestive about it, nothing that should make his mind rush down to his gutter, yet it still does.

His breath catches. The image that comes moments later leaves him completely breathless, and very much aroused: that same hand, Mydei’s hand, wrapped around his cock, gliding with the same precision as he thumbs at the leaking tip.

Fuck.

Phainon stares, deep in a trance, mind continuing to conjure the same image again and again. Mydei. Pumping his length, teasing him, making him come with just his hands… His mouth feels dry, skin too clammy under all the layers he’s wearing. Heavens, he can feel how hot his face is, and how quickly his cock fills up from the mental image alone.

“Damn,” Mydei mutters next to him, already swiping the game card again, and it takes all of Phainon’s willpower to look away from his hands and *anywhere* that it is not Mydeimos.

“Hahaha... You almost had it.” He forces a laugh that sounds strangled even to his own ears. He shouldn’t look when he hears the machine whirl back to life. He knows he shouldn’t. But his eyes drift back anyway, to the line of Mydei’s wrist, the movement of his fingers as he adjusts the lever again…

He needs to breathe. He needs to get away. Before Mydei catches him.

“Be right back!” Phainon blurts, voice pitching a little too high to pass as normal. “Bathroom.”

Mydei glances over his shoulder, frowning as the claw misses again. “Didn’t you—”

He bolts before Mydei can finish the question.

Stumbling into the nearest bathroom, Phainon leans against the furthest sink, chest rising and falling in shallow breaths, lungs desperately trying to get sufficient amounts of air. His heart beats in his ears, he can feel his pulse in his throat, and a rather familiar throb in his lower half.

Fuck. What is *wrong* with him?

He closes his eyes.

Counts to five.

It doesn’t help.

Mydei’s hands are the only thing he can think about— the curve of his wrist, the way his fingers wrapped so delicately around the joystick, the way his thumb rested on the button on top… Who the hell designed those control sticks to look this phallic!? Phainon mentally slaps himself.

“It’s only you. You shameless pervert.”

Phainon grips the edges of the sink until his knuckles hurt and he’s afraid the ceramic will crack under his death grip. He isn’t a hormone-driven teenager. He’s supposed to be composed, charming, confident... Not standing in a public bathroom, struggling to think straight, “*fuck you, brain,*” because his roommate’s fingers *looked too good on a joystick.*

“Get it together,” he mutters under his breath. His voice sounds too strained to be normal, and his pants are still obviously tented. Did Mydei really have to choose a pair of white slacks for him? Yeah. Back to blaming all his struggles on Mydei he goes.

It’s Mydei’s fault for being so handsome, his fault for doing everything so sensually, his fault for having long, slender fingers—

“Stop it.”

Splashing cold water over his heated face, Phainon can slowly feel his mind clearing. The temperature shocks him back into himself, at least enough to relax somewhat. His peace is short-lived unfortunately, as shame follows the moment he can think clearly again.

What would Mydei think if he knew? If he saw the way Phainon had looked at him just now? If he saw how his body reacted… He stands there for a couple more minutes, until his physical reaction is no longer noticeable and his face returns to a normal shade.

By the time he returns, Mydei is standing at the same place he left the man, two matching chimera keychains in his hand. The blonde grins at him triumphantly when he approaches, handing him the gray and blue chimera while keeping the orange one to himself. *Cute.*

This time, when their hands brush together, much to his surprise, Mydei doesn’t pull away, allowing Phainon’s knuckles to brush his for a long moment and leave him more confused than ever.

Does it mean Mydei is no longer trying to hide the mutual attraction? Hope surges in his chest, spreading warmth throughout his body.

“You really got two!” Phainon exclaims instead of dwelling on his thought for too long. He shouldn’t be getting too happy yet, not when he still hadn’t gotten an answer about his own emotions.

He’s having fun, sure, but does it mean he wants more than this?

Mydei hums, turning the little orange chimera between his fingers. “Told you I would.” There’s pride in his tone and something about seeing his crush so happy like that makes Phainon’s chest tighten further. He doesn’t deserve to look at Mydeimos like this, not after the indecent fantasies he had minutes ago. Yet he can’t stop.

His crush is too pretty for his own good. Even more when he is happy and proud of himself.

Golden orbs meet his, and Mydei's head tilts in confusion. *Even cuter*. “Is everything alright?”

“Yeah,” Phainon says quickly, tucking the keychain into his pocket before his trembling hands give him away. “Let’s check the bigger claw machines?”

They check them one by one, making idle commentary about the various stuffed animals inside, when they stop in front of a claw machine full of brightly colored fruit plushies, and Phainon stops. Among them is a silly-looking pomegranate with the silliest face he has ever seen. One that screams ‘no thoughts, head empty’.

“That one—” Phainon points at the toy, nudging Mydei with his elbow, teasing him. “—looks like you.”

Mydei gives him a flat look, “You think everything pomegranate has something to do with me. It looks more like you.”

He feigns offense. “That’s slander!” then opts for flirting “Or is it because I’m cute?”

“No, you look fruity and speak like you have no brain.” Mydei’s lips curve into a smirk that looks like he’s about to become an absolute menace.

“What is that supposed to mean!?” Phainon exclaims defensively, stepping closer to the machine to examine the toy further. “You know what, since you think it looks so much like me, I'm going to win it. And give it to you!”

“I already have you around the house. Two Phainons would be too much.”

“You’ll thank me later when you have an emotional support red Phainon to keep you company during cold nights.”

Mydei folds his arms over his chest, clearly expecting him to fail. Which, to be fair, is statistically likely to happen with his current Gacha losing streak and still somewhat unfocused mind, but Phainon’s stubbornness is one to

never be doubted. Eight tries and one card recharge later, he somehow manages to win the plushie.

Phainon lifts it triumphantly. “Behold!” He declares, chest puffed with pride, and hands it to Mydei. “Meet your new best friend!”

The blonde blinks at him, whistles in surprise, and before Phainon can say anything else, the smugness returns to his handsome face. “See you around Phainon. I’m to spend some quality time with my new friend here.”

“This is not what I meant! Mydei!” Phainon whines, dramatically, when Mydei turns around as if to walk away with the toy and leave him behind, already declaring the stuffed Pomegranate his No.1 enemy in his head. Stupid fruit and its stupid face.

“Jealous already?” Mydei teases. He squeezes the toy experimentally, then pulls it a little closer against his chest. The blonde then leans his face into the toy and looks away, as if suddenly feeling shy at his own tenderness, which melts Phainon’s heart. *“God, he’s adorable,”* he thinks, until Mydei hugs the Pomegranate tighter with a matching-colored flush on his face, *“and that stupid thing gets to be hugged by him first!"* Oh, this plushie is absolutely his enemy now.

“Thanks. I like it.”

“Does it mean he likes me? Does it mean he likes me?” Phainon’s brain goes into overdrive, but he somehow manages to keep his calm on the outside. He shrugs casually despite the flutter he feels in his heart. “Anytime.”

They spend another hour at the arcade. Competing, laughing, trash-talking each other's skills in a way only two close friends could, and when they finally exhaust themselves— wallets included— the sun is slowly beginning to descend in the skies. Mydei carries the Pomegranate plushie with him, hugging it like it’s something precious, raising an eyebrow when he catches Phainon staring. “What?”

“Nothing,” Phainon says quickly, unlocking the car. “Never thought I’d see a grown man hugging a toy in public.” “Shut up.” Mydei rolls his eyes, but he’s smiling when he slides into the passenger seat, toy on his lap.

He isn’t jealous. Totally not jealous. Not of a stuffed fruit.

Phainon forces his eyes on the road instead with a pout. He still doesn’t want the day to end, still unsure if he should make a move. His feelings are as clear as a day – he likes Mydeimos. He established that, but the answer to *“do I still want more”* has not been fully answered yet. The fear of not meeting society’s expectations is still there in the back of his head.

“Mind if we stop for a stroll? I don’t…” Phainon starts saying as they are nearing a park, it’s full of people despite the cold weather, and he hopes the coolness will help him clear his mind further. “…I don’t want to go home yet.”

“Sure.” Mydei nods.

Leaving the car, and the stupid stuffed toy Mydei names *Phainon #2* just to mess with him during the ride, they walk around the park, enjoying the last rays of the sun. Walking next to the blonde feels relaxing, yet it does nothing to clear his head. Instead, all Phainon can think about is how the couples around them are holding hands, and how badly he wants to do the same.

“Fuck it” feeling brave enough, he grabs at Mydei’s hand under the excuse of “my hands are cold,” expecting hesitation, a raised eyebrow, or the same withdrawal he had been receiving from Mydei since they fought.

None of that happens.

With a quiet hum, Mydei’s fingers lace with his like it’s the most natural thing in the world.

Phainon almost trips over nothing at all.

Taking a deep breath to steady himself, he looks around, waiting for someone to stop and clear their throat or look at them with disgust, maybe point an accusing finger, calling him a ‘freak’. But all Phainon sees are people not caring about it. A family walks down the path, laughing about something. A jogger runs past them without a second glance. An elderly lady smiles at him from one of the benches. The world keeps moving, unbothered by the fact that Phainon is no longer the prime example of society's expectations.

He can feel the blonde’s thumb tracing patterns on his knuckles, as if he knows what goes inside Phainon’s mind and tries to soothe his worries away.

Phainon risks a glance at the man next to him. Mydei’s gaze is fixed forward, looking as calm as ever if not for the small redness around his tattooed cheek. From the cold? From the hand holding? Who knows. What Phainon cares about is the lack of tension in his crush’s grip. If anything, Mydei adjusts his hold, fingers settling more comfortably between his, like their hands belong together and the awkward distance, the mixed signals, and the carefully set boundaries the man had established in the past week have disappeared completely.

And it feels right. Alarmingly so.

He remembers Cyrene’s words from their phone call, *“If it feels right, you’ll know that for sure.”* Perhaps… perhaps this is what his sister meant. Phainon lets himself think about it further, if he wants this, if he wants *more than this*— or at least he tries to, until his little moment of peace is interrupted.

“Wow! You’re prettier than mama!” A little girl runs to them, a bag of breadcrumbs in her tiny hands, which she points at Phainon with “and you’re so lucky, mister!” she exclaims with honesty saved for kids, and Phainon would be damned if his face doesn’t light up on fire from the little girl’s words.

She thinks they are together. A couple. They look like a couple.

It slaps him directly on his face. Not only does nobody around them seem to care, but even the little girl doesn't seem to be bothered by the fact he's holding hands with a guy. Instead, she sees it as something normal, sees them as a couple...

"Are you here to feed the duckies too?" the little girl asks them, eyes wide with excitement. Mydei lets go of his hand, much to Phainon's disappointment, and crouches in front of the girl. He gives her a fond smile and extends his palm, immediately receiving a few pieces of bread which he tosses into the water, laughing with her as a fat pigeon snatches them away before the ducks have a chance to.

Phainon looks at them, mesmerized, and something in the way Mydei looks, the way the last rays of sun reflect over his handsome features, makes everything fall in place— like a puzzle piece he tried so hard to fit the wrong way, only to slide in perfectly once rotated.

He doesn't just *like* Mydei. He loves him. He *wants* him. Wants to be with him. Not just today, but every day.

He wants to wake up every morning with the blonde beside him, look at his sleeping face, poke his cheek and wake him with kisses— Phainon bets Mydei would pout and blush if he catches him. He wants to hold Mydei when he cooks, and have him do the same when they cuddle on the couch. He wants to go on a thousand more dates, wants to laugh with him until their stomachs hurt, drag him to cons, teach him how to play on his console properly, he wants, he wants…

God. He wants so many things his head spins. And there is one person he wants to experience it all with— Mydeimos.

Phainon feels overwhelmed for a second, but his mind has never been clearer before. He doesn't just love Mydei. He's in love. Been in love with him for months now. And he doesn't want to have it any other way.

When the blonde notices he has grown quiet and turns to look at him, catching him staring, Phainon smiles at him— bright and full of emotion, joining the two on their mission to feed all the ducks in the pond.

They part from the girl once the breadcrumbs run out and her parents come to get her, apologizing for disturbing their date, to which both men look away and stammer a *“it’s not a date”* in perfect sync, laughing afterward. Phainon can’t stop thinking about how right it feels. How easy.

He was such an idiot for denying himself this for so long.

“Thank you,” Mydei says once they are back home. The blonde turns to him and buries his face into the crook of Phainon’s neck, and Phainon almost malfunctions once he feels Mydei’s arms sneak around his waist in a hug that is too intimate to be considered friendly or *‘bro like’*.

“F-for what?”

“For today,” Mydei responds, moving away to look at him with fondness Phainon hasn’t seen since that night they sort-of-cuddled on the couch. “I enjoyed it. A lot. I liked spending time with you.”

“Me too.” Phainon’s throat feels tight. He almost blurts it out, "*I like you, I want this, I want you.”* When Mydei is still looking at him with so much tenderness. But instead, he just says, “Can’t wait until next time!”

“Next time?” Mydei tilts his head, but the smile is there, small and sincere, like the last remains of his walls are crumbling and he finally allows himself to reflect Phainon’s emotions.

“Obviously. Today was so much fun! We have to do it again.”

“Sure thing. I’ll prep us dinner?” He chuckles softly, leaving Phainon, and walks down the hallway to his bedroom. To change clothes, Phainon assumes.

“Sounds like a plan. I’ll make a salad to go with it.” He shouts back. And just like that, he is left standing alone in the quiet living room, heart still racing.

“Not a date,” he mutters to himself with the dreamiest smile ever. *“Yeah. Sure.”*

He wants Mydei. Not as a roommate, not as a friend, not as some confused curiosity.

He wants *all* of him.

Chapter 9: So, Is It Really Gay To Kiss Your Homie Goodnight?

Chapter Summary

Phainon sips on his beer, praying for that liquid courage to kick in so he's less embarrassed about the whole ordeal of oversharing his, hopefully not one-sided, love life with the girls. "Fine. So, I like Mydei, in a romantic way."

Cipher blinks theatrically. "Shocking. Could've sworn you two are married already."

Castorice sighs, rolling her eyes, acting like he told her the sky is blue and not a revelation he barely came to realize a week ago. "Thank you, Captain Obvious."

"What do you two mean by that?" He's almost offended at their flat reaction.

"And? Did you confess?" Cipher interrupts his thought process.

"No," Phainon lets his shoulders sag, fixing his glasses higher on his nose, "I tried a few times, but none of the moments were right."

Or; Confessions are harder that Phainon had thought, or are they?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He was supposed to erase hope from his dictionary.

He was supposed to move on.

At least that’s what he told himself when he hit the same man he had developed feelings for, repeating the words again as he apologized, accepting that they would never be more than friends, and again when a random guy approached him at the gym, asking him out. He agreed despite not really wanting to, only because it’s a necessary step in order to move on.

Yet it seemed like the universe, or a certain white-haired man, were very much against the idea of him moving on.

“Are you free this Saturday?”

The question catches Mydei off guard. Is… Is Phainon asking him out? There is no way, right?

Despite himself, he agrees. It’s a simple hangout, nothing more than two friends enjoying the day together. Mydei does not let himself hope again, nor allows himself to think about any possible meanings behind the sudden invitation.

Hope is dangerous. Hope is how you misread things and end up breaking your own heart, and he already did that to himself once.

But no matter how hard he tries convincing himself, Mydei cannot stop the traitorous *‘what if it’s a date’* thought that pops in his mind from time to time, especially when Phainon suddenly starts cooking him breakfast, or returns home with his favorite snacks, or suddenly seeks physical touch like he himself used to do...

Even Hyacine, who had already given him a mouthful about ‘not communicating’ had given him a confused look after spending the day at his place and finally meeting Phainon, claiming that the man looks at Mydei like he had hung the stars in the skies, muttering about how *‘I’ll need therapy if they don’t talk about their feelings soon.’*

He can’t buy her therapy, but he makes a mental note to get her a spa day, a nice dinner, or something similar sometime soon. The pink-haired girl deserves that much for listening to his troubles over the past weeks.

Still, Hyacine's words plant the seed of hope in his heart anew, and Mydei finds himself thinking *"Is there a chance?"* Yearning hopefully for a scenario where his roommate had a change of heart, realized his feelings, something… Anything…

Mydei knows he shouldn't, that exact same hope landed him in this mess to begin with, and he's supposed to move on, not dwell on something that is not meant to be. But after yet another lonely night where none of his toys manage to satisfy the craving inside him to be loved and leaving him more vulnerable than ever, Mydei allows himself one last moment of weakness.

He decides to match Phainon's energy this outing, and if it hurts later, that's fine. He survived far worse than unrequited love.

Then Saturday comes, and Mydei can barely focus at work. He ends up messing three orders one after the other and takes his break earlier than intended, trying to convince himself he should focus, and they aren't going on a date later.

Only for his 'not date' to stare at him with his jaw on the floor once he returns home— figuratively, of course— and mumble how stunning Mydei looks, sending traitorous warmth to his face and spiking his heart-rate.

Don't read into it.

Don't hope.

Unfortunately for him, it's hard not to when everything feels like a date, when Phainon reaches for his palm mid-conversation and keeps complimenting him and even offers to pay the entire bill. Mydei refuses it, just like he should've refused the arcade visit, the word 'no' sitting ready on his tongue. He's ready to call back on his decision from the prior night and hide in the comfort of his room, where the words *'I like you'* don't threaten to spill out of his lips.

And then Phainon has to open his mouth, of course he does.

"Unless you're afraid I'll destroy you in every game."

Mydei finds himself saying ‘That’s a bold statement’ instead of calling it a day, the competitive streak inside him ignited immediately, unable to refuse a good challenge.

It proves to be more fun than he expected. They bicker like they used to, competing over every multiplayer game out there, and somewhere between catching Phainon staring at his ass—looking in complete daze as Mydei sways his hips to the rhythm of the dancing game—and laughing over accidentally shooting a basketball into the wrong station, his meticulously built walls slowly start to crumble.

He wants more than simple friendship with Phainon, he wants days like this to last forever, to lean in and share private smiles between them, to get closer, to hug and kiss and—

“I like him too much to move on,” Mydei realizes bitterly as he watches Phainon smile brightly at him, flashing him a peace sign, carefree and triumphant over beating him at a racing game.

“Let’s check the claw machines?” He offers quickly, dismissing the thought away, stooping only once one of the smaller machines catches his eye. Chimeras, the same one from the game Phainon had taught him how to play months ago, the same one he kept failing until this day, falling off every possible platform in seconds.

“Going to win one?” Phainon asks, a teasing lilt on his tongue like it’s another challenge.

“Two,” Mydei replies automatically. “I told you I’m good at these.”

Claw machine strategies are predictable, something he can understand, unlike the way his chest keeps tightening every time Phainon laughs earnestly or leans too close, like his heart keeps forgetting there is a line he has been trying very hard not to cross, no matter how badly he wants to ignore that damn line right now.

“Stop thinking about it,” he concentrates instead, calculating the angles needed to successfully grab them as he swipes the gaming card, fingers

closing on the small joystick.

Mydei is so focused on getting the little keychains, too used to tuning everything else out when he wants something that he doesn't notice Phainon go quiet. Doesn't notice the hungry, predatory look the white-haired man gives him.

Until Phainon laughs, loud and high-pitched, and Mydei pushes the button too soon by accident, turning to look at the blue-eyed man, right on time to see Phainon look away, cheeks flushed and posture stiff and well, his posture is not the only stiff thing there…

Before Mydei gets to say anything, his companion blurts something about needing to go to the bathroom despite using it minutes ago, and disappears.

Looking back at the machine, Mydei's eyebrows furrow, fighting the sudden urge to follow Phainon, tell him he saw *that*, and offer to help with the not-so-little problem.

Thankfully Mydei is better at restraint than his roommate and doesn't act on said urge, willing his own surge of desire down, whispering a fond "Pervert," under his breath and swipes the game card again, determined more than ever to get two keychains; one for himself, and a matching one for the snow-haired man who is not discreet at all about his attraction.

At least he knows, once again, that the physical attraction is still there, even if he has absolutely no idea what triggered it.

When the white-haired man finally returns from his impromptu bathroom trip, looking like he ran a marathon, Mydei doesn't comment on it. Instead, he extends his hand with a triumphant smile, handing the gray chimera to Phainon, allowing their fingers to brush without pulling away this time.

Phainon's eyes light up, bright and genuine, the redness of his cheeks deepens the longer neither of them pulls away, and Mydei can feel the remains of his walls crumble in real time— the earlier reaction might've been physical, but this? Those lingering touches and soft smiles tell him it's more than simple attraction.

Or so Mydei allows himself to hope, just for a little.

“Everything alright?” he asks, watching Phainon’s reaction carefully.

“Yeah,” the man answers too quickly, holding the keychain close to his chest like it’s something precious before putting it away in his pocket. “Let’s check the bigger machines?”

Mydei hums in agreement, telling himself not to dwell on the dismissive answer as Phainon’s actions show something completely different and maybe something did change in the past week and the white-haired man is slowly realizing his feelings.

Despite his attempts to focus, Mydei’s attention keeps circling back to the way Phainon didn’t flinch at the contact, nor brushed it off. The same way his hands linger again when he passes him the pomegranate plushie he won, after god knows how many attempts.

Something warm coils in Mydei’s chest, and he hugs the stuffed fruit closer without thinking, before he realizes what he’s doing and looks away, cheeks burning.

“Thanks,” he says quietly. “I like it.”

He wants to add “I like *you*,” but holds back, in case he’s misreading everything again.

Mydei doesn’t pay much attention for the rest of their arcade escapade, nor the ride home, or the impromptu stop at the park, mind too occupied with Phainon and what he should make out of this day.

He’s pretty sure something is different now as his roommate never reached out to him before; it was always Mydei reaching out and Phainon accepting, or withdrawing. Yet, at the same time, it’s hard to tell just by a few lingering touches from Phainon’s hand, the same hand that is holding his—

Wait a minute.

“My hands are freezing,” the snow-haired man says lightly, but the redness on his cheeks betrays him as he squeezes Mydei’s palm a little tighter.

Mydei freezes at first. His first instinct is to pull away and gauge the situation better, but Phainon’s hand is warm, *“that liar, his hands aren't freezing”*, and feels so right, *“I don’t want to let go”*, and he wants to keep holding it forever. So he matches the energy once again, lacing their fingers together as he tries to calm down his racing heart. It’s more than a friendly act and he *knows* it.

Guys don’t hold hands. Not like this, not in public, not when one of them is supposedly straight. The realization settles deep inside Mydei’s chest, heavy and terrifying and bright all at once.

He really shouldn’t hope.

But he still does, more desperate than ever.

And it’s the same hope that guides him to hug his roommate once they’re home, thanking him for the day, smiling as Phainon stiffens for half a second- then melts into the hug, arms wrapping around his waist with softness that makes Mydei’s throat tighten.

Offering to make dinner, Mydei escapes to his room to collect himself before he ends up saying something he shouldn’t. It’s too soon to jump to conclusions, Phainon could withdraw the next day, but the damage is done either way: all the careful walls he had built since the fight are now gone.

“And you thought you could move on.” He laughs at himself. Yeah, there’s no way he can stop liking Phainon even if it’s one sided.

◇

Something changes after that day. Mydei is not stupid, he can see how Phainon acts more like a lover and less like a friend with each passing day:

warmer, closer, more affectionate, like he once dared to hope. He knows their feelings are most likely mutual by now and they are dancing around each other the same way he watched Cipher dance around Castorice for months, knowing the lavender-haired girl was waiting for her to act but never making the first move.

It's not that he doesn't want to; he really does. But he also promised himself, back when he realized his feelings were one sided, that he'd take only what he's given and never try to take more than that. So if Phainon is content with what they have, so is he. He'll patiently wait until his roommate chooses to take their relationship to the next step.

And if he wishes, in the dark of the night, as he moans a muffled *'Phainon'* into the pillow, that the said man would make a move already— can anyone blame him for it?

✧

"I like someone." Mydei confesses on a Wednesday afternoon, sitting at a small café with his mother who insisted on *"seeing her baby after so long."*

Gorgo puts her mug down in silence, bright honey eyes widening in surprise before crinkling at the corners with unmistakable delight.

"Oh?" Her smile is a knowing one, the same smile she used when he was little and tried hiding sweets behind his back. "My little honeycake has a crush? Finally?"

"Mom, stop calling me honeycake," Mydei grumbles, rubbing a hand over his face, cheeks already burning at the old nickname that stopped being cute and became embarrassing the older he got.

"What? A mother can't be excited?" Gorgo laughs, reaching across the small table to hold his hand warmly. "Look at you, all flushed. It must be

serious if you're reacting like this. Tell me everything. Is he handsome? Does he cook? Please tell me he cooks—"

"Stop it." He huffs, both amused and mortified at once. "He… yeah. He's a nerd with no fashion sense and a gaming addiction, but he's really handsome and the sweetest guy I've met and" Mydei catches himself, biting the inside of his cheek, "and he is my roommate."

"The one Cipher dumped on you?" Gorgo's brows shoot up in surprise. She gives his hand one more reassuring squeeze. "So my quiet, too-careful-for-his-own-good son is pining after his straight roommate. Oh Mydeimos…"

"Don't." Mydei stops her, refusing the pity, then sighs. "I don't know if he's really as straight as he claimed. That's the problem."

Gorgo's expression turns into motherly gentleness immediately. She moves her chair to sit closer to her son, rubbing his shoulder. "Hey. Tell me what's going on."

Mydei stares at her face for a moment, searching for the right words. "It's complicated. We got close at first and I thought he liked me, but then he became distant and started sending mixed signals. It ended… Badly." He leaves the ending vague on purpose, not wanting to worry his mother. "We are friends now, we made up- and it seems like he's actually interested, but he won't make a move. Maybe I'm reading everything wrong again."

Gorgo hums thoughtfully, tilting her head. "Sounds like someone who likes you, but is scared of his own feelings."

"That's what Hyacine said," Mydei mutters.

"Well, that little girl is quite smart." His mother smiles. "But listen to your mother, who's been married to the most stubborn man in Kremnos for thirty years." Gorgo leans in as if telling a secret. "Wait for him to make the first real move. Guys like him love to feel in control. Let him come to you when he's ready and match his energy until then, show him you're interested but nothing beyond."

Mydei snorts. “That’s terrible advice. I might be waiting for years at this rate.”

“It’s excellent advice,” she corrects cheerfully. “A lingering touch here and there, and once your father made up his mind, he chased me for ten days straight. I kept refusing all those attempts at first, until I saw he was serious and came over to his place one night—” “I don’t want to know!” Mydei cuts her off, flustered. There are details about his parents he’d rather stay blissfully unaware of.

“Right, anyway. My little honeycake. What’s important is that once he does make that move? Don’t hold back. Grab him by the hair and kiss him senseless. You’ve waited long enough.”

He chokes on his coffee, trying desperately to regain the ability to breathe as his mother laughs.

“And whatever you do,” she adds, wiping a tear of mirth from her eye, “don’t let your father hear about this. He will drive here overnight, camp on your doorstep, and interrogate the poor boy about his intentions for hours.”

Mydei groans loudly, but he’s laughing too within seconds, unable to hold back. His father would absolutely pull something like this. He scrunches his nose, remembering all the times Eurypon had been overprotective during his teen years. “Please don’t tell him either.”

“Our little secret,” Gorgo winks, squeezing his shoulder one last time. “But I expect updates in exchange, and photos, preferably of you two being happy and in love.”

Mydei shakes his head with a smile. “Okay.” He really appreciates his mother.

As Gorgo moves on, telling a story about his father’s latest work projects back home, Mydei feels something lift off his chest.

Send a few signals and wait for Phainon to make the first move, and when he finally does: don’t hold back.

He can do that.

— ◇ —

Phainon is still grinning like an idiot when he finally collapses onto his bed, heart full of warmth he never thought he'd be feeling.

He spent one of the most fun days of his life, got his emotions in check— Cyrene would be proud of him for that— and now it leaves only one thing for him to do.

Confess.

Tell Mydei how he feels and pray for the best.

How does one do that again?

Surely he can't simply pop in the living room and tell Mydei, "hey, let's date." He was to make it right, possibly start with an apology for being so dense and in denial, then convey his feelings properly, so there are no chances for more miscommunications between them and only then actually ask the blonde out.

Phainon turns on his side, tugging at the blanket. "Alright," he mutters to himself. "You've handled marketing proposals that could make grown men cry. You can handle one confession."

His stomach twists.

"Except this one might make me cry," he admits, quietly. He never confessed to anyone before.

He runs through the day in his head again, frame by frame; the shared laughter and competitions at the arcade, holding Mydei's hand, the little girl

calling them a couple, the hug… Fuck, that hug was everything. Phainon wants it again, and again, until he forgets what being alone ever felt like.

Rolling onto his back again, Phainon stares up at the same ceiling that mocked him countless times in the past months. *"Okay, confession. You can do it."* He recounts all the times he had seen it in movies. *"Step one: perfect timing. Step two: be clear. Step three: Maybe flowers? Step four…"*

His mind blanks.

"Step four is where I figure out what the fuck I'm doing."

Phainon sighs and reaches for his phone, the screen lighting up his face. His thumb hovers over the Reddit app out of pure, shameful habit. He really shouldn't. No more public humiliation. No more threads like 'How do you know you're in love with your roommate?' or 'Does having erotic dreams about your roommate mean you're attracted to them?' He deleted that one less than a minute after posting, too embarrassed to even asking. He was attracted to Mydei, more than simply attracted actually.

He types a draft, deleting it right before he hits the post button. This question is too personal to ask the internet's opinion about. He can, and should, figure it on his own.

It's not that difficult, all he has to do is think about the times Mydei told him he had been asked out. For example, the scrawny guy who asked for his phone number at the grocery store. Or that short dude who stopped them in the middle of the street and Phainon kept pointing out his height, or lack of it, much to Mydei's annoyance and the guy's embarrassment.

Or the last man, the twink who, according to Mydei, "tried really hard to impress him" at the gym.

Phainon frowns. There is no real pattern here, and the only similar thing between these guys is their physical build. Does it mean?

Oh no.

“Oh no no no,” he whispers out loud, sitting up slowly as the understanding dawns on him like a truck about to send his ass into another world, like those mediocre anime he watches sometimes. “Fuck.”

His face goes bright red first, then, much to his mortification, he can feel himself twitch.

“Nope. Not thinking about that.”

Except, of course, he is thinking about *that*.

Phainon tries not to, but his brain unhelpfully conjures an image of Mydei pinning him down, those same mesmerizing golden eyes clouded with desire, his usually steady voice is much lower, breath hot against his ear as the blonde trails slick fingers down his hip, and lower, and lower—

“STOP!” he whisper-shouts into the quiet room, ass-cheeks clenching instinctively. He can’t do this.

With the last of his willpower, he takes that train of thought and throws it off the rails and out of his mind.

“It’s one thing to want to date him,” he mutters, “but it’s a whole different thing to…”

Sighing loudly and grabbing his discarded phone, Phainon does the one thing a guy who’s about to have another emotional meltdown would do: message his best friend for emotional support, or answers, or provide her blackmail material. All options are valid.

Phainon [01:23]: Hey. weird question but does it hurt taking it up the ass?

He already regrets sending the message.

Cipher [01:25]: first of all, THE FUCK???

Cipher [01:25]: second, why would I know? I have a GIRL-friend, in case you forgot.

Phainon [01:26]: idk...

That was obviously a mistake. It’s late and he isn’t thinking clearly. It’s something he can research on Google or ask Reddit. Well, maybe not Reddit. He made a fool of himself enough times on that app by now.

Phainon [01:33]: nvm. Ill search online.

Cipher [01:34]: why not ask the little princess?

Phainon [01:34]: little princess?

Cipher [01:36]: your roommate

Phainon [01:40]: why would he know? He likes smaller men… no?

Cipher [01:42]: HAHAHAHAHAHA SO THAT'S WHAT IT IS ABOUT! OMGGGGGG

He stares at the last line with confusion, watching the three dots pop up and disappear several times, indicating that Cipher is typing something. He hopes it’s an explanation.

Cipher [01:45]: call me. Now.

It’s not an explanation, but he still calls her as ordered.

She answers at the first ring. “Oh. My. God. You absolute disaster! Do you really think the little princess likes those twinks?”

“I- what. How am I supposed to know?”

“Because you live with him?” He can hear her trying her best to suppress a snicker, followed by rustling, to which he assumes it’s her moving somewhere where she doesn’t have to keep her voice hushed. “So? Why are you suddenly interested in the little princess's bed preferences?” Her grin is undoubtedly as wide as a cat who has caught a fish.

Phainon sighs, rubbing his face. “It’s, how do I explain it. I’ve been in denial about it for some time, but I came to terms with the fact that I like him, and that, based on the guys Mydei dates, he’s the one who… I don’t know, tops? Takes? Penetrates?” The last term makes him flinch, it sounds more vulgar than he thought.

“Bitch, please.” Cipher snorts.

“What, it's obvious!”

“Obvious if you’re either blind or somehow never been to his room. The little princess is so bad at hiding his toys away.” She laughs as Phainon almost combusts on the spot. Toy collection? Oh god. How is he supposed to look Mydei in the eyes now without thinking about…

He shakes his head vigorously until the world spins and the mental image temporarily dissolves.

“But anyway, instead of asking him for his preferences in bed, which are obviously not topping, you’re texting me? And you think you’re not a disaster.”

“I—” he sputters. “It’s too embarrassing to ask such thing! I haven’t even confessed yet.” He stops himself before he says anything stupid, like how reassuring it is to hear Mydei’s preferences in bed. It’s not that he’s against the idea or has any standpoints; he simply doesn’t think he’d like anything near his ass, personally.

At least it’s clear now that he and Mydeimos are compatible in that aspect too, if they ever get far enough into a relationship to try anything.

“You’re hopeless! Just tell him you like him already.” Cipher keeps laughing like he’s telling her the best joke she’s ever heard and not his love-life problems, and for a good minute, all that can be heard is his friend’s chuckles as her laugh dies down.

“I’m planning to,” Phainon grumbles quietly. “I just need the right timing for it.”

Cipher changes her tone into a serious one almost instantly. “I’m giving you a week. Don’t drag it too long boy. We meet up on Friday, and Cas and I better hear you two are all over each other by then.”

“Oh god.”

“Don’t *‘oh god’* me,” she mimics him. “You know I like both of you, so naturally I’d want my two gay besties to be happy and sappy together.”

He pinches the bridge of his nose, right above where his glasses would usually sit. “I’m not gay. I’m just into him—”

“It’s more dire than I thought.” He can hear the gray-haired woman sigh on the other side, “Meeting will be at our usual bar, you’re paying for the drinks.”

She hangs up before he can protest.

Phainon stares at the phone screen, then groans into the pillow. *Fantastic.* He will empty his wallet while being interrogated by his two closest friends.

And if it wasn’t bad enough, he also has to confess before Friday, or try to.



The rest of the week drags on slower than a new patch update for his favorite game. Phainon spends most evenings either thinking about every possible way he can confess or ‘relaxing,’ which, in his definition, means yelling at his screen and getting personally offended when he can’t get the last end-game reward.

He tried confessing three times so far: Once as they were watching a movie and a romantic scene was playing on screen. Then, during a grocery run, when Mydei was acting so cute denying his sweet tooth it took everything not to smother the man with kisses.

The most recent attempt was in the morning, right before Phainon left for work and Mydei handed him a lunch box. Phainon missed those lunchboxes so much that he almost burst into tears and sobbed ‘I love you.’

But none of the times felt right.

Which brings him to the present—still no confession on a Wednesday evening.

He’s midway through one of those “relaxation” nights, winding up after a long day at work, when the door opens.

“Welcome home!” Phainon calls, without looking away from the screen as he cannot afford to lose the boss fight again. That would be the seventh attempt, or the eighth? He thinks he lost count. “Dinner is in the fridge. I made a stir fry.”

“Thanks.” Mydei’s voice is low, as tired as the man appears to be once he dares a quick glance. The blonde kicks off his shoes, sets his motorcycle keys on the table, and comes over to join Phainon on the couch. “You’ve been here since I left three hours ago, haven’t you?”

“That’s slander,” Phainon huffs, dead serious. “I paused the game to cook earlier—oh god, no, fuck, I mis-clicked.”

The screen goes red within seconds. The “Try Again” writing mocks him.

From the corner of his eye, he sees Mydei’s smirk. “Skill issue?”

“You have no idea how much emotional damage that phrase causes.”

Mydei sits more comfortably, now that Phainon isn’t trashing around with the controller. The couch dips further under his weight, clothed knee brushing his uncovered one, arms pressing together as the blonde rests his head on his shoulder, and Phainon has to focus extra hard on the screen to not let it affect him.

It’s not that he doesn’t like the proximity, on the contrary, he likes it more than he probably should. It felt so wrong when Mydei was keeping his

distance from him.

“What are you playing this time?” Mydei’s smile is small, barely there, but it’s the soft kind of smile that makes Phainon’s brain short-circuit a little and wish to confess his feelings then and there. Phainon leans closer on instinct, allows his head to rest against Mydei’s as he convinces himself it’s not the perfect time to whisper an ‘I love you’, no matter how badly he wants to.

“Grinding the same. I need all the gems I can get.” Phainon answers, choosing to focus on the blonde’s question instead of thinking about confessing at the wrong moment by accident. “I really want this character, but the game hates me.”

“Didn’t you say this last month, too?” Mydei asks, eyes flicking between Phainon and the screen.

“Well, it’s the game’s fault for having really cool designs.”

“Sounds to me like you’ve got an addiction.”

Phainon gasps dramatically, leaning away to look fully at the blonde with mock offense. “How dare you call me out like that!”

“Someone has to address it.”

“For the record, this one has the best design so far!” he tries defending himself. He’s not a gacha addict. He swears he isn't.

“Oh yeah? Cooler than the hero with the broad sword you had to pull out your wallet for?”

So much for defending himself. Phainon lets his shoulders sag in defeat. “Do not remind me,” he still can’t clear the hardest difficulty despite getting both the character and their dedicated weapon. He needs better supports, or premium gear, or both, but his luck is too cursed to afford any, sadly.

Still, he opens the summoning screen, intending to show Mydei why he wants the new shiny character so much. Surely Mydei would understand the

appeal of a blonde, shirtless guy who fights with their bare hands.

And that's where his brain catches up.

"No wonder you like the character," it laughs at his expense.

Blonde? Check. Muscles? Check. Exposed chest? Double check. All there. The only thing missing is the tattoos.

If not for the different eye color or the much shorter hair, that character could almost look like a variant of his roommate.

"First that girl you went on a date with, now this character… You have a type." His brain is still busy mocking him.

Luckily, Mydei does not see the resemblance. Or at the very least, doesn't call him on it if he does.

He ditches the high difficulty boss fight and resumes exploring some of the maps after that, desperate to get enough for another consecutive summon. Mydei leans back against him, adding comments of "you missed a chest," "Weren't you supposed to counter?" "You sure that's how the puzzle works?" until Phainon elbows him.

"If you're so smart, *you* play."

"I know I'd do better than you."

"Ha. Bold words. You keep dying at every game I've taught you so far," He passes him the controller with a huff. "But sure, be my guest."

Mydei grabs the controller. It takes him a few minutes to adjust, but true to his word, he manages to clear the map in the next twenty-or-so minutes. Phainon doesn't know if to be impressed or upset that the same guy who supposedly sucks at gaming is better than him at his favorite game.

"Alright," he says instead. "Since you're so good. You do the summoning. If you don't get anything good, you'll be doing dishes for a whole week."

“What kind of challenge is that?” Mydei scowls.

Phainon shakes a finger in front of his face. “Don’t be like this, Mydeimos. Since you’re so good at it, you might also be extremely lucky. Let’s test it out. Unless you’re too scared the Gambling gods won’t be in your favor!”

“And if I do?” The competitive glint is back in Mydei’s eyes. Good. He took the bait so easily.

“Then you,” He stops, caught off-guard by the little smirk Mydei gives him. “Then I do the dishes for a week.”

“Two and we have a deal.”

“Fine.”

Mydei closes his eyes, whispers something under his breath in a language Phainon doesn’t understand, and presses the summoning button.

The screen starts with blue, then purple, and then turns gold in the last second.

“No way.” Phainon’s expression turns into one of shock, then disbelief—he adjusts his glasses to make sure he’s seeing correctly— and lastly to a pout as he resigns to doing the dishes for the next two weeks.

Mydei blinks. “Did I…?”

The screen flashes Phainon the character he wanted, followed by another SSR character two standard cards later. WHAT?

“NO WAY!” He grabs Mydei’s shoulders and shakes him like a prize-winning tree. “You got two SSRs in one multi summon, this is insane.”

He doesn’t notice the words tumbling out until he’s already hugging his crush from excitement. His cheek brushes the line of Mydei’s jaw, and he can smell the blonde’s natural musk, followed by traces of the same sweet cologne he is addicted to by now, and he hugs him tighter, wants to smother him with kisses—

Then he realizes what he’s doing.

“Oh, shit. Sorry!” Phainon jerks back, face flushed all the way to his neck. “I just can’t believe it. That’s some crazy luck there.”

Mydei’s reaction is more grounded. The man pulls him back into his arms, murmuring, “Relax. It’s just a hug.”

“I,” It feels like the right moment, and the confession is already forming on his tongue again, threatening to spill as the blonde keeps his face hidden in his shoulder, feeling almost... Relaxed? Phainon can’t remember when Mydei looked this content. Does it mean Mydei likes him too? “I like—”

“Hm?” His crush hums.

“This is it,” his mind screams at him. *“It’s the perfect moment.”*

But it’s not. Because Mydei just pulled him a rare character, and it could sound like something meaningless and lighthearted. He doesn’t want to hurt Mydeimos again, or say something that would lead to more misunderstandings; he can’t afford that.

“You’re officially my lucky charm.” Phainon coughs, changing the topic.

“I’ll put it on my résumé,” the blonde replies with a chuckle, pulling away. “Professional gacha summoner. Sounds impressive.”

They spend the rest of the evening without any more almost confessions or other incidents. Mydei grabs his share of dinner while Phainon sulks as he washes the dishes, allowing Mydei to keep exploring the maps on his game in the meantime.

It’s a little past midnight when his roommate finally stands to stretch, and Phainon’s eyes follow him without permission, zeroing on the way his shirt rides up slightly, the stretch of muscle, the tattoo lines disappearing into the hem of his pants, and suddenly Phainon is very curious to know how far lower they go...

He clears his throat fast. “You, uh, calling it a night?”

“Yeah. I have a morning shift tomorrow.” Mydei smiles at him, adding, “Don’t stay up all night again.”

“No promises.” Phainon adjusts his glasses just so he has something to do with his hands. Mydei did catch him playing all night long a few times before, and the outcome is always the same: he’s so tired for the rest of the day that he passes out the moment he gets home, only to be scolded by his crush for neglecting his health.

Mydei shakes his head fondly and disappears into the hallway, wishing him a “good night” and “sweet dreams.”

Oh.

That’s new. Phainon feels like he unlocked a new voice line. He sits there a moment longer, controller in his lap, heart beating too fast. Mydei just wished him sweet dreams. Sweet. *He thinks Phainon is sweet*.

“Totally normal behavior,” he mutters. “Completely fine. Just your regular mid-week crash out over a single sentence.”

His newly acquired character Yawns in his idle, mocking him.

— ◇ —

By Friday night, Phainon is one more confession attempt in and an actual confession out. In his defense, it wasn’t a perfect timing either.

And so, he accepts his fate of being scolded by his two friends. Phainon spends the early evening trying to figure out what to wear, mostly because Castorice is very particular about what she deems as passable on him, and his favorite orange shirt or the purple slacks he bought recently aren’t good enough. The lavender-haired girl threatened to burn them the one time he wore those pants.

Opting for wearing the same outfit he had worn for his not-date with Mydei, Phainon tames his mane and debates if he should stick to glasses or wear contacts, deciding on the former- knowing he might be too tired when he returns home and forget about them.

One last look in the mirror, to make sure he looks good, and he's ready to go.

"Going out?" Mydei lifts his head from the book he's reading as he sees him walking past the living room, and Phainon swears that for a long second Mydei was checking him out, golden eyes darker than usual.

"Yeah, to a bar with the gremlins." He pulls on his coat, pretending the buttons require intense concentration. "They requested my presence for, you know, casual girly gossip."

"Did not expect you to be part of the gossip club." Mydei chuckles before adding, "Tell Cas I said hi, and remind Cipher that she still owes me dinner." He stands, crossing the room in unhurried steps, and leans so close to Phainon's face that he swears he can feel the ghost of the man's breath on his lips. Then, like he didn't *almost kiss* him just now, Mydei swipes his thumb really close to his mouth, sending electric sparks down Phainon's spine like he had touched a socket.

"M-Mydei?"

"You still had some sauce from dinner over there," the blonde grumbles, eyes widening as if he suddenly realized what he was doing. Mydei turns away and wishes him a pleasant evening, his ears as red as Phainon's face feels.

Great. Now all he can think of is Mydei's soft fingers on his lips.

He's fucked.

"I will! Don't wait for me." Phainon shouts behind him, closing the door and leaning against the hallway's wall, allowing himself a few moments to

catch his breath and make sure his heart doesn't try to burst out of his ribs with how loud it's beating.

Oh, he's absolutely fucked.

◇

They meet up at the usual bar, the one he and Cipher frequent. The same bar with the eternally sticky tables and questionable drink names on the chalkboard behind the bartender, because why would anyone want a cocktail named *"The shots we didn't shoot"*?

Cipher waves at him the moment he steps inside like she's pointing at a wanted criminal and not saying hi to a friend. Castorice sits beside her, orderly as ever, hands wrapped around a steaming mug of something.

"There he is," Cipher announces as he slides across from them in the booth. "The man, the myth, the walking crisis."

"Hi to you too, Mydei mentioned you still owe him dinner by the way." He laughs as the gray-haired girl groans at the reminder, then smiles at Castorice, who returns the gesture. "So…"

"Drinks first," Cas says, although she already has one. "Trust me, you're going to want one, and I know this one does too." She points at her girlfriend, who pouts at her, making a *'what do you mean by this one?'* kind of face.

He listens to the lavender-haired girl, ordering two of their stronger beers, one for him, and one for the ball of chaos who will be blackmailing him for decades after tonight.

Cipher claps happily once her drink arrives, taking a large gulp of the cold beverage. "Okay. Start from the beginning so my girl here can catch up," she leans against Castorice with a grin.

Phainon sips on his beer, praying for that liquid courage to kick in so he's less embarrassed about the whole ordeal of oversharing his, hopefully not one-sided, love life with the girls. "Fine. So, I like Mydei, in a romantic way."

Cipher blinks theatrically. "Shocking. Could've sworn you two are married already."

Castorice sighs, rolling her eyes, acting like he told her the sky is blue and not a revelation he barely came to realize a week ago. "Thank you, Captain Obvious."

"What do you two mean by that?" He's almost offended at their flat reaction. Surely he wasn't that obvious about his attraction? He wasn't aware of it himself until very recently, for god's sake.

"You were pretty obvious," Cas adds, as if reading his mind, right before Cipher interrupts her. "And? Did you confess?"

"No," Phainon lets his shoulders sag, fixing his glasses higher on his nose, "I'm pretty sure he likes me so I tried a few times, but none of the moments were right." He stares at his drink, "I want it to be perfect. He deserves—"

"Stop," both women say at the same time, cutting his rambling off.

Cipher slams her glass a little too hard on the table. "You don't need to make it big or perfect. You're not proposing, at least I hope you aren't. So just tell him, like a human. You are human, yes?"

"Sometimes," Cas murmurs, amused by her own remark.

"I *am* Human," he hisses, mock-wounded. "A human who possibly panicked himself into a spiral about logistics, and—" Phainon clears his throat; eyes fixed on anything but the two girls, "and other logistics."

Cipher snorts loudly. It feels like a Deja vu from months ago, when she offered him her lease. "Right! Oh god. That message!"

“Don’t.” He pleads, but she’s already pulling her phone out to show Castorice the text she’s referring to. “It was dumb of me; I shouldn’t have assumed anything. But yeah, I might’ve jumped to a conclusion because of the guys he dated.”

Castorice takes a calm sip from her mug. “It’s natural to panic, Mydei panicked just as much when he stayed at our place after you two fought.”

Phainon looks at the lavender-haired girl with a puzzled look. “He did? What did he say?”

“He didn’t talk, he *sulked*,” Cipher corrects, “like a cat left outside in the rain. Spent an hour on our couch staring at the wall, refusing to eat. Cas had to bribe him with honeycakes. It was tragic.”

“It was quite endearing, actually,” Cas chimes in. “Not like he could help it, he was hurt and panicked you’d never want to talk to him again.”

Phainon’s chest tightens. “Oh god,” he says. “I messed up really bad with my denial, didn’t I?”

“You were fighting your own demons,” Cas reassures him. “And Mydei didn’t know that, so he was afraid he read you wrong. That you were repulsed by him, or weren’t into guys to begin with.” She explains.

Cipher pushes a napkin toward him, nodding vigorously. “Yup. He was so upset for hitting you. Yet, he wouldn’t shut up about you, no matter what. The little princess was smitten.”

Phainon looks up so fast he spills a bit of his drink. Technically, Mydei wasn’t wrong; he wasn’t into guys; pretty sure he still isn’t. Unless their name is Mydeimos and they look like a Greek god. “Cool. Great. Love that for me. Add it to the pile of things I wish I’d figured out before messing up. Can’t believe him going on a date was my wake-up call.” He sighs. Cipher was right. He would need a drink, or five, tonight.

He orders another round of drinks for them all.

Cipher squints. “Wait. Date?”

“A random guy asked him out,” Phainon mutters, sulking while studying his coaster with too much interest, feeling bitter for remembering that day’s events. “Came home to see Mydei getting ready for a date and that’s when I realized I was into him more than simply friends.”

Cipher and Castorice share a look. A whole silent conversation if he has to guess. Deep in his heart he hopes to be able to be this close to Mydei one day, where all they need to do is look at each other to understand everything.

“And how did the date go?” Castorice asks eventually, already knowing the answer. Phainon wouldn’t be sitting in front of her if it went well and Mydei moved on.

“He came home early and called the man a dick.” The memory loosens something in him. “Said the guy was only after his body. Which—fair. It is a very… Conspicuous body.” He makes a vague gesture, unable to say the word ‘hot’ out loud.

Cipher wiggles her brows. Castorice kicks her under the table without looking.

“And what happened after that?” the lavender-haired girl asks, encouraging him to share the events of the past two weeks with them.

Phainon chugs the rest of his beer and orders a third one, knowing he’s going to regret it, but that’s a problem for future him.

He tells them everything.

“Listen,” Cipher says once he finishes talking, suddenly sounding serious, which is quite uncharacteristic for her. “The guy tried to rebound, but it clearly didn’t work since you’re here telling us about how you’re convinced he likes you back and want to confess *your* feelings.” She points a finger at him, accusing. “So what are you waiting for? For Mydei to give up on waiting and move on for real?”

Phainon swallows, no. He definitely doesn't want that. "No! I do want to tell him how I feel. But what if the timing is wrong or I mess it up?" He asks, suddenly feeling the sinking sensation of dread in his stomach, the kind that leaves your legs numb and throat too tight to swallow.

"Then you fix it," Cipher answers, like it's obvious. "Apologize and say 'I worded that badly, let me try again.' Or something. You're better at talking than both of us here."

Castorice leans in, grabbing his hand before he spirals. "Look at me."

He does.

"You are good with words, Phainon. But you're also scared because it's your first serious relationship. Nothing is wrong with that. What matters is that you try. There's no need to make it perfect or time it right, just tell him."

Cipher pokes her girlfriend's cheek. "Look at Cas and me here, we danced around each other for months. Could've been down each other's pants sooner if we weren't cowards."

Castorice kicks her harder this time. Phainon almost chokes on his beer.

"You're right." He admits once he stops coughing. "Not communicating about our feelings almost ruined it once already. I should stop thinking about making it perfect and tell him how I feel."

Cipher throws confetti— or a shredded napkin, close enough—and Castorice nods once, like a judge appreciating a contestant's newfound determination.

"That's more like it," the lavender-haired girl praises him, while her girlfriend nods along, already pretty drunk.

He exhales, satisfied with their response. "Okay. I can do that."

"And do that tomorrow," Cipher cuts in. "Before you go back to your little perfectionist habit of waiting for the perfect moment again."

He pouts at her, quite tipsy himself. “I hate it when you’re right.”

“Nah. You love it, same way you’re going to love paying for another round of drinks,” she laughs like she told the best joke ever and orders refills for them all.

Castorice finishes her tea, opting for non-alcoholic drinks after the first round, and smiles at him fondly while the two slowly work through their fourth beer—three too many if you ask sober Phainon.

“He wants you, Phai,” she tells him, straightforward and gentle. “Probably waiting for you to make a move first, since he thought it was one-sided last time. So, as you say, ‘Don’t chicken out.’”

He hates it when she uses his own wording against him, not really.

By the time they leave the bar, Phainon is glad he took the bus here, realizing he can barely walk straight —he laughs at the irony— and orders a taxi, not trusting himself to make it home by public transport.

Cipher leans in to pat his shoulder while they wait for his ride, clearly as drunk as he is. “Tomorrow, you tell him how you feel. Tonight, you hydrate and pray for the hangover gods to spare you.”

Castorice presses a bottle of water into his palm, like on cue, and pats him on the shoulder with a smile that feels more like a threat, “Drink it.”

“I hate water.” He sulks, looking at the bottle through the partially smudged lenses of his glasses like the plastic offended his drunk self.



Phainon can barely remember the ride home or the walk to their building, all he knows is that he’s practicing confessions under his breath with each step. “Hi, Mydei. Can we talk?” he whispers to the fire hydrant outside their

house. “I like you. More than a friend, and I want to take you on a real date this time.” The fire Hydrant doesn’t respond, but it’s red like the tips of Mydei’s hair, so he’s not mad at the inanimate object, grinning like the drunk man he is at the grand confession.

It sounds great, definitely something he should remember tomorrow when he’s less made of liquid confidence and has more water in his veins than alcohol.

Opening the apartment door with more difficulty than it should be, he’s surprised to see light in the living room and a very familiar figure dozing off on the couch.

“Mydei?”

There he is. Lying on the couch, hugging that stupid pomegranate Phainon got him. His head lifts when Phainon stumbles in, eyes narrowing slightly, like he’s trying to see through the sleepy haze.

“You’re home late.”

Phainon blinks, grinning wide. “You’re home *early.*”

“It’s two in the morning; I’ve been here all night.” Mydei’s mouth twitches into a little smile that makes Phainon’s heart kick like a startled rabbit. “And you’re drunk.”

“Inc’rrect.” He slurs, “I’m… confidence-enhanc’d.” Phainon tosses his shoes to the floor, not caring to put them away properly. “Did ya wait for me?” His chest warms at the thought.

Mydei sighs. “You can’t even talk coherently.”

“That’ a yes.”

Finally able to unbutton his coat and hang it, Phainon takes a few steps closer, too confident in his walking ability for a man with too much beer in his system. The floor betrays him halfway there and tilts. Or he tilts. Either way, gravity suddenly wants him closer to the ground.

“Careful there.”

Strong arms catch him before the room finishes spinning. Mydei’s chest is both *really soft* and solid against his cheek, warm through the fabric of the sweater he’s wearing.

“T’nk you,” Phainon mumbles into his collar. “For c’tching m’.” The words come out slurred, and gods, his brain is a pile of static at the proximity. He leans back enough to look at Mydei through the thick frames of his glasses, and his vision swims pleasantly.

He means to say *thank you* again, but it melts halfway into an accidental *I like you,* mixing into something incoherent.

“Th’nksilikeu.”

Mydei blinks. “What?”

Phainon doesn’t clarify. Instead, he smiles, bright and full of teeth, and before he can think, because thinking is for sober people, he leans forward.

It’s not quite a kiss. More of a clumsy brush of lips that lands at the corner of Mydei’s mouth and not on his lips, warm and fleeting. But it feels so good that Phainon wants to lean in again and not miss this time.

Then his brain catches up.

He pulls back, eyes wide. “I’m sor—” the apology dies in his throat. He can’t apologize because he doesn’t feel sorry, not in the slightest, not in his drunken state at least.

Daring to glance at Mydei again, the blonde’s hands are still at Phainon’s waist, steadying him, but otherwise Mydei looks as stiff as a wooden board. His eyes are as wide as saucers, pupils dark to the point he can barely see the gold-like color of the man’s eyes, or is it the low lighting? He’s not sure.

Thinking is hard.

Mydeimos exhales slowly, pointing out again. “You’re drunk.”

“Only a ‘lil,” Phainon admits, full-blown grinning at him.

“Mhm. Now let’s get you to bed before you pass out.” Smiling despite himself, or at least that’s what Phainon thinks he sees, Mydei takes a deep breath and steers them gently toward Phainon’s bedroom. Phainon doesn’t resist it, allows himself to be guided as he leans against the blonde and nuzzles against his shoulder.

Everything is spinning around him, but he’s vaguely aware of being set on the edge of the bed before his sweater is taken off, then his socks, and lastly his pants. Phainon finds himself thanking his drunken state, or else he would’ve gotten hard over the fact that Mydei is practically stripping him.

“waited ‘fr me…” Phainon mumbles again, like it’s the only thing worth remembering.

“Yes,” Mydei answers quietly, tugging off his undershirt too, then putting a different one on him. “I did.”

The world spins again, and this time he lands onto something soft. He feels fingers brush his cheek and remove his glasses, then the click of his lamp switching off, and a quick press of lips to his forehead, one he is desperately praying to remember tomorrow.

“Goodnight, Phainon.”

— ◇ —

It’s not a real kiss. It's a clumsy brush of lips warm against the corner of his mouth, but something as simple as that is enough to send Mydei’s mind into a screeching halt. For one breathless second, he cannot think. Everything narrows to the softness of Phainon’s lips and the way his hands tighten on Mydei’s bicep like he *doesn’t want to let go*.

Then, before he has a chance to fully process the almost-kiss, Phainon pulls back with a half formed apology that he never finishes. He dares glancing back at the snow-haired man, and the little shit doesn't look sorry at all. He looks happy.

Phainon looks happy after kissing him.

Mydei has to force his lungs to work.

He gets Phainon to bed after that, stripping off all the layers without letting his eyes linger too much—just a little glimpse here and there, and fuck, maybe it's more than a little glimpse because the man looks really good under those clothes…

Composing himself before his drunk soon-to-be-boyfriend registers anything, Mydei tucks him into bed, removing his glasses so they don't get crushed, brushing the snow-soft hair from Phainon's forehead in the process and leaving a fleeting kiss there.

"Goodnight, Phainon."

He turns off the light and leaves the room quietly, heart pounding in his ears.

Hope is dangerous. He knows that.

But as he lies in bed, hugging the pomegranate plushie like he's been doing all week, he realizes there's no need to refuse hope anymore.

Phainon made the first move.

Mydei touches the corner of his mouth again and buries his reddening face into the soft fabric. His mother's voice surfaces to the front of his mind, bright and certain: *Once he does make that move? Don't hold back. Grab him by the hair and kiss him senseless.*

"It's time for me to return the favor," Mydei whispers into the darkness of the room. The ball is in his court now, and perhaps he can do a little more than kissing tomorrow…

After all, His mother was right. Phainon did make him wait long enough.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter was originally less than 6k words, Idk how it became close to 10k words this past week...
Enjoy the extra long chapter

Chapter 10: It Might Be Gay, But It Was Totally Worth It

Chapter Summary

He kissed Mydei.

He kissed his crush.

And not even properly! He missed! He kissed the corner of Mydei’s mouth.

“I ruined everything,” Phainon mutters into the softness of the pillow he’s currently trying to suffocate himself with. “I’ll have to look for a new place. Change my name. Grow a beard and move to another country...”

But nothing too crazy, yeah?

Phainons isn’t a dramatic person.

Or; a Praying circle for Phainon's sanity.

Chapter Notes

If you havent yet, Make sure you check this beautiful art by @maskyll - portraying the events of chapter 6 ❤

It's so beautiful i'm in tears

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first thing Phainon feels when he wakes is pain.

It's the kind of pain that makes him regret every single one of the life decisions that led him to drink four beers in one evening, or hang out with both Cipher and Castorice in a bar of all places.

His head is pounding, everything around him feels too bright, he wants to throw up, and worst of all, he has no clue how he made it to bed or got out of all the layers he was wearing.

Phainon groans, hugging his extra pillow like it might make the world stop spinning— it doesn't— and opens his eyes again, slowly this time, just enough to search for the bottle of water he usually keeps by his bed, praying it's not empty.

To his luck, the bottle is full, surprisingly so. And next to it is a small note with two painkillers on top. Phainon brings it close to his face and squints to read it without needing to put on his glasses.

"You're going to need these. Take it easy today."

Mydei.

Bless his soul for always taking care of him.

He takes both painkillers, washing them down with the entire bottle-worth of water, and falls back onto the sheets. Falling back asleep, Phainon prays that by the time he wakes up again the pills will kick in.

Thankfully, they do. When he wakes up for the second time, the world feels less unbearable, and the full-blown headache he was having is reduced to a dull pain, one he believes will go away sooner than later.

The only thing that is missing is the majority of his memories and his clothes, which he still can't recall taking off.

Looking up at the ceiling, Phainon tries to remember how the evening went.

He was sitting in the bar with Castorice and Cipher, told them about his feelings for Mydei, remembers them encouraging him to confess already and ordering more beer, then there was a blurry taxi ride… What happened after?

His mind slowly catches up to a fragmented memory of him confessing to a fire hydrant—he hopes nobody saw that—then a quick fragment of opening

the door to Mydei waiting for him. The next, and last, fragment makes all color drain from his skin: he’s in the man’s arms, lips pressing against Mydei’s, before completely blacking out.

Oh. Oh no.

Phainon rolls over to scream into his pillow.

“Fuck.”

He kissed Mydei.

“Fuck.”

He kissed his *crush.*

“Fuck.”

And not even properly! He missed! He kissed the corner of Mydei’s mouth.

“I ruined everything,” he mutters into the softness of the pillow he’s currently trying to suffocate himself with. “I’ll have to look for a new place. Change my name. Grow a beard and move to another country...”

But nothing too crazy, yeah?

Phainons isn’t a dramatic person.

He rolls out of bed an hour later, showered and marginally alive, mind wrapped in the heavy fog of regret at his drunken actions. Sadly, his pillow was not enough to end his misery, and their shower has no tub he can drown himself in... So hoping Mydei is not home is his last resort.

The apartment is surprisingly quiet when he enters the living room, the only indicator that Mydei was around is the lingering smell of coffee and cooking, probably from when he prepared breakfast. His roommate must be at work or has classes.

Either way, he's not home.

Good. That means minimal human contact until Phainon can find words grand enough to make up for his alcohol-laced stupidity and confess properly, preferably without unsolicited kissing this time. But first, he needs to make his stomach stop rumbling and eat something despite the lingering nausea the pills couldn't completely wipe.

He still can't believe he possibly fucked up everything he spoke about with the girls the night before, and now Mydei probably thinks he's an asshole, just like the people on Reddit deemed him, because who in their right mind kisses their roommate out of the blue without talking things out first!?

Apparently, Phainon does.

Slapping himself internally, he opens the fridge and grabs the first thing that looks edible: a plate with another small note attached to it, just like the one Mydei left by his bed. This one has 'hangover remedy' written on it.

Opening the foil with curiosity, he sees a mouthwatering breakfast burrito, and with his name basically written on it? Don't mind him if he digs in.

Moving out is dramatic, he decides while biting into the delicious wrap his crush made for him. Mydeimos wouldn't leave him food if he was mad. Perhaps he can skip the overthinking marathon and go with a simple apology like Cipher suggested. Mydei has been nothing but sweet for him since last night, if the memory of lips against his temple is real and not a fantasy he conjured.

He overreacted earlier, Phainon decides, taking another bite. He should stick to the original plan: apologize for the drunken assault like a rational adult, and then, depending on Mydei's reaction, confess his feelings. Phainon can do rational. He can handle this.

He finishes the divine burrito and returns to his room to get his phone, only to see two messages there:

Castorice [10:12]: Did you confess? Do I call an ambulance?

Followed by a message from Cipher.

Cipher [11:26]: ik youre probably balls deep in your new bf or smth, but Cas is worried. Are you alive?

Phainon chokes on his own spit and almost trips over nothing, again, feeling his face heat up so fast that steam might start coming out of his ears any second. Of course, Cipher would have no filter.

He answers Castorice quickly, ignoring Cipher out of spite, and drags himself to the living room, anticipation already kicking in for the moment Mydei would return home.

Time, though, chooses to become his enemy and moves slower than his coworkers on a Monday morning. Phainon tries to distract himself by watching videos first, giving up after the third one, as he pays no attention to them. Playing games proves to be just as futile as he can barely think of strategies and exploration when his mind is too busy rehearsing apologies.

Perhaps good old Reddit could be a decent enough pass time.

“Not posting anything, only reading random posts,” he swears, looking toward the balcony, like the gods themselves are sitting there and judging him for even considering it. His thumb is already hovering above the orange icon when the front door clicks open, making him jump in his seat, literally, and toss his phone to who-knows-where.

Looking to the entrance, Phainon sees his crush standing there, looking more tired than he ever remembers him, almost like Mydei didn’t sleep at all last night, which is considered the end of the world, because Mydei’s discipline runs *that* deep.

His roommate doesn’t greet him as usual, or says anything in fact, although the small smirk on his lips tells Phainon more than enough.

It feels like Mydeimos is planning something, and if he has to base it on the last time he saw the blonde like this—when he was caught staring at Mydei’s ass—Phainon knows his sanity is about to be put on trial.

The universe, though, doesn't give him much time to ponder over it, because Mydei crosses the room and falls on the couch.

Not onto the empty cushion. Not onto his usual spot.

But face first, onto Phainon's lap.

Mydei's cheek rests on his bare thighs, nose pressing into the edge of Phainon's shorts, arms curling loosely around his waist like they've been dating for years. Like they do this every day.

Phainon's reaction, aside from freezing and being too afraid to even breathe, is thinking *"Ok, so maybe he doesn't hate you and wants to cuddle,"* to which he shakes his head, internally. *"This must be his payback for last night's kiss, not some innocent cuddling."*

He's not sure which option is worse for his sanity.

The thought of enduring Mydei's proximity *this close* is both a blessing and a curse.

"Long day," his roommate groans, voice muffling into the soft fabric of the purple shorts he's resting his head on. "Customers were more demanding than usual," the sound vibrates through Phainon's skin and all the way to his heart, and other places. Places he absolutely doesn't want reacting with his crush's face so close to them.

After all, this proximity is new to him. Well, not *new-new*. They sort of cuddled this past week, and before then: Resting heads on shoulders while watching who-cares-what on TV, and exchanged a few lingering hugs too… But that was before Phainon almost kissed him in a surge of alcohol-induced stupidity.

Now, the feeling of Mydei's warm face pressing barely a few centimeters from his crotch makes him wish the couch cushions could swallow him and make him disappear, mostly because he cannot get up and run away if his body reacts to the proximity, and he already embarrassed himself enough with last night's kiss.

So, Phainon tries, *really* tries, to be normal about it and not end up like that one time Mydeimos rested his legs on his lap. He tries to breathe like a regular human being and reminds himself that Mydei using his lap as his personal cushion doesn't have to mean anything except *"work sucked"* and *"it's been a long day,"* like Mydei himself said.

And to his surprise, he's doing quite a good job; breathing evenly, not looking directly at the man resting on his thighs, focusing on literally anything else in the room like the screen of his paused game.

But then Mydei moves.

The blonde rolls over, hands leaving his waist, only to press the back of his head even closer to his ever-traitorous and eager dick, oblivious as ever to the turmoil he causes Phainon.

"Want to watch Strife's Kitchen? There's a new episode." He asks, already switching the channel from the console to the streaming site as if he knows Phainon wouldn't refuse, to which Phainon nods a weak "yeah, sure."

Perhaps focusing on people crying over burnt food would distract him enough from the warmth of his crush's palm resting right above his bare knee, kneading the bare skin subconsciously and sending tiny sparks of desire down Phainon's body.

He can't focus on the episode at all.

Not because the cooking show doesn't provide enough distraction, but because there is a certain blonde in his lap that keeps shifting every few seconds.

Phainon manages to preserve his dignity for about ten minutes, until Mydei moves again and presses too close to where he absolutely *shouldn't*, and the sudden pressure sends heat rushing down Phainon's body so fast it should qualify as a medical emergency.

"Oh no," He tries taking a deep breath, feeling his choker constrict when he swallows. *"Oh no no no."*

He can feel it. The slow, agonizingly inevitable way his body reacts. His cock fills up quick enough to leave him dizzy, tenting his pants and straining against the thin cotton of his shorts with absolutely zero shame, impossible to hide. And Mydei's head is right there. If he turns his head even slightly, he would feel it.

This cannot be happening. Not again. Not like this.

Phainon fixes his glasses for the umpteenth time, just to have something to do with his suddenly clammy hands.

And then the bastard moves again.

"You good there?" Mydei asks, tilting his head enough to glance up and *almost* press at the hardness between Phainon's legs. His eyes look like molten gold with the TV's glow, half-lidded and too amused for someone who is supposed to be tired from a long day at work. "You're fidgeting a lot."

Good? *Good*?

Phainon is about two seconds away from combusting. Three if he stops looking at the handsome features of his crush's face.

"I'm great," he lies openly. "Fantastic. Perfect. The best day of my life." He's sure the blonde is going to point out his obvious erection any moment now, and he'd be dying from mortification at how hard he is from something as simple as having Mydei resting on his lap.

"If you say so," Phainon swears he sees Mydei's lips twitch back into a smirk, and then he shifts again, making things so much worse, because he nuzzles. He nuzzles into Phainon's thigh in a deliberate, catlike motion, the palm that stopped moving on his knees is now tracing patterns across the bare skin while Mydei focuses back on the TV show.

Like he's not doing anything.

Like Phainon isn't fighting for dear life.

He bites the inside of his cheek until he tastes the coppery tang of blood, every muscle locking in place to keep from thrusting his hips out of pure instinct. The contestant on the TV is searing something with a blowtorch, and Phainon stares at the flames like they it's the most interesting thing he'd ever seen in a miserable attempt to focus on anything but the constant throbbing between his legs.

Phainon isn't sure how much time passes, except that it feels like an eternity, brought back from the desperate state of hyper focusing on the screen when Mydei speaks again, "Phainon," he murmurs, and Phainon can feel his lips against the fabric of his shorts, "you're surprisingly quiet."

He swears he can *feel* Mydei's smirk widening. The little shit.

Mydei is planning to kill him, slow and torturous as payback for last night's drunken kiss.

He is going to die, Phainon resigns quietly. He is going to die with a hard-on.

"I'm simply hooked on the cooking to make comments," he manages to say after a long moment, but there's no way Mydei would be buying his excuse, not this time. Phainon is never one to stay quiet and keep commentary to himself when they watch something together.

Sadly, he's right. Mydei doesn't buy it.

The blonde turns his head fully this time, looking at him with eyes that should not be this dark or hungry-looking. Mydei's fingers, which have been tracing patterns on his knee moments ago, move to press a feather-light touch over the straining erection that Phainon has been praying would magically disappear this entire time. His cock pulses, traitorous as ever, begging for more.

"Do you," Mydei pauses, warm amber orbs stare straight into his soul. His thumb presses harder at the outline of his length, dragging along it impossibly slow, and Phainon has to bite the inside of his cheek harder to stop himself from moaning at the—too perfect—touch.

“Want me to take care of this?”

Phainon freezes. His lungs forget their job. His brain bluescreens. He stares at the man in his lap opens his mouth, closes it, and opens again, knowing he possibly looks like a fish out of water.

Mydei’s smirk widens, waiting. The offering hangs in the air, heavier than any dumbbell he ever lifted, and Mydei keeps looking at him with his usual calmness, waiting for a response Phainon is not even sure he can muster; his brain fails to register anything that isn’t his heart trying to escape his ribcage.

“I—”

“You?” Mydei looks at him, then at the very visible tent in his pants, then at him again.

On the TV, A judge is yelling about a contestant needing to speak up, and all Phainon can think is that the universe has a cruel sense of humor.

“Iwanttoandilikeyousomuchbutidontdeservethis.”

It’s barely English – a slurred, panicked confession smashed into one sentence, but the cat is out of the bag now, and Phainon is pretty sure he just broke the world record for the most embarrassing confession ever or something.

Because who in their right mind would confess their feelings when their crush is offering them a handjob!?

Mydei blinks once, slowly, then snickers in disbelief, the kind of laugh that makes Phainon’s skin heat with shame, and possibly more arousal. Mydei should stop looking so effortlessly hot.

“You what?”

Phainon squeezes his eyes shut, feeling his glasses slide down his nose ever so slightly. “You heard me.”

“Say it again.”

“No.”

Mydei sits up, urging Phainon to spread his legs as he kneels between them unceremoniously, one hand hovering at the waistband of his shorts, nails grazing lightly at the trail of white hair right above it.

“Repeat it,” Mydei orders, quieter this time, with an authoritative edge that makes Phainon’s stomach drop and cock twitch. “Or I’ll walk away.”

“Don’t—” the last thing he wants is for Mydei to walk away, to leave him like that, not after offering to finally...

“You don’t know how badly I want this.” Phainon fixes his glasses, reaching to cup Mydei’s cheek, “I like you, ok? More than a friend or anything platonic. And I want it so much, but,” he pauses, sight blurring, tears threatening to spill over.

This isn’t how he wanted to confess. He wanted it to be sweet, romantic, *perfect*.

Not with him crying while Mydei is kneeling between his legs, about to get him off. He closes his eyes, feeling both desperation and frustration simmer inside him, “but I don’t deserve this. I was an ignorant fool in denial and I hurt you and—”

“Phainon,” Mydei interrupts him.

He opens his eyes slowly, looking down.

“You’re overthinking.”

“I’m not!”

“You are.” Mydei retorts. “But at least we can agree on you being a fool in denial. Took you too long to realize your feelings.” He adds, saying it like it’s the simplest thing in the world.

He says it so casually that it takes Phainon's brain a few seconds to reboot. "You *knew*? You knew I was panicking about liking you and you…"

Mydei hums, resting his cheek on Phainon's thigh, looking entirely too smug. "Suspected it when you started cooking breakfasts and growled at the guy ogling at me in the gym. Last night's drunken confession confirmed it."

Phainon wants to disappear. Not only did he kiss Mydei, but he also confessed!? "Oh my god."

"And it's mutual."

So much for rebooting his brain. He can feel it crash again in real time. "Wait. What?"

"I like you too, idiot," Mydei explains, matter-of-factly as if he's talking about the weather and not his feelings.

For a long moment, Phainon only stares at him, dumbfounded: mouth open, eyes wide and unblinking. The world narrows down to the sound of Mydei's voice, to the warmth of his cheek on his thigh, the *"I like you too"* he just said, composed and confident while Phainon's entire world crashes down with relief.

"It's mutual. He likes me back!"

"You, you can't just say that like you're commenting on a weather forecast!"

Mydei grins wider. "I can. Because I mean it."

Phainon's next breath comes out shaky, uneven, every thought dissolving into static. "I, what do I even—" he's not sure what he's trying to say at this point, and before his ability to think returns to him, Mydei moves.

He lifts himself effortlessly, curling a finger under Phainon's choker, and pulls him forward, lips pressing right at the corner of his mouth in a chaste kiss, a small payback that sends Phainon's mind into yet another reboot cycle.

“Do me a favor,” Mydei whispers, pressing another kiss at the other side of his mouth, avoiding his lips on purpose. Bastard. “Stop trying to deserve things. If you want something – say it.”

Phainon blinks a few times, allowing the words to sink in, and swallows hard, throat bobbing against Mydei’s fingers, the ones still holding his choker like a leash. “I-I want this, I want you.” He whispers, sheepish and embarrassed all of a sudden, “and I want you to… help me out,” redness spreads all the way to his neck at the request, “if the offer still stands.”

“The offer stands.” Mydei’s gaze drops down briefly before flicking back up. That dangerous smirk from earlier returns to his lips as he leans closer, whispering right into Phainon’s ear, “I've been wanting to pin you down and ride you for months. Ever since the day I saw how hard you got from looking at my ass.”

Phainon can feel himself pulse almost painfully at the thought of Mydei fucking himself on his cock, taking what he’s been wanting. Such dirty words should not get him instantly hard again, but they do.

He really is a pervert after all.

He’s pretty sure his face must be as red as those tattoos on his lover’s body by now— he feels giddy for calling Mydei his lover— yet he can’t look away from the man’s beautiful face, not when he sees equal desire in those golden eyes.

Mydeimos is as much of a pervert, he decides.

“Allow me then?” Mydei kneels back between Phainon’s spread thighs, fingers return to tease at the trail of hair right above his waistline.

Phainon nods, trying to brace himself for what’s about to come. He is finally about to experience his first sexual act, with *Mydei* nonetheless. He can die now and he’d die a happy man. Well, not now-now, the gods are merciful, right? They can take him after he gets to experience the softness of Mydei’s palm on him.

The blonde hooks his fingers into the waistband the same way he hooked them around his choker, and pulls the fabric down. And down. And lower still. Until Phainon's cock springs out of its confines, eager for attention - hard, flushed at the tip, and already beading with precum.

"Damn, you're impressive. Bigger than I thought." Mydei's eyes widen as he stares at the sizeable length, and Phainon chokes on air, twitching pathetically. He never thought he was big or *impressive*, as his lover calls it, but he's definitely enjoying the praise.

"So impressive I'm willing to pretend I didn't notice that color-crime you call an outfit." Mydei teases, and Phainon is about to retort, say something about how it's not the time to bring his fashion, but all words die on his tongue, becoming a broken moan as Mydei closes his palm around his cock; right below the sensitive head.

He gives him a few small squeezes, like he's testing how much pressure it takes to ruin Phainon—not a lot, apparently— because his hips buck into the touch immediately, followed by a quiet whimper. It's soft, Mydei's palm, much softer than his own, and although the pressure is barely there at first, every nerve in Phainon's body lights up like a live wire.

"Really? You-you're gonna bring up my clothes now? When I'm— fuck, when your hand is on my dick," letting out a shaky laugh once he remembers how to speak, Phainon closes his eyes, too afraid he'd come on the spot if he looks down at the blonde.

The touch is already overwhelming as is, leaving him the most vulnerable he has ever been: completely at someone else's mercy. The last thing he wants is to embarrass himself more than he already did in the past hour and come too soon.

"You're twitching a lot," Mydei murmurs with warmth and amusement alike, applying more pressure to the touch. His fingers slide to press at the base, deliberately, like he's savoring the heat, or the heaviness of Phainon's cock in his palm. "Cute."

Phainon would protest, he would absolutely protest, because he's anything but *cute*; he's masculine, manly, handsome… not cute. But the first upward stroke knocks every syllable out of him, again.

Mydei's smile curves wider, sinful and knowing.

"Enjoying this so much already?"

"Mydei!" It comes out as a whine, unsure what he's begging for.

"Look at me, Phainon." Mydei encourages, and like the lovestruck fool he is, Phainon does. He's met with his lover's pretty face, looking up at him from between his thighs, face too close to his cock, and Phainon's entire brain bluescreens for the second time.

He can't think. Can't breathe. Can only watch as Mydei leans down and drags his tongue, slow and unhurried, along the entire length, maintaining eye contact the entire time.

Phainon chokes on a gasp.

It's embarrassingly high-pitched.

He never, *never*, thought he'd feel Mydei's mouth on him.

He imagined it, of course. Fantasized about it as he fucked into his fist in the shower that day, and maybe a few more times after... But those fantasies hold nothing on the pure heat of Mydei's tongue sliding up a throbbing vein, to those soft lips mouthing at the base where his cock ends and balls start, nose nuzzling against snow-white curls.

"Oh fuck! Mydei!"

A hum vibrates against his skin, and Phainon almost ascends right then and there.

Pleased with the reaction, Mydei takes his time worshipping Phainon's cock, meticulous in the same way he is with everything he does— he licks at the underside, mouthing at the veins along the shaft, lapping at the slit,

then flattening his tongue and dragging it slowly, so slowly, all the way back to the base. Phainon's thighs twitch in with every movement, hips thrusting forward. He bites on his knuckle and whines, glasses sliding almost completely down his nose.

"Mydei, please!" He's not sure what he's pleading for. More? Too much? Both? "Please, I-I can't…"

Mydei pauses only to look up at him, thumb pressing around the drooling tip, smearing precum in slow circles that make Phainon's vision go white at the edges.

"Begging already?" he chuckles. "It almost sounds like you never been sucked before."

"I—" Phainon swallows, throat tight. He hadn't. Shame suddenly floods through him in a painful reminder that he's a failure. A failure who never got beyond making out with anyone throughout all his twenty-seven years of existence.

"It's my first time," he admits quietly, wincing at the sound of the words leaving his mouth.

Tears well up in his eyes and he braces himself for the inevitable rejection, same as every girl did once he admitted he's a pathetic virgin. Phainon's shoulders tense, eyes scrunched tight, waiting for Mydei to stand up, to walk away and tell him it's not going to work out...

"I see." Mydei hums, but instead of getting up or leaving the room he gives Phainon's thigh a reassuring squeeze.

"Open your eyes, please." He asks quietly, and when Phainon does, there's no disgust or judgment in the man's eyes.

Mydei doesn't look at him like he's a loser, or pathetic, or anything demeaning. He looks at him with so much warmth and adoration instead, like knowing he's Phainon's first is the biggest compliment he could ever receive.

“I'm flattered,” his lover smiles, giving his hip a quick kiss, adding, “that you want me to be your first.”

Phainon wants to cry for a whole different reason now. Mydei still wants him despite his clear lack of experience. He can hardly believe it.

As if sensing his self-doubt, Mydei gives him one stern look and resumes his earlier ministrations— leaning in to give the tip a slow, deliberate lick, eliciting a high-pitched whine in the process as Phainon’s erection strains back into full mast under the attention.

“I want to make you feel good, will you allow me?”

“P-please.” Every part of Phainon feels drawn too tight, like a bowstring second away from snapping. His thighs tremble helplessly, cock pulsing so hard it hurts and leaking steadily under Mydei’s attention.

“It’s hot when you try holding back” the blonde murmurs with a mischievous glint in his eyes and finally, *finally*, stops teasing him. He tucks a strand of hair behind his ear, lips parting as he wraps them around Phainon’s hardness. “Mydei! Oh god!” Phainon is gone. Ruined. Driven mad with desire.

It’s barely anything further than the head, but the heat is like nothing he had experienced before, nor is the wetness, or the way Mydei’s tongue presses at the slit, or the way he hums in satisfaction as if he’s the one experiencing a mind-blowing—

Phainon’s hands fly to hold Mydei’s shoulders, body hunching forward.

He comes with a broken cry. Pleasure crashes over him too fast, too intense, like all his nerves are collapsing simultaneously. His vision blacks out, breath coming out ragged and uneven, glasses sliding all the way off his face and down to the couch as he spills messily against Mydei’s tongue, his lips, his cheek.

Mydei pulls back in surprise, blinking through it, a smear of cum painting the sharp line of his cheekbone. He wipes it off with his thumb, licking the

finger clean with no shame, like it’s the best compliment he's ever gotten.

Phainon floats somewhere between euphoria and reality for a long minute. His chest rises and falls heavily, hips trembling in aftershocks, cock still twitching with remnants of pleasure. He’s glowing, basking in the aftermath of his orgasm…

And then realization hits.

His eyes snap wide, breath stuttering. The bliss evaporates in an instant, replaced by shame, crawling up his neck.

“Oh my—shit. Mydei, I didn’t, I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to—" Phainon’s voice cracks, mortified by how quickly he came. He buries his face in his hands, already wishing for those gods from earlier to take him right then and there. “I’m so so sorry.”

A warm hand curls around his wrist, tugging one hand away from his face, then the other.

“Hey,” Mydei puts the gasses back on his face and cups his cheek lovingly, “there’s nothing to be embarrassed about.”

Phainon’s breath stutters, at loss for words. What kind of lottery did he win to have such a sweet lover is beyond him.

“Besides,” Mydei smiles, amused as he looks between them, “You’re still hard, so we’re not done yet.”

He is, Phainon realizes once he lowers his eyes and looks at himself through his now smudged glasses. His cock lies hard and proud against his lower stomach, twitching weakly for attention, and before he can protest or say anything, Mydei is leaning in again, lips trailing along the oversensitive length.

“Wait! I’m still-!”

“Shh, I’ve got you.” The blonde hums and lowers his head, wrapping his mouth around the tip, then past it, and further, mouth sealing around

Phainon’s cock until half of him is engulfed in perfect heat.

“Holy fuck.”

Phainon’s vision whites out, hands flying to hold onto something, anything, landing on Mydei’s hair and tugging harshly on the blonde-red locks by accident. Heavens, he didn’t mean to do that, didn’t mean to pull Mydei’s hair so hard, but his lover only moans around his cock in approval, and Phainon thinks he got impossibly harder from hearing that.

Mydei sets a pace that under normal circumstances would be considered slow or sensual, but Phainon is too far gone from his earlier orgasm and still bordering on over-sensitivity.

Every drag of Mydei’s tongue shoots through his spine like fireworks, every suck eliciting unrestrained moans from him. It feels obscene. Like nothing he ever allowed himself to imagine, but here he is: half-sitting - half-lying on the couch, with the man he’s been crushing on for weeks between his legs. Mydei sinks his mouth a little deeper on his cock, tongue pressing along the underside in ways that make Phainon’s toes curl.

His glasses slide down again, and he pushes them up with trembling fingers, barely managing to lift them to his nose before Mydei pulls back just enough to breathe and speak.

“You’re good there?” The blonde murmurs, voice huskier than usual, thumb stroking the drooling tip, making Phainon’s hips jerk helplessly.

“I, yes. No. I don’t, fuck, I can’t—” Phainon’s voice breaks into a whimper he’d be mortified about if he was capable of embarrassment right now, but he isn’t, not when Mydei is taking him in his mouth again, hand pumping what he can’t fit.

His back arches off the couch, mouth falling open in a plea, a prayer, something incoherent that sounds like ‘Mydeimos’ as he feels the tip of his cock kiss the back of his lover’s throat every time Mydei bobs his head.

“Please,” He gasps, hands gripping onto the couch for dear life, hips bucking into the heat of Mydei’s mouth, unable to stop himself even when the man glares at him through wet lashes and presses on his thigh to stop him from thrusting. “Please, please! Don’t stop, don’t—please!”

He can feel his second orgasm building fast, embarrassingly so, pressure tightening low in his stomach. Phainon wants to chase it, wants to thrust deeper, but he’s completely at the mercy of Mydei, who is hollowing his cheeks with each suck, who is taking him deeper and deeper, until his nose presses into the soft white curls.

Phainon tries to warn him, tries to say something that makes sense, but all that comes out is a desperate, broken, “Mydei! I’m gonna, god, I’m—”

His lover hums in acknowledgment and swallows around him.

That’s all it takes.

Phainon’s orgasm crashes over him violently, so intense he screams, or so he thinks. He can hardly process what's happening, can hardly process anything except the bliss flooding through his system.

He’s pretty sure he died and this is what heaven feels like.

It’s only when his soul partially returns to his body, and pleasure teethers on pain, that Mydei pulls off with a wet pop, wiping the string of saliva connecting them, and smirks, satisfied at Phainon’s disheveled state. At least that’s what he thinks he sees through his blurred vision.

The blonde tucks him back into the shorts, fixing the glasses back on Phainon’s nose, and leans to whisper against his lips.

“Felt good, didn’t it?”

Phainon lets out an embarrassingly high-pitched whimper in response. He can’t speak, can barely remember how to. It’s near impossible to try remembering anything at all when Mydei’s lips are barely a few centimeters

from his, red and swollen, and he straddles Phainon's lap like it's his personal seat.

His hands fly to rest on Mydei's waist, to ground himself more than anything as his lover leans forward, hands pressing on the back of the couch, and kisses him.

It's filthy.

In the best way possible.

Mydei kisses him with hunger, like he wants to consume him, and Phainon parts his lips, letting himself be devoured. He can taste his cum on Mydei's tongue, warm and a little bitter and dizzying—does that mean that Mydei *swallowed*? —It should be too much, too obscene, but instead it sends a shiver down his spine.

He shouldn't like this. He shouldn't like this nearly as much as he does.

But God help him, he does.

Phainon kisses him back with every last bit of energy he has left, mind still floating somewhere above his own body because his first blowjob, his actual first real sexual encounter, was nothing like he had imagined. It was so much better, and more importantly, it was done by the man he loves.

He's blissed out of his mind, drunk on the taste of them mixed together and hungover with pleasure, when Mydei shifts forward a little, subconsciously, thrusting his hips shallowly, and Phainon feels it.

Mydei is still hard.

He feels like a bucket of cold water was poured on him.

Why is Mydei— why is he still untouched? Why did Phainon get two mind-blowing orgasms while Mydei is sitting here, searching for friction against his thigh, breathing unevenly, and all Phainon does is bask in his post orgasmic bliss instead of returning the favor.

What kind of a terrible boyfriend is he?

“Mydei,” he whispers, breathless. “You’re…why are you…?”

The blonde stills at the sound of his name, clouded molten-gold eyes meeting Phainon’s baby blue ones, following Phainon’s line of sight to his own tended pants.

“Don’t mind it,” he dismisses. “I’ll take care of that later. We’re here for you, not for me.”

It hits Phainon like a well-aimed punch because Mydei says it like he means it. Well, Mydei says *everything* like he means it, but that’s not the point. The point is that Mydei sounds like he truly doesn’t expect anything in return, planning to use his own hand later like his pleasure doesn’t matter. It hurts in a way Phainon didn’t expect.

He feels his stomach twist.

“Why would it only be about me?” he sulks, reaching out with a shaky hand to hold Mydei’s cheek, searching for his gaze.

Mydei gives a small, tired smile that doesn’t reach his eyes, but doesn’t answer back, averting his face away instead.

“No,” Phainon shakes his head, tracing slow circles over the man’s cheek in a silent plea for him to look back. “I want to make you feel good too, Mydeimos, please?”

Mydei’s gaze returns to him, eyes wide not in surprise, but in something closer to relief. “Are you sure?”

“I am.” Phainon interrupts, firm and final before his lover says anything else. “I do. And you said you wanted it too earlier. So let me... Teach me how to make you feel good.”

He swears he can see the tension dissolve from Mydei’s body in real time, like his last bit of hesitation, or whatever was holding him back is finally gone. The blonde nods once, pressing their foreheads together.

“Okay.”

Determined, Phainon’s fingers find the zipper of Mydei’s slacks, fumbling with it at first and groaning at the bothersome thing, but Mydei only lets out a fond huff, tilting his hips forward to help.

“Easy there,” he murmurs, and the comment alone makes Phainon blush so hard he feels the heat burning his ears.

“I’m trying,” Phainon mutters back, unzipping the slacks successfully on his second try.

Hesitant about what to do next, he slips his hand in the pants and cups Mydei’s erection through his underwear— gasping as he feels his lover twitch at the contact and groan next to his ear.

It’s new, terrifying in a way, but it’s also Mydei, and he so desperately doesn’t want to mess this up.

“Like this,” Mydei whispers, resting his head on Phainon’s shoulder, teeth nibbling at the clothed skin. “Start like this. Yes, you can apply more pressure.”

Phainon strokes him through the thin fabric, fingers mapping the shape of him clumsily, lack of experience evident in every motion. But at least it seems like he’s doing a decent job. Mydei’s hips buck into his palm with each stroke; it’s shallow, but enough to tell he’s enjoying it.

“That’s it,” the blonde breathes out. “A little tighter, but not too much—”

Phainon bites his lip, cheeks flushing scarlet at how wrecked Mydei sounds already, and adjusts his grip as he’s told. The reaction is immediate. Mydei bites back a loud groan, turning his head to mouth at the sun-shaped tattoo on the side of Phainon’s neck, the one covered mostly by his choker.

“Keep going,” he murmurs, sounding more breathless with each passing second. “Feels good.”

But it's not enough for Phainon. He wants, no, he *needs* to see how hard Mydei is for him, because of him. His desire takes over and he’s sliding the slacks lower, together with his underwear, until he frees Mydei’s cock from the tight confines.

Phainon stares, shamelessly, admiring his lover’s cock the same way he admires everything about Mydei: he’s quite thick, with a prominent vein near the base and a well-trimmed patch of blonde hair surrounding it, the head is flushed beautifully and beading precum Phainon wishes to taste.

Truly as beautiful as the rest of him.

Wrapping his fingers properly this time, Phainon gives the length a few pumps, gathering the precum to make the glide of his palm easier.

Mydei’s entire body jolts.

“Fuck. Phainon. Slow down,” he gasps, hands gripping tightly into the fabric of Phainon’s orange shirt. “Shit, you’re… Fuck—”

Slowing down as told, Phainon strokes him with less force, studying every hitch of Mydei’s breath, every shiver along his spine, adjusting the rhythm and pressure until he finds a pace that makes Mydei moan into the crook of his neck.

“Like that?” He asks, entranced at the way his hand moves on his lover’s cock. It’s new, touching another man, yet the sight is so erotic he feels himself twitching weakly in response.

“Yeah, like that,” Mydei nods against his shoulder, breath catching on every upward stroke, more so once Phainon learns how sensitive he is around the head and makes good use of this newly gained knowledge.

“Don’t stop.”

Phainon doesn’t. He can’t, won’t. He wants to see Mydei fall apart, needs to know what he looks like when he comes, to see him in the same kind of bliss he gave him minutes ago.

The blonde trembles, struggling to keep his weight steady as he rocks into Phainon's hand, breath coming faster, rougher. "I'm— I'm not gonna last."

It's the closest to desperation he had ever seen on Mydei. A complete contrast to his normally stoic appearance, and the knowledge that *he* is the one causing it sends Phainon reeling with pride.

"Come, for me," he pleads, increasing the pace. "I want you to come. Please, Mydei."

Mydei lets out a guttural groan, one hand burying itself in Phainon's soft hair as if holding for dear life, the other gripping his shirt so hard Phainon thinks he might rip it. Not that he gives a fuck about his clothes at the moment

"Phainon—fuck." His lover hisses, hips snapping forward one last time, and he comes. Milky ropes spill across Phainon's palm, dripping between his fingers, down his wrist, and onto his lap as Mydei rides the pleasure– head thrown back, mouth open in barely audible moans.

Seeing Mydei so close to losing control like this makes Phainon want to cry again, happily this time.

"Mydei," he whispers, tucking a strand of blond-red hair behind his ear. "I made you come."

"You did," the blonde lifts his head, smiling tiredly at him, brushing his thumb along Phainon's cheek. "And you were perfect."

Phainon swears his heart forgets how to beat at the praise.

Perfect. He was perfect. He made Mydei feel good.

They stay like that for a good while. Mydei slumped against him, boneless as he catches his breath, and Phainon, sitting on the couch, trying to convince his lungs that breathing is, in fact, an essential body function needed to stay alive.

It takes Phainon's brain another minute or so to climb out of his post-first-sexual-experience fog to realize he’s sitting there with cum drying on various parts of his body and clothes like this is a perfectly normal Saturday afternoon.

He can’t hold back the laugh. Chuckling quietly at first, then louder, almost delirious.

Mydei lifts his head to look at him, tilting it in question. And he's so beautiful like this— his hair is a mess, cheeks flushed, eyes half closed but still as sharp as ever.

“What’s so funny?” he asks.

Phainon shakes his head. “We really, fuck,” he laughs again. “We really did this backwards.”

Mydei blinks, “backwards?”

“I was supposed to, I don’t know, take you on a date first? Be romantic. Make you fall for me with one of my pick-up lines.” Phainon pauses, swallowing when Mydei’s expression softens into a smile. “Yet, we kind of started, you know...”

“Your charm does not lie there, Deliverer of bad pick-up lines,” Mydei humph’s back, sitting upright. He lifts his clean hand to adjust Phainon’s glasses, pushing them back up the bridge of his nose with ridiculous care, brushing the skin under his eye before adding, much softer this time, “but I might be falling either way.”

The confession makes Phainon’s heart stumble the same way it did when he saw Mydei for the first time.

“Getting all shy on me now?” the blonde asks, tone painfully neutral for someone who’s definitely smirking on the inside.

“Shut up,” Phainon mutters, which is absolutely not a denial. He doesn’t need to deny his love for Mydei, not anymore.

Although he still wants to make it right.

“Are you free tomorrow?”

“You asking me out properly this time?” Mydei tilts his head again, unable to contain his smirk any longer.

“Isn’t that obvious?” Phainon’s smile is immediate, bright, relieved, before he leans in and kisses him again.

This kiss is different. It’s proper for starters, lips brushing against lips slowly like they’re trying to memorize the shape of each other’s mouths. Phainon melts into it, hands finding Mydei’s waist, pulling him closer until they are pressed flush together.

“I’m free.” Mydei pulls back just enough to speak, breath ghosting Phainon’s face, voice low and warm in a way that has no right to be legal. “And maybe after you take me on an actual date,” he murmurs, “I can teach you more.”

Phainon pauses, processing that sentence like a man whose brain is still unplugged. “Teach me?” he echoes.

Mydei chuckles —quiet, breathy, entirely too fond— and presses a teasing kiss to the corner of his mouth. His fingers curl under Phainon’s choker, guiding his gaze up at him. “I can show you how good proper sex can feel.”

Phainon’s heart jumps to his throat. His hands tighten on Mydei’s waist without him meaning to. Heat flares up his neck and face and ears and *everywhere else*.

But his smile doesn’t break. It just turns shaky and stupid and smitten and so so lovestruck.

“Yeah,” he hides his face in Mydei’s chest, not caring about smudging his glasses again. “I’d really like that.”

Chapter End Notes

Take a shot every time Phainon malfunctions this chapter /j

Chapter 11: It’s Probably Gay, But I’ve Made Up My Mind

Chapter Summary

> Before Phainon can realize what’s happening, Mydei steps closer to him and reaches one hand around his waist, pulling him flush to his chest. His boyfriend is so close he can smell the addicting sweetness of his cologne, see the lines of ink on his face, how long his lashes are, how breathtakingly beautiful Mydeimos is…
>
> He’s too busy staring at the beauty of his boyfriend to notice him leaning closer, fully registering what is happening only when Mydei’s warm breath ghosts against white strands of hair, right next to Phainon’s ear.
>
> “Are you the deep sea?” The blonde murmurs, voice dropping to barely a whisper, “Because I keep getting lost in your eyes.”
>
> Or; Two can play the pick-up line game

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon doesn’t stop smiling for the rest of the evening.

He shouldn’t be, not after almost dying from embarrassment when Mydei noticed he was hard again and called him ‘insatiable,’ and *especially* not after spending over ten minutes cleaning his glasses, making the fatal mistake of fixing them with his soiled hand. Phainon had to learn the hard way how difficult it is to wipe cum from well, everywhere.

But he is still smiling.

After all, how can he not? He just had his first sexual experience, with Mydei nonetheless. He’s glowing. Radiant. Practically floating like a lovesick ghost who died from too much affection; even if it was his dick who got most of said affection. Minor details.

“And now, I’m taking him on a proper date tomorrow,” He nods at himself, proud.

Mydei deserves the world, especially after everything they've been through, and Phainon is going to give him at least a *small portion* of it, mostly because he’s still a little sappy after getting two mind-blowing orgasms. Three if he counts Mydei’s own.

But first, he needs to stop grinning like a lovestruck idiot and actually plan something.

“Okay,” he whispers, unsure why he’s whispering in the privacy of his room. “Okay, I can do this. I planned many dates before. I’m good at thinking.”

Except he isn’t. Not at the moment, not when Mydei occupies all his thoughts: the heat of his mouth, the addicting scent of his cologne, his expression; completely in bliss when Phainon brought him pleasure.

And maybe his taste too, since he’s a little freak who couldn’t hold back from licking some of the drying cum on his wrist the second Mydei got up to clean himself.

“Shit.” His lower half twitches in interest, reminding him he’s getting sidetracked again. Phainon shakes his head until the thought is gone and tries to compose himself, focus, do something productive...

He opens Reddit.

Clicking on the ‘create a post’ button feels like he is about to expose too much, which sounds a bit ironic considering the posts he has written in the past months. He stares at the app for a solid minute, contemplating what to type, sweating, heart thudding in a way that has nothing to do with fear and

everything to do with the fact that Mydei is right beyond the wall, and he wants tomorrow to be perfect for him.

No, Reddit is a mistake.

What Phainon needs is someone who knows Mydei, better than he does, which is impossible if you ask him, hence why he opts for a close second.

Castorice.

She had known Mydei for long enough.

Phainon [17:23]: Hey Cas I need help it’s an emergency

Three seconds pass.

Four.

Five.

Castorice [17:24]: So, how far did you two make it?

Phainon [17:26]: I’m not sharing details about my sex life

Castorice [17:26]: So there is a sex life now. Noted. You two didn’t hold back

Phainon [17:27]: I hate you.

Phainon [17:27]: Anyway, Im taking him on a date tomorrow and I need advice. I know he prefers quieter places for hangouts, but does it also apply for dates?

He watches the three dots signaling Cas’s typing for what feels like hours. How much can she type?

“a lot, she writes novels.” Phainon reminds himself. Hopefully the answer won’t be a novel length.

Castorice [17:35]: You're right, Mydei prefers less crowded places, and it applies for dates too. Ditch bars though as he's not a fan. You'll get bonus points if it has anything to do with art, music, or animals. Cutesy things are a plus too. Although since it's a date don't take him to somewhere you have to stay silent. Think a museum, or a nice park. Intimate but lets you talk.

Phainon [17:37]: You're a lifesaver Cas!

Castorice [17:38]: And now you owe this life saver all the details about this date next time we meet.

Phainon [17:39]: I promise!!!

Castorice [17:41]: Screenshotted :)

He reads her last message, already knowing he'll have to share every embarrassing detail with the lavender-haired girl. But that's a worry for future Phainon.

Phainon of the current moment has some thinking to do.

A museum… A nice park…

He opens the maps application, scrolls through the neighborhood, then downtown, and to the area around the river, when his eyes land on the perfect place.

The aquarium.

His breath catches, smile turning into a giddy laugh. Of course. A place where nothing is loud or overwhelming, where he could walk beside Mydei and enjoy each other's company even with all the people around them, and it covers the cute things and animals too.

There's really no better place for their first *actual* date.

Entering the website and pre-purchasing tickets for early noon, Phainon hesitates only once, wondering for a second if it's not too cliché. It works in movies, sure, but movies are not real life…

He shakes his head again and buys the tickets before his mind starts overthinking.

Phainon spends the rest of the evening researching the area for places to eat after, then digs through his wardrobe to match the perfect outfit, and writes everything down in his phone. The date has to be nothing but perfect after all.

Mydei's knock on his door distracts him about an hour later, and he opens it to the sight of his now-friend with benefits? Lover? More than a roommate? Looking at him with a faint dusting of pink on his cheeks as he tells him he prepared dinner.

"Nothing too fancy," Mydei says as always, but Phainon knows it's going to be divine, and so does his stomach, which growls loudly at the mention of food.

They sit across from each other at the dining table, Plates of—as divine as he expected— Greek-style chicken and lemony potatoes between them, eating in complete silence. It's not an uncomfortable one per se, but not entirely comfortable either, because neither seems to be sure how to act normally when barely an hour ago they were…

Phainon coughs awkwardly. Now is not the time to think about Mydei's perfect hands, or lips, or well, perfect *everything*.

Yet, he cannot help himself and glances at Mydei, who is looking back at him, gold-like eyes starting right into his soul with a warm smile for a long moment before he averts them like nothing happened, returning his attention to the plate, but his ears are pink and he keeps brushing his hair back behind his ear in a nervous habit Phainon never noticed until tonight.

Cute.

Trying to break the silence, and especially the awkwardness, Phainon clears his throat. "So, how was your day?" Smooth. Very smooth. He was not kidding when he told Cyrene he can't seem to manage words properly around this man.

Mydei looks up from his plate, tilting his head in question, expression changing into one of amusement instantly. “Morning wasn’t great, but the afternoon sure made up for it.”

Phainon nearly chokes on a piece of a potato.

“Yeah… it-it was a great afternoon,” he mumbles, face heating to the point where steam might be coming out of his ears every second now.

He ends up stabbing a poor piece of chicken as if it personally offended him, already resigning to the fact that Mydei’s smugness would be the death of him one day. Not that he minds. He’d die a happy man if it’s Mydeimos who kills him, preferably with that absurd body of his…

“Focus.” Phainon scolds his lizard brain.

“Right, before I forget. Be ready tomorrow at ten.”

Mydei tilts his head in question “?”

“I want to take you on a proper date like I said earlier. So, I thought I should give you enough time to hit the gym like you do in the mornings, but if you need more time because you tend to take a while in the shower so I can…” Phainon rambles, trailing off once he realizes he’s not making much sense anymore.

A fond smile tugs at Mydei’s lips. “What a considerate boyfriend.”

Boyfriend.

His brain registers the word, grabs it, trips over it, then rolls down a metaphorical staircase. They haven’t properly confessed yet—blurting out a confession while Mydei had his dick in his hands does not count— they haven’t labeled anything, so to hear Mydei call him his boyfriend so casually, like they’ve been dating for months?

He might need to rearrange the date to the nearest hospital instead, because he’s about to have a heart attack.

A good kind of heart attack.

Phainon swallows, cheeks pink, ears burning. “Trying to be the best boyfriend you ever had,” he forces a shy smile, fingers fiddling with the leather strap around his neck.

“You already are.” Mydei leans across the table, enough to press a quick kiss to his lips. “I’ll be ready at ten.”

Yeah. His heart is not going to make it.

— ◇ —

Sleep is as hard as his lower half was under Mydei’s touch earlier.

Wait, he worded that horribly.

Phainon simply cannot fall asleep. He tries, he really does, but it’s impossible when anticipation has his nerves on edge. He’s giddy, excited, terrified, all of the above. He’s trying, and failing, not to giggle into the pillow every time he thinks of them walking hand in hand and laughing together.

Oh, and if the neighbors below hear him? He didn’t giggle. He’s a grown man, a proper, tax-paying adult, who definitely did not just giggle and kick his feet over his crush like a teenager.

Sleep finally wins over a little past three in the morning, granting him a very pleasant dream of cuddling with his now-boyfriend, which, thankfully did not venture into territories beyond domestic and sweet. Phainon knows he wouldn’t be able to think properly for the rest of the day if his dream was an erotic one.

The gods chose to be merciful. For once.

Practically jumping out of bed, his first stop is a beeline to the bathroom, to style his absolute mess of a bed hair, put contact lenses, and maybe also spend a good twenty minutes trimming his pubic hair, in case Mydei intended to keep his promise and show him more… He almost cuts himself by accident, too distracted by the thought.

Once the reflection looking at him through the bathroom's mirror looks presentable enough, Phainon tracks to the kitchen to grab something edible, then back to his bedroom to dress, wearing the outfit he picked the night before: A black dress shirt, with matching black jeans, and a light brown jacket on top. He gives himself one last look in the mirror to appreciate the successful color combo—

And realizes it's not even nine. There's a whole hour, at the very least, before their date.

Phainon's first attempt to pass the time is by opening one of his favorite games: an idea that sounds great on paper, but is proven to be futile in practice. Instead of doing any missions or events, he stares at his idle character, mind drifting to Mydei.

Would he look as handsome as he looked on the day he went on the date with that gym guy? Would he use the same cologne? Would he allow Phainon to lean in and take a whiff of it right from his pulse point?

Ok, maybe concentrating is too big of a challenge.

He tries listening to music instead, but it feels like time doesn't move fast enough. Tries watching a random video, but he's paying no attention to it, and with each passing minute, Phainon feels more and more restless.

"This is ridiculous," he scolds himself. *"It's just a date! With your maybe-boyfriend, who also called you his boyfriend. Okay, that wording is not helping."*

Giving up on distractions, he leaves his room and knocks on Mydei's room door.

At 9:30 in the morning.

“Yeah?” Mydei opens the door while tugging down on a black turtle-neck sweater that fits him criminally well, giving Phainon a glimpse of his toned and tattooed abs. This time, Phainon doesn’t hold back, doesn’t need to. So, he stares shamelessly at his lover’s body, at least until Mydei chuckles.

“My eyes are up here.”

“You’re-” Phainon begins, then wisely aborts whatever improper thing was about to leave his mouth. “You’re ready! Great, let’s go.”

It feels like the first meeting all over again.

“Smooth,” Mydei smirks, adjusting a necklace around his neck, and Phainon finds himself staring again, this time at the color of the gem. Blue, like his eyes.

“You’d kill to be between those pecs like this necklace” his mind comments, like anyone asked it for opinions.

“Shut up,” Phainon mutters, both to his ever-unhelpful brain and to Mydei alike.

To his horror, or pleasure, he still hadn’t decided, the blonde’s teasing does not stop during the drive either.

If anything, it seems like Mydei is a lot less restrained around him now, laughing more openly as he jabs at Phainon’s already over-alert nerves. And Phainon likes it. He loves it. Mydei looks much better with a smile on his pretty face.

“You’re taking me to see fish?” the blonde asks as they turn into the parking lot of the Aquarium, eyebrows raised in surprise.

“Maybe the Aquarium wasn’t a good choice?” Phainon’s free hand fiddles with his choker, suddenly rethinking everything.

“Wow, don’t sound too excited.” He groans, trying not to sound too devastated about the lukewarm reaction.

Mydei studies him for a moment that stretches for a little too long, then smiles at him, soft and genuine. “I do like it, before you overthink again,” he says, and the sincerity in his tone makes Phainon stop rethinking his entire life and feel like he made the right decision, for once.

The Aquarium inside is warm and smells like fish, which shouldn’t be surprising, but it does not stop Phainon from having a mini-heart attack from thinking how unromantic it must be. He walks a little closer to Mydei than strictly necessary, hands tucked in his pockets as he tries to look for any sign of discomfort on the blonde’s face, relaxing only when Mydei’s arm links with his, followed by a quiet “You’re overthinking. I told you I like it.”

“I wasn’t!” He retorts, but smiles despite himself.

Mydeimos had always been good at reading him, ever since they moved in together all those months ago… Months he could’ve spent with this beautiful man in his arms instead of denying the attraction.

Heavens above, since when did he get so sappy?

Holding hands—like a proper couple— they walk along the route, pointing at various fish tanks and sharing commentaries between them. Mydei keeps walking close to him, squeezing his hand occasionally to get his attention, and in the reflections of the water tanks, they look no different than any other couple around them.

A wave of uneasiness washes over him with the realization, but he shakes it off before it can fully form. He made his decision. Phainon had decided he didn’t want to be the perfect follower of society’s rules no more, decided that he’d rewrite everything he had been taught about since childhood for the man in front of him.

For them.

He suddenly feels like confessing his love, again, right there in front of everyone.

“Mydei I…” he drifts off, realizing it’s a stupid idea. He can’t keep making confessions at weird moments. “I’m going to grab something to drink, want anything?” Phainon points at the vending machines instead. Hopefully stepping away for a second would help him compose himself and his nerves.

“Water is fine, thank you.” Mydei lets go of his hand, and Phainon beelines to the direction of the machine.

“Get your shit together man,” he scolds himself. *“It’s Mydei. The same Mydei you spent months around and feel comfortable with. Don’t make a fool of yourself simply because it’s an official date.”*

The pep talk helps, for the most part. Phainon feels a little more relaxed and returns to where he left Mydei with two bottles in hand, only to see a woman standing in front of his boyfriend.

And from the little he overhears; he doesn’t like where it’s going.

“Are you… I mean, it looks like you’re here alone? Maybe you want to walk around together? Or we can leave this place and have some coffee?"

Phainon doesn’t think for once, instinct taking over faster this time. He steps forward and grabs Mydei’s arm with his free hand, fingers threading through his like it’s the most natural thing in the world.

“Sorry it took me so long!” Phainon presses a quick kiss to Mydei’s cheek, surprised at his own bold display of affection, all while eyeing the woman with annoyance.

“Oh, um,” She stutters under his gaze, but Phainon has had enough.

“He’s taken. Stop disturbing our date.” He hisses at her through his smile, the venom of his words evident despite the cheerful facade. Next to him,

Mydei’s breath hitches, like he is just as surprised by Phainon’s possessiveness.

“I’m so sorry,” the woman apologizes quickly. “I didn’t think you were taken, my mistake.”

“It’s okay,” Mydei answers, still looking at Phainon rather than at her. “No harm done.”

The woman nods, murmurs another apology Phainon pays no mind to, and disappears into the flow of visitors.

Mydei’s warm hand squeezing his own brings Phainon to look at his boyfriend, suddenly aware of how he was acting like a territorial dog. He expects to see smugness, a teasing glint, or maybe get scolded by the blonde, but instead, Mydei looks at him with nothing but fondness.

“Didn’t know my boyfriend was so territorial,” the blonde muses, thumb brushing over Phainon’s knuckles, cheeks pink; unless it’s the lighting playing tricks on his eyes.

“Haha… Sorry about that.”

“Don’t be, you didn’t hesitate at all.” Mydei leans closer, bumping their shoulders together. His grip around Phainon’s palm tightens as he smiles softly.

“I didn’t want to,” Phainon admits, “I’ve made up my mind, about us.”

“That was very hot of you.”

Fuck.

His ears burn under the praise.

“You shouldn’t—” Phainon almost whimpers, stopping himself in the last second. They are still in public, and the last thing he wants is to pop a boner, no matter how difficult it is not to when his boyfriend says things like *that*.

Who is the shameless one now!?

“So, um,” his laugh is a little high pitched and breathless, and he’s chugging the entire bottle in one go just to distract himself. Phainon really needs to change the topic.

“Since we're on an official date, mind letting me try a pick-up line?”

Mydei blinks in confusion, but it seems to do the trick. Crisis averted. “Do I have a choice?”

“Nope.” Phainon lets a wide grin tug at his mouth and taps his chin in thought for a moment.

“Are you a fisherman? Because you’ve caught me in your net.”

For a split second, nothing happens. Then, Mydei huffs a quiet laugh, then a louder one, and louder until he has to cover his mouth to muffle himself.

“That’s awful,” he complains, shoulders still shaking with suppressed laughter. “Seriously awful.”

“Hey! I thought really hard about this one!” Phainon fakes being hurt, nudging him lightly with his elbow, “Unless you think you can do better?”

“You bet.”

Before Phainon can realize what’s happening, Mydei steps closer to him and reaches one hand around his waist—pulling him flush to his chest and making him feel hyperaware of their proximity. Mydei is so close he can smell the addicting sweetness of his cologne, see the lines of ink on his face, how long his lashes are, how breathtakingly beautiful Mydeimos is…

He’s too busy staring at the beauty of his boyfriend to notice him leaning closer, fully registering what is happening only when Mydei’s warm breath ghosts against white strands of hair, right next to Phainon’s ear.

“Are you the deep sea?” The blonde murmurs, voice dropping to barely a whisper, “Because I keep getting lost in your eyes.”

Crisis *not* averted.

“This should be illegal. There should be warning labels on this man.”

Heat shoots up Phainon’s spine, spreading so fast he can feel his ears, neck, face, every single inch of him burning. He looks away from the mane of blonde-red hair, and at their reflection on the fish tank beside them—painfully aware that his face matches the bright red corals inside it.

“That’s,” he clears his throat, “You can’t say things like that.”

“I can” Mydei replies, withdrawing enough to meet his eyes, soft amber orbs glinting in amusement, “if I want to.”

And the worst part is that Mydei says it so calmly, so matter-of-fact, like he isn’t aware of the way he makes Phainon completely malfunction every single time. Except he is. Mydeimos definitely knows what he’s doing based on the smug expression he’s wearing.

Mydei’s hand presses a little firmer at Phainon’s back before slipping away like nothing happened, the ghost of the touch lingers long after like a brand.

One quick bathroom break later, mostly so Phainon can calm himself down from the back-to-back heart attacks, they continue walking to the next exhibit, though Phainon feels more like he’s floating rather than walking.

Still, he forces himself to focus on the next fish tank, one that has a variety of small fish swimming lazily inside, and he notices Mydei looking at the fish inside with amusement. The blonde taps the glass lightly once Phainon catches up, pointing at a slow-moving blue fish drifting past, its head is bright yellow, slowly merging into a shade of blue through the body.

“There,” he says, the amused smile from seconds ago turning mischievous, bratty. “That one looks like you.”

Phainon looks at him, baffled. “Excuse me?”

Of all the things he expected to be compared to on this date, *“round fish with a bad color palette”* was not on the list.

“Wide eyes,” Mydei explains, “horrible color combination...” He emphasizes each point by lifting a finger. “And,” he leans closer to read the fish’s name, “it’s called ‘*Tropheops Red Cheek.’* The red cheek part matches too.”

“You brat!” Phainon groans, he tries to look offended, but it’s hard to be when his so-called boyfriend is smiling like that, and he kind of wants to kiss him senseless instead.

“I’m way more handsome than whatever this—” he points at the fish accusingly, “this thing is!”

“I think it has a unique charm, another similar point.”

Phainon sags his shoulders in defeat, bumping his forehead against Mydei’s chest, huffing. “I hate you.”

“No, you don’t.”

Mydei gives him a light pat on his head, stepping aside to the next tank, and when Phainon finally lifts his head, the comeback he worked so hard to think of dies on his tongue. Mydeimos, his boyfriend, is washed by the soft blue glow of the tank—his golden eyes look like amethysts instead of their usual molten gold shade, his sharp features softened by the hue.

The man looks ethereal, and all Phainon does is stand there, forgetting how to breathe, completely mesmerized.

“You idiot. Why did you deny your feelings for so long?”

It hits Phainon like a well-aimed punch. How stupid he’s been, how long he spent denying something that was obvious from the start. How much turmoil he put himself and Mydei just because he was scared of some stupid social standards.

He looks away again before Mydei can catch him staring, pretending to study the movement of the fish, hoping the sound of people around them is loud enough to mask how loud his heart is beating.

God. He really wants to step closer and kiss him right now.

He steps closer and presses another peck on Mydei's cheek. That should be enough for now.

"What's that for?" Mydei rests his head against Phainon's shoulder, acting shy all of a sudden.

"Adorable." Phainon wraps a hand around his boyfriend's waist, giving the clothed muscle a quick squeeze.

"Just felt like it."

They part, albeit reluctantly, and move on to the jellyfish hall next, watching with interest as the creatures float around, unbothered by life, by thoughts, by… anything really. What a great life.

"You really like these," Phainon points out, taking a quick pause from reading the signs containing fun facts about the jellyfish.

"They're relaxing," Mydei answers, quietly, like he's sharing a secret.

"So are you," Phainon blurts, brain-to-mouth filter gone.

Mydei turns to him, head tilting sideways in question. "You really think so?"

"I do."

His mouth wants to keep going, *"you're relaxing, and unfairly pretty, and the reason for my gay awakening,"* but he clamps his teeth down on that before it escapes.

"You are too. Surprisingly." The blonde admits, and Phainon is unsure if it's a blush he sees on Mydei's cheeks or the lighting from the tank.

"Surprisingly?" He repeats.

"You talk a lot" Mydei hums, "but it's calming."

Phainon feels something inside him melt at the rare show of verbal affection, warmth spreading through him in an inevitable way he desperately hopes doesn't show on his face, but the gentle press of Mydei's hand at the small of his back says otherwise— says Mydei knows exactly what he's doing, and exactly what effect his words have.

They walk throughout the rest of the exhibitions like that; quieter, slower, holding each other close. feels different from all the times Mydei had been tactile with him, perhaps because they are in public this time, or on a date. And on any other day, Phainon would be teasing Mydei mercilessly for showing affection publicly, but the blonde holds him with so much tenderness that Phainon can't remember the last time he felt this loved.

He briefly wonders if that's how Mydei felt back then, when Phainon returned his affection, and they cuddled on the couch. Did Mydei feel loved? Cherished? The thought feels welcomed and unwelcome all alike, mostly because he knows what his stupid self did next, and how much it must've hurt.

"You want to walk through the garden for a bit?" Mydei asks the moment they exit the building, bringing his train of thought to a halt.

Phainon nods.

It's surprisingly warm for the late fall day as Phainon follows closely behind Mydei, eyes not leaving the blonde man, finding it adorable how his roommate—no, how his boyfriend—looks so eager to sunbathe. "Like a big cat," he chuckles, catching Mydei's attention.

"Hm?"

"It's nothing, just admiring the view." Phainon smiles.

"You misspelled staring, it's a habit of yours." Mydei points out with a smile of his own.

They stop by an empty bench, one that is pointed at the large fountain in front of them, sitting down side by side, and Phainon's heart skips a beat

when Mydei leans his head on his shoulder, eyes closed. He really looks like a big cat like this.

Adorable.

“That was nice,” he says eventually. “The aquarium.”

“I told you,” Phainon replies, poking his tattooed cheek lightly. “I have impeccable taste.”

Mydei opens one eye and gives him a flat look, shaking his head slightly, “except when it comes to your fashion.”

Phainon chuckles and allows a quiet warmth to settle between them after, allowing him to gather his thoughts before he nudges Mydei to look at him.

“I…” He starts, searching for the right words “I wanted to start by apologizing.”

Mydei sits properly, looking at the fountain rather than at the white-haired man next to him. “About?”

“Everything,” Phainon exhales, long and slow, fingers playing with the edge of his jacket, unsure what to do with his hands. “We talked about it briefly yesterday, but I know I hurt you a lot. I kept pulling back, overthinking everything, ignoring my emotions, and as a result yours too.”

He rubs the back of his neck awkwardly.

“I was afraid, I guess. Of this—” Phainon gestures between them, “of us. I was being stupid, honestly, too caught up in living up to everyone’s expectations I ended up denying myself in the process.”

“You’re not stupid,” Mydei interjects, but allows him to keep talking nonetheless.

“I kind of was,” Phainon insists. “The universe could slap me in the face with an obvious sign and I’d still be like: ‘Hm. That can’t be right…’”

Mydei laughs under his breath, eyes softening as he turns to face him fully.

“It was my sister who opened my eyes. She told me to stop being what everyone expects and just follow what I wanted.” Phainon laughs softly. “I thought she was exaggerating at first, but it seems like it was the eye-opener I needed.”

“She sounds smart.”

“She is, but don’t tell her I said that.”

“No promises.”

The silence that follows is charged; neither of the men looks at the other, each trying to gather their thoughts.

“Frankly, I deserved that punch” Phainon speaks first, eyes searching Mydei’s, “although it hurt like hell. Your fists are no joke.”

The blonde looks at him for a moment that feels longer than it really is. “I apologize for that.”

“I can’t blame you, didn’t believe you’d give me a second chance after that.”

Mydei studies him, steady and unhurried, the same way he does everything. “I didn’t think so either,” he admits at last. “I did not want to get my hopes up again after that day, but something in me still wished for you to make a move.”

Something inside Phainon twists painfully.

No wonder Mydei sent him so many mixed signals, he really got a taste of his own medicine.

“…I’m glad you did, albeit drunkenly.” Mydei’s sharp golden eyes stare directly into Phainon’s soul, making him look away for a second, then back at Mydei’s eyes, watching the sunlight reflect in them so beautifully, the breeze rustling his blonde-red locks.

The sight steals the air from Phainon’s lungs.

“Let me say it again,” Unable to stop the confession from spilling from his lips this time, Phainon leans closer. “I like you, Mydeimos, a lot. No, I think it’s beyond that. I think I love you.”

Mydei doesn’t answer. Instead, he mimics Phainon and leans in too, almost startling him by the sudden proximity. Phainon’s eyes drift to his boyfriend’s lips subconsciously, tongue peeking out to wet his own, and that’s all the confirmation Mydei seems to need. Because not even a moment later, he feels the blonde’s lips on his.

The kiss is soft at first— a warm and shy brush of lips, but the tension between them snaps quickly and clean, and the second kiss is deeper, firmer, slow but charged. It’s not their first one, not after yesterday, but this one is different. It’s not charged with desire, it’s the kind of kiss that is so full of emotions it makes Phainon forget they’re outside, the time, the world, everything.

“I like you too,” Mydei’s fingers slide into his hair, breaking the kiss to whisper those words between them, and Phainon feels himself melting, heart pounding so loudly he hears it in his ears.

Mydei likes him back.

He likes him back.

Phainon feels lightheaded from hearing those words.

They pull back only when someone in the distance clears their throat, startling them both, and they end up pressing their foreheads together, laughing between them. It’s quiet and soft and so he’s in love he wants to cry. Happy tears, he swears.

“We should… probably go grab lunch.” He pulls back first, even if he doesn’t want to. But the sooner the date ends, the faster he can go back to kissing Mydei senseless in the privacy of their home, or at least the car.

Mydei looks at him with a hungry gaze, eyes trailing back to Phainon’s lips, “Do you really want to?” He asks.

“Not really.”

“Me neither,” Mydei admits, thumb stroking Phainon’s jaw once, slow and deliberate, “we could go home instead.”

The look he gives Phainon as he says those words, so warm and full of intent, makes Phainon thank the heaves he’s sitting, or else his knees would buckle.

“Yes, please.” It's all he manages. Already breathless.



During the short walk from the garden to the car, Phainon tries, and fails, to calm down. His legs feel like jelly, his heart beats too fast to pass as normal, and he feels himself filling up in the lower region at the not-so-subtle implication of Mydei’s words.

He convinces himself he’ll be as good as new once he has something to focus on. Or at least functional enough until they reach home. But the illusion shatters the second Mydei gets inside the car and, without a word, rests his hand on Phainon’s thigh, squeezing the soft flesh teasingly.

“Bastard.”

Mydei knows exactly what he’s doing— and he’s playing a dangerous game.

Phainon exhales sharply through his nose, grip tightening around the steering wheel.

Fuck.

They didn’t leave the parking lot or started driving at all, and he’s already losing it.

He starts the engine purely by muscle memory, drives through roads he hopes will take them home, all while he keeps his eyes fixed forward. Anything to keep his attention away from Mydei’s hand on his thigh...

The same hand that slides a little higher the moment they stop at a red light, and the whine that leaves Phainon is embarrassingly loud; helpless and needy as he bites on his lip painfully hard to stop himself from whining again.

“Is everything ok?” Mydei has the audacity to ask him, innocent and angelic, while being anything but it. Phainon notices him sinking further into the seat, relaxed, calm, as though nothing unusual is happening, as though he isn’t pushing Phainon toward insanity.

“Yep,” Phainon mutters, though the word comes out quite strained and high-pitched. “Perfect, love driving.”

“I see.” Mydei’s thumb drags along the seam inside of his thigh, slow, *torturous*.

He breaks at least two or three speed limits when the light turns green, pressing on the gas pedal a little too hard. It takes everything for Phainon to concentrate—is he even concentrating? —on driving and not on the way his boyfriend’s fingers inch closer and closer to his rapidly fattening cock.

They hit another red light.

Of course they do.

And of-fucking-course Mydei slides his hand higher, almost, *almost* where he needs his touch. Phainon bites back on another whine and tries to adjust himself subtly, but it’s impossible. He’s embarrassingly hard, and Mydei’s long and stupidly perfect fingers are still on his thigh.

“You’re tense,” the blonde hums, matter-of-factly like he’s commenting on the scenery outside.

“No shit, Sherlock.” Phainon holds the wheel so hard his wrists hurt. “Y-you are doing that on purpose.”

“Am I?” Mydei replies. “Doesn’t seem like you mind.”

“I—” Phainon swallows hard, feeling the pressure pulse painfully between his legs, regretting his choice of wearing a tight pair of jeans to the date. Not that he ever imagined Mydeimos being such a brat, or a tease, or a menace…

All the above.

“I mind in the sense that I can’t think.”

“You don’t need to think so hard,” Mydei says, and his thumb presses into the soft flesh, mere inches away from his straining cock. It’s not enough. “All you have to do is focus on driving.”

Phainon lets out a shaky breath, muttering, “I can’t focus either.”

“Mm,” Mydei murmurs, low and amused, tracing one teasing finger against the prominent bulge in Phainon’s jeans, only to return to his thigh like nothing. “You’ll survive.”

“Mydei!” Phainon almost moans the name out, “You really shouldn’t—”

“Shouldn’t what?” The question is innocent, yet the way his fingers curl into the meat of Phainon’s thigh is anything but.

Phainon inhales sharply, bucking his hips slightly into the air, almost missing a turn. “Please…”

That gets Mydei’s full attention.

His hand stops moving for a moment, and then he finally, *finally*, presses his palm on Phainon’s clothed length.

“Mydei, please—” Phainon whimpers, his voice trembling as much as his legs, trying his best to cling to the last thread of sanity, and tries is the keyword, because he doesn’t know what he’s doing anymore. He could be driving against traffic, and all he could focus on is Mydei’s soft hand on him.

“I like it when you beg for me,” Mydei muses, still being an impossible tease. “Although you should focus on the road. We missed two turns already.”

Phainon shudders visibly, knuckles white on the steering wheel, feeling like he might rip the damn thing if Mydei doesn’t stop, or applies more pressure, he’s not even sure anymore. “I’m trying!”

“Relax,” Mydei’s voice is low, warm, undeniably pleased with how much he’s been riling his boyfriend up. “You’re too tense.”

“I wonder why!”

“You could ask me to stop.”

Phainon turns his head to meet his gaze once they stop at another red light, catching briefly how dilated his pupils are in the mirror; the usual bright blue of his eyes looking almost black. “As if you would.”

All he gets is a chuckle, and Mydei’s hand withdraws as if to show *“Here, I'm behaving,”* only to be placed back on his thigh again.

Behaving his ass.

He’s not sure how he makes it home in one piece, or how long the rest of the drive lasts, all Phainon can do is park the car with shaky precision and thank every god out there he didn’t cause an accident. Unless “*coming in your pants because your boyfriend is a tease”* counts as an accident, and then he almost had one.

His hands are still gripping the wheel as the engine quiets, chest rising and falling too fast, cock painfully hard, so close to losing it he really can no

longer think coherently. He is one second away from pulling Mydei into his lap or dragging him into the backseat and begging to take the man then and there.

And Mydei, the menace he is, can see it. He sees every bit of Phainon’s turmoil with his stupidly preceptive eyes, and his voice sounds too seductive, too good to pass on when he leans closer and whispers against his lips, “Let's go inside, before you lose your mind.”

Phainon doesn’t trust himself to speak. He nods once instead.

The door barely closes behind them when he presses Mydei against the entrance wall, lips clashing together in a hungry kiss that tastes like everything he’s been holding back since he started driving. He presses one leg between Mydei's and the blonde arches beautifully for him, equally hard, hands clutching Phainon's jacket as if anchoring himself.

It’s messy, consuming, desperate in a way that leaves them both breathless.

Phainon has never been desired like this— never openly wanted by others, and the knowledge that Mydei is just as hungry for him, wants him not only romantically but physically, is almost enough to make him come on the spot.

They stumble together down the short hallway, mouths never staying apart for more than a few seconds. Phainon barely registers when his back hits a wall, nor when Mydei’s mouth trails down to his jaw, teeth grazing the skin in a way that sends sparks through his spine.

Their jackets come off first, then the rest of their shirts, belts, sweaters— Phainon doesn’t remember how or in what order, only that at some point there is warm skin beneath his palms and Mydei’s inked chest is pressed against his. Heavens above, the blonde looks impossibly good like this: hair tousled from Phainon’s hands, breath unsteady, pupils blown wide and hungry. It hits him all over again how beautiful Mydei is, how real this is, how much he wants him.

They barely make it to Mydei’s room, since it’s the closest one, and between passionate kisses and gropes of flesh; Phainon finds himself lying on the mattress with Mydei hovering above him.

Phainon looks up, breathless, flushed, a mix of anticipation and hunger pooling in his chest, and his boyfriend is looking down at him with a matching look— gaze so intense Phainon feels like it burns straight through him. There’s no hesitation. Nothing uncertainty. Just quiet, intent want.

So very much like Mydeimos, perfect like the rest of him.

He feels lightheaded, he’s too hard to think anyway, to the point of barely registering his pants being taken off, then his underwear, then Mydei climbing onto Phainon’s lap – equally naked. He only returns back to himself when he feels something liquid-like dripping down from Mydei’s fingers onto his stomach—lube? —and he watches the blonde pour more without a hint of surprise, like he’d been waiting for the moment.

When did he grab lube to begin with?

His lover lifts his hips off Phainon’s lap, slick fingers disappear behind him, and Phainon’s brain connects the dots, registering what is about to happen.

“Wait!”

Mydei pauses, glancing down at Phainon with a confused tilt of his head. “I told you,” He murmurs, pressing a soft kiss to his forehead, “that I’d show you how great sex is, but I need to prepare myself first.”

And then his hand returns to where it was between his cheeks, fingers moving deliberately, slowly, like Mydei had done this on a daily basis, and perhaps he did, but Phainon doesn’t like that.

“No. Don’t,” he manages, sitting up as fast as his trembling muscles allow.

Mydei looks genuinely confused at the objection, brows drawing together. “What? I can’t take you without—”

“That,” Phainon cuts in, breathless and unraveling, “is the problem.”

Stopping completely, Mydei looks at him with an unreadable expression, fingers still poised behind himself. And as stupid as it is, Phainon is suddenly jealous of Mydei’s hand.

He swallows hard, heat curling through his chest in something close to desperation. “I want to be the one to do it.”

Not letting Mydei respond, or protest—why would he protest? —Phainon grabs the man’s hips, flipping them over. His boyfriend lets out a surprised yelp as his back hits the mattress, hair falling loose around him, soft-looking chest rising fast, mouth parting as he looks up at Phainon with a hungry gaze, predatory almost.

The sight nearly ruins him.

Phainon settles over him, bracing himself with one knee between Mydei’s parted thighs, and reaches for the bottle of lubricant, slicking his fingers with a determination before leaning down until their foreheads touch.

“Don’t you think you teased me enough, Mydeimos?” he smirks, drawing out his beloved’s name. “You really think I’ll sit there and watch you open yourself for me like an obedient dog? It’s my turn to make you beg for me.”

Mydei huffs, “confident words,” he taunts, “for someone who could barely hold back yesterday.”

The last thin thread of Phainon’s restraint snaps.

Lack of experience be damned. He’s going to make this brat cry his name.

Chapter End Notes

Heh.

Chapter 12: Actually, I'm Not Gay, I'm Mydeisexual

Chapter Summary

> Phainon presses his tear stricken cheek to the blonde’s chest, allowing the sound of his beloved’s heartbeat to lull him into the realm of pleasant unconsciousness.
> The last thought passing through his head is how he wants to spend the rest of his life with Mydei by his side, no more fumbling or denying anything.
> He really is a fool.
> A sweaty, spent fool who has finally found something worth fighting for, and he’s ready to do everything to keep Mydeimos his.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lack of experience might’ve been damned, but in practice, Phainon isn’t sure what he’s doing.

He kneels between Mydei’s thighs, fingers trembling with eagerness as he slicks them and lets his hand hover centimeters away from Mydei’s ass.

What was he supposed to do again?

Do not get him wrong, he’s not clueless. Phainon watches porn, of course he does. What guy doesn’t? He even started watching gay porn recently—for research purposes, of course—so he should know the theory.

But theory never sat in front of him like this: handsome and flushed and looking at him with so much hunger it makes Phainon feel lightheaded.

Mydei lifts a brow at his frazzled expression, gold-like eyes amused, too composed for someone who is as equally hard as he is. “You can touch me, you know.”

“I know that,” Phainon snaps, voice cracking mid-word “I’m trying!”

“Then try harder,” Mydei’s smirk is just as infuriating as his calmness, and Phainon really, *really* wants to wipe it off of his face.

But first, there is another presence in the room that annoys him more than his boyfriend’s brattiness.

There is a stuffed pomegranate at the corner of the bed, looking back at him with its stupid face. *That* thing does not get to watch. Phainon is already jealous that the plushie gets to hug Mydei at night instead of him...

So, he grabs it and tosses it somewhere on the floor.

“What was that for? Phainon#2 did nothing to you!”

“It was looking,” he huffs defensively, and before Mydei can add any commentary or any more bratty remarks Phainon brings his palm to the soft flesh of his lover’s ass and pushes one finger past the tight rim- successfully making the blonde bite back on whatever he is about to say.

And possibly affecting himself in a similar way too. Because heat engulfs his finger immediately, tight, hot, soft, and did he mention hot already?

He can barely think straight.

His fingertip presses further and Mydei lets out a pleased groan, hips giving a small, involuntary roll that he can’t seem to suppress, driving the digit deeper.

A wave of need surges through Phainon at the reaction. God, he wants to feel that tightness around his cock so badly his lungs almost forget how to function.

Mydei moves under him, spreads his thighs farther apart, lets his head fall back onto the pillows as he murmurs a quiet “Fuck, Phainon.”

fuck indeed.

He’s so hard it hurts, and they haven’t done anything yet.

Taking a steadying breath, Phainon slides his free hand to wrap tightly around the base of his length, giving himself a few pumps to ease the pressure. The tightness around his finger leaves him dizzy, stealing his breath away every time Mydei clenches around it.

He curls his digit experimentally next, watching his lover’s reaction with lust-clouded eyes, memorizing the beautiful arch of Mydei’s back, the feeling of his blunt nails digging crescents into his bicep, the sound of his muffled grunts as he encourages Phainon.

“Just like that… Good boy.”

The praise makes Phainon reel and bite down on a whine of his own, applying extra pressure around the base of his cock. He never thought a simple praise would make him feel so pathetically turned on, but there he is, feeling like he’s about to cum because his boyfriend called him *good*.

But that’s a discovery to explore another time. He had yet to make Mydei cry out his name, which is his current priority. He has to punish the blonde for acting like a brat earlier.

Cursing under his breath, Phainon withdraws his finger to add a second one, scissoring them as impatience takes over him.

Mydei tenses immediately.

“Slow down,” He hisses, discomfort written all over his face, hand flying from Phainon’s bicep to his wrist to stop him.

“S-sorry!”

It’s not an easy task, but he stills his fingers until he feels Mydei slowly relax around the digits. His boyfriend rests his head back on the pillow and closes his eyes, hand leaving Phainon’s wrist to trail up to his inked chest—long fingers pressing into the soft flesh of his pectorals and tugging at a rosy nipple.

A soft and satisfied moan rumbles in his chest, hips thrusting shallowly into the air, searching for friction for his leaking length.

Phainon watches the sight like a predator watches his prey, mesmerized by it, and maybe a little jealous of his boyfriend's hands… Not that he's going to admit that part out loud.

He tries again, gentler as he was told, and he pushes one finger first, then slowly adds the second one, scissoring them a few times to stretch the impossible tightness around them. Once he feels the walls give in, he curls the digits upwards in what he remembers from those porn clips he researched—

Mydei chokes on a moan, legs tightening around Phainon's hips, cock leaking so much precum it's borderline obscene.

Phainon's brain crashes, slowly rebooting as he tries to figure out what happened. He could not remember any man or woman in the videos he watched reacting like *that*. He expected another grunt, maybe a gasp of his name, not a full-body shudder and a choked cry. Did he hurt Mydei by accident?

"Did I do something wrong?" he asks, hesitant, stopping his movement completely.

"No," Mydei breathes, golden eyes fluttering open, glossy and full of need, "that was good. Keep doing that."

"Good, you're being good." His mind reels at the praise. He curls his fingers the same way again, eager to make Mydei feel good, and even more eager to earn another praise from the blonde.

Perhaps he does have a praise kink, as perverted as it might sound.

Phainon rubs the same spot deliberately, applying more pressure on it, all while looking at his boyfriend, who seems to really enjoy what he's doing, who cannot help himself but buck his hips against Phainon's fingers, whose

moans spilling freely from the parted lips Phainon can no longer hold back from leaning in and kissing…

Who palms his chest harder and wraps one hand around his own cock.

No.

“Don’t.” Phainon swats the hand away before he can think what he’s doing. He *needs* to be the one to make Mydei cum, and he won’t allow for any other outcome.

“You’re stopping me?” Mydei asks in disbelief.

“Yes,” he breathes, baby-blue eyes burning with possessive need. “You’ll cum untouched on my fingers, or not at all.”

“What?” Mydei clenches around his fingers so hard it nearly destroys Phainon’s sanity right there, sending a myriad of thoughts through his head, the majority of them being somewhere between *“Oh, he likes it.”* And *“God, I need to be inside him.”*

“I—” stammering, Phainon leans in and kisses him again, hungry and full of desperation while his fingers thrust deeper, curling upward with growing confidence as Mydei moans against his lips. The heat around his digits grips him like vice, then relaxes again, and the slick sound that fills the room with every thrust makes Phainon’s own neglected cock throb even harder.

“I want to be the one to make you cum,” he admits, breaking the kiss.

“Then get on with it,” the blonde urges him, looking away, but the flush on his face is a beautiful one; darkening to the same shade of his tattoos, his equally neglected cock twitches desperately despite the seemingly collected façade.

“But Mydeimos, I'm pretty sure you like it,” Phainon murmurs, both teasing and genuinely overwhelmed at once.

“I can feel it...” He adds a third finger quickly and curls them deliberately, watching as Mydei’s body arches from the bed “…Right here.”

Phainon repeats the action just to emphasize, leaning back to watch Mydei's disheveled state: His facial expression, his nipples—hard and angry-red from all the teasing, his impossibly tight ass swallowing his fingers eagerly, and finally to his leaking cock; throbbing with need against his stomach, begging for release.

"You're close," Phainon whispers when Mydei's own restraint seems to weaken and he starts thrusting his hips back with uncharacteristic eagerness, groaning each time Phainon curls his fingers just right. "I can feel it, Mydei, I can feel you tightening even more. You're going to cum, don't you? You're going to cum on my fingers."

Mydei doesn't deny it, doesn't pretend to be composed anymore. He meets Phainon's gaze with heat that matches the tremors running through his body, and breathes out, "wrap your hand around my throat."

Phainon stills, swallowing hard. His free hand moves on instinct, wanting to be good for Mydei, but he hesitates. His fingers shake, unable to close it around Mydei's throat, terrified he'll misjudge the pressure… Terrified he'll hurt him.

"I don't want to," he shakes his head, "I don't want to hurt you."

"You won't," Mydei whispers, and the certainty in his eyes is grounding, steadying. "You want me to cum untouched, don't you?" he grabs Phainon's wrist, closing the distance between it and his neck, "then press right here. I trust you."

"He trusts you," Phainon's mind repeats, and just that is enough to unravel him. He takes a shaky inhale, and curls his fingers right where Mydei pressed his palm at, and with a loud exhale he applies pressure on his lover's throat.

Mydei's reaction is instant.

His breath stutters, throat bobbing against his palm, hips jerking upward, thighs clamping around Phainon's waist as a loud broken moan breaks from his lips.

“More” Mydei orders, sounding breathless already, “press harder.”

“Oh god. He’s really into it,” Phainon obeys, unable to look anywhere but at Mydei’s pleasure-struck face as he presses harder like he’s told, applies more pressure—

Mydei’s back arches off the mattress, throat pushing into Phainon’s palm. His eyes squeeze shut, mouth opening in a silent scream, and his hands grip the sheets so hard Phainon is afraid he might rip them, thighs shaking around his hips.

“Cum for me,” he begs, feeling just as breathless from the sight alone. “Please, I want to see you cumming.”

Phainon curls his fingers inside Mydei again, presses the same spot he’s been abusing in the past minutes…

“Phai-non!” And Mydei cums with a broken cry of his name.

Pleasure rips through him in waves, rim tightening painfully around Phainon’s digits as his cock pulses against his stomach, painting his chest and abdomen in milky release. Completely untouched.

Holy fuck.

He guides Mydei through it, pumping his fingers in a gentler pace, coaxing every last drop of cum until Mydei falls back into the sheets, chest heaving, blonde-red hair sticking to his face. Only then, Phainon slowly pulls his fingers out, breath shaky and uneven.

Watching Mydei fall apart like that, from his fingers and nothing else, does something to Phainon. Something he has a hard time putting into words.

So instead of wording his adoration he reaches for the blonde’s braid—the one resting on top of his right collarbone, and presses a tender kiss to it, whispering the man’s name with adoration. It is then that he finally acknowledges his own need, cock throbbing painfully as if to remind its owner how neglected it had been this entire time. Precum bubbles at the tip

in what feels like a cry for attention, every twitch making Phainon's breath hitch and his vision blur at the edges.

The realization hits him too sudden.

He feels *needy*. Pathetic. Like one touch from Mydei and he'd cum on the spot. He's barely able to think, to the point of not realizing he's shaking, not until he feels strong arms wrap around him, pulling him against a soft chest, anchoring him with touch and with steady warmth.

"Hey. You're hyperventilating." Mydei points out quietly, and only then Phainon registers that he was, in fact, at the verge of panicking from seeing his boyfriend experience pleasure from his touch, from jealousy at his own hand, from his lack of experience...

Maybe from a mix of it all.

All the confidence that had surged through him moments ago evaporates under the weight of his own patheticness. He feels like a shaky leaf. Weak, needy, overwhelmed by how badly he wants to be inside Mydei, but also terrified that the moment he tries, he'll embarrass himself again.

"You with me?" the blonde murmurs into his hair. He presses Phainon's forehead to his shoulder, pressing soothing kisses to the top of his head. Soft. Calming. "Take a deep breath. Yeah. Just like that."

Phainon listens, takes a deep inhale, and exhales it slowly, relaxing further with each intake of air. Mydei keeps holding him through it, steady and *there* until Phainon finds his voice again. "Sorry, I—" he's not sure how to say it without embarrassing himself, "I don't want to mess up the second we…"

"Want me to make you cum once first?"

His head lifts so fast he feels his neck cracking.

"Mydei," Phainon croaks, voice hitching into a whimper, or a squeak.

No, definitely not a squeak.

He did not *squeak*.

“You’re thinking too hard. I can see steam coming out of your ears.” Mydei points out, pressing one last kiss to his cheek, looking at him with reassurance. “I know you don’t want to release too fast again,” He adds, a little teasing but with no accusation or malice behind his words. “Taking the edge off will help with that.”

Phainon makes a sound that sounds more like a wounded groan than an actual word. His face feels like it’s on fire. “You’re not going to let me live that one down, are you?”

“No,” Mydei replies simply, without hesitation. “It was flattering.”

“You’re mean,” Phainon sobs, exaggerated, yet he’s smiling, feeling giddy and a little more relaxed thanks to Mydei’s steadiness.

His boyfriend is, unfortunately, right. He might need to take the edge off first. So, Phainon forces himself to swallow his pride and turns over to look at Mydei’s eyes, blue meeting gold, suddenly shy and self-conscious at the request he’s about to make.

“Can I…” he asks, cheeks burning. “Can I play with your chest while you…”

The rest of the sentence dies in his throat, too embarrassed to finish it. Heavens above, he feels like an absolute pervert for even asking.

Mydei chuckles in response, hand reaching to cup his cheek, the same smirk he was so determined to wipe off from the man’s face earlier is back, smug as ever. “I should have expected that from the pervert who kept staring at my chest every morning for months.”

“Never beating those pervert allegations.” Phainon’s mind jabs at him.

“I wasn’t!” He makes a noise that should never leave a grown man; high pitched, mortified, strangled, and drops his forehead to Mydei’s pectorals

like he can crawl into the gap between them and hide there forever. His ears burn. His neck burns.

His entire soul burns.

“You know, hiding in my chest doesn’t help your case.” Mydei is clearly delighted, putting extra emphasis on the words ‘*my*’ and ‘*chest*’.

Such a brat.

Before Phainon can retort back, or think about anything clever to say, his boyfriend pulls him to sit more comfortably between his legs, until he’s half-lying on Mydei’s lap. The blonde traces one palm down Phainon’s thigh, and that alone is enough to make him gasp, cock straining between them, begging for attention with renewed eagerness.

He really is about to cum from the lightest of touches, pathetic as it might be.

Then Mydei wraps his hand around him, and all remaining thoughts fly out of Phainon’s head.

His hips jolt up instinctively in a desperate thrust into Mydei’s fist as he grabs at the blonde’s forearm, holding to it like it’s the only thing keeping him grounded, fingers digging into warm skin.

“Mydei—” he gasps, pleading, unsure for what.

Mydei chuckles, he presses his thumb at the sensitive head, spreading the beading precum along the entire length to ease the glide of his palm. It’s slow, agonizingly so, and Phainon can’t help but moan, beg, mumble incoherently for more, never imagining that another’s hand could feel so much better than his own.

And so soft too, how Mydeimos has such soft hands is beyond him.

A blunt nail presses into his leaking slit, rendering Phainon unable to think clearly any further. He buries his face in his lover’s chest for the second

time, mouthing alongside the red lines of ink until he reaches his nipple; still swollen from Mydei's own hands, and latches his lips around it.

"Good boy," Mydei groans above him. "Put that mouth of yours to good use."

Phainon lets out an actual whimper. Loud and high pitched. He alternates between sucking and biting gently around the nub, pleased with the way Mydei's breath hitches when he tugs on it with his teeth, whining when the man on top of him applies more pressure to his cock in return, pumping faster.

Bringing one arm to knead the neglected pec, Phainon hums in delight – it's as soft as he imagined, even with the evident hard muscle beneath the softness.

Gods, he thought about Mydei's chest so many times in those months, fantasized about it, wondered if it was soft or on the firmer side like his own chest…

Ok, maybe he is a pervert.

What a great time to make self-discoveries about yourself, right?

Not that any of that matters, not when Mydei whispers into his hair, "just like that. You're so good."

Good.

That praise again. Phainon's hips jerk involuntarily in response, too far gone to feel mortified at how much he enjoys being called good, or any praise really, as long as it's from Mydeimos.

He moves to the other pectoral next, giving the perky nipple the same treatment albeit a little clumsy in his urgency, a little too eager too, and Mydei's free hand finds his hair, tugging on the white strands.

Phainon moans into his skin, pleasure coiling tight inside him, unbearably close to the edge. All he needs is a bit more… And as if sensing it, Mydei

increases the pace. He strokes him faster, harder, sliding his hand from tip to base; fist twisting right below the head in a way that makes Phainon cry out.

“Mydei!” He moans into his lover’s chest, teeth scraping over the inked skin, “I ’m-I can’t—”

“Let go,” Mydei guides him with his ever-present steadiness. “Don’t hold back.”

He doesn’t.

One more squeeze at the base and Phainon’s thighs lock, back arching, mouth going slack against Mydei’s chest as pleasure bursts everywhere inside him.

Phainon cums with a broken moan, white-hot blinding pleasure surging through him. His cock pulses in waves, thick release coating his boyfriend’s hand and dripping down his own stomach, body trembling beneath Mydei as the pleasure threatens to consume him whole.

Phainon can’t breathe. Can’t think. Can’t… anything really.

He’s boneless, ruined, floating in the afterlife, or after-orgasm life.

“You did well.” Slowly, gently, Mydei strokes him through it, removing his hand completely when Phainon starts whining from oversensitivity, and leans to him, pressing a chaste kiss to his lips.

Phainon makes a weak noise in the back of his throat, somewhere between gratitude, humiliation, and *too much*, and buries his face even deeper against Mydei’s chest, too overwhelmed to speak.

Mydei’s laugh is quiet, warm, vibrating deep in his chest and against Phainon’s cheek. His Clean hand strokes down the curve of his spine with affection that makes Phainon want to cry. Happy tears, he swears.

His lover shifts below him, pulling them closer until Phainon is practically lying on top of him and the movement drags Phainon’s softening cock

against Mydei’s hard one. He gasps, quiet and broken, holding Mydei’s waist to anchor himself.

“Sensitive?” the blonde asks with a smug lilt.

Phainon nods against his throat, too embarrassed to look up.

Mydei chuckles under his breath with amusement, although his voice comes out deeper, hungrier. He smooths a hand along Phainon’s cheek, guiding him back enough to see his flushed face. “Get up and lie down on the bed.”

Phainon nods through glossy eyes, obeying without question. He gets off Mydeimos, resting his head on the soft pillows, chest rising fast with anticipation of what is about to happen. His hands hover uselessly at his sides, twitching with the urge to reach for Mydei again, like he can no longer go without the physical contact.

Which might be quite right.

He feels addicted to the man.

Mydei sits up and crawls back to loom over Phainon, slow and deliberate, with the confidence of someone who knows the exact effect they cause.

“*Cheeky bastard.”*

A very correct cheeky bastard, Phainon notes in the back of his head, since he can feel himself twitch back into semi-hardness already.

The blonde leans closer, planting a kiss on Phainon’s jaw, and then another beneath his ear, then lower. Right between the leather straps of his choker. It shouldn’t be so hot, it shouldn’t be such a turn-on, but it is. Phainon jerks like he’s been shocked. A helpless whine escapes his lips, hips arching up, seeking friction.

“Sensitive here too,” Mydei murmurs against his skin, kissing the edge of the choker again, firmer this time, while his hand traces the sun tattoo below it with a feather-light touch like the god-damn tease he is.

Phainon shivers, thighs trembling, cock fattening into full-mast so fast he feels dizzy. “Mydei!”

“Shh,” Mydei’s mouth trails lower, teeth grazing one of the tattooed rays of sun right above his collarbone. “I’m not done with you.”

The promise tears another whine from Phainon. He can feel the coil in his stomach return, the heat that had loosened after coming tightens again with startling speed. Mydei’s kisses move down his chest, over the rapid beat of his heart, then to the hard planes of his stomach, each kiss nearing closer and closer to where Phainon really wants his mouth at.

“Already hard again?” Mydei whispers, kissing just above his hip. “Impressive.”

Phainon covers his face with one hand, mortified by how eager his body is, how desperately it is craving Mydei…

“Don’t hide from me.” His boyfriend huffs, pouting adorably as he brushes the hand away so he can see Phainon fully, and Phainon wants to hide further, suddenly very conscious of the fact his refractory period is non-existent in the man’s proximity.

But Mydei doesn’t let him; he moves back up with a predatory grace, unhurried, sure of himself, like he’s dominating the bedroom. His own hardness strains between them as he sits on Phainon's lap, ass brushing Phainon’s erection.

“Look at me,” Mydei murmurs.

And Phainon does.

Immediately regretting it.

Because the blonde holds his gaze as he scoops the drying cum from Phainon’s lower stomach, and reaches behind himself, pushing three cum-covered fingers into his entrance, sighing at the intrusion as he uses the semen as a lubricant.

Phainon’s mind short-circuits so hard it takes him a second to even register what he’s seeing.

His vision blurs. Heat sweeps through him so fast it feels like fever, mouth suddenly too dry to swallow properly. It’s the hottest thing he’s ever seen in his life and his body reacts like it’s been set on fire.

Mydei looks up at him then, cheeks flushed and gaze so intense he’s drowning in the molten gold of his boyfriend’s eyes. And before Phainon can recover from the sight of Mydei fingering himself with his cum, the blonde trails the same hand down his stomach again, smearing whatever cum is still there, and reaches Phainon’s cock – pumping it a few times.

“Mydei, wait,” he whispers, panic and excitement mixing in his voice as his lover aligns the now slick length with his entrance.

“I told you,” Mydei replies, lowering himself with agonizing slowness, “I’m planning to teach you how good sex can be.”

“That’s not—” The head of his cock pushes past Mydei’s rim, and Phainon’s eyes flutter shut, the heat swallowing him inch by inch, rendering him unable to keep talking. It’s too much, it’s not enough, he never felt something so hot and tight around him.

“Fuck,” he gasps, hands flying to Mydei’s hips, holding for dear life.

Mydei’s palms land on his chest, and he starts sinking lower. The pressure around his cock is unbearable, exquisite, dizzying… Phainon feels like he’s having an out-of-body experience.

“So this is what it feels like, this is how perfect it feels to become one with the person you love…” He’s partially glad that his first time is like this, with Mydei, his Mydei. It’s sappy and he knows it, but he couldn’t care less, now when the heat of his boyfriend’s body swallows him deeper, tight and velvety and more than anything he ever dreamt of.

Heavens help him, he never felt something so perfect.

“Fuck. It’s, Mydei, it’s—” His words are cuts off by a groan, fingers digging into the soft skin of Mydei’s hips, unsure where to look. Should he look at the place where their bodies join, at Mydei’s face as he sinks lower and lower on his hardness, or at the trembling rise and fall of his own chest? He can’t decide. He can’t...

Head tilting back against the pillows, Phainon groans again, loud and unrestrained as Mydei eases down another inch, as controlled as ever, as though he’s savoring how much it undoes Phainon. Until he finally, *finally-fucking-ly*, presses flush against Phainon’s balls.

The heat is unreal. Hotter and better than anything he ever felt. Better than Mydei’s mouth, better than all the fantasies combined, better than anything he can think of—not that he’s able to think at the moment.

He tries to take a deep breath, failing miserably.

His heart feels like it’s about to jump out of his chest.

“Wait Mydei. Plea-*ah*-se,” Phainon’s voice hitches on the last word, trembling with shock and pleasure and the sheer intensity of becoming one with his lover.

Mydei stills immediately, palms tracing soothing patterns over the halo-like golden tattoo on his chest. He studies Phainon’s expression with quiet curiosity, as though he expected this reaction and enjoys seeing it, enjoys making Phainon unravel.

“Try taking a deep breath,” he says, brushing his thumb lightly across Phainon’s collarbone.

Phainon tries. He really does. But the tight, molten hot pressure around him is so overwhelming it borders on unbearable, a hot, perfect vice that squeezes him in ways his mind can’t seem to process.

“Mydei, I-you’re… It’s tighter than, fuck, tighter than your mouth.”

An amused hum leaves Mydei's lips, warm and impossibly fond. "I figured it would overwhelm you a bit."

"A bit?" Phainon chokes out, voice cracking as another wave of pleasure surges through him, making him shudder. "I-I don't even know my own name right now."

Mydei leans down slowly, bracing his hands on either side of Phainon's head and presses their foreheads together. His voice drops, low and velvety, "It's alright, take your time, cum again if you're about to," he whispers between them, and the smugness in his tone doesn't go unnoticed, not when he clenches his ass on purpose.

The little shit.

Phainon swallows hard, takes several uneven breaths to get used to the tightness, to get used to Mydei's body squeezing around him. "Asshole," he finally manages to speak, lifting his head the tiniest bit to press a chaste kiss to Mydei's lips. "Move already, showoff."

And Mydei moves. He lifts his hips enough to let Phainon feel his cock drag against those velvety walls—

"Mydeimos!" Heavens above, he was not ready. Phainon's eyes roll back the more Mydei lifts himself, hips jerking upward as if chasing the heat, until the blonde sinks back down with a grunt of his own, leaving him borderline delirious with pleasure in the best way possible.

"Mydei," Phainon gasps again, fingers digging into the narrow waist of his lover, hard enough to bruise the delicate skin. Something possessive inside him sings in satisfaction at the idea of marking Mydei. "Please—"

"Begging already? Cute." Mydei teases, both affectionate and strained, hips never stopping moving, bouncing on Phainon's lap.

The sound Phainon makes is *embarrassing*. A broken, choked moan, loud enough that their neighbors could probably hear it.

“Mydei! Mydei, please!” he babbles, voice pitching higher and higher with every broken syllable, feeling tears prickle in his eyes from how good he feels, hips thrusting back into the heat of his beloved. “You’re - god! you’re so tight, so good, I can’t, Mydei—”

Above him, Mydei throws his head back at a particular hard thrust, hissing, “Fuck, Phainon, you’re so deep I can feel you in my stomach,” And while Phainon knows it’s physically impossible, it rewires something in him. He didn’t think he could get harder, didn’t think it was physically possible, but hearing the ever-polite Mydei saying something so filthy… *Fuck*. His cock throbs so violently he arches off the bed with a broken cry. “Mydei, you’re… I can’t— you’re saying things like that and I-I’m losing my mind.”

“Good,” His lover grunts, “lose yourself,” the blonde’s thighs flex around Phainon’s hips, breath growing shallower as he fucks himself on Phainon’s length with increased urgency, chasing both his own pleasure and bringing them closer and closer to completion.

All he needs is just a bit more. A few more thrusts.

“M-Mydei! I need to pull out, im gonna—”

He can feel warm fingers press at his throat, tracing over the choker before curling around the leather, tugging, pulling Phainon’s torso up from the mattress until their lips are mere centimeters apart. “No. Cum inside me, I want to feel it.”

“Who’s begging now?” Phainon manages to retort, hearing Mydei beg, or asking for something in general, gives him a boost of confidence, and he thrusts up, pushing deeper into Mydei’s heat, matching his boyfriend’s pace and meeting every frantic thrust with his own deliberate roll of his hips.

“I’m not begging,” Mydei hisses, leaning down to shut him up with a kiss, filling Phainon’s vision with nothing but golden eyes and flushed skin and the soft strands of Mydei’s partially dyed hair. “I’m telling you to be a good boy and cum for me.”

Phainon's entire body shudders like on command. He pulls Mydei closer, hands holding his lover's ass flush against his pelvis as pleasure tears through his core. His cock pulses deep inside Mydei, orgasm ripping away every last shred of coherency from his mind until he's shaking, gasping, clinging to his boyfriend like he's drowning and the man in his arms is his sole source of oxygen.

"That's it," Mydei murmurs, clenching around his twitching cock like a vice, like he doesn't want Phainon to pull out. "You're perfect."

Blinking the tears away—when did he start crying? —Phainon trembles, shaking, caught in the intense pleasure, and his hold on Mydei's ass weakens, and the blonde uses it in his own favor. He starts grinding on his lap again, his own erection leaking steadily onto Phainon's stomach, precum pooling on his lower belly.

And it might be the overstimulation, the pure *need*, or simply the sight of Mydei; flushed, brows drawn together, face contorted with pleasure as he rolls his hips against Phainon's half-soft cock in a chase for his own orgasm, that erases whatever refractory period Phainon's body should have after coming twice in twenty minutes or so.

He doesn't know what takes over him.

One moment he is trembling under Mydei's touch, dazed and blissed, and the next his body is moving on its own, driven by pure instinct. He grabs Mydei's shoulders, pushes him onto his back and sits between the man's spread thighs, wincing as his length slips out in the process, already mourning the loss of heat.

"Phainon!?" Mydei gasps, startled, hair spread behind him in a halo of yellow and red, resembling a beautiful sunset and the wheat fields of his little village alike.

Phainon doesn't answer. He pushes Mydei's knees up, folding him nearly in half, hands shaking with wild, consuming need he cannot control any longer. His entire body feels like a live wire, overstimulated but full of hunger for more, for *Mydeimos*.

He thrusts back inside.

The oversensitivity nearly knocks him out. His vision whites out at the edges, breath coming out in a broken gasp as Mydei's ass clamps down around him, tighter than before, too tight, impossibly tight. Phainon braces through it, barely, hips snapping forward little by little, rough and unsteady and determined to make his lover feel the same intense pleasure he did moments ago.

With one harsh slam of his hips, Phainon bottoms out with a loud hiss.

"Fuck, Phainon!" Mydei's moan is shocked, like the air is punched out of him, like he didn't expect the sudden shift, or the strength, or the urgency… Or the feral need surging off of Phainon in waves, and his nails dig into Phainon's back, scratching angry lines to the otherwise unblemished skin.

Phainon barely registers the pain.

"Mydei—" A strangled sob leaves him, tears sliding down his face and into the crook of Mydei's neck, soaking into blond-red strands as he starts thrusting into his boyfriend with pure abandon, chests pressed flush, elbows shaking to keep himself up. "You're so tight. I can't— I can't!"

He doesn't know what he's trying to say; coherence long gone. All he has left in him is desire, pure and molten and maddening. He pulls back until only the head patches on Mydei's abused rim and slams forward again with a pace that's wild and frantic, snaking one hand to wrap around Mydei's neglected cock.

It doesn't take much from there. A surprised moan rips from Mydei's throat, and Phainon lifts his head just in time to see the blonde's expression – eyes squeezed shut, eyebrows drawn together, teeth biting so hard into his bottom lip he's quite sure it'll bleed any second. His length pulses in Phainon's fist, coating the red tattoos on his abdomen in milky white.

He's beautiful, ethereal, and all *because of Phainon*.

Seeing the composure slip off Mydei’s face, seeing his beloved losing himself to pleasure leaves Phainon drunk on it, and his mind descends into a delirious confession, each thrust punctuating thoughts he can’t hold back, unable to stop when Mydei clenches on him so hard and so so good.

“Marry me.”

It slips out, a plea and a promise in one.

“I, fuck, I want you to have my kids—”

His hips drive forward hard enough to make the headboard rattle and he should feel embarrassed, but Phainon is not capable of embarrassment at the moment.

“Mydei, I love you! I love you so fucking much!”

Confessing like this… It’s a new level of shamelessness even for him. Yet the thought of Mydei with him, *like this*, forever, makes him pick up the pace, ignore the weak pleas of his lover to slow down, or give him a minute.

He simply can’t.

“Fuck. Phainon! Slow down. I just came," Mydei’s nails bite deeper into his back in a futile attempt to stop him, protests shattering into a loud cry as Phainon aims his hips just right, hitting the blonde’s bullied prostate head on. Another sharp breath follows, another quiet cry, and in the back of his mind Phainon realizes that there are tears trailing down Mydei’s face.

Oh god.

His boyfriend looks the most beautiful like this: wrecked and blissed out and crying on his cock.

“I’m going to breed you,” Phainon promises, high on pleasure himself, balls slapping against Mydei’s ass with every unforgiving thrust. “I’m gonna fill you so deep you’ll feel it for days. You’ll be so full, so full of me!”

His hips slap against Mydei's in a relentless rhythm, chasing both his own pleasure and needing to see Mydei's expression as he orgasms again, to memorize the sight in his mind.

A greedy possessive streak inside him wants to make sure Mydei can never be satisfied by anyone else.

Only by Phainon.

The blonde shakes beneath him, boneless and completely at his mercy, thighs trembling against Phainon's shoulders, chest rising and falling with every drag of Phainon's cock right into his sweet spot.

He's perfect. He's perfect for him. He's everything Phainon ever wanted.

"Please, Mydei, I need you. Fuck, please, please, please—"

Phainon is gone. Completely gone. His teeth sink into the delicate skin of his boyfriend's neck, needing to claim and mark him as the heat coils fast inside him, ready to snap every second.

"Mydei!" He cries out, broken and desperate, unable to hold it together. "I'm, I'm gonna… fuck! I'm gonna cum. I can't… Mydei I can't."

He can feel Mydei's grip on his shoulders, can feel his blunt nails dig deep enough to break skin as he's panting against his ear, strained with too much pleasure. "Phainon. slow down."

But there's nothing on the planet that can slow him now.

Phainon slams his hips forward with wild, uncontrolled force, feeling Mydei tighten helplessly around him with every pull, like he doesn't want Phainon to pull out despite the pleas to slow down.

Not that Phainon wants to either, he'd stay buried deep inside Mydei forever if he could.

Unable to hold back any longer, he reaches between them, wrapping his hand around Mydei's somehow-still-hard cock, firm and sure, stroking him

in rough pulls, needing them to reach their release together this time.

Mydei's breath stutters into a pained hiss from the sudden contact. His hips roll up into Phainon's fist, or away, he's not really sure anymore.

"I can't," he grunts, just as far gone, "too soon, fuck."

"You can." Phainon declares, thrusting into him harder—if that's even possible—rutting with desperate force as he pumps Mydei in the same wild rhythm.

"Cum, Mydei, please, for me! I need it."

"I'm—" the blonde gasps, chest rising hard, hands gripping Phainon's shoulders so hard he almost loses his balance.

With one more broken cry, Mydei cums again.

His cock pulses in Phainon's palm, spilling a few weak spurts over his fingers, milked completely dry. Mydei's hips jerk up, riding the waves of pleasure with fresh tears and moans he can no longer muffle, clenching so hard on Phainon's cock that it sends him over the edge moments later.

"I-I'm, Mydei. *Mydeimos*—!"

The orgasm tears through Phainon like nothing before; violent, desperate, overwhelming. His vision blacks out, hips stilling as he cums, pulsing inside the velvety walls of his lover. He sobs, cries, chants Mydei's name like a prayer, feeling the man below him tremble under him with each throb.

Until overstimulation takes over, dragging one more broken whimper from his lips, and another weak spurt of cum.

Phainon's arm gives in, and he collapses forward, chest pressed to Mydei's, panting desperately against his skin. His body is still shaking from the force of whatever-that-was that overtook him, wincing when Mydei clenches weakly around his oversensitive length, yet unable to pull out, not ready to part from the warmth of his lover.

Slowly, after what feels like minutes, or hours, he's not sure, Phainon’s lungs seem to remember how breathing works and he lifts his head, looking down at his spent lover. Mydei looks equally exhausted, chest heaving, a trail of drying tears down his cheeks, eyes rolled back in the image of pure bliss.

Phainon ends up crying again, sobbing quietly into the crook of Mydei’s neck, thanking him, babbling messy confessions, thanking him again… And again, and again. He knows he makes no sense, knows that Mydei is possibly floating somewhere and not registering anything, but he cannot help himself.

It takes a few more minutes until he can slowly lift himself, pressing a clumsy kiss to the corner of Mydei’s mouth, this time not caring that he missed. “I love you,” he murmurs, a little more coherent now. “I really… heavens above, I really love you.”

Mydei’s eyes are half-lidded but regain focus, and he smiles weakly at him as he returns the kiss, properly. There is no hunger behind it, only tenderness, affection, and most importantly: it’s a silent confirmation that the feeling is mutual.

It’s so very Mydei-like that Phainon thinks he fell even deeper just now.

He returns the kiss slowly at first, like he’s still afraid he has no right to want this much, but the immense love he feels for Mydeimos grows so fast inside him, forming into the kind of joy that breaks him and rebuilds him anew— leaving him grinning like a lovestruck fool.

“I love you so much” he breaks the kiss, whispering breathless and shaky between them, because what’s another confession after the myriad he already made?

“I do too,” Mydei hums.

The verbal affirmation is everything he didn’t know he needed, and he's both giddy and very aware of how tired he is all of a sudden. Exhaustion

crashes into him all at once like his body can finally relax after hearing Mydei saying he loves him too.

Phainon presses his tear stricken cheek to the blonde's chest, allowing the sound of his beloved's heartbeat to lull him into the realm of pleasant unconsciousness.

The last thought passing through his head is how he wants to spend the rest of his life with Mydei by his side, no more fumbling or denying anything.

He really is a fool.

A sweaty, spent fool who has finally found something worth fighting for, and he's ready to do everything to keep Mydeimos his.



Mydei falls back to the mattress, staring at the ceiling, trying to regain the ability to think, to breathe… to function in general. He feels like he has been hit by a truck; an emotional white-haired truck named Phainon who had successfully fucked him into incoherency and back, scratching that itch inside him so good Mydei saw stars, literally.

It was the best sex he ever had, no exaggerations. And this guy is supposed to be a virgin?

"Weren't you supposed to be a first timer or something?" he smacks the unconscious man on top of him, body protesting under the weight of his lover on him.

Phainon opens his eyes slowly, groggily, blinking at him with a pout, hand reaching to rub the spot Mydei just flicked.

"What was that for?"

“Weren’t you supposed to be a first timer?” Mydei repeats, “because that wasn’t a virgin. That was a sex demon.”

Phainon blinks at him again, pout morphing into the most pathetic and hopeful expression Mydei has ever seen on a grown man.

“This means I was good?” said boyfriend perks up immediately, sweet and grinning and a complete opposite to the possessive man from minutes ago. And heavens help him, Mydei swear he can see the ghost of a tail wagging behind him in excitement.

It’s so absurdly cute it knocks the air from his lungs more effectively than any of their lovemaking—if he can even call the wildest sex he ever had lovemaking—did.

“You were more than good,” Mydei laughs under his breath, fond despite knowing his hips would kill him by next morning, which is totally worth it.

Plus, he’s unable to stay mad when Phainon lights up instantly at the praise, like a dog being told he’s a good boy or offered a treat. “But I need you to pull out, we need a shower.”

“But…”

“Phainon.”

“Ok! Ok!” The white-haired man grumbles, lifting his body off Mydei’s slowly, breath stuttering mid-way. Mydei can see the way his pupils grow big again, and most importantly, can feel him twitch against his abused hole as he finally pulls all the way out.

He smacks Phainon again.

“Stop that, you horny mutt,” Mydei growls with no bite behind it, ass clenching in a futile attempt to stop the cum leaking out; the reason his insatiable boyfriend is getting hard again.

Phainon lifts his head to look at him with a hungry look, hands trying to pin Mydei back to the mattress. “But you look so good…”

“No,” Mydei cuts in flatly, swatting his arms away. “Or I’ll kick you out of the room.”

His partner immediately sags like a scolded puppy.

Is he dating a man or a dog?

“Sorry! Sorry. I’m normal now. Completely normal.”

“Normal men don’t propose mid sex, nor promise to put children in their *male* partner.”

“I—” Phainon sobers up instantly, color blooming high across his cheeks, all the way to his collarbones, and suddenly he can’t meet Mydei’s eyes anymore. “Is that a no then?” He ends up mumbling, shameless as ever.

Trying his best not to roll his eyes, Mydei watches him with the flattest look he can muster, but he ends up smiling despite himself. “Maybe someday. It’s too early to think about marriage and kids.”

“Y-yeah! Someday!”

Mydei really contemplates buying a fake tail and make Phainon wear it, the man already has a metaphorical one wagging behind him anyway.

“Next time, though,” he gives him a flat look, suddenly in the mood to tease his partner a little more, “try proposing when you’re not folding me in half.”

“You’re impossible.” Phainon sputters, covering his face with both hands.

“And you still love me enough to propose.”

“You will be the death of me, Mydeimos.”

“Good. Now let the ‘death of you’ kick you to the shower.” He chuckles.

“But I thought you said *we* need a shower—” Mydei can see his lover’s cock fattening up slowly against his thigh. That insatiable dog. He doesn’t

let him finish the sentence, smacking Phainon on the head for the third time, sharp and fond and very much deserved.

“I don’t trust you not to try anything if we shower together” He huffs, folding his arms, face contorting in discomfort for a second as the action applies pressure on his still-too-sensitive nipples.

Phainon gasps at him like he’s been mortally wounded, clutching at his chest dramatically. “I would never!”

“Like hell this man would behave when he’s half-hard again.” Mydei gives him an unimpressed look instead, and that does the job.

His boyfriend deflates instantly. “Okay, you’re right, I would…”

“I know you would, now go,” Mydei pushes him off the bed with his foot, hips screaming in protest at the action. “Or I’ll go first and finish all the hot water.”

“Cruel,” Phainon mutters, but he gets up obediently, legs wobbling a little. He pauses at the door, glancing back with that hopeful look and a cheeky grin, one that Mydei is unfortunately weak to.

“You sure you don’t want to join?”

He throws a pillow at his boyfriend before he ends up caving in. He wanted to throw Phainon#2 actually, just to annoy the real Phainon, but he’s not sure where the man tossed the poor pomegranate plushie to.

The pillow works well enough. Phainon disappears into the shower, the sound of running water starting moments later.

Lying back down with a tired sigh, Mydei stares at the ceiling and tries to process the mind-blowing sex they just had. Truth to be told, he had expected to take the lead, teach Phainon what and how to touch him, not to be folded in half and proposed—that was quite endearing, actually— and then fucked so good he almost passed out, but a first timer that is so natural at it Mydei doesn’t think any other man would make the cut after today.

His lower half twitches weakly at the recent memory, too spent to fill up but interested nonetheless. Which is quite surprising if he has to be honest. His body had never been this… Eager.

Speaking of eagerness and eager people, isn't his boyfriend taking a little too long in the shower?

Phainon is an efficient person; he has been nothing but efficient since the day he moved in. The man would normally shower in record time, shocking Mydei with how fast he is in and out.

And yet, it's been at least ten minutes now, if not longer.

"Unbelievable," Mydei mutters, mind slowly connecting the dots and he sits up. *"He's absolutely—"*

He doesn't let himself finish the thought; he doesn't need to. He already knows he's correct. Mydei's legs carry him to the bathroom with a slight limp before he can stop himself, and he hears it before he even opens the door: his name, muffled throughout the combination of water and the wall between them, but unmistakable.

If he wasn't hard until now - now he surely is.

Mydei opens the door, as quietly as possible, stepping inside the steamy room. And lo and behold, behind the thick layer of steam stands his boyfriend, back to the door, head bowed down, one hand braced flat against the tile.

The other hand thought… His other hand is stroking himself with slow, deliberate rolls of his hips.

Another moan of *'Mydeimos'* reverberates in the room, needy, broken.

Exactly like Mydei suspected.

His mouth goes dry. Shame and want collide low in his gut, both loving and hating how easily Phainon riles him up. Lust clouds his eyes, and he coughs once to gain his partner's attention.

“M-Mydei!” Phainon turns his head in surprise, but Mydei doesn’t let him say anything else. He mutters a quiet “fuck it” under his breath and opens the shower’s glass door, stepping inside, wasting no time from there onward. grabbing Phainon by the hips He shoves him against the tiled wall.

They stand face to face, close enough that their chests are pressed flush—Mydei’s tribal red tattoos against Phainon’s golden halo—and even closer once Mydei leans to capture his lover’s lips in a kiss, slotting their aching cocks together, wrapping his hand around both of them.

Phainon breaks the kiss with a loud whine, head tipping back against the tile. His hands fly to Mydei’s shoulders, fingers digging in skin as his hips jerk forward instinctively, chasing the tight heat of Mydei’s grip.

“Fuck, Mydei,” Phainon manages to breathe out, barely audible over the steady hiss of water. His eyes close as he keeps bucking into the warmth of Mydei’s palm needily, water clinging in heavy drops on his long lashes. “I thought, thought you didn’t want to join.”

“Changed my mind, you were taking too long in here,” Mydei murmurs, pressing another kiss to the man’s parted lips, increasing the pace…



It takes them almost thirty minutes, and possibly all the hot water, to actually finish showering. It’s a miracle in itself that they manage to keep their hands off each other after coming once, mostly. Phainon fidgets the entire time they wash themselves, sneaking hands to Mydei’s chest, mostly, behaving only after yet another warning glare and a flick to his forehead.

Fresh and clean and without any more wandering hands, Mydei returns to his room, clean and more tired than he was leaving it, watching himself in the mirror with a deep sigh. Phainon surely left a handiwork on his skin: his left shoulder looks like it has been mauled by a hungry dog—which,

Phainon is a hungry dog—and his chest is full of bite marks, and so are his neck and collarbones.

He resigns to his fate of hiding behind turtlenecks for the foreseeable future, thanking the cold weather for allowing such a fashion choice. Not that he owns any other kinds of sweaters to begin with.

He puts a face mask next, and while he waits for it to do its magic, his thoughts drift back to Phainon.

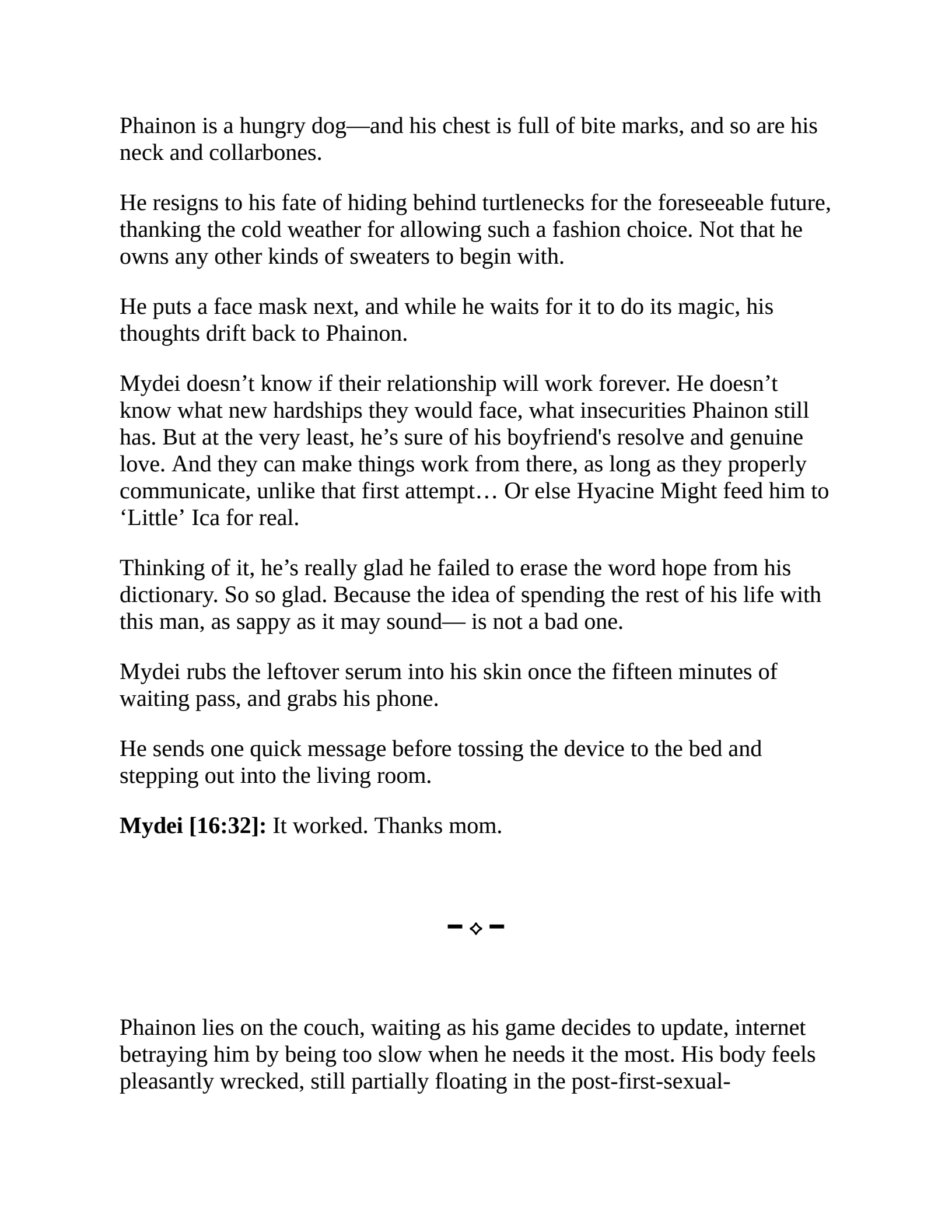
Mydei doesn’t know if their relationship will work forever. He doesn’t know what new hardships they would face, what insecurities Phainon still has. But at the very least, he’s sure of his boyfriend's resolve and genuine love. And they can make things work from there, as long as they properly communicate, unlike that first attempt… Or else Hyacine Might feed him to ‘Little’ Ica for real.

Thinking of it, he’s really glad he failed to erase the word hope from his dictionary. So so glad. Because the idea of spending the rest of his life with this man, as sappy as it may sound— is not a bad one.

Mydei rubs the leftover serum into his skin once the fifteen minutes of waiting pass, and grabs his phone.

He sends one quick message before tossing the device to the bed and stepping out into the living room.

Mydei [16:32]: It worked. Thanks mom.



Phainon lies on the couch, waiting as his game decides to update, internet betraying him by being too slow when he needs it the most. His body feels pleasantly wrecked, still partially floating in the post-first-sexual-

experience glow, scrolling aimlessly through the comments of his first Reddit as he waits for his internet connection to cooperate and allow him to do his daily missions.

“Looks like everyone there were right from the beginning. I was an asshole, and gay. Or at least Mydei-sexual if that's a thing...”

“It seems like Cyrene knew from the start too,” he muses, remembering his sister’s words of “don’t fall for your roommate.” Which he ended up doing.

He hears Mydei first, looking up right in time to yelp as the man drops onto him without ceremony, sprawling lazily across his chest with a cutesy yawn.

Mydei nuzzles deeper into the crook of his neck, blonde-red hair tickling his cheek as he does so, but Phainon feels too content to move under the heavy warmth he can proudly call his boyfriend after today.

“...What are you doing?” Mydei asks.

“Waiting for this game to update.” He points at the screen.

“No, on your phone.”

Phainon freezes.

Right, he never told Mydei about the Reddit posts. Nor does he know if he wants to.

“Um, nothing important. Just… Checking something.”

Mydei raises his head with a questioning tilt, staring up at him, “not very believable.”

Swallowing audibly, Phainon’s eyes refuse to meet his partner’s, blush creeping higher and higher on his face.

“It’s really nothing.”

“Phainon.”

“Okay,” Phainon immediately confesses, “so, remember when we first met at the café? When you laughed at my pick-up line?”

Mydei gives him another deadpan look, “Of course, it was so bad I can’t forget it.”

“Hey! It wasn’t bad,” Phainon hisses back, pouting. “But not the point. I, well, I made a Reddit post about it...”

He barely registers how quickly the phone disappears from his hands.

“HEY—!”

The post is right there on screen, and all Phainon can do is watch as Mydei reads it, completely mortified.

> **AITA for looking at the male barista during my first date?**
>
> u/user33550336 Throwaway acc… I know how the title sounds but hear me out!
>
> I (27m) was on a date (23f) recently…
>
> Like LETHAL face card. Somehow looking at him calmed my nerves. I'm not into guys or anything, I swear!
>
> All I did was appreciate a nice-looking bro.

Mydei reads it silently, face perfectly blank, until he reaches the line *I'm not into guys or anything, I swear!* and snorts, muffling his laughter into Phainon’s chest.

All while Phainon is dying beside him. Actually, physically dying.

“Lethal Face card, huh?” the blonde points out once he finishes reading the whole thing, and Phainon can do nothing but resign to his fate. His brat of a boyfriend is never going to let him live this down.

“In my defense it was before I knew I was… " You know,” he makes vague circles in the air with his hands. “Into men. It was months ago. I didn’t think I’d see you ever again, or live with you, or date you or—”

Much to his relief, or horror, Mydei doesn’t seem to pay attention to his rambling, too busy typing something, screen angled away so Phainon can’t see what exactly he’s doing.

“What are *you* doing?”

Before he can try snatching the phone back, Mydei reaches for his hand, warm, soft fingers lacing with his.

And takes a Photo.

He taps the screen a few more times and hands it back to Phainon, pressing a soft kiss to his cheek. “Nothing much, just letting the people who commented know how things ended.”

> **UPDATE: AITA for looking at the male barista during my first date?**
>
> u/user33550336
>
> Not sure if anyone wanted an update to the post below, but this guy is, in fact, quite gay. We’re together now.
>
> This is the barista, by the way.



u/ SleepDeprivedSince95

Not the AITA turning into a happily-ever-after!!!

I’m so proud of you both I could scream

u/ BelobogTrashCan

THE BARISTA IS REAL??

THE BARISTA IS *WITH YOU*???

SIR YOU WON LIFE’S LOTTERY.

u/ GachaVictim

OP: “I swear I’m not into guys.”

Also OP: *posts photo of holding hands with a guy*

IM SO HAPPY FOR YOU TWO

u/ ChimeraPancakes

I KNEW IT

I *KNEW* YOU WERE GAY

u/ ZeroPoints

Congratulations.

u/ MemMemMem

I knew this would be a romantic story like none that has come before.

u/ ForkThis

OP: “We’re together now :)”

Son of a nice lady… You lucky forker.

u/FolloweOfBeauty

I ship it

I ship it so hard

u/ April8th

This is the best arc this sub has ever had and I will die on that hill.

u/ Kitty_Thief

I feel like a proud mother, no homo.

u/ PrincessHomebody

What do you mean by “no homo,” darling? You're as gay as these two.

Chapter End Notes

I don’t want to yap too much, but oh boyyy what a ride.
It was originally supposed to be a one shot which I prayed won’t go over 10k words… look at it now— Almost 90k words in 4-ish months… These two really have me in a chokehold.
Totally not to be sappy, but I feel like a mother sending her child out of the nest. Not ready to let go, but know its time 😭😭😭

On a brighter note, thank you all for the lovely comments and kudos and art! I’m forever grateful for all of you and love you all!!!

See you all at the next brainworm ❤

P.S - I can't draw for shit, so excuse me for the anatomically incorrect hands.

End Notes

It all started with an joke between myself and a friend that Phainon would totally post something embarrasing on reddit...

Owing a huge thank you for Pancake for metally supporting me (and wanting to strangle phainon alongside me whenever he fumbled!) Youre the mvp

Come yap with me on twt❤ or through SP

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!